

PONNI'S BELOVED

Volume 1 : New Floods



An English Translation of Kalki Krishnamurthy's Ponniyin Selvan by

SUMEETHA MANIKANDAN

Ponni's Beloved

Volumes 1 to 5

**AN ENGLISH TRANSLATION OF
KALKI KRISHNAMURTHY'S PONNIYIN SELVAN**

by

Sumeetha Manikandan

Version 3.0

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[V. Sumeetha](#)

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Sumeetha Manikandan is a bestselling romance author whose novellas 'Perfect Groom' and 'These Lines of Mehendi' have been on the top of Amazon India charts ever since their publication. A bookaholic, thinker, feminist and a daydreamer, she reads across genres and is a crazy fan of history, romance and science fiction novels.

An avid reader of historical novels, she has been translating Kalki Krishnamurthy's classic Tamil novel Ponniyin Selvan for the past ten years and hopes to translate more of his novels into English.

Sumeetha is married to filmmaker K.S. Manikandan and lives with her daughter in Chennai.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I would like to acknowledge my father, S. Vijayaraghavan, who used to tell me the story of Ponniyin Selvan every evening during dinner and fuelled my interest to read the book.

My aunt, Ranganayaki, who lent me her Ponniyin Selvan books all those years ago when I was in school. I still treasure them to this day.

Navin and Vidya Sigamany for publishing the first drafts of Ponni's Beloved on their website Zine 5.com almost ten years ago and for editing the first two volumes of the book. I would like to thank Inderpreet Kaur Uppal for her stellar efforts in editing the first two volumes.

A very special thanks to my second editor, Dhivya Balaji, for editing the rest of the volumes, especially Volume 5. Her passion to retain the original essence of the novel matched mine and I was glad to find another kindred soul who loved these books as much as I do.

Eternal thanks to Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan, who encouraged me to resume the translation again. Writer and Journalist, Dhivakar Venkataraman, for providing valuable historical guidance for the cover page artwork.

Meenakshi Devaraj, an avid fan of the Ponniyin Selvan series, who rendered great help in translating Poonguzhali's song and the Devaram poems in this volume.

Friends like Raja King, Fowzia Iqbal, Abirami Baskaran, Sastha Prakash, Ramanujam Jaganathan, Thirukambigai Devi and countless others, who followed the translation avidly and promoted it among numerous groups.

I would also like to dedicate this book to all those fans who have been asking me for years to publish my translation, and to my husband who claims to be the first among them.

A special dedication is due to Abirami Baskaran whose encouraging words were invaluable. She was one of many who left us all too soon. May her soul rest in peace.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Kalki Krishnamurthy's Ponniyin Selvan was the first Tamil novel that I read. To tell you the truth, I learnt to read Tamil using elementary school books, just so that I could read this story.

They say that good books and great authors can transform lives. I have found it to be true in my case. I started translating this book ten years ago, as a hobby and realized that I could write. Today, I am a freelance writer who makes a living out of writing, and I owe my profession to this novel!

Many authors have written phenomenal books in Tamil literature after Kalki Krishnamurthy, but Ponniyin Selvan still remains the most popular book, widely read by many. Ponniyin Selvan has the right mixture of all things that makes an epic – political intrigue, conspiracy, betrayal, huge dollops of romance, infidelity, seduction, passion, alluring women, unrequited love, sacrifice and pure love.

Ponni's Beloved is an English translation, and as many readers have pointed out, no translation can do justice to the original. I have tried to capture the essence and soul of Kalki's writing in my translation.

I recently visited all the places (in India) that are mentioned in this novel. We started on Aadi 18 (Aug 3, 2019) for this trail trip almost on the footsteps of Vandiya Devan and saw all the fascinating places that he mentions in the journey. I have included some of the photos in this volume. For those who wish to sign up for this tour trail, do contact Tour Bee (7299646588). The tour trail was well organized

and the curator had many interesting stories about each place that we visited.

Thank you,

Sumeetha Manikandan.

FOREWORD

Kalki Krishnamurthy's *Ponniyin Selvan* was serialized in the post-independence era and it ran for four long years. Talking about a golden era in Tamil history, it ensnared the imagination of huge swathe of the Tamil population with people queuing in railway stations long before dawn to lay their hands on that week's edition of the Kalki magazine.

An entire generation dwelt upon the freshness of the novel and surprisingly it was not condemned to the recesses of the mind as a childhood fancy but continued to entice readers of subsequent generations as they were born and introduced to the Tamil language. The novel still has a colossal following but bounded by the hedges of a language that is not easy to learn, it strictly remained out of the mainstream and well within the realms of the Tamil speaking world.

Tamil people have been habitual migrants and the diaspora is spread over numerous countries. In today's generation, though many of them can speak

fluent Tamil they lack the patience to read the Tamil script that is spread over 1000 pages of a novel. And that's when the need arises a need for a good translation.

When I read the novel late in my thirties, the social media was just picking up and I was introduced to the yahoo group of Ponniyin Selvan fans around the year 2001. For the first time, readers from different age groups, settled in different lands were congregating online.

It was there that I came across a translation of Ponniyin Selvan into English. (There had been one earlier in print but that left much to be desired for those who had read the original. In fact, at one point the earlier translator mentioned 'Maize' for the Tamil word Cholan. But it was pointed out in the group that Maize entered India 500 years after the storyline period.)

The online translation was a bold bid by a youngster. As much as the substance within, the attempt bedazzled a lot of us because for 40 years or more it was almost sacrilege to deal with kalki's works. The

one sequel in the market at that time had been mauled by the copyright owners!

Over the next decade many of the members of the Yahoo group became novelists, biographers, bloggers, heritage activists and a host of history and literature connected personalities. And I would like to list Sumeetha's translation of Kalki's work as a starting point for all this.

A translated work should remind us of the original and it should have the author's imprint on the words. I think Sumeetha comes out in flying colours on both fronts. I am sure her work would open up the genius of Kalki to many who were deprived of it all these days.

Biography of Venkatesh Ramakrishnan:

Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan is a Chennai based bilingual novelist from India. South Indian historical fiction is his forte. He has published 3 novels in Tamil, 2 of them are sequels to the famous Kalki

Krishnamurthy novels Ponniyin Selvan and Sivagamiyin Sabatham respectively, with the titles Kaviri Mainthan and Kanji Tharagai. One of his other fictional work in Tamil is Thillayil Oru Kollaikaran. Gods, Kings & Slaves. The Siege of Madurai is his first novel in English.

Character List

CHOLA ROYAL FAMILY

Paranthaka I – Grandfather of Sundara Chola, Paranthaka I ruled from 907 to 955 CE.

Rajadhithan – Eldest son and heir apparent of Paranthaka I. Prince Rajadhithan died in the Thakkolam War (950 CE), after which the crown was passed on to his younger brother Gandaraditha Chola.

Gandaradithan – Son of Paranthaka I. Sundara Chola's uncle. He was the Chola king from 950 to 957 CE. He was known for his great devotion to Lord Shiva.

Sembiyanmadevi – King Gandaradithan's queen, known for her piety and devotion to Lord Shiva. She belongs to the clan of Mazhavarayar and married the king despite his advanced age.

Aringzhan Chola – Son of Paranthaka I, and the father of Sundara Chola. He reigned for a very short period (from 956 to 957 CE).

Kalyani – Wife of Aringzhan Chola and the mother of Sundara Chola. She belongs to the Vaithumbarayar clan and is famous for her beauty.

Madhuranthakan – Son of King Gandaradithan and Sembiyanmadevi, and the first cousin of Sundara Chola.

Paranthaka II (Sundara Chola) – Emperor of the Chola and Pandya kingdoms from 957 to 970 CE, when this story happens. His handsomeness earned him the popular epithet of 'Sundara Chola,' meaning Handsome Chola.

Vanamadevi – Consort of Paranthaka II and the empress of the Cholas, she is the mother of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan, Princess Kundavai, and Prince Arulmozhivarman. Her father is the noble chief Thirukkovalur Malayaman.

Aditya Karikalan – Eldest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi, and crown prince to the Chola throne, Aditya Karikalan is a peerless warrior who defeated and killed the Pandya king and established Chola suzerainty over his kingdom.

Kundavai – Daughter of Sundara Chola and the younger sister of Aditya Karikalan. Kundavai is cherished throughout the kingdom for her wit, wisdom, grace, and intelligence. She lives in Pazhaiarai along with her companions and friends.

Arulmozhivarman – The youngest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi, Arulmozhivarman is known throughout the kingdom as ‘Ponniyin Selvan.’ He later ascended the Chola throne as Raja Raja Cholan (985 - 1014 CE).

Noble Clans

PAZHUVUR CLAN

Periya Pazhuvetarayar – Lord Treasurer of the Chola kingdom and a peerless warrior who carried 64 battle scars on his body. He is the patriarch and the king of the powerful Pazhuvur clan and is an influential courtier and nobleman at the Chola court.

Nandini Devi – Queen and wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar, Nandini is a young woman renowned for her beauty. Nandini’s antecedents are a mystery and her past life is shrouded in secrecy.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar – Also known as Kalanthaka Kanda, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is the younger brother of Periya Pazhuvetarayar and is the commander of the Thanjavur fort. A powerful man with a strong physique, he is also the father-in-law of Prince Madhuranthakan.

KODUMBALUR CLAN

Budivikrama Kesari – The commander of troops in Elangai, he is also known as Kodumbalur Periya Vellar. He is the patriarch of the Kodumbalur Clan.

Vanathi – A Kodumbalur princess and the niece of Budivikrama Kesari, Vanathi is also the cherished companion and friend of Princess Kundavai, who hopes to wed her to Prince Arulmozhivarman.

Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar – Father of Vanathi and the younger brother of Budivikrama Kesari, he died valiantly in Elangai after leading a campaign across the sea.

SAMBUVARAYAR CLAN

Singannar Sambuvarayar – A powerful lord who ruled over Kadambur.

Kandanmaran – Son of Sambuvarayar who also fought along with Aditya Karikalan in many wars.

Manimegalai – Daughter of Sambuvarayar and the sister of Kandanmaran.

MALAYAMAN CLAN

Thirukkovalur Malayaman – Patriarch of the Malayaman clan and the father-in-law of Sundara Chola. He is close to his oldest grandson Aditya Karikalan.

VANAR CLAN

Vandiya Devan – Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan is Aditya Karikalan's bodyguard, friend, and confidante.

PANDYA KING'S BODYGUARDS

Ravidasan – The ringleader of the Pandya Abathuuthavigal who wish to avenge the death of their king. He is also known as 'Mandiravadi.'

Soman Sambavan – One of the conspirators and a member of Ravidasan's gang.

Edupankari – One of the Pandya conspirators who works in the Kadambur palace and overhears the noblemen's plots about the Chola succession.

Devaralan – Also known as Parameshwaran, he is one of the Pandya Abathuuthavigal who works in the Kadambur palace.

OTHER IMPORTANT CHARACTERS

Anirudha Brahmarayar – Prime Minister of the Chola Kingdom, and Sundara Cholar's trusted childhood friend and confidante.

Azhwarkadiyan Nambi – A Vaishnavite and a spy who is also known as Thirumalai or Thirumalaiappan. He also claims to be Nandini Devi's foster brother.

Parthibendra Pallavan – Close confidante and friend of Aditya Karikalan and a scion of the old Pallava dynasty.

Kudanthai Jodhidar – An astrologer in Kudanthai (present-day Kumbakonam) who is patronized by Kundavai.

KARAIYAR FAMILY

Thyagavidanga Karaiyar – Guardian of Kodi Karai lighthouse and father Poonguzhali and her brother Murugayyan.

Mandakini – Older sister of Thyagavidanga Karaiyar and Poonguzhali's aunt. She is also the woman who Sundara Cholar falls in love with while in Elangai. Many suspect her to be the mother of Nandini. Many also call her 'Oomai Rani' (translates to Mute Queen).

Vaani Ammai – Senthana Amuthan's deaf and mute mother, and the twin sister of Mandakini.

Senthana Amuthan – A devout Shaivite who provides flowers from his garden to Thallikullathar Temple; the son of Vaani Ammai.

Poonguzhali – Senthana Amuthan's cousin who lives in Kodi Karai; the boat girl who saves the life of Ponniyin Selvar.

Murugayyan – Poonguzhali's brother who is timid and under the control of his wife. He also plies his boat for his livelihood.

Rakkammal – Murugayyan's wife, who is also a Pandya rebel and a member of Ravidasan's gang.

Karuthiruman – A boatman who saves Mandakini and is in love with Vaani Ammai.

King Mahindan – King of Elangai who is presently hiding in Rohana mountains.

Ponni's Beloved Volume 1

New Floods

Table of Contents

[ABOUT THE AUTHOR](#)

[ACKNOWLEDGEMENT](#)

[AUTHOR'S NOTE](#)

[FOREWORD](#)

[CHARACTER LIST](#)

[A HISTORICAL NOTE](#)

[CHAPTER 1 - AADI PERRUKU](#)

[CHAPTER 2 - AZHWARKADIYAN NAMBI](#)

[CHAPTER 3 - THE VEILED PALANQUIN](#)

[CHAPTER 4 - THE KADAMBUR PALACE](#)

[CHAPTER 5 - KURAVAI KOOTHU](#)

[CHAPTER 6 - THE MIDNIGHT MEETING](#)

[CHAPTER 7 - LAUGHTER AND ANGER](#)

[CHAPTER 8 - WHO IS IN THE PALANQUIN?](#)

[CHAPTER 9 - FROM KADAMBUR TO KOLLIDAM](#)

[CHAPTER 10 - KUDANDHAI JODHIDAR](#)

[CHAPTER 11 - SUDDEN ENTRY](#)

[CHAPTER 12 – NANDINI](#)

[CHAPTER 13 - WAXING MOON](#)

CHAPTER 14 - A CROCODILE IN ARISALARU

CHAPTER 15 - VANATHI'S SCHEMES

CHAPTER 16 - PRINCE ARULMOZHIVARMAR

CHAPTER 17 - THE LAUGHING HORSE

CHAPTER 18 – EDUPANKARI

CHAPTER 19 - THE BATTLEFIELD

CHAPTER 20 - OUR FIRST ENEMY

CHAPTER 21 - THE VEIL PARTED

CHAPTER 22 - THE VELKARARS

CHAPTER 23 - AMUDAN'S MOTHER

CHAPTER 24 - THE CROW AND THE NIGHTINGALE

CHAPTER 25 - THANJAVUR FORT

CHAPTER 26 - DANGER! DANGER!

CHAPTER 27 - THE ROYAL POETS

CHAPTER 28 - THE IRON GRIP

CHAPTER 29 - THE ROYAL GUEST

CHAPTER 30 - CHITHIRAI MANDAPAM

CHAPTER 31 - THIEF! THIEF!

CHAPTER 32 – INSPECTION

CHAPTER 33 - A LADY ON A TREE

CHAPTER 34 - LATA MANDAPAM

CHAPTER 35 – MANDIRAVADI

CHAPTER 36 - DO YOU REMEMBER?

CHAPTER 37 - CLASH OF LIONS

CHAPTER 38 - NANDINI - THE SEDUCTRESS

CHAPTER 39 - SWIRLING WORLD!

CHAPTER 40 - THE DARK PALACE

CHAPTER 41 - THE UNDERGROUND CHAMBER

CHAPTER 42 – IS THIS YOUR FRIENDSHIP?

CHAPTER 43 – PAZHAIARAI

CHAPTER 44 – THIS IS HER DOING!

CHAPTER 45 – THE CRIME OF THE SPY

CHAPTER 46 – MURMURS AND RUMOURS

CHAPTER 47 – ISANA SHIVA PATTAR

CHAPTER 47 – WHIRLPOOLS AND BEAUTIFUL EYES

CHAPTER 49 – AN ASTONISHING TALE

CHAPTER 50 – PARANTHAKAR ADHURASALAI

CHAPTER 51 – MAMMALLAPURAM

CHAPTER 52 – OLD MAN’S MARRIAGE

CHAPTER 53 – MALAYAMAAN’S WRATH

CHAPTER 54 – THE VENOM OF A WOMAN

CHAPTER 55 – NANDINI’S LOVER

CHAPTER 56 – IN THE ANTHAPURAM

CHAPTER 57: MAYA MOHINI

A HISTORICAL NOTE

Centuries ago, the Cholas of South India rose to great heights when King Vijayalaya Chola (AD 846 - 871) conquered the Pallava Kingdom and established Thanjavur as the capital city of Cholas.

His son and successor King Aditya I (AD 871 - 907) vanquished the Pallavas and the Kongu land. Later, under the reign of his son Paranthakan I (AD 907-953), the Cholas acquired a dominion that laid the foundation for the vast empire that later Kings Rajarajan, Rajendran, and Kulothungan would establish and expand.

Paranthakan I won significant victories over the Banas, the Gangas, the Pandyas and the King of Elangai and one can learn all about his conquests from the many inscriptions that were written about him. Towards the end of his reign, the Rashtrakutas under the command of Krishnaraja III invaded the Chola Kingdom and the Chola Crown Prince Rajadithan, who led the army, fell dead at Thakkolam (near present day Arakonam) in AD 947-948. Following this defeat the Rashtrakutas seized Tondainadu and ruled over it for about a quarter of a century, confining the sway of the Cholas to their ancestral dominion comprising of Thanjavur and Tiruchinapalli.

King Paranthakan I had three sons, the eldest Rajadhitan (who was killed in the Thakkolam battle), Prince Gandaradithan and Prince Arizhayan. After the demise of King Paranthakan, Gandaradithan ascended the throne, but he was a widower who had no intention of marrying again or siring heirs. Instead, he proclaimed his nephew,

young Paranthakan II, (his brother Prince Arizhayan's son) as his heir apparent.

However, unexpectedly a few years before his death, King Gandaradithan got married to Sembiyanmadevi and begot Prince Madhuranthakan. Despite the birth of his own son, he willed that his nephew would remain the crown prince and his heir apparent. After his death, his Queen Sembiyanmadevi upheld her husband's wishes, as her own.

Paranthakan II ascended the throne after his uncle's death and ruled the Kingdom wisely. He was so attractive and handsome that he came to be known as King Sundara Chola, by his subjects. King Sundara Chola had two sons and one daughter. He made his eldest son, Prince Aditya Karikalan, a peerless warrior, his heir apparent.

This is where our story begins.

Chapter 1 - Aadi Perruku

Let us journey hundreds of years back in time. We are now in a Kingdom ruled by the glorious Chola^[1] kings.

To be precise, we are near a lake named Veerananarayana^[2] that is known today as Veeranam^[3].

Such a breath-taking sight! The vista of this lake makes one wonder about the wisdom of our ancestors and their perceptive farsightedness that made them build structures that would last for generations to come.

Today is the eighteenth day of the holy month of Aadi^[4]. On this day, every year, people gather along the banks of the nearest river or lake to enjoy the beautiful moonlit night and have a picnic with their families.

On the banks of the Veerananarayana Lake^[5] there appeared a young soldier on horseback who belonged to the brave warrior race of Vanars (Bana)^[6]. His titular name was Vallavareyan^[7] Vandiya Devan. While his tired horse trotted slowly, its master wasn't in any great hurry, as he was much engrossed by the spectacular sight that was unfolding ahead.



Veera Narayana Dam known today as Veeranam

So much water everywhere! Such a huge lake! Thought Vandiya Devan. This seems bigger than any other lake that I have seen so far. He tried to remember who built it.

Ah yes! [Prince Rajadithan^{\[8\]}](#), the eldest son of the Great Chola King Paranthaka I. He was a wise prince if ever there was one! He built this long dam on River Kaveri to help people with farming. Building a dam was not his sole claim to greatness. He was the bravest prince

seen in the recent times. Didn't he battle his enemies, atop an elephant in Thakkolam^[9] and die with a spear piercing his heart?

These Chola Kings are very strange indeed. They were as brave as they were intelligent and their faith in God was steadfast.

Wondering about his future, Vandiya Devan thanked his lucky stars that had brought him close to the scion of Chola Kingdom. He came to the southern end of the dam, where he noticed people picnicking with their families. Many lovely maidens were frolicking happily in the company of children and other young men. Some were laughing while some were singing songs about great kings and warriors of yore.

While he looked around, an old woman invited him to dine with her family. He immediately became the centre of attention of some of the young women gathered there who commented on his looks and giggled shyly. Vandiya Devan who was pleased by their attention wanted to accept the invitation. After all, who would want to lose an opportunity to be among such lovely women?

But he also noticed a few large boats approaching the bank of the dam. In the first boat, some soldiers started shooing away the people who were picnicking there.

Curious to learn as to who was arriving, Vandiya Devan moved around the crowd and asked an elderly man, "Ayya ^[10], who are those soldiers aboard the boats? Is someone important coming here?"

"Don't you know? Look at the flag in one of those boats. What do you see?" he asked.

“Looks like a picture of a palm tree.”

“It is the picture of a palm tree. Don’t you know that the palm tree is the emblem of Pazhuvetarayar?” he asked.

“What? Is the Great Warrior Pazhuvetarayar coming here?” asked Vandiya Devan surprised.

“It must be him. Who else will come bearing his emblem?”

Vandiya Devan had heard a lot about the Pazhuvetarayar brothers. Both brothers were great warriors widely acclaimed for their bravery. They belonged to a small township called Pazhuvur near Uraiyur ^[11], the old capital of the Chola Kingdom.

The clan of Pazhuvetarayar had been closely associated with the Cholas since King Vijayalaya’s time. One could say that they were as regal as royalty went. Renowned as the king makers in Chola dynasty they held numerous positions in the Chola court. Warriors from this clan were highly respected and were also given special privileges. One such privilege was to have an exclusive emblem, the palm tree.

The 60 years old, Periya Pazhuvetarayar was the most powerful man in the Chola royal court. He was in charge of the royal treasury and the entire finance of the Kingdom was under his control. He was also responsible for levying taxes on other petty kings, chiefs, and villages. His younger brother Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was the Commander of the Thanjavur Fort. No one could approach the King without his permission.

Having heard so much about both the brothers, Vandiya Devan, like any other warrior of that era, had an ardent wish to make their

acquaintance. However, he also remembered what Prince Aditya Karikalan had told him at the Golden Palace of Kanchi^[12].

“Vandiya Deva, I know that you are a true warrior. And I also know that you are brilliant which is why I am entrusting you with this important mission. Here are two confidential messages, one is for the King and my father Sundara Chola and the other is for my sister Princess Kundavai. Let no one in Thanjavur know that you are my messenger, no matter how important they are. Don’t get into any unnecessary fights and skirmishes. Beware of the Pazhuvetarayar brothers and my Uncle Madhuranthakan. I don’t want them to suspect the true nature of your mission because I sense treason in the air.”

Prince Aditya Karikalan was not only the heir apparent but was also the Supreme Commander of the Northern armies. The Prince had advised and cautioned Vandiya Devan about the dangers that he would encounter during the course of his mission more than once.

Recollecting his words, Vandiya Devan’s desire to make acquaintance with the Pazhuvur brothers diminished.



Chapter 2 - Azhwarkadiyan Nambi

Riding along the banks of the lake, Vandiya Devan turned his horse towards the South. As he rode, he wondered about his mission. He intuitively felt that he was bound on an adventure that was destined to change his life forever. As he travelled towards the Chola Empire, he couldn't help but be amazed by the scenic beauty of the fertile lands and the gurgling tributaries of the River Kaveri.

He had heard about the numerous temples that the Chola Kings had built along the banks of the river Ponni^[13] and was excited about the fact that he would be visiting famous cities like Thanjavur^[14] the present capital of Cholas and Pazhairai, a former capital. Apart from that, he was going to meet the Emperor! A great warrior whose handsome mien made people forget his real name 'Paranthakan' and led them to call him 'Sundara Chola'^[15] . And if that was not enough, he was also going to meet the most beautiful and intelligent woman in the Chola Empire, Elayapirati ^[16] Kundavai Devi.

He just hoped he wouldn't have any significant hurdles to surmount to accomplish his mission.

But what if there are obstacles? As long as, I have a sword in hand, I can tackle any hurdle, he told himself.

Wanting to reach Kadambur^[17] before sunset, he hurried along the road. Being an auspicious day, people had flocked there to perform puja.

The town wore a festive look. There were numerous shops selling flowers and eatables. Apart from them, there were astrologers, numerologists, and sorcerers offering their services to the people. In the midst of all this, he saw a huge crowd gathered around and heard a few loud voices arguing. Curious to know what was happening, Vandiya Devan left his horse in a corner and elbowed his way through the crowd.

He found out that there were only three people in the middle, and they were arguing energetically. And the crowd seemed to be cheering and supporting their favourite. Of the three, one was a fat Vaishnavan^[18], with a knot of hair in front of his face and sandalwood paste all over his body; he had a staff in hand. The second man had applied vibuthi^[19] all over his body and was obviously a Saivar^[20]. The third man was a saffron clad Advaiti sanyasi^[21] with a shaven head - a follower of Adi Shankaracharya.

At this point, the Saivar spoke up, “Oi! Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, try answering this. Vishnu^[22] and Brahma^[23] attempted to find the head and the foot of our Lord Shiva. Didn’t they fail in their attempt and accept defeat? Then how can you say that Vishnu is greater than Lord Shiva^[24]?”

Hearing this Azhwarkadiyan Nambi said, “Ooi Veerasaiva Padathuli Pattar, stop talking nonsense. Your lord granted many useless wishes to the ten-headed Ravana^[25].

Didn’t all these wishes become a waste before our Vishnu’s avatar Rama? Then how can you say that Shiva is greater than our Lord

Vishnu?”

Now it was the Sanyasis’s turn. “Why are you both fighting unnecessarily? No matter how long you argue, you will not find the answer to this question. You both are still stuck in a lower level of bhakti. You will have to rise above this level, to gain true enlightenment. Once you reach that level, you will find that there is no Shiva or Vishnu. You will find that the entire world is a Maya. Sarvam Brahman Mayam. Our Adi Shankaracharya said in his Brahma Sutra...”

At this point, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi interrupted and said, “Enough Sanyasi! Your Shankaracharya, after writing all the Upanishads and Brahma Sutram, wrote in the end,

Baja Govindam Baja Govindam

Baja Govindam Mudamadi

Worship Govinda, Worship Govinda, Worship Govinda.

Oh, fool! Rules of Grammar will not save you at the time of your death.

He was evidently talking about fools like you when he wrote ‘Mudamadi.’” This won applause for him from the crowd. But the Sanyasi was unruffled.

He said, “Nambi! You are right I am indeed a ‘fool’ who tried to attempt a civil debate with a staff-sporting rogue like you.”

“Do you know why I keep this staff? I expressly use it to break the shaven heads of Sanyasi’s like you,” said Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

The crowd loved this retort and cheered him loudly.

“Nambi! Stop this. Let the staff be in your hands. But even if you attack me, I will not allow myself to get angry. Everything is Maya. The attacker is Brahman[26], and the victim is also Brahman. If you try to hit me, it would mean that you are hitting yourself,” said the Sanyasi.

“Look here everyone! One Brahman is going to attack another Brahman. I am going to beat myself senseless with this staff,” shouted Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and went near the Sanyasi.

After watching all this, Vallavareyan felt that the Vaishnavan had to be taught a lesson. At this point, the Sanyasi slipped away hurriedly into the crowd.

“Oi! Padathuli Pattar, what do you say now? Do you wish to debate, or will you run away like that Sanyasi?” asked Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

“Me? I would never run away like him. Do you think I am like your Krishna, to steal butter and then get beaten by Gopis[27]?” asked Padathuli Pattar.

“Really? It seems you have forgotten that your Lord Shiva got beaten soundly on his back, while he was unloading sand,” said Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

Wanting to stop the fight, Vandiya Devan, took a step forward and said, “Why are you people fighting thus?”

Azhwarkadiyan immediately turned towards him and asked, “Who are you to interfere?”

Some people in the crowd took an immediate liking to our young warrior, and they told Vandiya Devan, “You tell these people to stop fighting, thambi^[28] . We will support you.”

“I don’t think Lord Shiva and Lord Vishnu are fighting amongst themselves. Last I heard they are living peacefully. Then why should this Nambi and Pattar fight among themselves?” said Vandiya Devan.

Hearing this, many in the crowd burst out laughing.

“This boy is mocking us. But let him tell us who is the Supreme God - Lord Shiva or Lord Vishnu,” said the Pattar.

“Lord Shiva is great, and so is Lord Vishnu. You can worship whomever you want. Why do you want to fight over this?” said Vandiya Devan.

“How can you tell that they both are great Gods? Do you have any proof?” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

“Proof? You want proof? Yesterday, I went to Vaikundam^[29] and incidentally Lord Shiva had also come there. Both Shiva and Vishnu were sitting on thrones that were of the same height, which I measured just so that I can be sure. And then, I asked them who the greater god among them was? Do you know what they said?

Harium Sivanum Onnu

Ariyadavar Vaayil Mannu

Vishnu and Siva are one and the same.

And those who do not know this need to eat mud!

“And they gave me a handful of dirt,” said Vandiya Devan and opened his palm to show a fistful. The crowd, much inspired by this act, applauded him and proceeded to heap mud on both Nambi and the Pattar.

Nambi became hysterical and started shouting, “You scoundrels! You atheists!”

A clash of arms seemed inevitable at this point. Thankfully, they heard the sound of coaches and drums close by. The crowd dispersed to make way for the procession.

“Great Warrior! Slayer of Mara Pandiyan. Victorious in 24 wars and bearer of 64 brave scars! The Treasurer of the Chola Kingdom, Periya Pazhuvetarayar, is on his way,” announced a man who was at the head of the procession. After him, came the flag holders, the drum beaters and an endless row of soldiers.

In the end, came a beautifully decorated elephant. On the elephant sat a powerful looking man. His face reflected power, the pride of his position and his physical strength. Vandiya Devan looked at him in wonder and said to himself, “This is Periya Pazhuvetarayar.”

Behind the elephant, came a heavily veiled palanquin. It caught Vandiya Devan’s attention, and he wondered who could be inside. The next instant, a fair complexioned hand wearing bracelets opened the veil of the palanquin, and a face looked through the parted curtain.

Vandiya Devan was an admirer of woman’s beauty. Though the woman in the palanquin was beautiful with a glowing complexion, it didn’t inspire happiness in his heart. Instead, he felt fear and disgust.

Simultaneously, the woman looked at something or someone near Vandiya Devan, and a scream escaped her mouth. She immediately disappeared behind the silken veils of the palanquin.

Vallavareyan sensed that the woman had looked at someone next to him and had got frightened. He wondered who that could be and looked around and found Azhwarkadiyan standing beside him with an indescribable expression of disgust and distaste on his face.



Chapter 3 - The Veiled Palanquin

Sometimes, small inconsequential moments lead to momentous periods in one's life. It is indeed life's great mystery, or one might even call it as God's grand plan! One such small incident occurred in Vandiya Devan's life.

In the last chapter, we saw him watching the procession of Pazhuvur soldiers while his horse was tethered away at a distance. Unfortunately, his horse became the focus of attention for some of these soldiers who were at the tail of the procession.

"Friends! Look at that kurudai," said one soldier.

A horse is called kudirai in Tamil. However, in some dialects, it is also known as 'kurudai.' Since this soldier called it a kurudai, his friend corrected him and told that it must be called 'kudirai.'

Another soldier interrupted saying, "Please stop your literary argument. First, let's make sure whether this is a horse or a donkey."

"Fine. Let me do a little test," said one of the soldiers and tried to mount the horse. But the horse wouldn't let him, knowing well enough that he was not his master.

"What a roguish beast! It won't allow me to mount. Only a scion from a royal family can mount him. If that is so, only a Mutharayan from Thanjavur can mount him," said the soldiers while the others laughed.

The Cholas had destroyed the Mutharayan clan a hundred years ago. The Thanjavur Fort came into the Cholas' possession only after

Mutharayans were destroyed.

“Thandavaraya, I don’t think this is a real horse. It may belong to the poi kaal kudirai (false horse performance) group,” said one of the soldiers.

“Fine then. I will test that as well,” said Thandavaraya and twisted the tail of the horse. The horse kicked and ran off.

“Aha! The horse is running. It was, after all, a real horse!” shouted the Pazhuvur soldiers and went after it. The poor harassed horse ran right into the middle of the crowd, knocking people down in the marketplace.

“Did you see what those Pazhuvur rogues did? Why didn’t you show some of your bravery here?” Azhwarkadiyan asked.

Vandiya Devan was furious at first, and it infuriated him further to listen to the Nambi’s taunt as well. But he watched the scene patiently without giving in to the urge to start a fight. Pazhuvur soldiers were many in numbers, and he knew that it would be very unwise to confront them. And after the horse bolted, they too moved out of the scene.

Instead, he went searching for the horse. He knew that it would stop after galloping for a while. He swore to himself that one day he would teach a lesson to these proud Pazhuvur soldiers that they would never forget.

He found his horse near an isolated place. He massaged its back and murmured soft words to it, soothing its nerves and then returned to the marketplace along with it. Many, who had gathered there, asked him why he brought such a wild beast in the crowd. Before he

could respond, another man in the group said that it was neither his mistake nor the horse's mistake. It was the proud Pazhuvur soldiers who were after all responsible for the commotion.

He saw Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, still standing at the roadside and wondered why he had not gone his way.

"Thambi, in which direction are you going?" he asked.

"Me? I am going in the Eastern direction and then the West and then the North and then the Southwest..." said Vandiya Devan.

"I did not ask that. Where are you staying tonight?" asked Azhwarkadiyan.

"Why are you interested in that?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"Just wondering if you are staying at the Kadambur Palace. I have some work there," said Azhwarkadiyan.

"Ha! How did you know that I was planning to stay there?" asked Vandiya Devan surprised.

"Why are you so surprised? Today many noblemen and representatives from all noble families in the Chola Kingdom have come to stay in Kadambur Palace, including Periya Pazhuvetarayar. Since you seemed like a stranger in this place, I thought you might be staying there too," said the Nambi.

"Really?" asked Vandiya Devan, astonished. "Is Pazhuvetarayar going to stay at the Kadambur Palace?"

"Of course! I am surprised that you didn't know this. The procession that we saw was heading towards Kadambur and not just that, all the horses, the palanquin, and elephant that we saw now were sent from

Kadambur palace to honour their prime guest. Wherever he goes, he expects people to welcome him thus,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

Vandiya Devan started thinking whether he should go to Kadambur palace at all. He could never get another chance to stay in the same place where Periya Pazhuvetarayar was and who knew maybe he could make acquaintance with this great warrior. But he couldn't forget what the Pazhuvur soldiers did to his horse just a little while ago.

“Thambi, I need a favour from you,” said the Nambi in a very sweet voice.

“How can I help you? I am a stranger here,” said Vandiya Devan.

“I am sure you can help me. Please take me along with you to Kadambur,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

“Why? Is a Saivar coming there? You want to debate who the Supreme God is?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“No! No! Do you think I just go around arguing and fighting with others? Tonight, there will be a big feast in Kadambur Palace. After that, there will be kuravai koothu^[30], and I have always wanted to watch it. That's why I wish to go there,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

“If that is so then how can I take you?”

“You can say that I am your servant,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

Vandiya Devan got a suspicion that Azhwarkadiyan was not being truthful. He guessed that there might be another reason as to why he wished to accompany him.

“I can’t help you in this. If you want to lie and cheat to get to that place you better find somebody else. I don’t need a servant like you. Even if I tell people that you are my servant I doubt if they would believe it. Now that you have told me all this, I am wondering if they will allow me inside the palace,” said Vandiya Devan.

“Oh! In that case, you have not come here by invitation, is it?” questioned Azhwarkadiyan.

“I do have an invitation. Kadambur Sambuverayar’s son Kandanmaran is a good friend of mine. He asked me to visit their palace if ever I come hereabouts,” said Vandiya Devan.

“Oh! If that is so, then I don’t think you can get into the palace easily today,” said the Nambi.

Both started walking silently together.

“Why are you following me?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“I can ask the same question to you. Why are you following me? Why don’t you go your way?” asked the Nambi.

“Problem is, I don’t know the way, Nambi. Where are you going? Are you going to Kadambur?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“No! You have refused to take me there. How can I go? I am going to Vinnakara temple,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

“Is that Veerananarayana Temple^[31]?” asked Vandiya Devan.



Veera Narayana Temple

“Yes.”

“I want to visit that temple too.”

“I thought maybe you wouldn’t come to a Vishnu temple. The temple priest here is a great devotee of Maha Vishnu,” said the Nambi and entered the temple.

“It’s very crowded here. Is it a special day today?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“Today is the eighteenth day of the holy Aadi month which also happens to be an auspicious day for the worship of Aandal. Thambi! Have you heard any of Aandal’s poems?” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

“No. I haven’t,” said Vandiya Devan.

“Don’t. Please don’t listen to them,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

“Why not?”

“If you listen to them, you will throw away your sword and spear and fall in love with Krishna, just like me,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

“Do you know any of Aandal’s^[32] poems? Can you sing them?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“I do. I will be singing them at the temple,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

Standing at the Garba Griha^[33] of the temple, Azhwarkadiyan sang many Aandal Pasurams^[34]. He saw tears streaming from Nambi’s eyes when he finished the songs.

After the darshan, they came out of the temple and Vandiya Devan apologized to Nambi he said, “Swami, I didn’t know you were such a big devotee. Please forgive me if I had said anything inappropriate.”

“I forgive you thambi. Will you help me now?” he asked.

“I told you that I couldn't assist you to get into Kadambur, and you too agreed,” said Vandiya Devan.

“No. This is another matter. I will write a small note. Can you give it to someone in Kadambur?” asked Nambi.

“Who?”

“To the lady in the veiled palanquin,” said Nambi.

“Nambi! Who do you think I am? How dare you ask me this? If somebody else had said this I would have...” started Vandiya Devan furiously.

“Thambi! If you don’t want to do it, you can happily go on your way. But if you had helped me with this matter, I could help you with many other things at a later date. You are free to take my leave...”

Vandiya Devan immediately mounted his horse and rode towards Kadambur.



Chapter 4 - The Kadambur Palace

Vandiya Devan reached Kadambur Palace within an hour after he left Veeranarayana Temple. Sengannar Sambuverayar was one of the foremost noblemen in the Chola Kingdom. His palace stood as a testimony of his power. It looked almost as huge as a king's fort with high walls and well-armed guards.



Sri Rudrapathi Temple at Keezha Kadambur.

At the entrance, there were horses, elephants and their caretakers moving around and guards on the fort ramparts holding torches.

“Seems like something important happening here. Why did I have to come here today, of all days?” thought Vandiya Devan.

But he was also interested in knowing what was happening in Kadambur palace. The doors of the palace lay open, but they were heavily guarded.

Vandiya Devan knew that if he hesitated, the guards wouldn't allow him inside. So, he rode up to the entrance boldly and as expected the guards surrounded him.

“Is this how ‘guests’ are greeted here?” asked Vallavareyan furiously.

“Who are you? You tell us that first,” asked one of the soldiers carelessly.

“You dare to ask ‘me’ who I am? I am Vallavareyan, Vandiya Devan of the Vanar Clan in Thiruvallam^[35]. Once upon a time, soldiers like you, proudly carved the names of my ancestors on their chests,” bellowed Vandiya Devan.

“You might have as well brought an announcer to herald your arrival,” sniggered one of the soldiers eliciting laughter from the other soldiers as well.”

“Whoever you are, you cannot go inside. The invited guests have all arrived, and our master has ordered us not to allow anybody else inside,” said the head of the guards.

Hearing the commotion and the jeers at the entrance, soldiers engaged in other chores near the palace gates, gathered at the entrance to find out what's happening.

Along with them, came the gang of Pazhuvur soldiers who had harassed our hero's horse, a little while ago.

"Look my friends! It's the same horse."

"Don't call it a horse. Call it a donkey."

"Look how proudly this 'guest' is sitting on the donkey."

You might as well imagine how angry our hot-blooded hero might be after hearing this!

This isn't the time to fight. I must remember what Prince Karikalar told me. Maybe I should just go back or else maybe I should show them Karikalar's signet ring to gain entrance,"

But when he heard the jeering words of Pazhuvur soldiers', he made a decision.

"I wish to leave. Release my horse."

The soldiers who were blocking him, gave way. He immediately kicked his horse, deep in the belly causing it to lift its hooves high up in the air, striking the jeering soldiers, and simultaneously he pulled out his sword.

Many things happened instantly. The soldiers inside the palace, hearing the commotion, urgently shut the massive doors, while a soldier on the fort's ramparts beat the drum signalling an intruder and the guards started running towards the entrance.

Twenty to thirty soldiers surrounded Vandiya Devan and his horse. He jumped down and started swinging his sword around him, lest they attack him and at the same time he began shouting at the top of his voice, “Kandanmara, your guards are attacking me!”

Hearing this, the soldiers stopped in their tracks and hesitated to approach him. Next moment, they heard a thundering voice from the terrace of the palace.

“What is this commotion? And what is happening here?”

“Master, this man tried to enter the palace and when we didn’t allow him inside, he attacked us and started shouting our young master’s name.”

“Kandanmara, go and check what’s happening down there,” ordered the same thundering voice. Vandiya Devan and the guards remained quiet until Kandanmaran came down.

“What is happening here?” asked Kandanmaran and when his eyes fell on Vandiya Devan, he became excited.

“Vallava, is it really you?” he asked looking at Vandiya Devan and then enveloped him in a bear hug.

“Kandanmara, you invited me earnestly so many times, so I thought I would visit you today. But I never expected such a ‘welcome’ in your palace.” said Vandiya Devan pointing at the guards.

“Fools! You don’t know how to behave with guests!” shouted Kandanmaran at the guards.

After that, Kandanmaran took Vandiya Devan’s hand and pulled him inside the palace. He was thoroughly excited to see his best friend.

He immediately took him to the terrace of the palace to introduce him to his father.

On the way, Vandiya Devan asked him, “Kandanmara, what’s happening here? Why so many guards?”

“That I will tell you later. But do you remember when we were guarding the border you said that you want to meet Pazhuvetarayar, Mazhavereyar, and many others? Today is your lucky day Vandiya Deva; you can meet them all here,” said Kandanmaran.

In the terrace, Kandanmaran’s father and other noblemen were sitting and conversing with each other. Kandanmaran took Vandiya Devan to his father and introduced him.

“Father, do you remember, I told you about my best friend, Vandiya Devan. This is him.”

Kandanmaran’s father didn’t seem too very happy to see him. He said, “Really? So, all that chaos downstairs was because of him?”

Kandanmaran, angered by his father’s words, replied “No. It was because of those fools that we have got as guards.”

“Even then, he needn’t have created so much of a commotion,” said Kandanmaran’s father.

Not wanting to argue further with his father, Kandanmaran pulled Vandiya Devan along and took him to the centre of the terrace, where many noblemen had assembled. There he introduced Vandiya Devan to Pazhuvetarayar.

“Mama^[36], this is my friend Vandiya Devan of Vanar clan. For a very long time, he has been telling me that he wanted to meet you. He would always ask me whether you really had sixty-four battle scars on your body. And I used to say to him that one day, he can count them himself if he wants.”

“Really Thambi, so you think there cannot be a brave soldier from any other clan, other than the Vanar, and unless you count the scars, you won’t believe the heroic accounts of anybody, is it?” asked Pazhuvetarayar.

Both Vandiya Devan and Kandanmaran were shocked. They never thought that Pazhuvetarayar would twist their casual words in this manner.

Vandiya Devan was furious. But he nonetheless he said, “Ayya, how can I think thus, when I am in the presence of a great warrior?”

“I am very pleased to meet you,” said Pazhuvetarayar, though he didn’t look happy at all.

When they left the terrace, they met Kandanmaran’s father downstairs who told them to get Vandiya Devan his dinner, so that he could retire for the day.

After that, Kandanmaran took Vandiya Devan to the anthapuram to introduce his mother.

He also introduced his sister to him, who hid behind her mother shyly. Vandiya Devan, to whom Kandanmaran had described his sister to no end, felt disappointed when he barely got a glimpse of her. But he was also more disappointed when he noticed that lady in the veiled palanquin was not present among the women there!



Chapter 5 - Kuravai Koothu

After stepping out of the anthapuram^[37], Vandiya Devan heard a woman's voice calling out for his friend from inside.

"Mother is calling me. Wait here, I will come back soon," said Kandanmaran and re-entered the anthapuram.

Vandiya Devan heard the women folk talking and laughing simultaneously and a garble of voices questioning his friend, who was finding it difficult to answer. He thought that they were all laughing at him. Soon Kandanmaran came out and said, "Come, I will show you our palace."

Vandiya Devan asked, "Kandanmara, when you went inside the anthapuram, the womenfolk were laughing so much. What is the matter? Are they very 'happy' after seeing me?"

"They liked you very much. But don't worry they were not laughing at you."

"Then why were they laughing?" he persisted.

"You know, Pazhuvetarayar, at this age, he has married a young woman. He brought her here in a veiled palanquin but didn't send her to the anthapuram. He keeps her locked in his own quarters. One of our handmaidens saw her from the window and was describing her beauty. That is why they were all laughing. Each one of them is trying to guess which Kingdom she is from, and some thought that I might know something and asked me. They say that she might be from the

Chera^[38] Kingdom. You know that Pazhuvetarayar's ancestors are from the Chera kingdom," said Kandanmaran.

"Oh, yes! I think you told me once. Kandanmara, when did Pazhuvetarayar marry this mysterious beauty?"

"About two years ago, I think. Since then, he has not left her alone even for a minute. He takes her everywhere in a veiled palanquin. All over the Chola Kingdom people are ridiculing him for getting married to a woman young enough to be his granddaughter. That is why the women folk were also laughing."

"I don't believe that is the reason, Kandanmara. Shall I tell you the real reason behind their laughter? But please don't think that I am talking ill of them, the entire women race is like that. The women in your family are dark-complexioned beauties, whereas Pazhuvetarayar's beloved is fair complexioned. That's why they don't like her. They are jealous," explained Vandiya Devan.

"My God! How do you know about her complexion? Have you seen her? When and where did you see her? If Pazhuvetarayar learns about this, you will lose your head!" said Kandanmaran.

"Kandanmara, you know very well that I am not scared of these things, and I haven't done anything inappropriate. In Veeranarayanapuram, when Pazhuvetarayar and his entourage came along, I stood watching along with the crowd. I heard that you sent the entire procession of horses, elephants, and soldiers. Is that true?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"That's right. What of it?" asked Kandanmaran.

“Nothing. I was just comparing the welcome reception that we both got here; that’s all...” Vandiya Devan said cheekily.

Kandanmaran laughed out loud and said, “Pazhuvetarayar got a welcome that befitted the treasurer of the kingdom. You got a welcome that befits a true warrior. Don’t worry, tomorrow by God’s grace when you become the son-in-law of this family, you will get another rousing welcome from all of us. Anyway, you were telling me about Pazhuvetarayar’s ‘beloved wife’ and we changed the subject. Tell me, where did you see her?”

“I was watching Pazhuvetarayar’s procession. When I saw him on the elephant, I thought that one day, I should also become like him. After the elephant had passed, I saw a veiled palanquin. I was wondering who could be inside when I saw a fair hand parting the veils, and a fair face looked out. I just had a glimpse; that’s all. Now that you told me, I guess that woman must be Pazhuvetarayar’s mysterious wife,” Vandiya Devan said.

“Vandiya Deva you lucky man! Do you know nobody has laid eyes on that woman? At least, you had a glimpse of her face. What is your guess? Which Kingdom do you think, she is from?” asked Kandanmaran excitedly.

“When I saw her first, I didn’t give it a thought but now when I think back, she might be from the kingdom of Kashmir, Greece, or maybe she is from Arabia. Do you know women in Arabia are kept veiled all the time?” said Vandiya Devan.

Just then, they both heard heralding sounds of conches and the beating of drums.

“What is that noise?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“The Kuravai Koothu is starting. Do you wish to watch it now or would you rather dine and sleep?”

“I have never seen Kuravai Koothu before. I would like to watch,” said Vandiya Devan, remembering Azhwarkadiyan. Both the friends went up to the courtyard where the stage had been set and sat down in the last row of seats. The other noble guests had already assembled there. The dancers (mostly women) came up on the stage wearing charming costumes. They were wearing saffron-coloured saris with red flowers in their hair. They had also entwined the flowers around their hands and necks. The stage was decorated with paintings of the peacock, cock, and spear, which are the holy symbols of Lord Muruga^[39]. The dancers began to dance and sing simultaneously about the exploits of Lord Muruga. After performing many a song, they bowed low to the audience and left the stage.

Next came, ‘Devaralan and Devaratti^[40]’ who performed a war dance wearing blood-red clothes. Both their eyes were bloodshot, and even their mouth was red from chewing betel leaves and tobacco. The dance started slowly but gained momentum, as Lord Muruga went about vanquishing his enemies. As the dance became wild, Devaratti left the stage in fear and Devaralan danced alone violently with vigorous movements.

It is a belief that sometimes when the dancers perform religious and ritualistic dances, the Gods possess them. The same happened here! As Devaralan’s dance became wild, the musicians stopped playing, and a pujari^[41] stepped forward, playing just a hand drum while Devaralan danced shaking and trembling from head to foot as if a

spirit possessed him. The others in the audience whispered to one another, “He has been possessed!”

The pujari then asked Devaralan, “Vela! Muruga! What is your divine message for your servants?”

“Ask me anything. I will tell you,” Devaralan said.

“Will it rain this year? Will the kingdom prosper? Will we get our heart’s desire?” asked the pujari.

“Yes, it will rain. The kingdom will flourish; you will succeed in all your undertakings. But to get your heart’s desire you will have to give a sacrifice for my Mother Durga^[42].”

“What sacrifice does she demand?”

“Will you give whatever she asks for?” asked Devaralan.

“Yes, indeed,” said the Pujari.

“Her sacrifice should be of royal blood.”

Hearing this, the noblemen exchanged meaningful looks. At this point, Devaralan fainted. Devaratti then came on the stage and took him away, while everybody dispersed quietly.

A mixture of emotions overwhelmed Vandiya Devan. He heard a lone wolf howling somewhere, outside the palace. When he looked in that direction, he thought he saw Azhwarkadiyan’s head on the wall! He shook his head and looked again - there was nothing there!



Chapter 6 - The Midnight Meeting

After the Kuravai Koothu, a big feast was spread out for the guests. Vallavareyan didn't enjoy it much as he was exhausted. Nonetheless, he sat down along with his friend who kept a steady stream of conversation about his guests.

Apart from Pazhuvetarayar, Mazhavereyar, Mazhapadi Thanavan, Kunrathur Perunilakezhar, Mammudi Pallavareyar, Thenthongi Kalingarayer, Vanangamudi Munnaireyar, Devasenathipati Puvareyar were some of the prominent figures in Sambuverayar's guest list that night.

Vandiya Devan was aware that these noblemen were the most influential officials of the Chola court. It wouldn't be wrong to call them as petty kings and powerful chieftains. In those days, one could not be a king just by birth. Only those, who stood by the emperor with loyalty and bravery during a war, would be recognized and given lands and property and established as a petty king or a lord.

Vandiya Devan realized that unless it was something of great import these noblemen would not have gathered here.

Why have they all come here...? What is happening here today?

With these questions playing in his mind, he went with Kandanmaran to the terrace, where he was given a bed under the stars at the far end.

"You look exhausted, Vallava. Get some sleep. I will just attend to the other guests and come here soon enough," said Kandanmaran.

Vandiya Devan, who was exhausted from the journey, fell asleep immediately only to awaken in his dream world. He dreamt of a wolf howling somewhere, and suddenly one wolf became a hundred, and they came charging towards him. Vandiya Devan started running.

In front of him, hundred dogs came towards him barking. Terrified, Vandiya Devan looked around and spotted a Kali temple. In the entrance, he saw a sacrificial stone and a Pujari suddenly appeared from behind the statue.

“So... you come at last! What is the history of your royal race? How long did your clan rule?” asked the Pujari.

“The Vanar clan ruled for almost 300 years. During my father’s time, we lost our kingdom to Vaithumbarayar^[43].” Vandiya Devan answered.

“Then you are not the perfect sacrifice for Mother Kali. Go away!”

Suddenly the statue of Kali vanished, and Lord Krishna’s appeared instead. And two beautiful women start singing the Aandal Pasuram, as they garlanded the deity.

Vallavareyan was mesmerized by the sight. Behind him, he heard a familiar voice singing. He turned -- it was Azhwarkadiyan. No, it was Azhwarkadiyan’s head that was singing! It was severed and kept on the sacrificial stone!

Unable to stand the gory sight any longer, Vandiya Devan turned in his sleep and hit his head on a pillar. The dream ended, and he woke

up, but he saw something that had appeared in his dreams just now. It was Azhwarkadiyan's head!

In the terrace where Vandiya Devan slept, the high walls of the palace could be seen -- this was where he saw Azhwarkadiyan's face. Vandiya Devan blinked his eyes, but the head didn't vanish. Azhwarkadiyan had somehow climbed the walls and was looking at something that was happening on the other side of the wall within the palace.

"This is suspicious. Azhwarkadiyan has not come here with any noble intentions," thought Vandiya Devan. "He is spying on somebody... if he intends any harm to my friend's family, it is my duty to warn and protect them."

He immediately got up and walked towards the place where Azhwarkadiyan's head was seen. Since he was sleeping at the far end of the terrace, it took some time before he reached across. As he neared, he heard a babble of voices from below. He got behind a huge pillar and cautiously looked down. A fire log was burning low, emitting a dim light. Although very few lamps were lit, he could see that all the guests, Kandanmaran, and his father were sitting there.

Azhwarkadiyan was spying on them! Vandiya Devan noted that he had cleverly selected a spot from where he could see and listen to what was happening though no one could see him from below because of the dark shadows from the trees around.

Vandiya Devan was determined to warn the people below about this. But it was impossible to do so without drawing attention to himself.

Azhwarkadiyan would probably disappear before he could explain to Kandanmaran's father as to why he raised an alarm.

If they asked him to explain why he was roaming around in the terrace, what answer, could he possibly give? He also remembered how Kandanmaran's father had given him a half-hearted welcome. He didn't want to embarrass Kandanmaran, who had welcomed him despite his father's disapproval.

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan looked down and spotted a veiled palanquin in a corner. Could this be the same palanquin that carried Pazhuvetarayar's wife? He wondered where that fair complexioned woman was. The old man didn't even send her to the anthapuram!

People who are this old should never get married. Look at the fate of this great warrior. He is so enslaved by the beauty of the woman that he doesn't allow her out of his sight for even a minute. Maybe she was still in the palanquin. What did he see in her anyway? She was not that beautiful. He could still remember the disgust that he felt when he had got a glimpse of her.

Was Azhwarkadiyan spying around here because of her? Maybe he was related to her and wanted to send her a message or she could be his sister or lover, who was to know? Pazhuvetarayar could have kidnapped her and married her forcibly. Vandiya Devan was sure that he was quite capable of such a lowly act. That's probably why Azhwarkadiyan was looking out for an opportunity to meet her.

It would be better if I didn't get involved in such affairs. I should get back to my bed, thought Vandiya Devan.

And this is when he heard his name being mentioned in the conference below.

“What about that boy, your son’s friend who has come here? Where is he sleeping? Are you sure he is not spying on us? Don’t forget that he is under the command of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan. We must make sure that no one learns of our plan until it gets fulfilled. If at all, you suspect that he knows something, he must be killed immediately!” Pazhuvetarayar was saying.

You can imagine how Vandiya Devan would have felt on hearing this. At that instant, he decided that he would hear out every single word that was spoken there.

What objection did Pazhuvetarayar have if he worked under the command of the Crown Prince? What would they be discussing here that Prince Aditya shouldn’t know?

The next second, he heard his friend defending him, “Vandiya Devan is fast asleep at the far end of the terrace. He cannot hear a word of what’s happening here, and he does not poke his nose into things that do not concern him. Even if he does get to know something, it won’t affect our plans in any way. I can assure you that.”

“I am glad that you trust your friend so much, but we don’t know anything about him, that’s why I warned you. We are about to discuss the future of the Chola Kingdom’s throne, and we cannot afford to be careless,” said Pazhuvetarayar.



Chapter 7 - Laughter and Anger

When Vandiya Devan heard Pazhuvetarayar talk about the royal throne, he decided to hear out everything that was happening in the meeting below.

Who are they to discuss or determine anything about the royal throne? I must definitely learn what is happening here? I can just sit here and listen and what does it matter if Azhwarkadiyan is spying on them. This is more important.

“By a lucky chance, I have got an opportunity to know what’s happening here. Why miss it?” he thought.

By this time Pazhuvetarayar had started speaking at the conference below.

“I have brought important information for all of you. That’s why I asked the noble Sambuverayar to invite us all here. Maharaja Sundara Chola’s health has been steadily deteriorating. I secretly asked our royal physician, and he says that there is absolutely no chance of his health improving. His days are numbered. And it is up to us, to think about the future of the royal throne.”

“What do the astrologers say?” asked one of the noble men.

“Why ask the astrologers? Haven’t you seen the comet that has been appearing in the sky, for the past few weeks? They say whenever a comet appears, there will be death in the royal family,” said another.

“I have asked the astrologers as well, and they say that the king might live for some more time. Anyway, we will have to decide who should ascend the throne next,” said Pazhuvetarayar.

“What is the use of discussing that now? Aditya Karikalan was made the Crown Prince two years ago,” said one of the noblemen.

“True. But before he took that decision, did Sundara Chola consult any of us? We all have stood by the Chola Kingdom with loyalty and have sacrificed our sons and grandsons in the battlefield. Even now warriors from each of our clans have gone to Elangai^[44] to fight for the Chola Kingdom. Don’t you think we deserve the right to be consulted about who should be the next heir to the throne? Even King Dasaratha^[45] asked his council of ministers, before deciding to crown Rama^[46]. But our Sundara Chola didn’t think it necessary to consult anyone...”

At this someone interrupted and said, “It is true that he didn’t consult any of us here, but it wouldn’t be right to say that he didn’t ask anybody at all. He must have consulted Periyapirati^[47] Sembiyanmadevi and Kundavai Devi. Can the noble Pazhuvetarayar refute this?”

Hearing this, some people laughed.

“Great! You are all laughing! I don’t know how you are able to, though. This is so shameful for me that I would prefer to die. When Devaralan asked for sacrifice why didn’t you sacrifice me? My clan is almost a thousand years old. I would be the perfect sacrifice,” growled Pazhuvetarayar.

Hearing this everybody fell silent in the group.

“My lord, please forgive our mistake. It was just a harmless joke. You are our leader. You cannot desert us now. We are ready to act according to your wishes,” said Sambuvereyar.

“I am sorry, I lost my patience. Let me tell you, one thing. About a hundred years ago, King Vijayalaya captured Thanjavur and crushed the Mutharaiyar. Since then, the Chola Kingdom has been steadily growing powerful. We have expanded the Kingdom up to Krishna River, but the territory beyond that has not been conquered and nor has Elangai come within our power. Can anyone tell me the reason, why they are holding out to us?” asked Pazhuvetarayar.

“We all know the reason. The first reason is Northern commander Prince Aditya Karikalan and the second is our Southern Commander Prince Arulmozhivarman,” said Mazhaverreyar.

“I agree with Mazhaverreyar. For the past 100 years, only those warriors who have had years of experience in warfare have become commanders, but now the Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan is the Northern commander. But what do you think he is doing? He is not preparing to conquer the lands beyond Krishna River - instead, he is sitting in Kanchi, building a golden palace. Have you ever heard of a Prince building a golden palace to reside? Even the great King Paranthaka Chola thought it fit to build a golden roof for Lord Shiva’s temple and not a golden palace for himself. In Kanchi, Pallava Emperors^[48] have built many magnificent stone palaces, but our Crown Prince found them all lacking in grandeur. He needs a golden

palace to live in. He is using all the wealth that was won from the Gangapadi^[49] to build this splendid palace of his. And what more, he didn't send one piece of that gold to the royal treasury in Thanjavur."

"Is the work on Golden Palace completed?" asked one of the noble men.

"Yes, the work has been completed. That's what my spies have told me. We have also been getting message after message for Sundara Chola from his dear son, asking him to come and stay in the palace," said Pazhuvetarayar.

"Is the Maharaja going to Kanchi?" asked one of them in a worried tone.

"Nothing of that sort will happen when I am there. My brother is the commander of the Thanjavur Fort, and no one can approach the King without his permission. No one can enter the fort and meet the king or give messages. We have already stopped two or three messages that came for him."

This elicited cheers among the group, and they all shouted, "Long live Pazhuvetarayar."

"Wait, there is more. You have only heard of our Crown Prince's actions. Wait until you hear about Prince Arulmozhivarman's strange warfare. We all know about Yuddha Dharma^[50] and the way it was fought by our ancestors. 'If we wage a war on another Kingdom, our soldiers will have to make arrangements to procure food in that Kingdom.' This is what we have been following. But do you know what Prince Arulmozhivarman says? He wants us to send him food

from the Chola Kingdom. It has been almost a year since I have been sending ships loaded with sacks filled with rice and grains.”

“Strange! Strange!”

“Never heard of anything like this before,” exclaimed the noblemen.

“Do you know what reason he gives for his actions? He says that he doesn’t want to trouble the people of Elangai by grabbing food from them. We have to fight only the royal forces of Elangai and not their people. Therefore, we are compelled to send them food from here...
“

“I have never heard anything like this before. This looks as if we will have to fall at the feet of the people, whom we have conquered,” said Sambuverayar.

“Do you know the problems that I have to face because of both these Princes? The treasury is getting depleted, thanks to them and I am forced to levy more tax on all of you. That’s why I have been nominated as the head of the treasury. It’s only my loyalty to the Chola Kingdom that’s stopping me from resigning my post. Otherwise, I would have done that a long time ago.”

“No! No! You must not do that. You cannot desert us this way. Have you tried speaking to the Emperor?” asked Mazhavereyar.

“Of course, I have. But each time he says, ‘Ask Periyapirati or Kundavai.’ As I mentioned earlier, because of his illness the Emperor has lost his sense of judgment. He does not consult any of us before taking an important decision. He has more trust on the advice of his aunt Sembiyanmadevi and of course next comes his dear daughter Kundavai. He wants ‘us’ to go to her for advice; we who have grown

old serving this kingdom, must go and ask advice from that little girl. I have never heard of women interfering in the affairs of the kingdom. How long will I have to bear this? It drives me mad. I wish to resign my post and go away to Pazhuvur.”

“No! No!” Cried everybody at the same time.

“Then what do we do? I cannot bear to be in this kingdom that has become worse than Allirajyam^[51].



Chapter 8 - Who is in the Palanquin?

After Pazhuvetarayar's declaration, silence reigned in the meeting for a while and then indistinct murmurs and mutterings were heard, as people discussed in hushed whispers amongst themselves and Vandiya Devan couldn't hear anything.

Sambuverayar spoke up and said, "We cannot keep on talking amongst ourselves the whole night. Does anybody here have something to say?"

"I have a doubt. And I am sure just like me, many others here in this group have the same doubt. We would like to clear this up with the Pazhuvur Lord if he so permits us," said one of them.

"If I am not mistaken, this is Vanangamudiyar^[52], right? Why don't you come here?" said Pazhuvetarayar.

Vanangamudiyar got up and came to the center of the courtyard, where there was more light.

"I show all my anger in the battlefield, not when I am among friends, so feel free to ask any doubt," said Pazhuvetarayar.

"You stated that Sundara Chola asks the advice of women, but many people say the same about you, as well. Though I didn't believe it, I would like to clarify it with you."

"Can you be more specific?"

"We all know that the Noble Pazhuvur Lord got married two years ago..."

“Vanangamudiyaray! I forbid you to bring this subject up. How can you embarrass our distinguished guest in this manner with unwanted questions like...” objected Sambuverayar.

“Sambuverayaray! Please be patient. Let Vanangamudiyar finish what he started. Yes, I agree that at the age of 55 years, I got married. But I am not ashamed of it. I have never declared myself to be Lord Rama who would be content with just one wife. I fell in love with her, and she fell in love with me, and we got married according to the ancient Hindu Shastra. Whatever could be wrong with this?”

“No, I never said that it was wrong. I don’t think anybody here has only one wife. But...”

“But what? Don’t hesitate, please ask whatever doubt you have?”

“But people say that you listen to whatever your young wife says and follow her advice while taking important decisions related to the Kingdom. They also say that you take her along with you, wherever you go.”

Somebody suddenly laughed in the crowd. Because of the dim light and the dark shadows that the trees cast around they didn’t know who had laughed in the group. Sambuverayar became furious and got up, “Who dared to laugh? Come forward and give an explanation.”

“Sambuverayaray! It was me who laughed,” said Pazhuvetarayar. And then he said, Vanagamudiyaray! What is wrong in taking my wife along with me wherever I travel? It is true that I have always taken her along with me. But the rumour that I listen to her advice to conduct affairs of the Kingdom is wrong. I have never done that...”

“Alright. In that case, I have one more doubt. What is this Palanquin doing here? Shouldn’t it be in the anthapuram? Is somebody sitting inside it, because I heard the clanking of bangles?”

Everybody fell silent. This question was apparently running in everybody's mind.

“Right question! I am entitled to give a reply to this. But can I give you an answer at the end of this meeting? Do you all have that much faith in me?” said Pazhuvetarayar.

“Of course, we do,” said everybody simultaneously.

“Thank you, my friends. So, let us finish discussing what we started. Let Sundara Chola live for a long time but in case he dies like the astrologers and the physicians predict, we will have to decide who should ascend the throne?”

“We would like to hear your opinion about this, my Lord. We will abide by your decision,” said Sambuverayar.

“That is not right. Each one of us will have to think and decide upon this. I would like to remind you about some old incidents that happened. We all know that Sundara Chola’s uncle, the great King Gandaradithan, ascended the throne after King Paranthakan I. When he died 24 years ago, his son Madhuranthakan was but a one-year-old baby. Which is why, we all agreed to crown Sundara Chola, Gandaradithan’s nephew as the next king. And Sundara Chola has been a good King to all of us, until two years ago when he fell ill. He has been loved by the people for bringing in prosperity and peace in the Chola Kingdom. But now that he is ailing, who should ascend the throne next? Who has more rights, Sundara Chola’s son or

Gandaradithar's son? Think and tell me, should it be Gandaradithar's son Madhuranthakan who has attained the right age and is acclaimed as a great devotee of Lord Shiva just like his father or should it be Aditya Karikalan who is Sundara Chola's son."

"Madhuranthakan should ascend the throne. He is the rightful heir," said Sambuverayar. After he said that many others followed and agreed.

"If you all feel that Madhuranthakan is the rightful heir then we must strive towards establishing his royal rights. We should be willing to pledge our life for him. Are we ready to do that?" asked Pazhuvetarayar.

The crowd fell silent again. After some time, Sambuverayar spoke, "We are eager to pledge our lives for Madhuranthakan, but we have other doubts. What does Prince Madhuranthakan want? Does he wish to ascend the throne after Sundara Chola? Is he ready to take the responsibility of this great kingdom? All that we have heard about him is that he has renounced worldly life and is forever involved in his devotion towards Lord Shiva. He himself has publicly declared that he has no wish to be the King. And we also know that his respected mother, Periyapirati Sembiyanmadevi, does not want her son to ascend the throne, which is why she has brought him up to be an ardent devotee of Lord Shiva."

"Correct question. I am obliged to remove this doubt. My apologies, I should have spoken about this earlier, but I forgot. It is true that Sembiyanmadevi does not wish her son to ascend the throne, which is why she had deliberately kept him away from the affairs of the kingdom. Not many people know the reason as to why she did that.

She feared that if he ascended the throne or even aspired to ascend the throne, his life would be in danger. Wouldn't a mother desire that her only son is alive rather than risk dying trying to be the king? Prince Madhuranthakan indulged her in this wish for the past 25 years and involved himself completely in religious work. But lately, he has felt that this Chola Kingdom belongs to him and that he has to take up the responsibilities that come along with it. If he gets to know to know that you are all ready to support him, he is willing to come out in open and claim his right to the throne," said Pazhuvetarayar.

"Is that true? Is there any proof for this?" asked one of the noblemen.

"I will provide you with evidence that will satisfy all of you. At the same time, I will also clear Vanangamudiyar's earlier doubt," said Pazhuvetarayar and walked towards the veiled palanquin.

He stood near the palanquin and said, "My dear Prince, it is time for you to come out and meet your loyal allies who are ready to fight unto death for your royal rights over the Chola throne."

Vandiya Devan cautiously looked down from the terrace. He saw the same fair hand parting the veils but what he had assumed to be lady's bangles was actually an ornamental bracelet that royal princes generally wore. The next instant 'a beautiful prince' had come out of the palanquin.

"This is King Gandaradithan's son Madhuranthakan. Since he came in a palanquin, I had assumed that he was a woman. Even Azhwarkadiyan made the same mistake" thought Vandiya Devan. He looked up to see whether Azhwarkadiyan was still hanging on the wall but couldn't see anything because of the dark shadows.

By then, everybody had started cheering, “Long live Prince Madhuranthakan! Long Live Lord Pazhuvetarayar!” Vandiya Devan felt that it might be dangerous to linger around, so he made his way back to his bed.



Chapter 9 - From Kadambur To Kollidam

Vandiya Devan had lived most of his life in dry regions where there was no river or large lake, which is why he never learned how to swim. Once, while he was patrolling the border of the Chola Kingdom (near the Rashtrakuta Kingdom), he got caught in a current in the river. The current swirled him round and round and started dragging him down. He started losing consciousness; the current had sucked out all his energy. Just when he thought that he would die, he miraculously escaped, and a wave dumped him on the shore.

That night when he went back to his bed, he felt the same swirling motion in his head. But this time, he was not stuck in a river's current, but in a very dangerous political game.

How am I going to escape from this now? he thought. The Chola Kingdom has only been recently relieved of warring enemies thanks to Prince Aditya Karikalan. The Crown Prince is a great warrior and an intelligent statesman. His leadership qualities were also admirable because that's what had made him lead a small army against King Krishna and crush the Rashtrakutas."

Just when the Chola Kingdom became safe from these enemies, new plots against the Kingdom are being hatched by some of the most influential and powerful noblemen of the Kingdom!"

“Almost all the powerful nobles and cheiftains are involved in this plot against the Kingdom. What would be the result of this dangerous scheme? Is this the first time they are having this kind of meeting? It seems that Pazhuvetarayar has been taking Prince Madhuranthakan in his veiled palanquin all around the Chola Kingdom. How very convenient indeed that he got married to a young wife at this age? It is aiding him a lot in plotting against the King!” thought Vandiya Devan.

So far, Vandiya Devan had never had any second thoughts about Prince Aditya Karikalar’s rights to the throne. He had never even thought that there could be another claimant to it. The only thing that he had heard about Prince Madhuranthakan was that he was a great devotee of Lord Shiva, just like his father. But he had never imagined that the Prince had any claims over the throne.

But who has more rights to the throne? Prince Aditya Karikalan or Prince Madhuranthakan? It seems that they both have equal rights and claims over the throne. But what is my duty now? I had so many plans for my future thinking that Prince Aditya would ascend the throne and may be in due course of time by serving him well I could retrieve my old Kingdom from him. Now someone has challenged Prince Aditya’s authority. When will he overcome these hurdles? When will he become the King? And when will I get my Kingdom back

With these thoughts racing through his mind, it took him a long time to sleep. The next morning, he did not get up until almost mid-morning when Kandanmaran shook him that he woke up with a start.

“Did you sleep well yesterday?” asked his friend, as a good host should. “Yesterday after the other guests retired to their chambers, I came here. You were sound asleep,” he added.

It took Vandiya Devan some time to suppress all the thoughts that rose in his mind about the previous night. He was afraid that he would blabber something about the midnight conference that he was not supposed to know about. So, he said carefully, “I was dead tired yesterday. I must have slept like a log. Oh, God! It is so late. I must leave immediately. Kandanmara, please ask your servants to get my horse ready for my journey.”

“What nonsense! How can you go now? What’s the hurry anyway? You will have to stay here for at least ten days,” said Kandanmaran.

“No, my dear friend, I can’t stay. I need to reach Thanjavur urgently. My uncle is not well. He might die any minute. I have to go to see him,” lied Vandiya Devan.

“Oh, is that so? Then you will have to stay here when you return from Thanjavur.”

“Sure, but now you have to give me leave.”

“Wait, don’t rush like this. You can partake your morning meal here and then we can go. I will accompany you to Kollidam^[53].”

“How is that possible? So many notable guests are at your house - how can you leave them and come with me?” objected Vandiya Devan.

“No guest is as important to me, thank you,” said Kandanmaran and after a pause, he continued, “My father and the other servants will attend to the guests. I couldn’t even talk to you properly yesterday, so I am coming with you till Kollidam.”

“As you wish, my friend,” accepted Vandiya Devan.

After an hour or so, both friends set out towards Kollidam in their respective horses. Since the horses were trotting slowly, they had time to look around and reminisce about the time they had fought together at the border.

After some time Vandiya Deva said, “Kandanmara, even if I stayed for only one night at your place, it was very useful for me. But I just have one disappointment. You spoke so much about your sister's beauty while we were together, but I couldn’t get a decent glimpse of her yesterday. She was so shy that she was hiding behind your mother all the time. I agree that girls are naturally shy by nature, but your sister seems to be extremely shy.”

Kandanmaran looked as if he wished to say something but he kept quiet.

Vandiya Devan continued, “Anyway I will be staying in your house for some time on my return journey - I will try to talk to her then. Maybe, by then she would have overcome her shyness. What did you say her name was?”

“Manimegalai.”

“What a beautiful name! I am sure she must be as beautiful...”

Kandanmaran couldn’t take it anymore. He interrupted, “My friend! Please, forget about my sister. Just forget everything I said about

her. Don't even talk about her to me."

"What is this, Kandanmara? Why even yesterday you hinted that I could become the son-in-law of your house!" exclaimed Vandiya Devan.

"Yes, that was what I thought. But now things have changed. My parents have fixed another bridegroom for her, and she has agreed to the match too."

Vandiya Devan thought, "Long Live Manimegalai." It was not very difficult for him to guess who that bridegroom would be. It must be the great prince who travels in a veiled palanquin - Prince Madhuranthakan.

"Oh! So, you have fixed your sister's marriage with one of the noblemen who came yesterday. Let me tell you frankly, Kandanmara, I am neither disappointed nor frustrated. I rather expected something like this to happen."

"You expected something like this to happen!" exclaimed Kandanmaran.

"Who would like to have a poor orphan like me as their son-in-law? I have no possessions, no kingdom, no land and no property, no home. I am a nobody. What if my ancestors were 'great' once upon a time? It is of no value in today's world."

"My friend, enough! Please don't insult my family anymore. I beg you. Our change of plans has got nothing to do with what you are. We have a very important reason for this. When you know come to know about it, you will accept it yourself. But right now, I can't talk about it. So please forgive me."

“Kandanmara! What is this? Why are you talking so mysteriously?”

“You will have to forgive me for that, my friend. It is something that I can’t share, even with you. But whatever happens, it will not affect our friendship. I can assure you that. Please have faith in me. I will not forsake you. I promise.”

“I thank you for that pledge. But I don’t see any reason for it because I am not dependent on ‘you’ for anything. I depend only on my sword.”

“Don’t worry, we will soon get an opportunity to use our swords. At that time, we will fight together like brothers, shoulder to shoulder.”

“What are you talking about? Do you expect a war soon or are you planning to go to Ellangai to join the war?”

“Ellangai? If you hear about the war there, you will be surprised. Do you know, we are forced to send ships full of food for the soldiers who are fighting there? It seems that they won’t take any food from the people there. It is so shameful! But I am not talking about that war. I will tell you when the time comes. But until then don’t ask me anything.”

“Fine, if you don’t want to tell me, you don’t have to. Anyway, we have reached Kollidam.”

At a distance, they saw the rushing waters of Kollidam, a tributary of the Cauvery. They saw a boat and a boatman at the bank. He already had one passenger who looked like a Saivar.

When they neared the bank, the boatman asked, “Lord, are you coming?”

“My friend is coming. Wait awhile,” Kandanmaran said.

Both the friends got down from their horses.

“I was quite thoughtless to come with the horse. What do I do with it? Can we get him on the boat too?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“No, you can’t take a horse across this river in a boat. Don’t worry, that’s why I had asked two of my servants to follow us on foot. One will ride your horse back to Kadambur while the other will come with you across the river and buy you another horse.”

“How considerate of you! You really are a true friend.”

“You must have thought our Kollidam is like the dry placid rivers of Palaram^[54]. You cannot take a horse on the boat across our river.”

“That’s right. Forgive me for thinking that way about your river. So much water everywhere, it looks like a sea!”

Both friends embraced each other. Vandiya Devan and one of Kandanmaran’s servants got into the boat. As the boatman started rowing, they heard a shout from a distance.

“Stop! Halt the boat. Wait for me.”

The man who was shouting came running towards the boat. At one glance Vandiya Devan knew who it was. It was Azhwarkadiyan Nambi!

The Saivar in the boat immediately shouted, “Row harder! I will not come with that scoundrel in this boat. Let him come on the next ferry.”

But Vandiya Devan interrupted and said, “Please wait. Let him come. We have room.”

He thought it would be interesting to ask the Nambi about the previous night’s incidents.



Chapter 10 - Kudandhai Jodhidar

When you see the Ponni River flowing through the Chola Kingdom, you are tempted to describe her thus –

Born in Kudaga Nadu^[55], when Ponni (river) attained age, she wanted to meet her bridegroom, Samudrarajan (the sea). In her desire to meet him, she ran wildly through the forests and plains. As she neared him, her desire for him grew and there sprang from her, two arms racing to reach out to him. As her desire intensified, she developed more arms, each racing to reach out first to her lover.

Do you want to know how our bride was bedecked to meet her groom? The women of the Chola Kingdom beautified her with fertile green sarees and lovely flowers.

“River Ponni! Is there a young woman in our kingdom who has not been elated by your presence? Could there be anyone in this world who is not enamored by your beauty?”

Did you know that one of the arms of the Ponni is called Arisalaru? But not many people know that there is a river flowing there at all because of the thick grove of trees that grow on the banks. Some compare Arisalaru to a princess who is too shy to leave the anthapuram. But no one can compare her beauty with anything else in this world.

Now let us go and meet this shy beautiful princess who is hiding behind the trees. But what do you think we see there? A beautifully crafted boat in the shape of a swan and who do you think was on it?

Heavenly apsaras^[56]! And there is nothing in this world that can compare to their beauty as well.

Among these apsaras, there was one woman who stood out. She looked like a queen who was born to rule the three worlds. Beside her was another woman who was playing a veena^[57] and singing along with it. They both were exceptionally beautiful women.

Though they both were gorgeous, there was a difference in their beauty. Dignity and intelligence shone in the face of the first woman while goodness was marked in the second.

The first had the complexion of a lotus flower while the second had that of a full moon. We could go on with comparisons of their beauty, but we are running out of time because both of them are headed somewhere.

Without any further ado, let me introduce them to you. The first woman is King Sundara Chola's daughter, Princess Kundavai, the sister of Prince Arulmozhivarman later to be known as King Rajaraja Chola. Her intelligence and goodness inspired so much respect among the people that they called her Elayapirati. Later in history, we will also know her as a woman who brought up King Rajarajan's son, King Rajendra Chola, and inspired him to achieve greatness.

The other woman is Princess Kundavai's companion and close friend belonging to the clan of Kodumbalur^[58]. Only one thing can be predicted about her at this point in the story. She was going to be the luckiest woman in the history of South India.

After the boat had reached the bank, both the women got down. Princess Kundavai told the other women, “Girls! Stay here, we will be back in an hour.”

All the other women in the boat were not mere companions of the princess. They were all daughters of petty kings and noble lords who ruled under Sundara Chola. They were sent to live with Princess Kundavai as her companions, but when Princess Kundavai took only the Kodumbalur Princess along with her, they naturally felt jealous and disappointed.

Both the princesses walked towards the royal chariot that was awaiting them.

“Vanathi, get into the chariot,” Kundavai told her and got into the chariot after her.

“Akka[\[59\]](#), where are we going? Will you tell me?” asked Vanathi.

“Why won’t I tell you? We are going to Kudandhai Jodhidhar’s house.”

“Why are we going to the Jodhidhar’s house?”

“Why else would I go there? It is for you, my dear. You have been looking so depressed, and you have become so thin and emaciated because you are not eating properly. I am going to ask the astrologer when your health will improve.”

“Akka, please let’s go back. There is nothing wrong with me. Let’s not go there to ask about me.”

“Fine! We will not ask about you. We will go there and ask about me. Satisfied?”

“What do you want to know from the astrologer, akka?”

“Will I get married? Or will I have to stay unmarried all my life?”

“Akka, what is the use of asking the astrologer this question? You will have to ask yourself. You just have to indicate your consent and princes from all over the world will come forward to marry you.”

“You may be right, Vanathi, but if I get married to a prince, he would want to take me to his kingdom. And I don’t want to leave the Chola Kingdom. I have taken a vow that I will never leave my kingdom.”

“That is not a big hurdle. You just have to tell the lucky prince who marries you, to stay back here with you - that’s all.”

“I will be just inviting more trouble. You don’t realize the problems that could arise if I demanded that.”

“But you will have to get married, one day or the other.”

“Who says so? Look at Avvayar^[60]. Did she get married?”

“Avvayar became an old woman because God granted her that wish but you are not like her.”

“Well, if at all I have to get married, I will choose a poor soldier, who won’t take me away from this Chola Kingdom.”

“Akka, then, you will never leave this place.”

“No, even if you call me to heaven, I will not leave my home and come with you.”

“Ah! Today my heart is at peace.”

“And why is that?”

“I thought that if you get married and leave this kingdom, then I would have gone along with you because I cannot live without you. At the same time, I don’t want to leave this beautiful Chola Kingdom.”

“But if you get married you will have to go.”

“I am not getting married, Akka.”

“What? What happened to all that advice you gave me, just now?”

“I am not ‘you’ by any respect.”

“My dear, don’t try to fool me. I know that you don’t have any particular love for the Chola Kingdom because the real ‘*Chola* Kingdom’ that you are in love with, has gone to Elangai to fight. Do you think I don’t know your secret?”

“Akka, do you think I am that foolish? He is like the rising sun, and I am like the mist that will disappear when the sun’s rays fall on it. How can the mist desire the love of the sun?”

“Why not? Haven’t you seen the mist covering the sun in the morning?”

Hearing this, Vanathi suddenly became enthusiastic, “So you really think that the mist can attain the sun’s affection?” But again, her happiness evaporated. “The mist wishes to gain the sun’s attention but what does the sun do - it burns so fiercely that the mist disappears.”

“That is wrong, Vanathi. Knowing the mists’ desire the sun absorbs her within himself. The sun is so possessive about the mist that it does not want anybody to look at her in the daylight.”

“Akka, you are trying to pacify me.”

“So, you do accept the fact that you are depressed about something? That’s why we are going to see the Kudandhai^[61] Jodhidar^[62].”

“If I am depressed, how will he know the reason?” sighed Vanathi.

Kudandhai Jodhidar’s house was located on the outskirts of the Kudandhai town and could be approached without entering the town. When the chariot reached the astrologer’s house, they found him and his pupil waiting outside to welcome them.

“Devi, welcome, welcome! I am most fortunate indeed that you have graced my poor house with your presence. Please come inside.”

“Jodhidaray! Do you expect anybody to come here at this time?”

“No Amma, nowadays not many people come in search of me. People go to an astrologer, only when there are problems or troubles in their life. But in the Chola Kingdom, thanks to our King Sundara Chola, everybody is living happily and prosperously. Then why would they come to astrologers like me?”

“So, you mean to say, that I have some problem in my life which is why I have come to see you?”

“No Amma, you have come here to solve my problem. When people don’t have problems, the astrologer has nothing to do. He has no customers, and so no money - that’s why you have come here. Please come inside Devi,” answered the astrologer cleverly.

Kundavai and Vanathi went inside the astrologer’s thatched house. The astrologer told his pupil, “You stay here and keep watch. By any

chance, if somebody does come, don't allow them inside."

Both the princesses went inside the astrologer's puja room and sat in the seats that were kept ready for them. He sat in front of them.

"Devi, please tell me the reason for your visit."

"Jodhidaray, can't you find that out through your astrology?"

"I can," said the astrologer and closed his eyes and chanted a mantra. After some time, he opened his eyes and said, "You have come here to learn the future of this young girl. That's what Devi Parasakthi^[63] tells me."

"Fantastic! Your powers are great indeed. Yes, that is indeed the purpose of my visit.

A year ago, she came to live with me in Pazhaiarai^[64]. Then she was very cheerful and happy. For the past four months, I don't know what has happened to her, she is very depressed. She says that her health is fine, but I am not happy to see her like this. Her uncle has left her in my care, and it's my responsibility to keep her happy. What shall I say, if he asks me what has happened to her..."

"Devi, this is Kodumbalur Ilaya Velar's daughter. Her name is Vanathi, isn't that so?"

"Yes. How do you know all this?"

"I have the horoscope of this princess in my collection. Please wait," he said. Then he opened a wooden chest in the room and rummaged in it and took out a palm leaf manuscript.



Chapter 11 - Sudden Entry

Modern-day Kumbakonam (near Thanjavur) was called Kudhandhai in those days. It was situated between Thanjavur and Pazhairai, the old capital of the Cholas. It was not only famous for its temples but also for its astrologer Kudandhai Jodhidar, who was patronized by the members of the royal family and other noblemen. And that's probably why he had a huge collection of horoscopes of Princesses and Princes belonging to different clans. He took out Vanathi's horoscope and studied it intently.

After some time, he looked up to see Vanathi's face then looked back at the horoscope and then looked up again...

"Jodhidaray! Are you going to say something or not?" asked Kundavai, losing her patience.

"Amma, what will I say? What do I say? I am rendered speechless. Once when I had looked at this horoscope by chance, I couldn't believe it myself. But now when I look at this girl's face and her horoscope, I am astonished," said the Jodhidar at last.

"Well if you are surprised enough, can you please tell us something?" asked Kundavai.

"Amma, this is a very lucky horoscope. If you don't misunderstand me, I would like to tell you one thing. Her horoscope is more fortunate than yours. I have never in my life come across such a lucky horoscope before." he declared.

Kundavai smiled and looked at Vanathi who was looking shy, “Akka, how come this Jodhidar is calling this unlucky being the luckiest person in the world?” asked Vanathi with disbelief.

“Amma what did you say? If my predictions about you are wrong, I will never predict anything else ever again.”

“No Jodhidaray! Don’t do that. Your astrological skills help a lot of people. She does not believe it because you are talking ‘generally.’ Can you tell us something specific?” asked Kundavai.

“Alright. Four months ago, an incident occurred which seemed inauspicious, but it is not so because she is going to get all the luck in the world because of that.”

“Vanathi, what did I tell you? See?” exclaimed Kundavai.

“I think you told him all this beforehand.”

“Look how she is talking!”

“Let her speak Amma, tomorrow when she gets married to the greatest of the kings...”

“Well said! All young girls love to hear about their marriage. Where will her groom come from? Can you tell us something about that?”

“Oh, yes I can.” he said and studied the horoscope intently.

“Amma, the groom for this princess will come from this Kingdom. But at present, he is not here. He has gone across the sea!”

Hearing this Kundavai looked at Vanathi, whose face reflected the happiness of her heart.

“Who is he? Which clan will he belong to? Is there some way to know who he is?”

“Oh, yes. This girl’s groom will have the Sangu Chakram^[65] mark in his hands.”

Kundavai looked again excitedly at Vanathi, but she looked down shyly.

“Then there will be a mark in her hand also,” exclaimed Kundavai.

“Amma, have you ever seen this girl’s feet?”

“Jodhidaray! What are you talking? Do you want me to fall at her feet?”

“No! No! I am not saying that. What I am saying is, one day queens, princesses, and noblewomen would consider themselves fortunate to bow down before her feet.”

“Akka, this old man is mocking me. Is this why you brought me here? Come let us leave,” exclaimed Vanathi with anger.

“Why are you getting upset, my girl? Let him say anything he wants.”

“I am not saying anything from imagination. It is all written in her horoscope. Ask her to show her feet. If the lines of the lotus flower are not there, then I will surely give up this profession.”

“Enough Jodhidaray! If you say even one more word about her, she is going to drag me out of this house. Can you tell us something about her groom?”

“Yes, I can. Her husband will be a very brave soldier. He will win a hundred battles. He will be a great king - an emperor who will rule over many kingdoms...”

“I don’t believe this! How is this possible?” exclaimed Kundavai who was looking both pleased and worried at the same time.

“Even, I don’t believe all this. I think he is saying all this because he thinks that you will be happy to hear it,” said Vanathi.

“Amma if you don’t believe me now that is fine. But one day you will understand the truth of my words. Please don’t forget this poor astrologer at that time.”

“Akka, shall we leave?” asked Vanathi who was on the verge of tears.

“I have just one more thing to tell Amma, the Prince who will marry this girl will have to face many hurdles and dangers...”

“Oh, God!” exclaimed both the women.

“But he will surpass all the dangers and hurdles and attain greatness. Devi, one day, take a look at her stomach. If she doesn’t have the lines of the banyan leaf, I will leave this profession.”

“What is so special about banyan leaf?”

“Don’t you know who resides in the banyan leaf? The Great Maha Vishnu himself! A child will be born to this girl - who will be the very embodiment of Maha Vishnu. Unlike her husband, her child will not have any danger or hurdle. Wherever he goes, he will be victorious.

He will conquer many lands, win many battles and he will be known as the greatest king in history...”

As the Jodhidar went on like this, Kundavai in rapt attention heard every word of his with her eyes wide open. Suddenly she heard Vanathi’s faint voice.

“Akka! I am feeling faint.” moaned Vanathi and fainted.

“Jodhidaray! Hurry get me some water!” said Kundavai and pulled Vanathi onto her lap. And when the Jodhidar got a jug of water, she sprinkled a handful on Vanathi’s face.

“Don’t worry Amma, everything will be alright.” consoled the Jodhidar.

“No, No, I am not worried. This is nothing new. She has a habit of fainting. After some time, she will wake up and ask what happened.” said Kundavai.

And then lowering her voice, Kundavai asked, “Jodhidaray, I came to ask one vital question. Everywhere people are discussing disturbing rumors. A comet is seen in the sky for the past few days. Is there a meaning behind all this? Is there any danger to the kingdom?”

“Amma, this one thing I cannot tell you. There is no horoscope for kingdoms. So we cannot make any kind of prediction about all this. Maybe a soothsayer can predict events with the help of his third eye but not this poor astrologer.”

“Jodhidaray! You are very clever indeed. I know that there cannot be a horoscope for kingdoms, but if you look at my father’s and

brother's horoscopes you can surely tell the future of this kingdom, can't you?"

"I will do that leisurely on another day Amma. In general, times are not good. Everybody in the royal family will have to be careful."

"I am anxious about my father. I don't think his health has improved since he left Pazhaiarailxv."

"I told you earlier itself Amma. There is a grave danger awaiting the Emperor and the royal family as well. Only with the grace of Durga Devi will it be averted."

"Akka, where are we?" asked Vanathi faintly as she opened her eyes in Kundavai's lap.

"My sweet! You are still on earth. Your chariot to heaven has not arrived yet. Can you get up and walk or do I have to carry you?"

Vanathi sat up immediately and asked, "Did I faint, Akka?"

"No. You just slept off in my lap. I even sang a sweet lullaby for you. Didn't you hear it?"

"Don't get angry, Akka! I didn't do it deliberately."

"Oh, no, you didn't. If the Jodhidar had told me similar predictions, I would have probably fainted too."

"No, Akka! It is not because of that. I didn't believe his predictions anyway."

"I don't know whether you believed them or not, but you scared him quite well. I shouldn't have brought a coward like you along with me."

"I told you earlier that I won't come."

“It is my fault, dear girl. Get up. Can you walk or shall I carry you?”

“No, I can walk.”

“One second Amma, I will get Durga Devi’s offering for you.” said the astrologer and started closing the palm leaf manuscript.

“Jodhidaray! You said so many things about me. But you didn’t say anything about Akka.” asked Vanathi.

“Amma, I have read Elayapirati’s horoscope before. What else would you like to know?”

“Tell me about the lucky prince who is going to marry her.”

“He will be a brave soldier, blessed by Brihaspati^[66] in intelligence, graced by Saraswathi ^[67]in learning. He will also be as skilful as Arjuna^[68] and as handsome as Manmadan^[69].”

“When will this prince come?”

“He is coming, Amma. He will appear before her very soon.”

Kundavai much amused by all this asked, “How will he come? On horse or chariot or else will he walk it up here or will he jump down here from the roof?”

“Akka, I can hear a horse outside.”

“You will always hear all kinds of noise.”

“No, I am not joking. Listen carefully.” Vanathi was right. They could hear a horse neighing outside the house.

“So what? People will be riding horses in Kudandhai town. What about it?”

“No, I think it is coming here.”

“You will hear all sorts of strange things. Come let us go.” Just at that instant, they heard an argument outside the house.

“Is this the Jodhidhar’s house?”

“Yes. Who are you?”

“Is the Jodhidhar there?”

“You can’t go inside.”

“Why not?”

“I won’t let you.”

“I want to see the Jodhidhar.”

“Come afterwards.”

“I can’t. I am in a hurry.”

“Stop! Do not go inside!”

“Stand aside. If you try to stop me, I will kill you.”

“Ayya! Ayya! Please don’t go inside.”

At this instant, a young soldier barged into the house while the Jodhidhar’s disciple was trying to hold him from behind.

I am sure you would have guessed who this young soldier is. Who else could it be but our friend Vandiya Devan?

Everybody looked at Vandiya Devan, and he too looked at everybody. No, he looked only at one person in the house. Even that is not true. He only saw Kundavai's face but that too not properly. He looked at her beautiful lips, her laughing eyes, her glowing fair complexion and her flushed cheeks in parts and they registered in his mind separately.

All this happened in a split of a second. The next instant he turned towards the Jodhidhar's pupil and asked, "Why didn't you tell me that there were women inside the house? If you had done that, I wouldn't have barged in like this."

And then he turned and walked out of the house but not before shooting yet another glance at Kundavai.

"My God! Looks as if a storm blew in!" exclaimed Kundavai.

"It's still not over. Listen to that," said Vanathi.

Vandiya Devan and the Jodhidhar's pupil were still arguing outside the house.

"Jodhidaray! Who is that man?" asked Kundavai.

"I don't know Amma, seems like a stranger."

Kundavai thought about something and burst out laughing. "Why are you laughing, Akka?"

"You are asking me why? Just a short while ago, we were talking about when and how my groom will come? That's why I am laughing." said Kundavai and laughed. Vanathi joined in the laughter with her.

The Jodhidar gave them both kungumum^[70] and the prasadam^[71] with a thoughtful look on his face. After taking the kungumum, both the ladies took leave of the astrologer and came out of the hut.

Outside Vandiya Devan was standing. When they came out, he apologized, “Forgive my intrusion. I didn’t know there were women inside otherwise I wouldn’t have barged in.”

Kundavai looked at him mischievously but didn’t say a word. She took Vanathi’s hand in hers and walked to the chariot that was waiting for them.

Incensed by her lack of attention towards him, Vandiya Devan declared loudly, “The women in Kudandhai seem to lack manners. They don’t even have the courtesy to answer a man who is talking to them.”

After the women got into the chariot and the charioteer steered it towards the road. Vandiya Devan stood watching it until the chariot disappeared.



Chapter 12 – Nandini

You are probably wondering how Vandiya Devan arrived at the Jodhidhar's house when we had left him on the banks of Kollidam.

Here is how it happened.

After Azhwarkadiyan had got into the boat, the Saivar looked at Vandiya Devan and told him, "Thambi, I am allowing him on the boat only because of you and on one condition. He should not say that Maha Vishnu's name while he is on it. If he does, I will ask the boatmen to throw him in the river."

"Nambi, did you hear that?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"If he does not say his Shiva's name then I will not say my lord's name."

"Who are you to tell me, not take Shiva's name?" growled the Saivaite and started singing a song about his lord.

Immediately, Azhwarkadiyan started singing poems of Aandal. Hearing this, the Saivaite said, "Shiva! Shiva!" and shut his ears with a disgusted look on his face.

After the song was over, Azhwarkadiyan looked at Vandiya Devan and said, "Thambi, this Saivar doesn't even want to listen to my lord's name, but little does he realize that this river is flowing directly from Srirangam where it washed my lord's feet. That is why Lord Shiva had meditated under this river at Thirvinaikaval because he knew that it is holy..."

Even before Azhwarkadiyan could finish, the Saivar pounced on him from the other end of the boat. Vandiya Devan, the Kadambur soldier, and the boatmen had to intervene and separate them.

“I think you both want to capsize the boat, fall into the river and attain salvation, but I have no intention of dying right now.” said Vandiya Devan.

“I don’t know whether we will attain salvation, but one thing is for sure - we will definitely end up in a crocodile’s stomach.” said one of the boatmen, pointing towards a passing crocodile.

“I am not afraid of crocodiles. My lord saved a mere elephant from a crocodile. He will surely save me too.” said Azhwarkadiyan.

“No, no, your lord is busy hiding behind the gopis of Vrindavan^[72],” said the Saivar.

“Or maybe Shiva has got another Bhasmasuran^[73] troubling him, which is why my lord has gone to help him.”

“This Vaishnavan seems to have forgotten how Vishnu was defeated during the Tripurasamharam^[74].”

.....
Why are Azhwarkadiyan and the Saivar fighting thus? We saw a similar scene in Veerananarayanapuram also.

About 600 years ago, Buddhism and Jainism were flourishing in Tamil Nadu. And during the same period, great devotees of Vishnu and Shiva who were called Azhvars^[75] and Nayanmars^[76] appeared and composed beautiful songs and poems praising Shiva and

Vishnu. Patronized by kings, they travelled from one place to another and were instrumental in building and renovating many temples in South India. Thanks to these great devotees, Buddhism and Jainism declined in Tamil Nadu.

At the same time, in a remote village in Kerala, there appeared a great saint. Renouncing the world at a young age, he came to be known as Adi Shankaracharya. Traveling all over India, he propounded a new meaning to the Vedas and to the Bhagwad Gita. He also established eight seats of learning. Following his teachings, there appeared many Advaita Sanyasis, who travelled from one place to another.

During the time of our story, there was an enormous religious movement happening in South India. On one side, there appeared Veera Saivars and on the other Veera Vaishnavas. Both parties tried to establish the supremacy of Vishnu over Shiva (or vice versa) by debating endlessly.

And sometimes, the Advaita Sanyasis also joined these debates. If you remember, we saw one such debate in Veeranarayanapuram and, not unlike that scenario, most of these discussions ended in fistfights also.

There is also a traditional story, which was told about the conflict between Saivars and Vaishnavaites.

Once a Veera Vaishnavar was walking by the temple walls of Thiruvinaikaval^[77]. Suddenly, a stone fell on his head, and he started bleeding. When he looked up, he saw a crow sitting on the tower of the temple.

Immediately, he forgot his pain and hailed the crow thus, “O! Veera Vaishnava crow of Srirangam! Raze this Shiva temple of Thiruvinaikaval to the ground!”

Now that we have learned of the religious situation in South India then, we will be able to understand the animosity between saivars and vaishnavars of that period.

*

After the ferry had reached the bank, the Saivaite looked at Azhwarkadiyan and cursed him for one last time, “May you go to hell!”

The Kadambur soldier also left with the Saivar, to buy a horse from the nearby town. Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan sat under the banyan tree near the riverbank to talk.

Both Nambi and Vandiya Devan were interested in learning about each other’s experience in Kadambur Palace, the previous night. But they approached the subject, in a roundabout way.

“Thambi, you left me and went off to Kadambur alone yesterday...”

“You have no idea how difficult it was for me to get inside,”

“Really? Then what did you do? You didn’t go?”

“No, No I went. Once I make up my mind to do something, I do it no matter what happens. The palace guards stopped me, but I threw them aside and entered the palace. Later, my friend came and took me inside.”

“Oh, yes! I thought something like this would have happened. You are a very brave soldier indeed! What happened after that? Did you meet the guests? How many had come?”

“Many guests had come. I don’t remember their names. But Pazhuvetarayar had come along with his young wife. My God! How can I describe her beauty?”

“You saw her!

“Of course, I did. My friend took me to the anthapuram. I saw her there. Among all the dark-complexioned women she looked like an apsara. Even Ramba^[78], Urvashi^[79], Indrani ^[80] and all other heavenly damsels would be incomparable to her beauty.”

“I see. What happened after that? Did you watch the Kuravai Koothu?”

“Oh, yes, I did. It was enchanting. I remembered you, when I saw their performance.”

“I just was not lucky enough to see it. What happened after that?”

“There was a war dance by Devaralan.”

“Did the Gods come upon him? Did he prophesize anything?”

“Yes, he did. He said that the land will prosper, rains will come, and the kingdom will flourish.”

“Is that all?”

“He said many other things related to the kingdom. But I didn’t bother to listen to all that.”

“You made a big mistake, Thambi. You should have listened to it. You are such a brave soldier, but if you wish to grow in life, you must pay attention, whenever somebody talks about the affairs of the Kingdom.”

“I agree with you, Nambi. This morning, I too felt the same way.”

“Why?”

“Kandanmaran came along with me to Kollidam. He was telling me that after the feast, all the guests had an important meeting, where they were discussing something about the kingdom.”

“What did they discuss?”

“I don’t know. Kandanmaran was talking generally. He didn’t tell me anything specifically. But from his mysterious words, I was able to deduce one thing. Something is going to change in this kingdom. What do you think it is?”

“What do I think about what?”

“Everywhere people are talking and discussing different rumours. A comet is seen in the sky for the past few days. Will there be some change in the kingdom? People are saying that many high officials are sitting together to discuss who the next heir is. Who do you think would be the next king?”

“How will I know all that, Thambi? I am but a poor devotee of my Lord Vishnu. All that I do is travel from one place to another, singing my lord's praises.”

Saying thus Azhwarkadiyan started singing one of his favourite Aandal poems.

“Please for God’s sake stop your song!” begged Vandiya Devan.

“It is such a beautiful song, Thambi! And you are asking me to stop singing it?”

“Nambi! I have a doubt. Shall I tell you what it is?”

“Sure, why not?”

“Promise me that you won’t pick up your stick and come after me.”

“Are you joking, Thambi? How can I come after a brave soldier like you?”

“I think your Vaishnavam, devotion, and these songs are just a drama that you put on. Am I correct?”

“Oh, my God! How can you say that?”

“I think you are acting thus just to conceal your desire for women. I have seen many people like you, who lust after women. I just can’t understand what you see in them.”

“Thambi! There are people who lust after women, but I am not one among them, and neither is my devotion towards my lord an act.”

“Then, why did you ask me to give your message to that lady in the palanquin, that too when you know that she is another man’s wife. And you wanted to come to Kadambur only to meet her. Please, don’t try to deny it.”

“I don’t deny it, Thambi. But I wanted to meet her for a different reason. That is a big story.”

“My horse hasn’t arrived yet. I have lot of time. Why don’t you tell me that story?”

“This is not just any story, Thambi, but a real one. Are you sure you want to hear it?”

“Only if you wish to tell me.”

“Yes, I think I will tell you. Who knows, you might be able to help me later. I hope at least then, you will help me.”

“Yes, I will, but only if I know that it is for the right cause.”

“Alright. You know this Pazhuvetarayar’s younger wife - her name is Nandini. You will be shocked to hear her story. It will make you wonder whether there is any dharma left in this world...”

*

Azhwarkadiyan was born in a remote village in the Pandya Kingdom. His father was a staunch Vaishnavait. One day, his father found a beautiful baby girl abandoned in their garden. He brought the baby home and adopted her as their daughter. And since the baby was beautiful and was found in a garden, she was named Nandini . Azhwarkadiyan loved and cared for her, just like a brother.

Growing up in an orthodox Vaishnavait family, Nandini’s devotion towards Maha Vishnu blossomed. Noticing this, Azhwarkadiyan sought to bring her up like another Andal. After their father’s death, he became her guardian. They both travelled from one place to another, collecting and compiling songs written by the Azhvars.

Three years ago, Azhwarkadiyan had gone on a pilgrimage to Thirumalai^[81]. While he was away, a terrible danger befell Nandini.

The final war between the Pandyas and the Cholas was being fought on Pandya land. Wounded severely in the battle, the Pandya king was saved by his bodyguards, who sought to hide him away, until he recovers. As Nandini's hut, was on the outskirts of the village, they took the wounded king there. Nandini took pity on the dying man and dressed his wounds.

At the same time, the Chola soldiers started searching high and low for the Pandya King. Soon one band of soldiers found him in Nandini's hut and killed him at once. Pazhuvetarayar, one of the commanders leading the Chola soldiers, was enamoured by Nandini's beauty, and he kidnapped and married her. Since then, Azhwarkadiyan had been trying to meet her and if possible, help her escape but in vain.

*

After listening to his tale, Vandiya Devan felt sorry for Azhwarkadiyan. He even thought of telling him that it was not Nandini, who was in the veiled palanquin but Prince Madhuranthakan. But something stopped him from doing so. He didn't want to take the risk of telling him that information without knowing for sure, whether the story he had heard just then was true or false.

Even as he was thinking thus, he spotted the Kadambur soldier and the horse at a distance.

"Thambi, I need your help."

“How can I help you Nambi? Pazhuvetarayar is a very influential nobleman in this kingdom, and I am but a poor soldier. I don’t know how I can help you?” answered Vandiya Devan carefully.

But after a pause, he asked, “Nambi, you say that you are not interested in political affairs. But can you answer this question? If something happens to the king, who will ascend the throne next?” and watched whether there was any change in Nambi’s countenance but there was none.

“How will I know that? You should ask Kudandhai Jodhidar.”

“Really? Is he that good?”

“Oh, yes, he is. He is an expert in astrology.”

Vandiya Devan immediately decided to meet him on his way.



Chapter 13 - Waxing Moon

After the chariot had left, the Jodhidar took Vandiya Devan inside his hut to his pooja room. After pointing him to a seat, the Jodhidar asked him, “Who are you, thambi? How did you come here?”

Vandiya Devan started laughing.

“Why are you laughing, thambi?”

“Nothing, Jodhidaray! I was thinking that since you are such a learned astrologer, can’t you find out who I am through your astrology.”

“Why not? I can find that out myself. But the only problem is that if I see astrology that way, then who is going to pay my fees?”

Vandiya Devan laughed out hearing this. “Jodhidaray! Who are those people who left just now?”

“Oh, them! I know whom you are asking about, thambi! You are asking about those people who were here when you barged in. You are asking about those people, who just now left in the chariot.”

“Yes, I am asking about them.”

“Ask. Whoever said that you couldn’t ask? The people about whom you are asking were, two women.”

“Thank you so much for telling me that, Jodhidaray! But incidentally, I knew that they both were women because I am not blind. When I see somebody, I can find out whether it is a man or a woman. I can also find out, if a man happened to dress like a woman.”

“Then why did you ask?”

“I was asking who those women were... which clan? What name...”

“Oh, I see. Women are generally set into four categories. Padmini, Chithini, Ghandarvi and Vidyadri^[82]...”

“Oh, God!”

“What, thambi?”

“I am calling out to my God, and you are asking me what?”

“Why not? God is omnipresent. I don’t think you have been in the company of the elders, which is why you didn’t know this simple truth. God is present within you, within me...”

“Please for God’s sake, stop.”

“It was God who made me talk so long, and it is God who asked me to stop.”

“Jodhidaray! Who were those women who just now left? What is their name? What clan do they belong to? If you can, please tell me plainly...”

“If I tell you plainly, what will you give me in return?”

“I will thank you from the bottom of my heart.”

“Who wants that, thambi? Can you give me some money?”

“If I give you money, will you tell me?”

“Thambi, listen to this. Many people will come to a Jodhidar’s house. I will not say anything about the individuals who left just now. And

tomorrow, if somebody comes and asks me about you, I will not say anything about you either.”

“Azhwarkadiyan was right about you, I think.”

“Azhwarkadiyan? Who is that?”

“You don’t know him? The way he was talking about you, I thought you would know him.”

“I might know the person by sight but not by name. Can you tell me what he looks like?”

“He is short and stout. He ties his hair in a knot on his forehead. He is fair complexioned and applies sandalwood with the mark of Vishnu all over his body. If he sees a Saivar, he will immediately start a debate, and if he sees an advaiti, it is his stick that would do the talking.”

“Seems to me that you are talking about Thirumalaiappan.”

“Really! So, he is known by different names?”

“Oh, yes. He is known by various names in different places.”

“So, you are saying that he is a big fraud, and one cannot believe what he says.”

“Mostly three-fourths of what he says will be imagination, but one-fourth might just be true.”

“So, you are saying that he is a very dangerous person.”

“We cannot say that too. If you are dangerous to him, he will also look dangerous to you.”

“So, you are saying that one cannot believe what he says.”

“It depends on what he said to you, thambi.”

“For example, he told me that if I go to you to learn about my future and that you would be able to guide me well.”

“I said that one-fourth of what he says would be true. This belongs there.”

“Then please tell me something about my future. It is getting late for me.”

“Where do you have to go, thambi?”

“Why don’t you find that out through your astrology? Where should I go and where I shouldn’t go? If I go to one place, will my task get completed?”

“Thambi, I will need some information about you to predict all this. I will need your horoscope; if not that then at least your name, star, and native place.”

“My name is Vandiya Devan.”

“Oh! You belong to the Vanar clan.”

“Yes. You are right.”

“Would you perchance be Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan?”

“Yes, I am.”

“You should have told me this earlier, thambi. I even have your horoscope in my collection.”

“Really! How come you have my horoscope?”

“What other work does an astrologer have, thambi? I have a collection of horoscopes of Princes and Princesses born in great royal clans.”

“But I am not from any great royal family.”

“Thambi, how can you say that? Your clan is so great that the poets have made it immortal, through their poems. Haven’t you heard any of those poems that were sung about your clan?”

“Why don’t you tell me one then?”

Immediately the Jodhidar sang a poem, which described how the great flag of the Vanar Kingdom was and how high it flew in all kingdoms in the South.

“How is the poem?”

“The poem was superb to listen to, but it is a bit behind the times. Today, I can tie our flag only on a cow’s horn and that too, only if it allows me to.”

“Today your fortunes are thus. Who knows how it will be tomorrow?”

“I thought you would be able to tell me.”

“What am I thambi but an ordinary man, just like you. It is the stars that rule us. I can just interpret them for you.”

“What do the stars say about me?”

“You will grow day by day.”

“Great! I thought I have already grown enough. I am so tall that I had to bend to enter your house. Please tell me something specific.”

“If you ask me specific questions, then I can give specific predictions.”

“I am going to Thanjavur on an important task. Will I complete it successfully?”

“If you are going to Thanjavur on personal work then you will complete it successfully. But if you are going there on behalf of somebody else, then I will have to check out that person’s horoscope.”

“Jodhidaray, you are very clever.”

“Don’t praise me so much, thambi.”

“Fine, I will ask you directly. I wish to meet the Emperor. Would that be possible?”

“Thambi, there are two great astrologers in Thanjavur - you will have to ask them.”

“Oh! Who are they?”

“Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Chinna Pazhuvetarayar!”

“People say that the Emperor is very ill. Is it true?”

“People will talk all sorts of things. Neither should you believe in it and nor should you repeat it anywhere.”

“If something happens to the Emperor, who do you think will ascend the throne?”

“It is neither you nor I, then why should we worry about it?”

“Thank God for that.”

“Yes, thambi. To be the heir apparent of a kingdom is no joke. It is a very dangerous position.”

“Jodhidaray, can you tell me the future of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalar in Kanchi?”

“You are going to Thanjavur on his behalf, am I correct?”

“Yes, I am -- you found out at last.”

“I don’t have his horoscope with me. I will have to look at that to predict anything about him.”

“How is Prince Madhuranthakar’s future?”

“His horoscope is a very strange one and very like a woman’s horoscope. He will always be under somebody’s authority.”

“People say that the Chola Kingdom is ruled by a woman. Is it true?”

“Where do they talk like that, thambi?”

“Near Kollidam.”

“They are probably referring to the authority wielded by Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s young wife.”

“No, they were not referring to her.”

“Then?”

“They say that Emperor’s daughter Princess Kundavai rules the kingdom.”

The Jodhidar looked at Vandiya Devan for a moment to ascertain whether the young man was aware of the fact that it was Princess

Kundavai, who had left just then. But he couldn't find out anything from his face.

“Wrong, thambi! Absolutely wrong! Maharaja Sundara Chola is in Thanjavur, whereas his daughter lives in Pazhaiarai. Moreover...”

“Moreover?”

“Nowadays it is the Pazhuvur brothers who are wielding all the authority, not the Emperor.”

Saying this, the Jodhidar looked carefully at Vandiya Devan.

Noticing this Vandiya Devan said, “I am not Pazhuvetar's spy. So, you don't have to suspect me. Just a short while ago, you told me that the stars rule us. Can you tell me what the stars foretell about the Chola Kingdom?”

“I can say this without any doubt, thambi. Have you seen the new floods of the Kaveri River? They flow right from the end of Aani^[83] month to the Puratasi^[84]. The Chola Kingdom is like the floods that come in the river every year. Its fame and greatness will grow year after year until it carves a niche of greatness in the history of Chola Kingdom.”

“Thank you. Just tell me one more thing. I have always wanted to travel by ship. Would it be possible?”

“Your wish will be fulfilled, thambi. Your stars are very fortunate indeed. You will always be moving from one place to another. You will travel by horse, elephant, chariot and very soon you are going to journey in a ship too.”

“Thanks so much, Ayya. Tell me one more thing - what do the stars foretell about Prince Arulmozhivarmar?”

“Thambi! Sailors who travel by ship depend on the compass to know the direction. Sometimes the lighthouse is also there to guide them. But in the middle of the sea, where you see water in every direction, the sailors depend on only one thing to learn the direction, and that is the pole star. Even the Saptarishi Mandal [\[85\]](#), changes direction but the pole star is anchored in one place. Prince Arulmozhivarmar is like that pole star. His ideals, bravery, and knowledge are unparalleled in this world. If young men like you follow his ideals, you will achieve your goal in life.”

“My God! You have so much to say about him.”

“If you ask anybody in the Chola King about Prince Arulmozhivarmar, they will describe him just as I did.”

“Thank you for reading my fortune. I will take my leave now.”

“Your stars are lucky, so you will be successful in all your ventures.”

“Please accept this as a token of my appreciation. This is all I can afford right now.” Saying thus Vandiya Devan gave the Jodhidar five gold coins.

“You are as generous as your ancestors,” said the Jodhidar and took his fees.



Chapter 14 - A Crocodile in Arisalaru

After he had left the Kudandhai town, Vallavareyan went towards the Arisalaru River. As he proceeded towards the land of the Cholas, he couldn't help admiring the beauty of his surroundings.

There was greenery everywhere! Green fields, trees, crops, small ponds, beautiful lakes and friendly villagers... No wonder the kingdom was so prosperous!

As he passed by, he saw farmers toiling in their fields while their wives cooked food in homes made of thatched huts. While the people were at work, hens fed on the grains kept outside the huts. Children ran hither and thither engaged in pranks and games while some sat outside and play pallaanguzhi^[86].

As he passed by, Vallavareyan could smell cooked rice and fried fish. It made his mouth water. In those days, most soldiers ate meat and fish, just like him.

He also noticed that there were many ironsmiths in the villages he passed, where craftsmen made swords and spears.

While Vallavareyan was enjoying the picturesque scenery, his inner mind was engaged elsewhere on a beautiful woman.

Why didn't that woman speak to me? What would she have lost if she had? Does she think that I am nobody? Who could she be? Whoever she is, she doesn't seem to know how to behave. That Jodhidar escaped without even telling me who she was. He is clever! Very clever! But he is so very experienced in worldly affairs. He

didn't say anything new about my future anyway. But he was very careful when it came to political matters. Either he escaped without saying anything, or he just played around with words to say something that everybody knew. Anyway, he told me that my stars are lucky so - long live Kudandhai Jodhidar!

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan continued on the road towards Arisalaru. As described earlier, the Arisalaru River remains hidden among a thick grove of trees that grew along the shore, which is why when Vandiya Devan reached Arisalaru he could hear the sound of flowing water but couldn't get a glimpse of the river.

As he rode along, he heard faint voices of women talking and laughing combined with the tinkling sounds of bangles and anklets. Vandiya Devan rode slowly looking through the grove of trees wondering from where these sounds came. Then suddenly he heard a shout, "Oh, God! Crocodile! Crocodile! Somebody help!"

Vandiya Devan immediately spurred his horse towards the direction of the voice. He rode straight through the small shrubs and dismounted near the shore and made his way through the thick grove of trees and saw the frightened women. To his surprise, he also saw the women he had met in the Jodhidar's house, a little while ago.

But that was not all. He saw that a dangerous crocodile had cornered the women near the trees. They didn't have enough room to move away nor time enough to go around the trees and escape the beast.

He immediately knew what to do. And we know that once Vandiya Devan decides on something he doesn't take much time to act on it.

In a split second, he took his spear, aimed and threw it at the crocodile. The spear hit the crocodile on its nose. Next, he drew his sword and ran towards it wanting to finish it once and for all.

Then something unexpected happened. The women started laughing. Vandiya Devan stopped in his tracks in surprise!

How could these women laugh at such a critical hour?" he thought and looked around at the faces of the women. He did not see fear or worry. Instead, they were all looking cheerful and mischievous. Next, he looked at the crocodile. Instead of making any kind of movement, it was lying still. Vandiya Devan couldn't believe that these were the same women who shouted for help, a little while ago.

"Girls! Please be quiet," said the woman who had captured Vandiya Devan's imagination.

Vandiya Devan looked at her and back at the crocodile and hesitated. She came towards him and stood between him and the crocodile, as if she wanted to protect the crocodile and said, "Ayya! I thank you for coming to our rescue, but you needn't have bothered."



Chapter 15 - Vanathi's Schemes

What did the other women in the boat do after Princess Kundavai and Vanathi left for Kudandhai Jodhidar's house? Let us see that now.

"Tharakai, see how lucky this Vanathi is – Kundavai Devi seems to have some special love for her."

"Nothing of that sort, Varani. Vanathi has been acting strange for the past few months - and she faints for no reason at all. That's why Kundavai Devi has taken her to the Jodhidar. If a ghost or a spirit has possessed her, we need to exorcise it. Kundavai Devi is worried because Vanathi's parents are dead, and her uncle has appointed 'her' as a guardian."

"You must be joking. No spirit or ghost can possess Vanathi. She is as vicious as a ghost."

"And you know what? She does not actually faint. It is all an act."

"Yes Niravathi, you are right. And on that day, when the Prince had to leave for Elangai, she let the aarathi [\[87\]](#) plate fall down just to get his attention. Otherwise, how can you just let go of something that you had in your hand? And is our Prince a bear or a tiger to be frightened of?"

"And immediately she pretended as if she lost consciousness. Imagine how clever you have to be, to think that fast."

“The surprising thing is that Prince Arulmozhivarmar and Kundavai Devi believed that she had really fainted.”

“Yes, the times are like that. People have faith in only those who cheat, lie and act these days. There is absolutely no value for truth or honesty.”

“Yes, you are right. Prince Arulmozhivarmar who was ready to leave for battle came back to check whether she was alright - doesn't this show to what extent her acting was convincing?”

“Nothing of that sort. It only shows how kind-hearted our prince is. He had seen that a girl had fainted before he left. He naturally wanted to know what happened to her. You need not construe any other meaning from his actions.”

“You are right about the Prince. You cannot find a more benevolent prince anywhere in this world. And this Vanathi is trying to make a fool out of him with her acting skills.”

“And once our Prince comes back from Ellangai she will try her skills again. We must not allow that to happen. We must be very careful.”

“If I don't make this Vanathi go mad by the time the Prince comes back I will change my name.”

“Let us first finish the task that Kundavai Devi asked us to do. We will have to do it before she comes.”

They opened the lower compartment of their boat. There lay a crocodile within it. It was a dead crocodile, which had been preserved and stuffed with straw and cotton. After they had brought

out the crocodile, they rowed the boat to the shore. They placed the crocodile under a tree by the shore so that it was half within the water and half on land. They also tied the tail of the crocodile to a tree with a small rope so that it did not move away with the running waters of the Arisalaru.

“Mandakini, why did Kundavai Devi asked us to tie this dead crocodile under the tree?”

“Vanathi is so petrified of everything. Kundavai Devi wants to make her brave... that’s why.”

“Looks as if Kundavai Devi has decided to wed our Prince to this Vanathi.”

“If that’s true, I will poison her.”

“You don’t have to do all that. Kings from all over the world want to give their daughters to our Prince. And he is not going to look at this Kodumbalur Vanathi when the best of princesses are in line to wed him.”

“But our Prince says that if ever he gets married, it would be to a girl from Chola land.”

“That is good news for us. Vanathi is not the only bright girl in the world. If she can put on an act so can we. We too can try our best to win his heart.”



Chapter 16 - Prince Arulmozhivarmar

About 980 years ago, when King Sundara Chola was ruling the Chola Kingdom, there was no other royal power in South to challenge him. The might of the Cholas was steadily rising as they expanded their territories and improved economy and trade. Before Sundara Chola's reign, his uncle Gandaradithan (Prince Madhuranthakan's father) ruled the Chola Kingdom. He was a great devotee of Lord Shiva and was not interested in waging wars. Taking advantage of the situation, the Pandya king who was in hiding tried to win back his kingdom, with the help of the Elangai king. Sundara Chola rallied the Chola troops and crushed their revolution and sent the Pandya king back into hiding.

After restoring order in the Pandya kingdom, the generals and commanders wanted to teach a lesson to the Elangai king, Mahindan, whose support had enabled the Pandya King to rise again and again. Sundara Chola decided to send Kodumbalur Illaya Vellar (Vanathi's father) as a commander of the troops to Elangai.

Unfortunately for him, the Chola army arrived in batches, and he was forced to lead a small batch of the army against the enemy. Due to the lesser number of soldiers and limited resources, the Chola army was defeated, and Kodumbalur Illaya Vellar died bravely of grave wounds.

Learning about the defeat of the Chola army in Elangai, the Pandya King who was hiding came out in open and started rallying an army again. But this time, he paid a terrible price for rising against the

Cholas. It was Sundara Chola's eldest son Aditya Karikalan who led the army, and he won the war by beheading the Pandya king, thus earning the title - The slayer of Veera Pandiyan.

Despite these victories, the Elangai king still supported the Pandya dynasty and continued to be hostile towards the Cholas. Sundara Chola decided to send his army again, to teach him a lesson. There arose a big argument among the prominent commanders and generals in the Chola Kingdom, as to who should lead the attack in Elangai.

Prince Aditya Karikalan was at war with the Rashtrakutas at the border. Therefore, Sundara Chola's youngest son Prince Arulmozhivarmar came forward and expressed his wish to take command.

"Father, it is time for me to take the lead and go to the war front. I am tired of sitting idle in the palace."

Prince Arulmozhivarmar was a 19-year-old young man, at that time. He was the youngest and hence the most loved one in the family.

Sundara Chola was a very handsome man. His father Aringzhan Chola married Princess Kalyani of the Vaithumbarayar clan, being enamoured by her beauty. After their marriage, the Vaithumbarayar clan who were hostile to the Cholas became their friends. The beautiful Princess Kalyani gave birth to a son, who was named Paranthakan after the great King Paranthaka I. But the child was so handsome and attractive to look at that people started calling him Sundara Chola.

Born to such a handsome king, the children of Sundara Chola were all attractive in appearance, but the youngest Prince Arulmozhivarmar was the most handsome of them all. He was the beloved of all in the Kingdom, but none loved him more than his older sister Princess Kundavai. Even though she was barely two years older than him, she took it upon herself to take care of her younger brother. And Arulmozhi respected and loved his elder sister and allowed her to guide him in all matters.

Right from the time Arulmozhi was born, many astrologers had predicted that he would attain kingship and would rule as an Emperor. More than anybody else, Kundavai Devi believed in these predictions. She often looked at her brother's palm, while he was asleep and noted the Sangu Chakram mark - a sign that signified kingship. And she sought to teach him all the skills and knowledge that a king should know.

"He is destined to rule a kingdom though it may not be this one. Who knows... the world is vast... maybe he will earn a kingdom with the might of his sword." thought Kundavai.

That's why, when Prince Arulmozhivarmar asked her permission to go the war front in Elangai, she did not object.

"Thambi! You know that I cannot live without you, even for a second, but I cannot let you sit idle in this palace either. It is time for you to go out and gain victory. Go to Elangai. Lead the army there and come back victorious."

With the blessings of his elder sister, Prince Arulmozhivarmar left for Elangai, leading a massive army. After conquering their capital city, he came back home again, since food materials and finance for his

campaign did not arrive steadily from home. After making sufficient arrangements for his army, the prince prepared to leave again.

Kundavai Devi had arranged for a special pooja^[88] and yagna^[89] to be conducted in Pazhaiarai Palace, on the day he left. The womenfolk in the palace and the other elders came out to the courtyard, to bid farewell to their dear prince. Princess Vanathi was also there along with the other companions of Kundavai Devi. They each had an aarathi plate in their hands, with a lamp within it. When the Prince approached them, they got ready to bid an auspicious farewell to him.

But Vanathi's body trembled for some reason. The aarathi plate slipped from her hands and fell down. Immediately, the elderly women frowned and declared that it an ill omen but when they saw that the lamp had not been extinguished, they felt that it was an excellent omen.

Prince Arulmozhivarmar was very much amused. He smiled charmingly at everybody and left. After he had left, Vanathi fainted and fell.

Princess Kundavai asked her friends to carry Vanathi to the anthapuram and without waiting to bid farewell to her brother, she went to Vanathi's room and tried to revive her. Prince Arulmozhivarmar who saw Vanathi faint sent a messenger enquiring about her. Kundavai sent back a message, asking the Prince to come inside. Respecting her wishes, the Prince returned to the anthapuram and saw Vanathi lying in Kundavai's lap. Feeling sorry for her, the Prince asked his sister, "Akka, who is this girl?"

“This is Kodumbalur Illaya Vellar’s daughter. Her name is Vanathi. She gets scared very easily.”

“Ah! Now I understand why she fainted. Her father went to Elangai and died in the battle. Perhaps she thought about that.”

“Maybe. But don’t worry... I will look after her. You take care of yourself and send me messages from there as frequently as possible.”

“Yes, Akka.”

Perhaps it was the sweet voice of the Prince that woke Vanathi up. She opened her eyes and saw the Prince’s face looming in front of her. She immediately sat up blushing and the memory of what she had done rushed in.

She turned towards Kundavai and sobbed, “Akka, forgive me, I dropped the aarathi plate.”

Before Kundavai could reply to her, the Prince said, “Vanathi, you don’t have to blame yourself for that. Everybody makes mistakes and moreover, you have a very valid reason to get scared.”

Vanathi couldn’t believe her ears. The Prince who would never look at women, in general, was actually speaking to her.

“Akka, keep me informed about what is happening here. And the next time you write to me, let me know about the health of this girl and take good care of her. My army is waiting outside... I will take your leave now.”

Since that day, Kundavai showed special love towards Vanathi. She taught her all the skills that she had learnt and spoke to her about

the ambitions she had nurtured in her heart for her brother. And Vanathi listened to all this with rapt attention. As mentioned before, she fainted a few more times and each time Princess Kundavai revived her with care. Whenever she regained consciousness, she clung to Kundavai and cried, and the Princess would console her with kind words.



Chapter 17 - The Laughing Horse

Kundavai had long decided that Vanathi was the right life partner for her brother, Prince Arulmozhi. But there was only one problem with her. She was frightened of everything! And Kundavai was not ready to marry her brother to a cowardly girl. So, to make Vanathi brave, she had arranged for the crocodile game. But thankfully, Vanathi passed the test successfully.

After they had come to the boat, they rowed around for a while and then came near the bank, where Kundavai's companions had tied the dead crocodile. They all got off the boat and played in the water for some time. Suddenly one of the girls screamed, "Crocodile! Crocodile! Somebody help!"

Immediately the other girls started screaming. But Vanathi did not get scared. Instead, she said, "The crocodile is strong only when it is in the water and not when it is lying on the shore. So, don't be scared."

"You, smart girl! Somebody must have told you that this is not a real crocodile." said one of the girls.

"Even if it is a real one, I would not have got scared. I am only frightened of lizards," declared Vanathi.

This was precisely when our hero appeared to save the poor girls from the dead crocodile. He sprang down from his horse and threw a spear at it.

When Kundavai came and stood in front of the crocodile and spoke to him, he was mesmerized. His disappointment about her not talking to him earlier vanished but something was troubling him.

Why is she standing near the crocodile? Why does she say that I need not bother about it? Why is that crocodile not moving?

While he was thinking thus, Kundavai continued, “Ayya! You barged in hurriedly into the Jodhidar’s house when we were inside and later apologized for it. But I did not reply to you at that time. Please do not conclude that the women of the Chola Kingdom do not know any etiquette. My companion had suddenly fainted, and I was disturbed by it hence I couldn’t speak to you then...”

What a beautiful voice! Why is my heart beating so? I have never experienced this sensation even on the battlefield. Even if I want to interrupt and say something to her, I am not able to. I feel as I have lost my voice.

Meanwhile, Kundavai continued, “Even now, you came to save us poor women from a dangerous crocodile by throwing your spear at it. And I am sure, it will be tough to find another soldier who can aim so perfectly.”

Hearing this, the girls started laughing again. And the magic of Kundavai’s voice broke its hold over Vandiya Devan. He immediately went near the crocodile, ignoring Kundavai and pulled out his spear. He expected blood to gush out; instead, some straw and cloth rags came out of its body. This elicited another peal of laughter from the girls.

Vandiya Devan had never felt so humiliated in his life.

If they had been men instead of women, I would have killed them instantly. But these are women, there is nothing that I can do about it but leave the scene immediately.

He walked back to the road without even looking at the woman who had stolen his heart. When he reached the road, his horse, which was waiting for him, looked at him and neighed. It seemed as if the horse had joined these women in laughing at him. He mounted the horse and whipped it sharply. It sprang forward and galloped away.

Kundavai kept looking at the horse until the dust settled on the road.

Later she told her companions sternly, “Girls, you still don’t know how to behave before strangers. When we are alone, you can laugh and joke about anything but when you are in the presence of a stranger that too a man, shouldn’t you behave properly? What will that young man think about Chola women?”



Chapter 18 – Edupankari

It has been some time since we left our friend, Azhwarkadiyan near Kollidam River. Let us see what he is doing.

After Vandiya Devan had left for Kudandhai, Azhwarkadiyan said to himself, “This young man is brilliant. If I ask him, one question he has a hundred questions for me. I couldn’t find out exactly who he is working for or where he is headed. I couldn’t even find out whether he was a part of the secret midnight meeting in Kadambur. Thank God! I mentioned Kudandhai Jodhidar’s name. Whatever information I couldn’t find out, I am sure the Jodhidar will.”

“Are you talking to the banyan tree or to yourself?” Thirumalai heard this and turned around to see the soldier who had accompanied Vandiya Devan from Kadambur standing.

“Oh, it’s you! I am neither talking to myself nor to the tree. There is a ghost that resides in this tree. I was talking to it.”

“Really! Is that ghost, a Vaishnavar or Saivar?”

“I too was asking the same question, when you came and interrupted me. What is your name?”

“Why are you asking?”

“You saved my life by restraining that Saivar in the boat, so I must know your name.”

“My name is Edupankari,” he said after some hesitation.

“Oh, Edupankari is it? It sounds very familiar to me.”

Edupankari did something strange now. He spread out the back of his right palm and placed his left palm and moved the thumb finger of both the hands and looked at Azhwarkadiyan.

“What did you do now? What was that sign?”

Hearing this Edupankari's face darkened.

“Me? I didn't do anything.”

“Yes! Yes! You did. I saw just now. It was a mudra^[90] that is shown to depict Maha Vishnu's first avatar.”

“What is Maha Vishnu's first avatar?”

“Maha Vishnu's first avatar is Machchavataram^[91].”

“You mean the ‘fish.’”

“Yes.”

“I don't know, Sami^[92]. Your eyes are very strange. You see ghosts in banyan trees and fish in my hand. Maybe, you like fish a lot.”

“No! No! Nothing like that. Never mind. Do you know in which direction that Saivar went?”

“Oh, yes. I saw him at the marketplace, where I was purchasing the horse. He was cursing you.”

“What was he saying?”

“He was saying that if he ever meets you again, he is going to shear your hair and wipe away the Vaishnava signs in your body...”

“If that is so, I will have to meet him immediately. Do you know where he is from?”

“He told that he is from Puliurukum Vellur.”

“I will head towards that place immediately. What about you? Where are you going? Are you going in that direction?”

“Me? No! No! I must get back to Kadambur. Otherwise, the young master will scold me.”

“Then, go right now. I think the ferry is leaving.”

“I will leave then, Sami,” said Edupankari and started walking towards the river. After walking a little while, he turned back again. By that time Azhwarkadiyan did something strange. He swiftly climbed up the tree and hid in the branches. That’s why when Edupankari turned back on his way to the boat, he couldn’t see where he was.

When Edupankari reached the riverbank, the boatman asked him, “Are you coming in the boat?”

“No, I will come later. You can leave now.”

“The way you hurried here, I thought you will get in,” said the boatman and started rowing.

By this time, Azhwarkadiyan had settled himself comfortably in the branches of the banyan tree and was watching what Edupankari was doing. When he saw him coming back, he thought, “I knew that he would not get into the boat. He is coming back here. I must follow him and learn where he is going. What could be the meaning of the sign that he did with his hands? Fish! What does fish symbolize?”

Could it be...? Why not? It is entirely possible. I just have to wait patiently.”

Azhwarkadiyan’s suspicion came true soon enough. Edupankari returned to the banyan tree and looked around everywhere as if he is searching for somebody. But he did not look at the branches of the tree where Thirumalai was hiding. Even if he did, he couldn’t have seen Thirumalai hidden among the thick leaves. Edupankari sat down beneath the tree and seemed to be waiting for somebody.

About one hour passed. Thirumalai’s legs had become numb. He found it impossible to perch up the tree for one more minute. But Edupankari was still waiting under the tree. “How to escape? Even if I try to climb down the tree carefully, I am bound to make some noise or the other. And Edupankari also has a dagger with him, which he won’t hesitate to use if he learns that he is being spied on.”

“What else to do? Shall I just jump on him screaming loudly? He will probably think that I am some ghost and faint, or he might even run away?”

While Thirumalai was thinking thus, someone appeared from the northern direction. Thirumalai felt the Edupankari was waiting for this person because he got up when he saw him approaching the banyan tree.

After he had come, Edupankari showed the same sign with his hands that he showed to Azhwarkadiyan and the stranger also did the same.

“What is your name?” asked the stranger.

“My name is Edupankari. What is yours?”

“Soman Sambavan.”

“I was waiting for you.”

“I know.”

“In which direction should we go?”

“In the eastern direction.”

“To which place?”

“To the Pallipadai^[93] of the enemy.”

“You mean the one near Thirupurampayam^[94] ?”

“Don’t shout! What if somebody hears you?” said Soman Sambavan and looked around.

“There is nobody here.”

“There is no place where anybody can hide?”

“No.”

“Good. Come let us go. You will have to lead the way. I am not very sure about the route.”

“Fine. The route is through the jungle, which is tough to cross. We will have to be careful.”

“Alright. Come let us go.”

Saying thus they both left in the eastern direction. After they had left, Azhwarkadiyan climbed down the tree.

“Times are terrible. Many things are happening in the kingdom. And by God’s grace, I have got a chance to learn about it. In Kadambur

palace, I couldn't hear anything properly. The same must not happen here. They are going to Thirupurampayam Pallipadai. He must have meant the Ganga King's Pallipadai. That is a dilapidated temple in the middle of the jungle. Why are they going there? If it is something that these two have to do, they will talk or do it here itself. They need not walk all the way to the forest. Which means they are other people who are coming together to meet. Why did they say? Enemy's Pallipadai? Whose enemy was King Ganga? Aha! Looks as if my guess is coming true. It would be better to get to that place much earlier than these fellows. I can take another route."

Thinking thus Azhwarkadiyan headed east.



Chapter 19 - The Battlefield

In those days, it was a practice to build memorial temples for war heroes. These temples were called Pallipadai. Near Kudandhai, there was a small village called Thirupurampayam, where a Pallipadai was built for the Ganga King Prathivipithan, in memory of his heroic deeds in the gory war that took place here.



Thirupurampayam Pallipadai Temple

In the world history, many famous battles have changed the course of the history, for example, the Battle of Waterloo or The Wars of Panipat, etc. In the same way, the war that was fought near Thirupurampayam changed the course of Tamil history.

The Chola dynasty, like any other royal power in the world, had seen its share of ups and down. After the reign of great kings like Karikalan Vallavan^[95], Perunalakilli^[96], Eranchet Chenni, there was a steady decline in their power. The Pandya and Pallava kings gained more power and suppressed the Cholas. And thanks to the Pandyas, the Cholas were forced to relocate from their old capital, Uraiyur, to Pazhairai, which was near Kudandhai though they still retained their titles, which proclaimed Uraiyur as their capital.

Many years passed and Vijayalaya Chola became the king of the Chola Kingdom. He was a great warrior. Tales about this king are legendary in the Chola history. It was said that he had 99 battle scars from various battles on his body. Poems and songs heralded the bravery of this old king.

Due to his advanced age, Vijayalaya Chola crowned his son, Aditya Chola as the king and retired from public life. During that time there arose a bitter fight among the Pallavas and Pandyas. Both were powerful kingdoms that had reduced the Chola Kingdom to ignominy. The Pandya King was Varagunavarman at that time.

Because of the enmity between these two powers, the Chola Kingdom was subjected to many an inconvenience - they fought their wars on Chola land. Nevertheless, the Chola king turned this situation to his advantage. Each time there was a war, he would join one of these warring sides with his small army.

Very soon, what was to be the final war between the two kingdoms was declared. This was the war that was to decide the fate of the three kingdoms, Chola, Pandya, and Pallava and it happened near Thirupurampayam. This time, the Pandya king came with a massive army while the Pallava king had the support of the Ganga king, Prathivipithan and Aditya Chola and his small army.

Even though the Cholas had a small army, they nonetheless joined in because they knew that if the Pandyas won, their fate would be

sealed. There were countless elephants, horses, chariots and foot soldiers on both the sides. And when both the armies met on the battlefield, there was a storm in the making. The battle raged incessantly for three days. Blood flowed like rivulets everywhere. Heaps of bodies of soldiers, horses and elephants lay decomposing.

After three days of war, a tiny section of Pallava army had survived, and they were wounded and weary. But the Pandya forces, scenting victory, were thirsty for more blood. They attacked the Pallava forces with more vigour and killed many mercilessly.

In the Pallava camp, the three kings Aparajithavarman (the Pallava King), Prathivipithan (the Ganga King) and Aditya Chola (the Chola King) held a council of war, where they decided that retreating would be their best choice to survive the onslaught of the Pandya forces.

At that point, something strange happened on the battlefield. Paralyzed in both the legs and advanced in age Vijayalaya Chola (King Aditya Chola's father) somehow arrived at the battlefield. And when he heard that the Pallava army was planning to retreat, he decided to stay back and face the Pandya army. His resolution gave new hope to the Pallava soldiers.

"I want one elephant. Get me one elephant," asked Vijayalaya Chola.

"All our elephants are dead. Not even one is alive," said the Pallava commanders.

"One horse. Get me one horse."

"All our horses are dead or wounded. None are fit to be mounted."

"I want at least two soldiers. If there are any, please come forward."

Instead of two, two hundred came forward.

"Arrange yourself in rows of two. Two soldiers lift me up on your shoulders, the rest stand behind in a row. If the soldiers who bear me on their shoulders are struck down, be ready to lift me up on your shoulders."

Saying thus, he unsheathed two long sharp swords. Two young soldiers lifted him up on their shoulders.

“Come, let us go to the battlefield!” he cried.

The war was still going on in one part of the battlefield.

Mounted on the shoulders of two soldiers, Vijayalaya Chola's sword wreaked havoc in the battlefield. Wherever he went, there lay soldiers wounded or dead. Chola and Pallava soldiers, who had earlier retreated, came back to the battlefield to watch this old soldier fight.

And fortune favoured the Cholas. Slowly, the Pandya soldiers started fleeing, and the entire army of Pallavas pressed forward determined in their quest for victory.

The goddess of war now began favouring the Cholas and the Pallavas. The Pandya soldiers started fleeing from the battlefield.



Thirupurampayam Battlefield today

The Ganga King Prathivipithan fought bravely and died heroically on the battlefield. In memory of his brave deeds, a Pallipadai (war memorial) was raised in the battlefield.



Thirupurampayam Pallipadai Temple

For a long time, the battlefield lay deserted. People believed that the spirits of the dead soldiers haunted the place. After some time, a thick forest started growing there, engulfing the Pallipadai of the Ganga King.

Our friend, Thirumalaiappan arrived there after the sun had set. Finding the route through the thick forest he had made his way laboriously to the Pallipadai. Looking around everywhere, he climbed to the roof of the Pallipadai with the help of the tree next to it.

After settling himself comfortably there, he waited. One hour passed by, and then two, three? But there was no sign of the men, whom he had seen near Kollidam. Azhwarkadiyan looked around sharply in the darkness while his ears were straining to hear any strange sound. But all that he could hear were the sounds of wolves and bats.

After some time, he got bored, he looked up at the sky and addressed the stars, "Oh, Heavenly stars! I know you must be laughing at the stupidity of us human beings. You have all the reasons to laugh at us. You have been here since time immemorial. And you have seen the terrible war that happened here. You must be thinking as to why we human beings kill each other like this. And they call this 'bravery.'"

"Even after a man has been dead and gone for hundred years, people consider him as an enemy. This is the enemy's Pallipadai it seems, and they are going to discuss something important here. In the name of the dead people, they want to torture the ones that are living. Why won't you laugh? Laugh well.

"Oh, God! Is it a waste coming all the way here? Why didn't they come here? Did they change their plans? Have they gone

somewhere else? Did I listen to them properly? Did they refer to this place? If all my efforts for today go waste, I will never forgive myself. What is that? Looks like a torch. Thank God! Somebody is coming.”

A group of people had come near the Pallipadai. But instead of sitting nearby they went near the banyan tree, which was at a distance from the Pallipadai and sat there in a circle. A few more people came and joined the group. One person who had come in the end had a bag in his hands. He suddenly spread out a cloth on the ground, opened his bag and dropped its contents in the cloth. They were gold coins!

The man who had opened the bag now shouted almost hysterically, “Friends! We are going to destroy the Chola race with the help of their own gold.”

“Ravidasaray! Please lower your voice. Let’s talk quietly,” said one of his group members.

“So what? What if we shout here? There is nobody out here to hear us except wolves and bats and luckily they won’t go and tell anybody.”

“Even then, I think we should lower our voice.”

Azhwarkadiyan was able to see what they were doing but was unable to hear anything that they said. He nimbly climbed down from the roof of the Pallipadai and hid behind the banyan tree. He accidentally stepped on a twig, which made a distinct sound. Immediately Ravidasan and his group members stopped talking and turned towards the direction of the sound.

Ravidasan gave the fire torch to one of his men and asked him to look behind the tree. Azhwarkadiyan’s heart almost stopped. There

was no way to escape!

Luckily for him, a bat started screeching, “Ooh... ooh...”



Chapter 20 - Our First Enemy

Azhwarkadiyan greatly appreciated the timely help given by the bat. Ravidasan and his gang thought that the bat had made the sound and continued with their discussion, while Azhwarkadiyan neared the Banyan tree and listened in.

“This bat frightened us out of our wits. Let us kill it.” cried one of the gang members.

But Ravidasan said, “No, why do you wish to kill it unnecessarily? Instead, let us save our swords to kill our enemies. Bats are our friends. Just like us, they come out of their nests, when men are asleep.

“Listen to me, friends! Until we have the vast treasury of Thanjavur, we need not worry about gold. All that we need is people who can take up this dangerous task and complete it successfully. We need to divide ourselves into two groups. One group should journey to Elangai and the other to Kancheepuram. We need to complete both the tasks at the same time; otherwise our enemies will be forewarned. Who among you is willing to go to Elangai?”

“I will go!”

“Let me go!”

“On second thoughts, I think we should decide who should go, at the next meeting. We need to make a lot of preparation before we leave.”

“Ravidasaray, which is the best route to Elangai?”

“We can go via Kodi Karai. That would be the easiest way. But reaching Kodi Karai from here is difficult. Moreover, the Cholas have spies all through that route. So it would be safe for us to go to Sethu and cross the sea there. We will reach Mandhotham. From there, we will have to find our way inland. Whoever goes to Elangai, must know to swim and row a boat. Who among us knows to swim?”

“I know.”

“I know too.”

“First, we must meet the Elangai King, Mahindan, and talk to him about our plans. So whoever is to go there must know to speak Sinhalam^[97]. Where are our other two friends, Soman Sambavan and Edupankari?”

“Here they come!” said one of the men.

The two men came from the opposite direction, making their way through the shrubs. Azhwarkadiyan wound himself around the tree to avoid detection.

Seeing them, Ravidasan said, “Welcome, my friends! What happened - why are you so late? I was afraid you both were in some kind of danger. How did you come?”

“We came through the Kollidam river side. On the way, we were attacked by a pack of wolves. It took us time to avoid them and reach here.”

“If you are afraid of the lion or tiger, I can understand, but you are afraid of wolves! How will you take care of bigger enemies when you

flee from a mere pack of wolves?” asked one of the gang members.

“Do not dismiss wolves in such a light manner, my friend. They are more vicious than the lion or tiger. Lions and tigers attack us alone. Therefore, we can manage them, but wolves attack in a pack, which makes them very dangerous. These Chola wolves attacked our king in huge numbers; that is why our brave king had such a gory death. Let us destroy this race of wolves!”

“Let us avenge our king’s death!” cried the entire gang.

“I have something that will help us accomplish it!” said Ravidasan, pointing towards the heap of coins.

Soman Sambavan immediately picked up a few coins - on one side of the coin, the figure of a tiger was inscribed, while on the other, a palm tree.

“Chola’s money with Pazhuvetarayar’s emblem. I have kept my promise. What news have you brought? Does Edupankari have something to convey to us?” asked Ravidasan.

“Yes. He has brought important news,” said Soman Sambavan.

Edupankari spoke up, “As per your orders I have been working in Sambuverayar’s palace for the past many months. Yesterday, there was a big feast in the palace. Periya Pazhuvetarayar, Vanagamudiyar, Mazhapadi Mazhavereyar and many other prominent noblemen had come. Pazhuvetarayar had come along with his young wife, in a veiled palanquin, at least that’s what everybody thought. Pazhuvetarayar announced that Sundara Chola might die any time now. Everybody decided that the next heir apparent should not be Aditya Karikalan but Prince

Madhuranthakan. But some raised doubts about whether Madhuranthakan would agree to be the next Emperor. Pazhuvetarayar told them that Madhuranthakan himself would agree to this in person. Next instant, he went near the veiled palanquin and out comes Prince Madhuranthakan, who later declared that he would like to be the next Chola King.”

“Huh! So, they want to crown a prince, who acts like a woman. Good. Everything seems to be happening according to our plans. If there is division within the Chola Kingdom, it bodes well for our cause. We can carry out our plans without attracting suspicion. Edupankari, tell me one thing - how did you learn all these details?”

“When the midnight meeting was about to begin, Sambuverayar had asked me to stand guard near the door, to prevent anybody from coming near. While I was on guard, I was able to listen in.”

“Splendid. Did you see or hear anything else?”

“Yes, I did. One man was watching them from the fort walls.”

“Aha! Who was it?”

“A Vaishnavan!”

“Did you tell Sambuverayar about him?”

“No! I thought you had sent him there.”

“No, I didn’t. You have made a great mistake! He is not one of us. He is short and stout with a fair complexion. He calls himself Azhwarkadiyan, sometimes Thirumalaiappan.”

“Yes, he is the one. I realized my mistake this morning.”

“How come?”

“Yesterday, after all, the guests had arrived, young master Kandanmaran’s friend came to the palace. He is not involved in the plot that these kings are hatching. This morning, when he was leaving, Kandanmaran came along with him to Kollidam. And I also came along with them. Kandanmaran wanted me to go with his friend across the Kollidam and buy him a horse. When the ferry was about to leave, this Vaishnavan came and joined us. From the manner he spoke, I wondered whether he was one of us. Later, I went to buy a horse for that young man. After I came back, I found this Vaishnavan was still standing there. I showed him our secret symbol, but he failed to understand that. That’s when I realized that he was not one of us.”

“You could have killed him at least after you realized that he was not one of us. And you should not have shown our secret symbol to strangers like him.”

“Friends listen to this. Our enemies are there in Kanchi and in Elangai. But our first enemy is this ‘Vaishnavan.’ If at all you see him anywhere, kill him mercilessly, just as you would kill a snake or a scorpion.”

“Ravidasaray! Who is this Vaishnavan?”

“He is a very dangerous spy!”

“Whom does he work for?”

“I am not sure about that. He might be working for Sembiyanmadevi.”

“Why would that pious old lady want a spy? I have heard that she is forever immersed in puja.”

“All that devotion is an act. Just like the Vaishnavan’s devotion towards Vishnu.”

“Are there any other spies like him?”

“There is an astrologer in Kudandhai. Do not ever go there. Under the pretext of reading your fortune, he will get information from you, but he is harmless. This Vaishnavan is dangerous. He must be killed at all costs.”

You can imagine how Azhwarkadiyan felt when he heard this. He was afraid that he might not leave the place alive, and to make matters worse, he felt an urgent urge to sneeze. He stuffed his mouth with a cloth and sneezed, but Ravidasan and his gang heard the noise.

Immediately Ravidasan handed a fire torch to one of the members and asked him to check out what that sound was.

Azhwarkadiyan’s heart almost stopped, when the fire torch came nearer. He looked around for a way to escape. Upon the tree, he saw a giant bat hanging. He immediately took it in his hands. Just as the torchbearer came near him, he threw the bat at him and ran away from the scene.

As he ran, he could hear the commotion behind him as the other gang members gathered around the one who had fallen and was telling the others that a bat had attacked him...



Chapter 21 - The Veil Parted

Can a man dwell in two different worlds at the same time?

Yes, he can. If you need any proof, you must take a glimpse at Vandiya Devan. As he was traveling through the Chola Kingdom, his eyes were admiring the beauty of the rich Chola land.

No wonder Chola kings are blessed because they rule over such beautiful lands. When he thought about Chola Kings, he also remembered the dangers that Sundara Chola was facing.

What is my duty? Should I just deliver the message that Prince Aditya has given or should I warn the Emperor about the plot that his noblemen are hatching against his sons? But why should I get involved in this? Why should I care as to who will be next heir? After all these Cholas, are the traditional enemies of my clan? Thanks to them and the Vaithumbarayars, I have no kingdom to rule today.

No! No! I cannot blame them. Why should I remember all those old stories? How can I say that they were wrong in annexing my kingdom? As long as there are kingdoms, fights over territories are inevitable. Even my own ancestors have deprived many kings of their kingdoms. They cannot rule like King Yudhistira^[98] or King Rama in these days.

So, I will not call it an injustice. In fact, we should say that the Cholas are not as ruthless as my ancestors. They try to foster friendly relations with the rival clans through marriage. Aringhza Chola^[99] got married to the beautiful Princess Kalyani ^[100] of Vaithumbaraya clan.

No wonder, their son Sundara Chola and his children are so well known for their beauty.

Just when he thought this, he remembered the beautiful woman he saw near Arisalaru River. This is not the first time he thought about her. Though his mind was thinking about the Chola Kingdom and Chola kings, his inner mind was actively thinking about her! Soon he was consciously thinking about her. Whenever he saw a beautiful flower or a pond he was comparing it with her beauty.

Is there anything else in nature that can be compared to her beauty? None! She is truly a dream of a poet.

I think she resembles somebody I know. What if she is the...? No! It can't be. It shouldn't be. If she is Kundavai Devi, then how can I go and give her the message after behaving with her in such an uncouth manner.

Thus, he rode along thinking about this along the banks of the Kaveri River. Finally, he reached Thiruvaiyaru^[101]. He had heard much about this famous town. A city that was truly an inspiration for many artists, singers, dancers, musicians...

He remembered the song that Sambandhaswamy had composed about this place. He described it as a place where one can hear the divine music and see the cosmic dance of Lord Shiva. Vandiya Devan felt that the description was apt even today...

I must stay here for a day and look around...

After he had come to this decision, he saw something that made him change his mind. Along the banks of Kaveri River, he saw a veiled palanquin approaching his way. There were soldiers in the front and

the back. As the palanquin approached, he saw that it bore the symbol of a palm tree. This was Pazhuvetarayar's young wife's palanquin. But Pazhuvetarayar was nowhere to be seen. He was probably coming by a different route.

The palanquin was proceeding towards Thanjavur. Vandiya Devan immediately changed his mind about staying at Thiruvaiyaru. He started following the palanquin.

Maybe for some reason, Prince Madhuranthakan might come out of the palanquin. And if I can make acquaintance with him, it might come handy sometime. Who knows - he might even help me to get an audience with the Emperor?

So, he followed the palanquin and the foot soldiers at a distance. But they didn't stop anywhere in between as Vandiya Devan expected. At a distance, he could see the fort walls of Thanjavur. Vandiya Devan felt that if the palanquin entered the fort, he wouldn't be able to meet the prince. He must do something daring to make them stop the palanquin.

More than anything else, he wanted to expose to the world, how a man was traveling like a woman in a palanquin - that too secretly as somebody else's wife. He felt that it was the most shameful thing to do.

Just as he was thinking thus, a soldier who was walking along with the palanquin came towards him.

"Who are you? Why are you following the palanquin from Thiruvaiyaru?"

“I am not following you. I am going to Thanjavur. This is the road that goes to Thanjavur, right?”

“That’s right. But it is only for important people. For other people, there is a different route.”

“Really! I didn’t know. I am also a very important person.”

Hearing this, the soldier smiled at him. “Why are you going to Thanjavur?”

“My uncle is not keeping well. I am on my way to see him.”

“What does your uncle do in Thanjavur? Does he work in the palace?”

“No! He is a storekeeper in a guesthouse.”

“I see. Then why don’t you ride ahead of us? Why are you coming behind us?”

“The horse is tired, Ayya. Trust me. I have no pleasure in trotting like this behind you.”

Saying thus he neared the palanquin from behind. He immediately got an idea. He pressed his legs in the horse's belly. Immediately the horse lifted its hoofs. The palanquin bearers got frightened. They hastily placed the palanquin on the ground.

At the same instant, Vandiya Devan started shouting, “Maharaja [\[102\]](#)! Maharaja! Your soldiers are attacking my horse.”

Hearing the commotion, the veils of the palanquin parted.



Chapter 22 - The Velkarars

A fair hand parted the veils of the palanquin. Vandiya Devan immediately got down from his horse and went near the palanquin saying, “Maharaja! Maharaja! Your palanquin bearers...”

When he looked up, he was dazed and his speech slurred, “No! No! You are the princess of Pazhuvur. Your horse came and hit my palanquin.”

All this happened within a blink of an eye. The palanquin bearers and the other soldiers immediately surrounded Vandiya Devan. Despite all this activity around him, Vandiya Devan was unable to take his eyes off the beauty that was before him.

Yes! Contrary to his expectations, there was a real woman sitting in the palanquin instead of Prince Madhuranthakan. And she was no ordinary woman! Her dazzling beauty made his head swirl.

At the same time, luckily for Vandiya Devan, an idea occurred to him, which he decided to use to his advantage. With great effort, he collected his thoughts and spoke up, “My apologies Devi. I assume you are the young queen of the Pazhuvur Lord. I have an important message for you.”

The Pazhuvur Queen who was looking at him with interest smiled at him. She signalled her soldiers to move away from Vandiya Devan.

“Yes. I am the queen of Pazhuvur. What did you say just a little while ago, about the palanquin bearers?”

“Devi! Your palanquin bearers came and hit my horse deliberately. And my horse got frightened.”

“That is very amusing, but I would prefer the truth. Why did you come and collide with my palanquin?” asked the young queen sternly.

“Devi! Nandini Devi! Your brother, Azhwarkadiyan, told me to meet you. He wanted me to deliver a message to you. I couldn’t think of any other way to meet you that’s why I had to stop you thus.”

Vandiya Devan watched Nandini’s reaction intently. At the mention of ‘Azhwarkadiyan’, Nandini’s eyes widened a bit, and she immediately said, “Let us not discuss this in the middle of the road. Come to my palace tomorrow and we can talk more.”

“Devi! Devi! They won’t let me inside the fort or the palace. How will I come?”

Nandini immediately opened her silk purse and took out the Pazhuvur signet ring and gave it to him.

“If you show this ring, they will allow you inside the fort and the palace. Do not follow me anymore.” Saying thus she disappeared inside the multitude of veils.

While he watched, the palanquin was borne away by the bearers and the Pazhuvur soldier who spoke to him earlier gave him a hard stare. But Vandiya Devan was in no condition to notice all this. The beauty and the mesmerizing voice of the Pazhuvur Queen befuddled his mind.

How could any woman be so beautiful? Even the heavenly apsaras can't compete with her beauty. I wouldn't blame Pazhuvetarayar for being enslaved by her. Who wouldn't be? And no wonder they are mocking him all over the country. They surely make quite a pair. An old, battle-scarred warrior and this young woman. What wouldn't he do to get a smile out of her?

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan walked slowly leading his horse towards the Thanjavur Fort. A small township had sprung around the fort where people had set up shops for fruits, flowers, and sweets. The market was bustling with people teeming everywhere to buy eatables, while some were just standing as if they were expecting a procession to come by. Vandiya Devan was exhausted. He had decided not to enter the fort that night. He wanted to find a good guesthouse to rest and sleep.

Looking around he spotted a youth, standing nearby holding two baskets of flowers. Vandiya Devan also noted that he was a Saivar wearing beads of rudraksha [\[103\]](#) on his neck and hands.

“Thambi! Why is everybody standing here? Is there a procession coming from the fort?”

“You are new to this place, are you?”

“Yes. I have come from Thondai Mandalam [\[104\]](#).”

“No wonder you didn't know. I suggest you get down from your horse and wait here.”

Immediately Vandiya Devan got down from his horse.

“Thambi! Why did you ask me to get down?”

“We are expecting the Velkarar Army^[105] to come out of the fort. That’s why we are all standing here.”

“Why shouldn’t I watch the procession sitting on my horse?”

“Yes, you can but if the Velkarar soldiers see you there will be trouble.”

“What trouble? Will they take my horse?”

“Not only the horse, but they will also take you along with them as well. In this town, we try as much as possible not to get into trouble with them. Even the Pazhuvur soldiers stay clear of them.”

While the youth was talking thus, they heard the gates of the fort opening. Vandiya Devan had heard about the Velkarar Army. They were an elite band of soldiers who are the bodyguards of the Chola Kings. Unlike other royal guards, the Velkarars take a holy oath in front of their presiding deity, Durga, to protect the life of the Emperor at any cost. If they failed in their duty, they would sacrifice their heads to the Goddess.

As the fort gates opened, two soldiers on horseback came out bearing two flags. This was a special flag of the Velkarars with a picture of a tiger on the top with a crown and a sacrificial stone with a bleeding head under it. It was quite terrifying to see!

After the horsemen, there came a band of fifty drummers. After them, a group of a thousand soldiers marched out shouting!

“Long live King of Cholas!”

“Long live Sundara Chola!”

“Long live the King of Thanjavur!”

“Long live Prince Aditya Karikalan!”

“Long live Prince Arulmozhivarmar!”

“Long live the clan of Cholas!”

Thus, the Velkarar Army marched out of the Thanjavur Fort, as Vandiya Devan stood watching.



Chapter 23 - Amudan's Mother

As the Velkarar's army passed by, Vandiya Devan noticed that these soldiers too amused themselves at the cost of others, just like the Pazhuvur soldiers.

One of the soldiers walked into a sweet shop and picked a basket full of Adhirasam^[106] and distributed it among his friends. After that, he took the basket and placed it on the head of the shop's owner and laughed merrily.

One other soldier snatched a flower basket from an old woman and threw the flowers high up in the air, while his friends tried to catch the flowers that were falling. One other band of soldiers stopped a bullock cart that was coming by, made the driver get down and drove it towards the market crowd.

These soldiers are also like the Pazhuvur soldiers, amusing themselves at the expense of the ordinary people. Thank God! They didn't notice me. Otherwise, there would have been a bloody skirmish.

He also didn't fail to notice one difference. The townsmen didn't seem to resent them for all the trouble that they caused. In fact, most of them joined them in their merriment.

Vandiya Devan wanted to ask the Saivaite youth about this, but when he looked around, the youth was nowhere to be seen.

Vandiya Devan knew that once the Velkarar's army came out of the fort, no one would be allowed to enter without proper authority. The

Royal Family and their retainers, Ministers in the royal court, and Pazhuvetarayar's family members were the only ones who had unrestricted entry into the fort. That's why he had decided early on that he wouldn't enter the fort that night. There was no point in going there now since it would not be possible to get an audience with the King at this hour.

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan walked along the fort walls through the roads of Thanjavur. His horse was exhausted and weary from the long journey. He would need to find a good guesthouse for it to rest.

Who knows? Tomorrow I might have to leave Thanjavur in a hurry, and I would be able to do it only if the horse is well rested.

Thanjavur was the new capital city growing in importance and population. People were coming in large numbers from other parts of the kingdom to visit and trade in this new city. There were also many foreign dignitaries who were there on a visit as emissaries from their respective kingdoms.

As Vandiya Devan walked through the marketplace, he saw numerous flower shops, which reminded him of the Saivaite youth he met earlier. He wished he could meet him again to enquire about guesthouses in Thanjavur. While he was thinking thus, he saw the young man walking towards him. He immediately dismounted his horse, went to him and said, "Thambi, what happened to all the flower baskets that you had? You have sold them all?"

"I was not taking the flowers to sell in the market. I was taking it to the temple for evening pooja."

"Oh! For which temple are you doing this service?"

“Thallikulathar temple.”

“Oh, yes! I have heard about the Thanjai Thallikulathar temple. Is it a big temple?”

“No, it is not. Nowadays, in Thanjavur, it is the Durga Temple that is being given more importance. Every day there is some special pooja happening there, thanks to the patronage of the royal family and the Pazhuvur clan.”

“Do you get paid for this service?”

“We were retained by the late King Gandaradithan Chola to do this service.

“Is the Thallikulathar temple built of black stone or sandstone?” On his way, he had seen many temples being built in black stone.

“No. It is a sandstone temple. I have heard that it will be soon renovated by Queen Sembiyanmadevi but...”

“But what?”

“What is the use of talking about these rumours? There is a saying that we must be careful about what we talk during the day, and we mustn’t talk about it at all during the night. And we are standing in the marketplace, among some many people...”

“This is the best place to talk secretly. In this hustle and bustle, no one can hear us.”

“But we do not have any secrets to talk about.” said the youth looking a bit suspiciously at Vandiya Devan.

Vandiya Devan realized that the young man was quite intelligent. He wanted to learn more things about the happenings in Thanjavur, without arousing his suspicion.

“That’s true. We have no secrets to discuss. Never mind all that thambi, I am looking for a guesthouse to sleep tonight. Can you help me?”

“You have lots of places to choose in this city. There are many royal guesthouses available for the dignitaries. But if you wish you can...”

“Thambi, what is your name?”

“Amuthan. Senthana Amuthan.”

“Good name. You were about to say that if I say wish I can come and stay in your house.”

“Yes. But how did you know.”

“I am very intuitive. Where is your house?”

“Outside the city limits, we have a small garden with a farm and a hut.”

“Ah! That would be ideal for me. I want to rest in a place away from the hustle and bustle of this city, and I would also like to meet your mother and tell her that she is lucky to have a fine young man like you, as her son.”

“No, Ayya. My mother is very unlucky.”

“Why do you say that? Is it because, your father...”

“My father died at a young age, but that’s not why she is unlucky. She has been unlucky since her birth. You will know it when you meet her.”

After about a half hour walk, they reached Amudan’s house. Even at some distance, Vandiya Devan was able to smell the scent of flowers that bloom during the night. In the middle of the farm, there were two small huts. One of the huts belonged to Amudan and the other to a family who helped them maintain the farm. Amudan helped Vandiya Devan to tie his horse and arranged to feed it.

After that, he took him to his hut where Vandiya Devan met Amudan’s mother. Vandiya Devan immediately realized why Amudan had called his mother unlucky. She was deaf and mute, but she looked kind and intelligent.

Amudan, with the help of signs, explained to his mother that Vandiya Devan was a guest who would stay with them for a night. His mother expressed her welcome with her smile.

After some time, his mother served them both food. While having dinner, Vandiya Devan learned many things that were happening in Thanjavur. He first checked out who was inside the fort and who was out of town.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had their palaces within the fort. Their retainers and soldiers under their command stayed there too. Sundara Chola’s most trusted Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar has a palace within the fort. The King’s retainers, royal priest and other prominent officials of the royal court too were housed within the fort along with their families. Apart

from them, jewellers, diamond merchants and silk merchants who were patronized by the royal family, also resided within the fort.

After learning all this, Vandiya Devan asked, “Are all the ministers inside the fort?”

“How will they all be inside the fort? Most of them keep going out on official work. Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar left for the Pandya Kingdom, a few days ago. Periya Pazhuvetarayar left for Nadunadu four days ago. He has not returned yet.”

“Are you sure?”

“This evening, I saw the Pazhuvur Queen’s palanquin coming inside, but Periya Pazhuvetarayar did not arrive along with her.”

“Thambi, is Prince Madhuranthakar inside the fort?”

“Yes. His palace is right next to Pazhuvetarayar’s palace. He is the son-in-law of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.”

“Oh, is he? I didn’t know that.”

“Not many people know about it. Since the Emperor is unwell, they did not celebrate the wedding grandly.”

“Good. So, the Prince will be inside the fort, right?”

“Yes. He comes out of the fort very rarely. It is said that he is deeply immersed in his pooja and meditation towards Lord Shiva.”

“Is it not surprising for him to marry so suddenly after declaring that he is going to be a sanyasi?”

“Yes, it was surprising indeed, and I have heard that after his marriage, he has changed a lot. But why should we talk about these things? Many things keep happening among the royalty...”

Vandiya Devan wanted to learn few more details from Senthana Amuthan, but he didn't want to arouse his suspicion. Moreover, he was terribly tired after the long journey. Amudan arranged for a bed to be placed in the verandah of his hut for Vandiya Devan.

Just before he was about to sleep, Vandiya Devan thought about the beautiful wife of the Pazhuvur Lord.

My God! What beauty? When I saw her for the first time, I was dumbstruck.

Vandiya Devan remembered an incident that happened when he was young. He was passing through a forest when he suddenly came upon a snake. It had spread its hood and was dancing before him. He was so awestruck by its beauty that he couldn't take his eyes off. Whenever the snake moved, his body too moved in the same direction. Vandiya Devan remembered that he had felt the same way that afternoon when he had met Nandini.

My God! What an example? Why am I comparing that beautiful woman to a snake? There is nobody in this world to compete with her beauty. What about that woman I saw in Kudandhai Jhodhidar's house? She was also stunning. They both are gorgeous, but there is a difference in their beauty. She looked stately and dignified, whereas Nandini was alluring and seductive. As he went on comparing both the women, sleep overtook him...



Chapter 24 - The Crow and the Nightingale

Vandiya Devan slept like a log the whole night. In the morning he woke up only when he heard Senthana Amuthan singing beautiful hymns while plucking flowers from the garden. He instantly felt sorry for his friend's mother, who couldn't hear such a beautiful voice. His sweet voice, pure devotion, and simple life made Vandiya Devan to ponder upon the futility of his life.

Why should I forever roam around like this carrying a sword ready to kill somebody or be killed by someone? Why shouldn't I tend a garden like Senthana Amuthan and lead a peaceful life?

After some time, his thoughts ran in a different direction.

Not everybody can be a good soul like Senthana Amuthan. Some people plot against one other and try to harm others. People need a king to protect them and kings need an army of bodyguards like the Velkarars to protect them from enemies. They also need messengers like me. Yes, today I will have to meet the Emperor at any cost before Periya Pazhuvetarayar returns.

There was a small pond near the garden. Vandiya Devan took his bath there and dressed himself with care. It was not clear whether he took the pains to do that because he was meeting the Emperor or because he thought he might be meeting the beautiful Pazhuvur Queen.

After partaking a morning meal, Vandiya Devan and Senthana Amuthan left the house. Amudan carried two baskets of flowers for the morning pooja in the temple. Vandiya Devan had decided not to take his horse inside the fort. He wanted to rest his horse for the day since he felt that he might be leaving Thanjavur in a hurry. On their way to the fort, he learned a few more details from Amudan.

“You don’t have any other relatives?”

“Yes, I do, my mother's brother and sister. The brother lives in Kodikarai, and the sister passed away long back. My uncle is the guardian of the lighthouse in Kodikarai. He has a son and a daughter. His daughter...”

“What about the daughter?”

“You know, it’s a strange thing in my family. Either some of us are born mute and deaf or else we are endowed with a sweet voice...”

“Your uncle's daughter is not mute, is she?”

“No! No!”

“Then she must be a good singer. Is her voice sweeter than yours?”

“That’s a good question. It is like asking whether the nightingale sings better than the crow. When Poonghuzhali sings the sea calms down and listens. Even the animals in the Kodikarai forest stop in their tracks to listen to her...”

“Poonghuzhali? A very beautiful name.”

“It is not just her name, she herself is breath-taking. Even Rathi^[107] and Indrani can’t compete with her beauty.”

“Good! She is your uncle's daughter, which makes her your bride by rights. So, when is the wedding?”

“She might be the perfect bride for me, but I do not consider myself the ideal groom for her. If they conduct a swayamvaram^[108] for her, like they used to in the olden days of yore, I am sure even the heavenly gods would come down to wed her.”

“So, you mean to say that even if she wishes to marry you, you will refuse her?”

“Never! If God were to appear before me and ask me ‘Would you like to come to Kailasham^[109] in this mortal frame of yours or would you like to marry Poonghuzhali?’ then I would definitely choose to marry Poonghuzhali. But what is the use of my wishing all this?”

“Why do you talk so? Who can stop you if you want to marry her? Not all marriages take place with the bride's consent. For example, look at how 60-year-old Periya Pazhuvetarayar married this young woman. Do you think it happened with her agreement?”

“Anna^[110]! Be careful what you say about these people. Now that you're entering the fort, please be very careful about whatever you say about the Pazhuvetarayars.”

“Are you trying to scare me, thambi?”

“No Anna. It is the truth. The Pazhuvetarayars are very powerful now, and they are the real rulers of the Chola Kingdom. In Thanjavur,

there is nobody to supersede their authority.”

“Doesn't the Emperor have any power?”

“The Emperor is unwell, and he is almost like a puppet in the hands of the Pazhuvetarayars. He doesn't listen to his own sons nowadays.”

“Really? But they were not this powerful two years ago, were they?”

“No. It was only after he fell ill and came to Thanjavur that they become so powerful. With the Emperor unwell, there is nobody to question them. Rumours say that even Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar become so disgusted with their authority that he has left for the Pandya Kingdom.”

“Why did the Emperor leave Pazhaiarai? Do you know?”

“I will tell you what I know, Anna. Three years ago, when King Veera Pandyan died in the war, the Chola soldiers committed a lot of atrocities in the Pandya kingdom, which is, of course, natural during any war. Incensed by this, the supporters of the late Pandya king took an oath to destroy the Chola clan. That's why the Emperor was shifted to Thanjavur; here the fort is impregnable, it would be easier to protect him, and the physicians too recommended a change of location for his health.”

“Everybody talks about Sundara Chola's health, but nobody knows what really ails him?”

“Why not? The Emperor has been struck by paralysis. He cannot walk. He cannot ride a horse or an elephant. He can't even get out of his bed. That's why he doesn't ever come out of the palace. And I have also heard that he is not very sound in his mind, as well.”

“Oh, no! How sad!”

“We dare not pity the King, Anna. These Pazhuvetarayars might consider it as royal indecorum and throw us in the dungeon!”

Vandiya Devan thought, “Pazhuvetarayar! Pazhuvetarayar! The Emperor shouldn’t have entrusted them with so much power. Now they are misusing it. I must warn the Emperor about them when I get a chance.”

Soon, they were near the fort. Vandiya Devan parted from his new friend and went towards the entrance of the fort.



Chapter 25 - Thanjavur Fort

The signet ring with the image of the palm tree was like the magic ring in mythological tales. At the entrance of the fort, there were flower-sellers, vegetable and fruit vendors waiting to get inside; the guards were exercising the utmost authority in allowing them inside.

But our young hero did not hesitate he walked up briskly towards the entrance and showed his magic ring to them. Immediately, the guards respectfully withdrew and opened the door to let him inside.

Vandiya Devan did not know that this was a momentous occasion - his stepping inside the fort. This would set off a chain of many important events in the history of the Chola Kingdom.

After entering the fort, Vandiya Devan stood spellbound for a while. This was his first visit to a big capital city like Thanjavur. Though he had lived in the old capital city of the Pallava kings, Kanchi was not a bustling city like Thanjavur. It was full of old, dilapidated buildings crumbling away which Prince Aditya Karikalan was rebuilding now. But Thanjavur was different. It was a new city, a testimony to the power of the Cholas. There were new palaces, gardens, and shops everywhere. The whole atmosphere was electrifying.

Vandiya Devan had assumed that there would not be many people inside the fort due to the restrictions and vigilance enforced by the guards, but he was pleasantly surprised to note the crowds thronging the market. There were people on horseback, others traveling on horse carts and elephants, bullock carts laden with rice bags going

about their business. There were people selling sweets, milk and curd, bargaining with their vendors. And there was the timekeeper on the top of a tall tower, who announced the time by ringing the bell.

“My God! There is truly no other city like Thanjavur indeed! It looks as if there is a carnival going on...”

Vandiya Devan did not want anybody to know that he was a stranger to the city. He thought that if he were to ask people for directions, they might consider him an unimportant and insignificant stranger who was gaping at the sights of the city. So, he decided to find his way to the king’s palace without anybody’s help. He thought that it would not be that difficult a job.

As he looked around, he saw Chola flags with the symbolic tiger flying high all around. The flag of the Pazhuvetarayars was also seen everywhere flying low next to the tiger. He also spotted a tiger flag flying on a tall tower; it was, by and large, the biggest flag in Thanjavur. He decided it must be the palace of the Chola king, so he started walking towards it.

His first task was to hand over the Prince’s message to the Emperor and convey the verbal message from the Crown Prince.

“But I can’t meet the Emperor without the Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s permission. How do I get his permission? By God’s grace, I was able to enter the fort, but I should not be dependent on God for everything. I need to find a way to meet the Emperor alone. I need an idea!”

He wanted to confirm whether Periya Pazhuvetarayar had returned to the fort. He went up to a guard who was sitting near the entrance

of the fort and asked him, “Do you know whether Pazhuvetarayar has returned?”

“Which Pazhuvetarayar are you asking about, thambi? Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is in the royal palace.”

“I know that. I was asking about Periya Pazhuvetarayar.”

“The Pazhuvur Queen came back to the fort yesterday evening, but Periya Pazhuvetarayar did not come along with her. We are expecting him tonight.”

That’s good news for me, Vandiya Devan thought. He had to meet the king and give him the message before Periya Pazhuvetarayar came back to the fort. While he was thinking so, an idea dawned in his mind, which he decided to use.

He did not have to wander much to find the royal palace. He kept walking towards the direction of the big flag that was flying on the tall tower. Very soon, he was in front of it. It was not just any palace - it appeared to be a small fortress. It looked as if an entire army was guarding the palace. There were armed soldiers on horseback in front of the gates, archers on the walls, and foot soldiers at strategic positions. Vandiya Devan remembered the description he had heard of the legendary city of Ujjain under the rule of the mythical King Vikramaditya, it seemed to fit the royal palace of Thanjavur.

There were four roads to reach the palace. And at the head of each road were batches of soldiers on guard who did not allow bystanders to linger there for a long time. But Vandiya Devan did not hesitate in the slightest. He walked rapidly towards the entrance of the palace. Immediately, the guards barred his way, but when Vandiya Devan

showed them his magic ring, they let him pass after checking the insignia on the ring.

“I am inside the palace, but I don’t know how many soldiers I have to pass to reach the Emperor. How will I find the Emperor’s chamber in this vast palace?”

Even while he thought thus, he heard a babble of voices behind him. He turned and saw a group of men entering the palace. They were dressed in costly silk, bejewelled turbans and a few pearl necklaces each, and were carrying a bunch of palm manuscripts in their hands. They looked like poets.

He heard the head of the guard speaking to his men, “The poets have arrived for an audience with the Emperor. Take them to the visitor’s room. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is holding court there.”

“My dear poets! You can leave the palace through this way, only if the Emperor showers you with gifts.” joked one of the guards from outside.

Listening to this conversation, Vandiya Devan knew that they had solved his problem. “All I need to do now is to follow this group of poets and reach Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. I needn’t ask anybody for directions!” he thought gleefully.



Chapter 26 - Danger! Danger!

Walking through the palace, they reached the visitor's room with Vandiya Devan in the lead. There he saw Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, sitting on a throne with his soldiers and servants around him.

A servant was holding palm leaves on which were written messages for Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. The accountant was waiting with the daily accounts and the soldiers for orders from their master. In other words, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar looked the very image of power!

When he saw Vandiya Devan, his face brightened, and he asked, "Who are you thambi?"

Whenever Chinna Pazhuvetarayar saw young warriors like Vandiya Devan, he became very gracious. That was because he wished to enlist all capable young fighters in his own army!

"Dalapathi, I have come from Kanchipuram. Prince Aditya Karikalan has sent a message."

As soon as he heard that Vandiya Devan was from Kanchipuram, Chinna Pazhuvetar's face fell.

"What? What did you say?"

"Prince Karikalan has sent a message for the King."

"Give it here. Let me see."

Vandiya Devan took out the olai suvadi^[111] and gave it to him saying, "Dalapathi, the olai is for the Emperor."

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar went ahead and opened the olai without heeding Vandiya Devan's words and muttered, "Nothing new in this anyway..."

"Dalapathi, the olai is for..."

"What about it? I will give it to the Emperor."

"But I was asked to give it personally..."

"So, you don't believe that I would deliver this message to him. Prince Aditya told you to do so, did he?" asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar nastily.

"Prince Aditya didn't ask me to do this. But your brother did."

"What? You met Periya Pazhuvetarayar? Where?"

"On my way here, I had stopped at Kadambur Palace for a night. I met him there. He also gave me this ring."

"Aha! Why didn't you tell this earlier? So, you stayed overnight at Kadambur? Who else had come there?"

"Noble lords from Mazhanadu, Nadunadu, Thirumunaipadi [\[112\]](#) had come..."

"Wait! Wait! Let's talk of this later. You can give this olai to the Emperor personally now. Later, if the poets come, they will go on talking..."

"You there! Take this young soldier to the Emperor's chamber," he said to a soldier.

Vandiya Devan followed the soldier inside the palace while admiring the statues and the beautiful paintings that embellished the rich

walls.

For the past few years, the Chola throne room had been converted into Emperor's sick bed. After handing over the administration of the kingdom to his noblemen and trusted courtiers, the King has been convalescing from paralysis. But there were occasions, where he had to give audience to some influential people - ministers, Velkarar Army heads and other officials.

Victorious in numerous wars and named Sundara Chola (the Beautiful Chola) by his people for his handsome looks, Paranthaka lay in his bed, shrunken and lean. Vandiya Devan's eyes filled with tears when he saw the Emperor's wasted body. Beside the Emperor sat the Empress Vanamadevi. Vandiya Devan took out the olai respectfully and handed it over to the King.

The Emperor took the olai from him, "Where have you come from? Who has sent this?"

"My Lord! I have come from Kanchipuram. Prince Aditya has sent this olai."

The Emperor's face brightened. He immediately turned towards his queen saying, "Devi, your son has sent the olai."

"Aha! The Prince has built a golden palace in Kanchipuram, and he wants us to come and stay there for some days," said the Emperor with a frown after reading the olai.

"Devi! See what your son has done? My grandfather, Paranthaka Chakravarti took all the gold from the treasury and built a golden roof for Lord Shiva's temple, but he did not erect a golden palace to live!

He and my father were more interested in the construction of temples. But look at what Aditya Karikalan has done.”

When she had heard that they had received an olai from their son, the queen’s face had brightened but when she heard her speak thus her face was clouded with sorrow.

At this time Vandiya Devan intervened and said, “My Lord! Your son has not done anything wrong. Our scriptures teach us to respect our parents as Gods. So, what’s wrong with building a golden palace for you and the Queen?”

“We may appear as gods to our children, but others may not consider us in that light.”

“My Lord! Parents are gods to their children while the King is God for his subjects. So, the Prince has not done anything wrong.”

“Devi! See how intelligent this boy is. As long as Karikalan has people like him with him, we needn’t worry about his recklessness.”

Then, he turned towards Vandiya Devan and said, “Even if the Prince has done the right thing by building the golden palace, it is not possible for me to leave this Thanjavur Palace. I can’t travel and go to Kanchipuram. Aditya should come and see us here. We too are eager to see him. Come tomorrow and I will ask the scribe to give you a written reply.”

At this time Vandiya Devan could hear a group of people entering the room. It was the group of poets. And who knew - even Chinna Pazhuvetarayar might be with them. And then it would be impossible to tell the King, the other message that Prince Aditya had asked me to deliver. So urgently addressed the king, “Prabhu, please listen to

me. This is important. You will need to leave this Thanjavur palace immediately. You are in danger here. Abaayam^[113] Abaayam! Abaayam!”

Even as he was saying this, Chinna Pazzhuvetarayar entered the room. And it appeared as if he had heard the last sentence of Vandiya Devan because his face was flushed with anger.



Chapter 27 - The Royal Poets

As the royal poets entered the king's courtroom, the announcer heralded their arrival, "Behold the royal poets, gems of the literary world, the literary giants!"

After they piled into the room, they came forward and blessed the king with a poem,

"May you live a hundred autumns, O King!

May your fame spread far and wide!

May you and your kingdom prosper!"

King Sundara Chola, however, didn't like them hailing him thus, but he didn't give any indication of his feelings. Instead, he spoke as a gracious host and asked how they fared.

But Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was sharp enough to notice this. He immediately said, "Noble King, the poets have come only to pay their respects to you. I request you not to strain yourself too much."

"Yes, my Lord! The noble Pazhuvetarayar is right. We do not want to cause you any inconvenience," the poets said in a chorus.

"I am pleased to see you all together after such a long time. Everybody, please sit down. And I would like to hear the new poems that you have composed."

All the poets sat on the luxurious carpet that was spread for the visitors. Vandiya Devan also sat along with them. He couldn't deliver the complete verbal message that Prince Aditya had tasked him to

do. But he thought he might be able to talk to the king again after the poets left.

It had not escaped Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's notice that Vandiya Devan had sat down with the poets. He had first intended to remove the young warrior from the room. But later, he felt that it would be better if he were right there. After the poets had left, he wanted to question him alone. He could still hear the young man's warning to the King, "*Abaayam! Abaayam!*"

"My dear poets! It has been a long time since I heard any good poems. Have any of you composed or heard anything new?"

Immediately a poet stood up from the group, "My lord! Even though you are an ardent Shiva devotee, you have helped the Buddhist monasteries in the Chola Kingdom with funds and amenities. The grateful Buddhist monks are praying for your good health with a poem..."

"Really? That is very kind of them. Can you recite this poem?"

The poet immediately recited the poem, which described how grateful the Buddhist monks were to King Sundara Chola, who had built them monasteries, served the people and how they wished him a long life.

After listening to the poem, one of the poets remarked, "I never knew that these Buddhists were such grateful people."

But the king smiled at them and said, "I don't think I did anything great to help them. I don't see the need for such praise for such a small deed."

“Noble King, how can you say that? Those who have seen your generosity would surely beg to differ. It is no surprise that they praise you so much. In fact, Lord Indra and God Shiva too have experienced your benevolence and are praising you much!”

On hearing this, Sundara Chola smiled and asked, “What is that story? Why should Lord Indra and God Shiva praise me?”

“Lord, allow me to recite a poem; you will then realize the meaning of what I just told you,” Saying thus, the poet recited a poem, which elicited much praise from all the poets and the king.

“Can you explain the meaning of this poem?” asked the king.

“Once, King Indra was at war with the demon Virata. In the war, his elephant Airavatham^[114] died, and he was not able to replace it with an elephant that had the same strength and powers as Airavatham.

In the end, he came to Pazhaiarai and met Emperor Sundara Chola and requested him to find him an elephant that would match his legendary Airavatham in strength. Listening to this, Sundara Chola said, ‘I do not have an elephant that can match your Airavatham, but I do have elephants that are more powerful.’ Saying thus, the king showed Lord Indra all the elephants that he possessed and asked him to select any elephant of his choice. Lord Indra looked around and found it unable to decide which elephant to take. So Sundara Chola himself picked an elephant for Lord Indra. But the elephant looked so powerful that Lord Indra wondered how he could control it. It seemed even his fiery thunderbolt wouldn’t be able to bend the elephant’s will to his own. But Sundara Chola sensed Lord Indra’s

fear so he gave him a powerful mahout's stick to control the elephant...

"Another time, Lord Surya and Lord Rahu^[115] were engaged in a big battle. Rahu tried to swallow Surya but instead got burned by the intensity of Surya's heat. But Lord Surya lost all his horses in the fight. Without them, he was stuck in one place. Feeling sorry for him, King Sundara Chola immediately picked seven horses from his stable and presented them to Lord Surya. Lord Surya was grateful for help from a king who was born in his own race...

"Once, when Lord Shiva and Parvati were getting married in Mount Kailash, the bridal party brought everything but forgot to bring a palanquin. And Lord Shiva had only his bull to mount his bride on. Learning about this, King Sundara Chola immediately presented his pearl-studded palanquin to the Lord and his wife. Lord Shiva blessed him and thanked him for his timely help. It is indeed no wonder that such an Emperor now rules the three worlds..."

Listening to these flights of fantasy, Sundara Chola laughed, until his eyes watered. The queen's face brightened. It had been a long time since she had seen her husband so cheerful.

After the Emperor had laughed his fill, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar came forward and said, "Lord, I have made a terrible mistake. Please forgive me for that."

"Ah! What did you do, Commander? Did you go and snatch all the things that I had presented Indra, Surya, and Shiva? I know you are capable of such things!" He started laughing loudly again. The queen, poets and even Vandiya Devan joined him in his laughter.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar shot a venomous look at Vandiya Devan. After the laughter had subsided, he turned and told the king, "Lord, my mistake was that I did not allow the poets to come and visit you earlier. If I had known that their presence would make you so cheerful, I would have done this a long time ago. I have realized my mistake now. I have never seen you laugh so much before; even the queen is happy to see you laughing and joking."

"Yes Dalapati, well said! I have always told you to allow the poets to visit me. But you always listen to the physician and not to me."

On hearing this, the royal physician came forward to say something. But the king instead turned towards the poets and asked them, "Do you know who wrote this lovely poem?"

"No, my Lord! That's what we would also like to know. If we knew who this poet is, we would honour him with the title, 'King of Poets.'"

"I am not surprised that the poet has not revealed his name. Which poet would come forward and claim the honour of writing such lies indeed?"

The poets were dumbstruck by the king's statement. At this point, Vandiya Devan got up and said, "My Lord, you cannot call this poem a lie! If an ordinary man says something that's not true, then it is known as a 'lie.' If people who run a kingdom say the same thing, it is called 'strategy', but if a poet said the same thing, it is called 'imagination.'"

The poets turned towards him saying, "Well said! Well said!"

The king looked at him and said, "Oh, you are the one who has come from Kanchi. Very clever boy!"

He turned towards the poets and said, “My dear poets! It is a brilliant poem, but you don’t have to give this poet any titles because he already bears many meaningless titles like – ‘King of All Three Worlds.’”

The poets were dumbstruck on hearing this declaration.



Chapter 28 - The Iron Grip

The chief of the royal poets got up and asked, “Lord! Then... you are the great poet who wrote this poem...”

“Yes, I am that great poet,” said the King sarcastically. The poets were flabbergasted.

Sundara Chola then began, “My dear poets! You don’t have to be so surprised at this. Years ago, when we were all in Pazhaiarai, we had a small gathering of poets just like today. And many poets came and sang poems and obtained gifts from me. Kundavai who was with me then was full of praise for them. I then told her that I could compose a poem too. And as a joke, I told her this poem and asked her to give me a gift. But that naughty girl gave me only two playful slaps, as a present. This happened, some eight years ago but I can still remember it very clearly.”

When the King mentioned Kundavai’s name, Vandiya Devan’s heart skipped a beat. He couldn’t wait to meet this wondrous princess. He also noticed how proud Sundara Chola looked when he spoke about his daughter.

Vandiya Devan’s hand instinctively went to the bundle of cloth that he had tied around his waist because that was where he had kept the message that he had to give to Kundavai. But he had a shock when he realized that the bundle was empty.

“My God! What happened to that other message? Where has it fallen? Did I drop it when I gave the other olai to the King? What if it

had fallen in the visitor's room? Then it would inevitably end up in Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's hands. How could I have been so careless?"

After this, Vandiya Devan was immersed in his own thoughts and worries and did not much heed to the proceedings in the room.

But Sundara Chola was still talking to the poets, "This poem was just a joke that I had written for Kundavai. But she seems to have told somebody about it. Maybe she told Issana Shiva Pattar in Pazhaiarai, and he has spread it all over..."

"My Lord, so what if you had meant it to be a joke. It is a beautiful poem. You deserve to be the 'King of poets.'"

"But if I were to compose the same poem now, I would add some more verses to it. I wouldn't have stopped with giving the elephant to Indra, the horse to Surya and palanquin to Shiva. When Lord Shiva kicked away Lord Yama, who was trying to take Markandeyan's life, Lord Yama's bull died. And Lord Yama found it tough to travel without his bull. So Sundara Chola presented him with a bull. This I would have added in the poem. And do you know Lord Yama is approaching me on this very same bull? And not even our Dalapati can stop him..."

Listening to this, Queen Vanamadevi's resolve broke, and she started crying. But Chinna Pazhuvetarayar stood unmoved. He immediately said, "Lord, I am willing to fight even Lord Yama in your service."

"I have no doubt about that, Dalapati, but nobody can stop Lord Yama. The most that we can do is to become strong enough, not to

fear him. Does anybody here know the poem, ‘Namai Anjom’?”

One of the poets got up and started singing...

As the poet finished, the King exclaimed, “Aha! What a beautiful poem! Such deep meaning! This poet is really blessed because he has seen God with his own naked eyes. Otherwise, he couldn’t have written such a beautiful poem. My dear poets, henceforth please stop singing poems about my exploits. Instead, it would be nice if you could get more poems written by Appar [\[116\]](#) and compile them into a volume.”

“My Lord, if you give us the permission, we can start work on it right away.”

“No! I don’t think you can do it now. Maybe after my time...” Saying thus the King became silent.

The royal physician silently moved to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and whispered something into his ear.

Immediately Chinna Pazhuvetarayar addressed the King saying, “My Lord, you had earlier told me that you wished to hear a poem from the Sangam period. Let the poets sing that and then leave.”

“Yes, yes, I forgot. Nowadays I keep forgetting everything. Yes, can anybody sing a song from that period?”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar signaled to the chief of poets, who immediately got up and said, “My Lord, among your ancestors was a great king called Karikala Peruvellathar. He was a great king who travelled all the way to the Himalayas and established Chola supremacy everywhere. During his reign, Kaveripattnam [\[117\]](#) was the

capital of the kingdom. It was also a vibrant port where ships from all over the world used to come and trade. One poet described this harbour thus...”

The poet recited the poem, which described the wealth that had come from all over the world and how ships laden with food had come from Elangai. The King interrupted the recital and asked, “Dalapati! This poem describes how food was transported to our kingdom from Elangai. That’s why you had asked this poet to recite this song to me.”

“Yes, my Lord,” said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, looking shocked that the King had so quickly understood his intentions.

“Fine, Dalapati. Please present the poets with ample rewards. My dear poets, you may take your leave now.”

The poets got up, blessed the King and took their leave. Vandiya Devan, who was impatient to search for the missing olai, tried to slip out of the room along with them. But just when he was just about to step out, somebody caught his wrist in an iron grip and placed a hand on his shoulder.

Vandiya Devan was by no means a puny man. He was quite healthy and vigorous, but he had never come across anybody who could hold him in such a vice grip! He looked up and saw that the man who held him so tightly was none other than Chinna Pazhuvetarayar!



Chapter 29 - The Royal Guest

After the poets had taken their leave, the royal physician prepared the medicine for the king and the queen fed it to her husband lovingly. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar waited for a while and then came forward dragging Vandiya Devan along with him.

“My lord, do you see any improvement in your health due to the new medicine?”

“Our physician says that there is an improvement, so does the queen. But I have lost all hope. I think all your efforts are in vain. Lord Yama has gone to Pazhaiarai in search of me. When he finds that I am not there, he will come to Thanjavur one day...”

“My Lord! You shouldn’t speak thus. Your ancestors...”

“Ah, my ancestors were not scared of Lord Yama. If only I were fortunate enough to die in a battlefield like them, I would welcome such a death with open hands. My uncle Rajadhithar died bravely in the battlefield of Thakkolam and people now herald him as the “Brave Prince of the Thakkolam war.” But what will people say about me? “The old king who died in his sick bed!” My other uncle, Gandaradithar who was a great Shiva devotee was also not afraid of death. He travelled all over the kingdom visiting Shiva temples and died with the name of his lord on his lips. But here I am, helpless with limbs that refuse to move. How long do I suffer this and be a burden to everyone? But something tells me that I won’t live long...”

“Chakravarthy! Our royal physician says that there is no danger to your life. So do the astrologers, but I heard this boy telling you that you are in danger here.”

“This is the young man who has come from Kanchipuram. Yes, you said something about the danger. Were you referring to my health thambi?”

Vallavareyan’s mind worked furiously. It was evident that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had overheard what he had tried to tell the king. And he urgently needed an idea, so he sought the help of literature!

“Chakravarti! Why would I warn about any danger, when we have a brave commander like Chinna Pazhuvetarayar guarding the fort? I was just saying, “Abayam [\[118\]](#)! Abayam!” I am the only survivor of our great Vanar clan that ruled for about 300 years. And I have been serving the Chola Kingdom with my heart and soul. If only, your highness could return a small part of my old kingdom, I swear that I will serve the Chola Kingdom, until my last breath. I am but an orphan with nary a support other than your son’s kindness. That was why I said, ‘Abayam Prabhu,’” said Vallavareyan speaking continuously.

Hearing this Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s face wore a scowl, while the king looked on fascinated.

The queen looked at him with pity and said, “What a gifted boy he is. So articulate! He truly has the blessings of Goddess Saraswati, to speak thus!”

Vandiya Devan immediately turned towards her and said, “Amma! Please put in a word for me with the king. I am an orphan. I don’t

have anybody else in this world to speak for me. Please request the king to give me a small part of my ancestral kingdom. Even if I were granted ten villages, I would be content.”

Sundara Chola turned towards Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and said, “Dalapati! I like this young man very much. I think the queen is already thinking of adopting him as our third son. Why don’t we give him a part of his kingdom back? I don’t think there will be any difficulty in that. What is your opinion?”

“I don’t think there is any room for my opinion here. We need to ask Prince Aditya Karikalar.”

“Chakravarthy! Whenever I ask the Prince, he says that he needs to ask you and the noble Pazhuvetarayar brothers. But the Pazhuvur Lord says that he needs to ask the Prince. In all this, the state of my petition...”

“My dear boy! Don’t worry. I will get both their approval and fulfil your wish.” said the king and turned towards Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, “Dalapati! This boy had brought a message from Karikalan. The Prince has built a new golden palace and wants us to go there and stay with him.”

“Your wish is my command, my lord.”

“Oh, yes, my wish is your command indeed, but my legs refuse to move. And I refuse to be carried all the way to Kanchi in a palanquin, like the womenfolk. I want the Prince to come to Thanjavur.”

“Is it right for the Prince to come to Thanjavur now, my lord? Our enemies have stationed a formidable army at the border...”

“Parthibendran and Malayaman will take care of the border. I want the Prince here, next to me. I want to recall Prince Arulmozhi from Elangai as well. I need to decide something very important whilst they both are here. And when Arulmozhi comes back, we can talk about your objections to sending food for our army in Elangai.”

“Chakravarthy! I am not objecting to anything. It is the citizens of this kingdom, who are objecting to it. Last year’s harvest was barely enough for us, and when the people knew that they had to send half of it to Elangai, they were not happy. Right now, they are only grumbling about it, but if this situation continues, very soon they might protest openly.”

“I am sure that the Prince will not do anything that people of this kingdom object to. It would be better if we could sort out all these issues when he comes here. After Periya Pazhuvetarayar comes back, ask him to send a message to Elangai asking the Prince to return immediately. When is the Pazhuvur Lord expected?”

“He will arrive tonight.”

“Tomorrow, we will send a message to Kanchi. This boy can take the message to the Prince.”

“My lord, this boy has travelled from Kanchi in one spell. He must be exhausted. We can send somebody else to Kanchi.”

“Fine. Let him also stay here until the Prince comes back.”

At this point, the queen got up from the bed signalling that the interview was over. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar turned apologetically towards the king and said, “I am sorry, my lord. It is time for us to leave now.”

“Dalapati! This boy is our guest. So please take care of him. If the Chakravarthi’s health was fine, I would have asked him to stay with us in our palace.” said the queen.

“I will take care of him, Amma! Don’t worry about him. I will take good care of him.” said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar twirling his moustache ominously.



Chapter 30 - Chithirai Mandapam

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar took Vandiya Devan back to the Asthana Mandapam. He was not satisfied with the explanation that the boy had given in the presence of the Emperor. He wondered whether he had made a mistake in letting Vandiya Devan meet the Emperor alone. It was but natural to suspect him since he was Aditya Karikalan's messenger but Periya Pazhuvetarayar had sent him with his own signet ring.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar couldn't believe that he could have heard the boy, say 'Abayam' as 'Abaayam.'

It would be better to keep him in the fort until Periya Pazhuvetarayar comes back. And if possible, I can even enlist him as a spy under my command. Who knows, he might be helpful. He seems bright enough. And if I can give back his kingdom, he would be grateful enough to serve us faithfully.

After reaching the visitor's room, he saw that Vandiya Devan looking around frantically as if he was searching for something. He was right. Vandiya Devan was indeed looking for the other important message hoping that it might have fallen near the commander's throne.

If I don't find that message, I will never forgive myself. How will I meet the Princess without it?

While he was thinking thus, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar called his servants and said, "This boy is our royal guest. Provide lodgings for

him in our guesthouse and take good care of him and be with him, until I come.”

After Vandiya Devan had left, a soldier came towards Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and held out an olai respectfully. “My lord, I found this olai on the way to the Emperor’s chamber. I think it fell out of the bundle that the boy was carrying.”

The dalapati was immediately interested. He opened the olai and read it. As he read it, his eyebrows arched, and his face wore a very dangerous look.

“Aha! This is a message that Aditya Karikalan has written to Princess Kundavai.”

“You wanted me to send you a trustworthy soldier who is brave, smart and ingenious therefore I have sent Vandiya Devan to you. You can trust him completely and entrust any confidential task to him. He will complete it, come what may!”

“What is this mystery? Does Periya Pazhuvetarayar know about this olai? I need to be more careful with this boy now.” he thought and whispered some secret instructions to the soldier who had brought the olai.

At the royal guest house of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s palace, Vandiya Devan was treated like a king. His servants got him new clothes and ornaments, while Vandiya Devan had a refreshing bath. In his enthusiasm to wear the costly silks, he even forgot his worry about the missing olai. After the bath, a tasty feast was laid before him, to which he did full justice.

Then they took him on a tour of the palace and asked him to wait at the Chitharai mandapam. “Why don’t you look at these beautiful paintings until Chinna Pazhuvetarayar arrives?”

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Thanjavur, which had recently become the new capital of the Cholas, was well known for its beautiful sculptures and paintings. If Thiruvaiyaru was famous for dance and music, Thanjavur was known for arts. The Chithirai Mandapam [\[119\]](#)in Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s palace was well known for its beautiful paintings and art.

The paintings portrayed the history of the Chola Kings chronologically. Of these, the central portion of the pictures showcased the kings from the past 100 years in Chola history.

It is important that the readers learn more details about the history of the Chola Kings to understand the rest of this story...

We have earlier mentioned about King Vijayalaya Chola who was the bearer of 99 battle scars in his body. Among the Chola Kings, it was customary to take up titles such as ‘Parakesari’ or ‘Rajakesari’.

After the reign of Parakesari Vijayalaya Chola, his son Rajakesari Aditya Chola came to the throne. He was the rightful heir to the fearless legacy of King Vijayalaya Chola and was a brave soldier. He joined forces with the Pallavas and defeated the Pandyas in the Thakkolam war. Later, he fought a war against the Pallava King, Aparajitha Varman. Riding an elephant, Aditya Chola attacked

Aparajitha Varman and killed him in the war. After annexing Thondai Mandalam (North Tamil Nadu), he captured Kongu Mandalam (near present day Coimbatore in Tamil Nadu).

After Rajakesari Aditya Chola, Parakesari Paranthakan came to the throne. He ruled the kingdom for 41 years. Paranthaka Chola is yet another legend in the Chola history whose battle campaigns mirrored those of his ancestor King Karikala Peruvellathan who had captured parts of Northern India and brought it under the reign of Cholas.

But during the fag end of his reign, the Chola Kingdom faced grave danger. The Rashtrakutas were steadily growing in power, and they sought to put a stop to the ascendancy of the Cholas in Tamil Nadu. With a strong army, they entered Tamil Nadu and were successful in capturing some lands.

King Paranthakan had three sons; the eldest was Prince Rajadhithan who was a great warrior. Anticipating this war, he was stationed in Thirumunaipadi with an army to intercept the Rashtrakutas. While he was there, he also built the Veeranarayana dam that we saw in the first chapter.

Near Arakonam, a fierce battle was fought between the Cholas and the Rashtrakutas. In this war, Rajadhithan fought like the brave warrior that he was, riding atop his elephant and he died in the end, after winning the battle.

If Rajadhithan had not perished in the fight, he would have ascended the throne after King Paranthakan and his descendants would have ruled the Chola Kingdom in the years to come. Since Prince Rajadhithan died without an heir, his younger brother and the second son of King Paranthakan, Prince Gandaradithan became the king.

This king, just like his father and grandfather was a great Shiva devotee. In truth, he was a saint at heart and was not interested in ruling the kingdom. During his reign, he built many Shiva temples all over Tamil Nadu and composed many songs.

While he was engaged thus, he entrusted the responsibility of ruling the kingdom to his younger brother Aringhza Chola. He was also a great warrior like Prince Rajadhithan and was stationed near Thirunavalur was checking the progress of the Rashtrakuta army. King Gandaradithan had decided early on that the throne would pass on to his brother Aringhza Chola after his reign. There was a crucial reason behind this decision. King Gandaradithan's first wife had died even before he became the King and they were childless. King Gandaradithan was uninterested in getting married again just to sire an heir.

Of the three brothers, only Prince Aringhza Chola had a son, named after his grandfather as Paranthakan whom people lovingly called 'Sundara Chola' because of his handsome looks.

King Gandaradithan had decided that after his reign, the throne would pass on to his brother Aringhza Chola and later to his nephew, Sundara Chola. He declared this decision to everybody and wrote a will to this effect, after getting everybody's approval. Ironically after settling the issue of succession, a significant incident happened in his life - he fell in love!

He met the daughter of Mazhvareyan, a petty king under the Chola reign and fell in love with her at first sight. This girl was not only beautiful but also an ardent devotee of Shiva - just like himself. This made him give up his resolution of not getting married again. Despite

his advanced age, Sembiyanmadevi [\[120\]](#) agreed to marry him as she too had fallen in love with him!

Soon, a son was born to the couple, and they named him Madhuranthakan. But Gandaradithar did not wish to change the arrangement that he already made for the kingdom. Therefore, they decided to bring up their son as an ardent Shiva devotee away from the affairs of the kingdom. And the king made it clear to everybody that after his reign, the throne would pass on to Aringhza Chola and his dynasty.

Thus, the throne passed on from Rajadhithan to Gandaradithan and then to Aringhza Chola. After the reign of Gandaradithan, Aringhza Chola did not rule for a long time. He died within one year after his brother's demise, and Sundara Chola came to power. He brought much-needed peace and order to the Kingdom. He crushed the Rashtrakutas with an iron hand. He had two sons - Aditya Karikalan and Arulmozhiarman - who were brave warriors and assisted their father in the state affairs.



Chapter 31 - Thief! Thief!

Walking up and down the Chitharai mandapam, Vandiya Devan was lost in a myriad of emotions and thoughts as he looked at each painting that depicted the life history of the Chola kings.

They were all such great warriors. They performed such brave acts! The Chola Kingdom is indeed blessed to be under the rule of such heroic kings...

He also did not fail to notice one thing among the paintings - they also etched the role of the Pazhuvur warriors in the history of the Chola Kingdom. Right from the time of Vijayalaya Chola, warriors from this clan had laid their life down for the Chola kings. One Pazhuvetarayar had carried King Vijayalaya on his shoulder during the Thirupurampayam war, while another had helped Aditya Chola to slay the Pallava king Aparajitha Varman. And in the many wars that King Paranthakan fought, it was the Pazhuvetarayars who had led the Chola army from the forefront. When Prince Rajadhithan was wounded, it was a Pazhuvetarayar, who rallied the forces and led the Cholas to victory and gave the happy news to the dying prince.

After seeing all this depicted in the paintings, Vandiya Devan was not surprised that the Pazhuvur brothers wielded so much power in the kingdom. They were the kingmakers in Chola history!

But now, I am in trouble! Chinna Pazhuvetarayar obviously has some suspicion about the signet ring story. And in the meantime, if Periya Pazhuvetarayar comes back, my lie will be exposed...

Vandiya Devan had also heard about the infamous underground dungeon prison of Thanjavur that was under Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's control. Stories about this prison were legendary. It was told that no one had ever escaped from there and even if they managed to get out, it was as a bag of skin and bones, without a sane thought in their mind.

How do I escape this fate? I need to do something and get out of this fort before Periya Pazhuvetarayar comes back...

He had even given up the idea of meeting the beautiful queen of the Pazhuvur Lord!

Even if the other olai is missing, I can meet Kundavai Devi and give her the message verbally. If she wants to believe, let her; otherwise, she can go to hell! But I have to get out of this fort right away!

Suddenly he wondered what had happened to his clothes that he had taken off before having his bath.

Did Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's servants take them for inspection? Was that why he had been given new clothes? He was dead sure that the other olai was in Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's possession. That was why Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had caught hold of his hand roughly, while in the king's presence. And that was the reason why he had sent three soldiers to take care of him. Aha! Got it! I've got an idea. Now let me put it in action.

He went and looked out of the window of the Chitharai Mandapam. He saw Chinna Pazhuvetarayar coming towards the palace on an elephant. He immediately went out. The soldiers who had come along with him were playing a game of dice. Vandiya Devan went up

to them and asked, “I would like to know what happened to my old clothes?”

“Why do you need your old clothes now? We have given you such fine new clothes instead.”

“I don’t need these. Please bring me my old clothes.”

“They have been given to the washer men, thambi. As soon as they come back, we will bring them to you.”

“I don’t believe you. I had kept some money in my clothes. You people have stolen it. Bring back my clothes, otherwise...”

“Otherwise what?”

“Will you get my clothes or not?”

“We can get it for you only if they are available, thambi. We have already thrown your clothes to the crocodiles. How can we bring them to you?” saying thus the soldiers started laughing.

“You lying scoundrels! I am going to complain to your master right away,” he said and tried to walk out of the mandapam. Immediately one of the soldiers barred his way. Vandiya Devan was waiting for this to happen. He immediately hit him hard on his nose. The soldier fell bleeding. The other two tried to wrestle with him but met with the same fate. Now all three of them got up and approached him carefully. One part of Vandiya Devan’s mind heard the sounds outside the mandapam. He immediately attacked them shouting loudly, “You thieves! You scoundrels!”

At that point Chinna Pazhuvetarayar entered the mandapam, asking, “What is happening here?”



Chapter 32 – Inspection

When Vandiya Devan saw Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, he started walking towards him, but the soldiers caught him from behind and held him.

Vandiya Devan boldly looked up and said, “Dalapati! You have come here at the right time. Your soldiers have tried to kill me after stealing everything that I had. Is this how you treat your royal guests in Thanjavur? I am not only your guest. I am the guest of the Emperor. If you can treat a royal messenger sent by the Crown Prince like this, then I dare not think about the fate of others. I am surprised that you have thieves for your servants. If this had happened in Thondai Mandalam, they would have been dead by now.”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was shocked to see the three soldiers wounded by this, a mere boy. Now he desperately wanted to recruit Vandiya Devan into his own army. So, he spoke patiently, “Wait, thambi! I don’t think they could have done all this. Let me interrogate them.”

“Yes. Please question them and give me justice. And ask them to return my belongings to me.”

“You there! Leave him be and come here. What did I tell you and what have you done? Why did you behave thus?” asked Dalapati angrily.

“Master, we did exactly as you instructed us. We arranged for his bath, got him new clothes and served him food. After he had eaten,

we took him to the palace and left him in the Chithirai Mandapam. He was looking at the paintings for some time. After that, he suddenly asked for his old clothes and then attacked us.”

“How can three soldiers get beaten up by a mere boy like him?” shouted Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

“Master, we were lenient with him because he is your guest. If you give us permission, we can take care of him properly.”

“Enough! What do you say, thambi?”

“I say that you give them permission, and I will show them how to treat royal guests. It has been a long time since I have fought with enemies of the Cholas. Allow me to teach these servants of yours, a good lesson.”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar smiled at him and said, “Thambi! It is enough if you fight with the enemies of the Chola Kingdom. It is imperative that we maintain peace in this fort, especially when the Emperor is ailing.”

“If that is so, please ask them to return my clothes and my other belongings.”

“Where are they?”

“Master, as per your instructions, we have kept them safely.”

“Dalapati! See how they lie. They told me earlier that the clothes have gone for washing, and now they say that you had asked them to keep it safely, and who knows one day, they might even call you a ‘thief’!”

“Fools! I just asked you to get him new clothes. I didn’t say anything about the old ones. These fools are blabbering, thambi. Anyway, why do you need your old clothes? Did you have any valuables stored in them?”

“Yes, I had kept some money in them...” Even before Vandiya Devan could finish Chinna Pazhuvetarayar said, “You don’t have to worry about it. I will give you enough money for your journey back to Kanchi.”

“Dalapati! I am Aditya Karikalan’s messenger. I do not accept money from anybody else.”

“Fine. In that case, your clothes and your money will be returned to you. Did you have anything else?”

Vandiya Devan thought for a while, hesitated, and then said, “I had kept one other important thing in my clothes. I hope your soldiers have not meddled with it. If they did, they are dead.”

“Aha! You have a really fiery temper. You seem to forget in whose presence you are right now. Since you are a mere boy, I am going to pardon your behaviour. What was this other thing that you had in your clothes?”

“Dalapati, I can’t speak about it. It is confidential.”

“There is nothing confidential in Thanjai fort. Tell me what it is.”

“It is a confidential matter that Prince Karikalar had entrusted to me. I can’t talk about it.”

“Prince Karikalar is the Commander of the Northern Territory. His authority is only in Thondai Mandalam. This is Thanjavur. Here

Emperor King Sundara Chola has absolute power.”

“Dalapati! Undoubtedly, wherever the flag of the Cholas is hoisted, is under Sundara Chola’s authority.”

“That’s why, thambi, there cannot be any secrets in this fort. This is for the emperor’s security.”

“Dalapati! The Chola Kingdom is indebted to you and Periya Pazhuvetarayar for taking care of the Emperor. Even this morning he remarked that Lord Yama is afraid of you.”

“Yes, thambi! If we were in Pazhaiarai, I don’t know what disaster would have struck by now. The assassins from the Pandya kingdom might have killed him.”

“Oh! Even you are talking about this - then what I have heard is right.”

“What did you hear?”

“I have heard that somebody is plotting against the Emperor and his sons.”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar bit his lower lip in anger. It was evident that he had been losing to this mere boy so much so that now he must answer his accusations. So, he decided to end the conversation immediately.

“You don’t have to worry about all that. We will take care of it. So, you just want your old clothes back.”

“Yes. My old clothes and the things that I had kept in them.”

“You still haven’t told me what you had kept in them.”

“Well since you insist, I will tell you about it. Prince Karikalar had given me two messages - one for the Emperor and the other for Princess Kundavai.”

“Then you cannot take the message back to Kanchi. I wonder why Prince Karikalar would urgently send a message to Kundavai now.”

“I don’t know. I do not have the habit of reading other people’s messages but if you want to read that message as you read the other olai, you are free to do it. The responsibility is yours, of course. I just want my belongings back, intact. That’s all I ask for.”

“You don’t have to worry. I will personally bring it back to you.” Saying thus, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar left. When Vandiya Devan tried to follow him, soldiers barred his way. Vandiya Devan did not want to pick up another fight with them, so he kept quiet.

After some time, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar came back with another soldier who was carrying a tray, which had all his clothes.

“Thambi, here are your belongings. Please check and let me know if everything is in order.”

Vandiya Devan took the tray from the soldier and checked his clothes. The bundle of cloth, which he used to tie around his waist, was also there. He urgently opened it and found that the olai, which was previously missing, had reappeared.

How did it come back? Chinna Pazhuvetarayar must have kept the olai back there.

He also noticed that there were more coins in his money.

Was Chinna Pazhuvetarayar testing him?

“Are all your belongings intact, thambi? Or is something missing?”

“Let me check,” said Vandiya Devan and started counting the money. He kept the extra coins separately. “Dalapati, I was born in the brave Vanar clan, and I am the messenger of Aditya Karikalan. I do not accept money from other people.”

“I appreciate your honesty. Nevertheless, keep the money for your travel expenses. When would you like to leave? Today? Or would you prefer to leave tomorrow after meeting Periya Pazhuvetarayar.”

“Of course, I would like to meet Periya Pazhuvetarayar before leaving. But tell your soldiers to keep away from me,” Saying thus, he closed his moneybag.

“Good! If you need anything, just ask me you will have it immediately.”

“Dalapati! This is my first visit to Thanjavur. I would like to see more of this beautiful city.”

“Of course, you can. Here, these two soldiers will take you around the city. But don’t go out of the fort. You are free to roam anywhere inside the fort.” Chinna Pazhuvetarayar got two new soldiers to accompany Vandiya Devan.

Before they left, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar took the two soldiers aside and whispered in a low voice, but Vandiya Devan already knew what he would have told them.



Chapter 33 - A Lady on a Tree

Vandiya Devan started out on a tour of Thanjavur along with the two soldiers that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had sent along. He knew exactly what Chinna Pazhuvetarayar would have told them. He would have asked them not to let him out of their sight. And he was sure that by now, guards at the fort entrance would have orders not to let anybody outside.

So, while he was going around the fort, he was furiously thinking about ways to escape and hide but first, he would have to evade these guards that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had sent with him. After that, he had to break out from the fort as well.

He could give the guards the slip very easily. He could always attack them and escape - but where would he run? He had a fair idea about how strongly the fort was guarded, and the security inside was tighter than ever. Nobody could get into or leave the fort without Chinna Pazhuvetrayar's knowledge. And if he tried to run away from these two soldiers, they would raise the alarm. If caught he would then be led straight to the underground prison or else, he would be killed.

I need to escape from here somehow without raising an alarm. There must be some way out of this fort. Most forts have an underground escape route. But how do I find it?

While he was thinking thus, he remembered the Pazhuvur queen.

There is only one person who could help him in this fort, and that was Nandini Devi. All I have to do is to spin some more stories about Azhwarkadiyan. To meet her, I have to find out where Periya Pazhuvetarayar's palace is. And most importantly these leeches, should not know about it. I need to be very careful. But what if Periya Pazhuvetarayar comes to the palace while I am there?

While Vandiya Devan was thinking about all kinds of possibilities, he was not silent. He kept asking the soldiers who were with him, "Whose palace is this?", "What temple is this?" He carefully watched all the palaces and waited patiently for a response like, "This is Periya Pazhuvetarayar's palace" and "This is the Pazhuvur Queen's palace." He also noticed that the Thanjavur Fort was quite extensive, with many small lanes. There were many thick groves and enormous gardens. If somebody wanted to hide around for two or three days, they could do so without any problem. But to stay hidden there indefinitely was not possible. He would have to ask for asylum from somebody. But who would give him shelter in their house? Nandini might. He would have to use all his imagination and make up a good, believable story. Only then...

Aha! What is that procession? Who is shouting? Aha! This is the Velkarar Army coming out of the king's palace. This is the best opportunity I would ever get...

As he watched the Velkarar Army proceeding towards the fort's entrance, he asked the soldiers who they were. And while they were telling him all about it, he neared the procession, telling them that he wished to join this strong force and serve the Chola King.

Shouting along with the Velkarar soldiers, he joined the march, but the Chinna Pazhuvetarayar soldiers did not dare to do so. Instead, they walked behind the procession hoping that he would eventually come out.

As the procession went ahead, Vandiya Devan kept moving here and there and shouted himself hoarse along with the soldiers. Some of the Velkarar soldiers looked at him strangely but did not stop him.

At this point, the procession came to a crossroad, where the soldiers near Vandiya Devan saw a pretty young woman walking along, holding a jar of curd. One of the Velkarar soldiers immediately went up to her and asked her, "I am very thirsty. Can you give me some curd?"

"I don't have curd, but I would be happy to give you a nice slap if you want," retorted the woman cheekily.

"That's fine. You can give me that too if you want," said the soldier and approached her while the other soldiers laughed.

The woman immediately turned and fled the scene. The soldiers shouted and ran after her. For Vandiya Devan, this was a golden opportunity. He quickly ran screaming after them. The entire scene was very chaotic with the soldiers shouting, one after the other. The Velkarar soldiers pursued the woman for some time and then gave up when they couldn't find her anywhere. But Vandiya Devan kept running down the lanes changing his route often and keeping off the main roads.

The Velkarar Army typically left the fort during the dusk. And while Vandiya Devan was walking through the streets it was already dark.

In some streets, he found high walls, but none was as high as the outer walls of the fort. But he felt that if he could just keep walking on, he would end up near the outer walls of the fort.

After reaching there, I can think about getting out of the fort. Anyway, I have the entire night to plan and escape.

It was quite dark now. Walking up to the end of the road, he found another wall. He didn't know how high it was, but he felt that it might be the outer wall of the fort. Since it was quite dark, he decided to wait for the moonlight. By now Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's soldiers would have gone back with the message that he had escaped. They would start searching everywhere inside the fort and outside as well.

Let them search! If I don't escape from this fort, I will change my name for sure...

Swearing thus, Vandiya Devan sat down there itself. Since he had been roaming around right from the morning, he dozed off.

After some time, he woke up with a start. He was surprised that he had fallen asleep. And was more confused as to what woke him up. He got up and looked around. The moon was shining brightly so he was able to see where he exactly was. He was sure that he had woken because somebody had called him. He looked up at the wall where he was sitting. It certainly didn't look like the fort wall. It was probably a palace wall. Then his eyes fell on something, which made him jump out of his skin.

What is that thing perched on top of the wall? Is it a ghost?

Even while he was wondering thus, the 'ghost' spoke to him, "What happened? Did you doze off? I have been calling to you for so long."

Ah! This is not a ghost. Seems like a live young woman. Is this a dream?

“What? You are still sleepy, are you? How long should I sit here? I will throw the rope ladder. Please climb over carefully.”

Saying thus she threw a rope ladder on the wall. Vandiya Devan did not understand anything, but he felt that this was an excellent opportunity to escape from the streets, where soldiers would be searching for him.

Let me climb the ladder and then get the details later.

While he was climbing, the woman said, “You are so slow! You are sitting and sleeping here, while our Elaya Rani^[121] is waiting for you.” Hearing this, he almost fell off the ladder.

“Could it be the Pazhuvur Elaya Rani? How could she have known that I was sitting here? Or else is she expecting somebody else? Did this woman mistake me for someone else? Whatever it is, I can’t back off now.”

The woman helped him to jump from the wall. When he got up and looked at her, he felt as if this was the same woman who was chased by the Velkarars. By now he had lost the ability to be surprised. He wondered how many more surprises or shocks were in store for him that night.

“Why are you staring at me like that? Take the ladder off the wall and come with me.”

Vandiya Devan pulled the rope ladder off from the wall and followed the woman into the garden. He wanted to ask her whose palace it

was, but when he opened his mouth to ask, the woman put a finger to her lips and shushed him. She strode quickly, beckoning him to follow.



Chapter 34 - Lata Mandapam

The woman led him through the thick groves of trees. Vandiya Devan found it difficult to keep pace with her. Stumbling in the darkness, he almost collided with a tree. On seeing this, the woman asked him, "What happened? Have you forgotten the way?"

In reply, Vandiya Devan said, "Shh." At the same time, he heard some noise on the other side of the wall in the place where he was sleeping a little while ago. It seemed as if two or three people were running here and there searching for something. Vandiya Devan laughed softly.

"Why are you laughing?"

"Didn't you hear the sound of people who were searching for me outside the wall? I am happy that I escaped from them."

On hearing this, the woman was suddenly afraid, "Somebody was searching for you?"

"Yes. Otherwise, why would I be sitting outside the wall?"

Hearing this, the woman took a good look at him for the first time. Vandiya Devan asked her, "What are you staring at?"

"Just checking whether you are 'you'?"

"If I weren't 'me' then who would I be?"

"Last time when you came here, you had a big moustache."

“Good question. A person like me, who has to climb over the wall and meet somebody, has to change his appearance once in a while.”

“But you look younger than before.”

“When the heart is brimming with happiness, people start looking younger.”

“What are you happy about then?”

“As long as I have your Elaya Rani’s patronage, I have every reason to be happy.”

“Don’t mock her. Today she is Elaya Rani, but very soon, she will be the queen of the entire kingdom.”

“I too, am saying the same thing.”

“Saying the same thing indeed! If you have your way, you will even ask for a share in the kingdom, saying that she got it through your sorcery.”

Vandiya Devan understood exactly whom the junior queen was expecting.

Who was he going to meet? Would it be Nandini or Prince Madhuranthakan’s wife? Oh, God! Please help me. I don’t know whom I am going to meet in a few seconds. I have never met with failure in my life, and I don’t want to lose in front of a woman.

Vandiya Devan saw that they were approaching a big palace through the rear entrance. But they didn’t enter the palace. Instead, they were going towards a small garden that adjoined the palace. Next to the garden, he saw another palace with nary a lamp in it. In the

centre of the garden, there was a small lata mandapam^[122], which was entwined by the creepers growing there.

The woman who was accompanying Vandiya Devan went ahead to inform her mistress of his arrival. He could smell the fragrance of the flowers that were blooming in the dark, while he waited there. He saw the woman entering the lata mandapam and heard her mistress say, “Ask him to come immediately. I have been waiting a long time for him.”

He knew that it was Nandini’s voice! There was no doubt.

In the next instant, I am going to be in front of her. What will I say? Will she be angry? She is expecting a mandiravadi ^[123], but I have come here in his stead. Will she be surprised or angry? Or both?

Nandini’s maid signalled him to enter the Lata Mandapam. Vandiya Devan walked through the garden and entered it. The scene that met his eyes was immediately etched in his mind.

Two big beautiful lamps were hanging from the ceiling of the mandapam and in that light, he saw Nandini sitting in the centre of the mandapam on a soft couch on which beautiful flowers were spread. Earlier, when Vandiya Devan had first laid his eyes on her, he had thought she was a breath-taking woman, but now she looked every inch a goddess. The aesthetics of the entire scene and the enthralling fragrance of the flowers stirred the poet in him and made him feel as if he were drugged.

Vandiya Deva! Be careful! You drank wine, once in your life and when you found that you were losing your senses, you swore that you wouldn’t touch it ever again. It would do well to remember that

oath now. Do not lose your senses over a woman's beauty. This is more dangerous than drinking wine. Thus, warned Vandiya Devan's mind.

When Nandini saw Vandiya Devan, she was so surprised that her lips parted to reveal a beautiful row of teeth. And Vandiya Devan took advantage of this and spoke up.

"Devi! Your maid suddenly doubted my identity. And do you know how she asked me about this? She asked me whether I am 'me'?" he said and started laughing.

Nandini who had got over her surprise by now gave him a mesmerizing smile and said, "Vasuki! Why are you still standing here? Go back to your place and wait until I call you."

"Yes Amma," Saying thus, Vasuki came out of the lata mandapam and sat in the garden path.

Nandini lowered her voice a bit and said, "Foolish woman! She suspected that you were not a sorcerer. Most of the sorcerers that I have met are just tricksters and liars, but you are a real sorcerer. What spell did you cast on her and come into my presence?"

"Devi! I didn't cast any spell. I climbed the ladder that you had kept on the wall."

"That is quite evident. But how did you convince her that you are the mandiravadi?"

"I just flashed a charming smile at her. That's it. If I still couldn't she convince her, I would have shown her the signet ring that you had given."

“You have it safely with you right? Then why didn’t you show it to the palace guards and come to me directly? Why did you have to come to me through the garden path and that too, in this manner?”

“Devi! Your brother-in-law Chinna Pazhuvetarayar has got worthless men around him. First, they tried to steal all my belongings, after that they were following me like a shadow and wouldn’t leave me alone at all. I had a tough time escaping from them, and when I was walking through the streets, I just stood near your palace walls catching my breath, when I saw that there was a ladder kept on the wall. I thought you had remembered me and had arranged this for me. Only now, I realize that it was a big mistake. Please forgive me.”

“There is no need to ask for forgiveness.”

“Why Devi?”

“Whatever you had assumed is not very far from the truth. Do you know why I wished to see the mandiravadi?”

“I don’t know Devi. I don’t know any spell, and nor can I read people’s minds.

“Ever since I saw you yesterday morning I was wondering when I would see you again. And when you didn’t come to my palace today, I thought I would ask the mandiravadi about you.”

“What a coincidence!”

“What?”

“I too have been thinking about you ever since I met you yesterday.”

“Do you believe in reincarnations?”

“Reincarnation? I don’t understand.”

“In the previous birth, if two people were very friendly or in love, the bond between them is so strong that it continues even in the next birth. That’s what I meant.”

“Until this moment, I didn’t believe in it, but I think I will start very soon.”

When Vandiya Devan said this, he knew that he was uttering a blatant lie. He was, in fact, thinking about the woman he met at Kudandhai Jodhidar’s house. But there was no way that Nandini would know about this. So, she thought that he was talking about her.

“But that’s not the reason why you have come to meet me. You said something about Azhwarkadiyan sending me a message...”

“Yes, Devi. I came here to give you his message. But when I saw you, I forgot everything.”

“Where did you meet Azhwarkadiyan?”

“I met him in Veerananarayanapuram. He was trying to prove with the help of this stout stick that Maha Vishnu is greater than Shiva. At that time, Periya Pazhuvetarayar and his entourage passed through. Behind his elephant, your veiled palanquin too came, and when you peeped out of the palanquin, Azhwarkadiyan knew that it was you. And since I was staying in Kadambur palace that night, he wanted me to pass on a message to you. But I couldn’t meet you in the palace. Thankfully, we met near Thanjavur, that too when your palanquin hit my horse.”

While Vandiya Devan was saying thus, Nandini was looking below at the flowers on her couch. But he was not able to decipher anything from her facial expression.

Hearing the last sentence that he said, Nandini spoke up smiling at him, "Yes. You are right. My palanquin always gets me into trouble."



Chapter 35 – Mandiravadi

They heard sounds of gongs and coaches and noise of the fort doors opening. Nandini, who was much distracted by the sound, listened intently. Her maid came running inside saying, “Amma! The Lord has arrived!”

“I know. You go back to your place.”

She turned to Vandiya Devan and said, “Periya Pazhuvetarayar has returned to the fort. After meeting the king and his brother, he will come here. You must leave before he comes. Give me Azhwarkadiyan’s message.”

“Devi! That Veera Vaishnavan claimed that you were his sister. Is that right?”

“Why do you doubt it?”

“Would you believe it if I were to tell you that a parrot and a monkey were born to the same mother?”

Nandini laughed and said, “In a way he is right. We grew up in the same family, in the same house. He took care of me like a brother. He must be very disappointed in me now.”

“Let me give you his message then. ‘Dear Sister, Lord Krishna is waiting for you. Come with me and let’s live the rest of our lives reciting his name.’”

Nandini sighed deeply and said, “I am surprised that he has still not given up on me. Please give him this message when you meet him

next. Ask him to forget me completely. I am not worthy enough to be a Goddess like Aandal.”

“I will not accept that, Devi.”

“What will you not accept?”

“That you cannot try to be like Aandal. She had to compose songs and shed tears, day and night for Lord Krishna before he appeared before her and married her. But you don’t have to do anything of that sort. As soon as Krishna sees you, he will forget Radha [\[124\]](#), Rukmini [\[125\]](#), Satyabhama [\[126\]](#) and all his other wives and come after you.”

“You do know how to flatter people.”

“What is flattery?”

“When you praise somebody sky high right to their face, it is called flattery.”

“In that case, please turn and sit with your back facing me.”

“Why?”

“I won’t praise you to your face. But I will praise you to your back!”

“You are very clever.”

“Now it is you who is flattering me.”

“Then you can also turn your back to me.”

“Devi, neither on the battlefield nor with women, do I ever show my back. You can flatter me right to my face.”

Nandini let out a peel of laughter. “You are really a mandiravadi. It’s been a long time since I have laughed like this.”

“But it is dangerous to make you laugh, Devi. When the flower blossoms, the bee is mesmerized.”

“You are not only a mandiravadi but also a poet.”

“Yes, I do sing some poems, but only in the battlefield. My poems are known to be deadly enough to kill.”

“My dear poet, you haven’t told me what your name is?”

“My given name is Vandiya Devan, and my titular name is Vallavareyan.”

“Oh! You are of royal birth, are you?”

“Yes, I was born in the old Vanar clan.”

“And your kingdom...”

“The entire earth is in my possession now.”

Nandini looked him up and down and said thoughtfully, “Nothing is impossible. If you wish, you can regain your kingdom.”

“How is that possible? My kingdom was annexed by the Cholas.”

“I can recover it for you.”

“Devi, thank you but no. What little wish I had, about ruling my own kingdom has gone ever since I met the Emperor. It is not worth having a kingdom of my own if I have to depend on other people to rule it. Instead, I prefer to be a free bird with no limits to, where I could fly.”

“I think the same too,” said Nandini and then asked, “Why are Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s soldiers searching for you?”

“Just like your maid...they are suspicious too.”

“About what?”

“They want to know where I got the palm tree signet ring from.”

A mask of fear spread over Nandini’s face. She immediately asked, “Where is the ring?”

“I have it here, Devi. I wouldn’t lose it for anything,” he said and showed it to her.

“How did they know that you have this ring?”

“I had always wanted to meet King Sundara Chola. So, I used the ring to fulfil my wish. After meeting the king, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar asked me where I got the ring from.”

“And what did you say?”

“I didn’t tell him your name, Devi. I stated that Periya Pazhuvetarayar gave it to me in Kadambur.”

“Did he believe you?”

“I don’t think he accepted my words me completely. That’s why he had sent his men to follow me. He probably wanted to find out more about me before his brother returns to the fort.”

“You don’t have to worry about Periya Pazhuvetarayar. I will see to it that he does you no harm.”

“Devi, I know the influence you have over Periya Pazhuvetarayar, but I have some important tasks that I have to attend to. If you can please help me escape from the fort, I would be grateful to you.”

“What other important work do you have?”

“I have a lot of work to do. For instance, I have to meet Azhwarkadiyan and give him your message. What shall I tell him?”

“Ask him to forget that he ever had a sister called Nandini.”

“I don’t think it is an easy thing to do.”

“What?”

“To forget you. When a person like me who has met you only twice won’t be able to forget you, how can one expect Azhwarkadiyan to do it?”

Nandini’s face flushed with the joy of admiration. She asked, “Why were you so eager to meet the king?”

“Who wouldn’t want to meet the king? Ever since I was a little boy, I have heard how handsome he is and about all his famous deeds.”

“Yes, the king is indeed very proud of his beauty and his daughter is prouder than him.”

“Daughter? Whom are you talking about?”

“Who else but that vain Princess Kundavai?”

Vandiya Devan thought to himself, *Vandiya Deva! You are lucky. Here is your chance to escape from her. Grab it fast!*

Nandini suddenly sat upright and said, “Ayya, I have something to tell you...”

“Yes, Devi. Tell me.”

“You and I can come to an agreement. If you help me with something, I will help you escape from the fort.”

“Devi! You are the wife of the most powerful person in the Chola Kingdom. And I am only a poor soldier. How can I be of any help to you?”

Wanting to know whether he really meant what he said Nandini looked at him sharply. But Vandiya Devan stood looking at her resolutely.

“I need a trustworthy person who would do errands for me. If I get you a position in this palace, would you stay?”

“I have already agreed to do similar work for another woman. If she says ‘no,’ then I will come to you.”

“Who is that?”

“You just now spoke of her very lovingly! Princess Kundavai.”

“It’s a lie! It can’t be. You are mocking me.”

“Devi, many people have already read this olai secretly. So, I don’t think there will be any problem if you read it too.” Saying thus he took the olai that Aditya Karikalan had given for Kundavai and handed it over to Nandini.

Nandini took the olai and read it by the lamplight. After she had finished, she looked up, her eyes flashing dangerously. Vandiya

Devan was once again reminded of the dancing snake he had seen when he was young. It made him shiver.

Nandini gave the olai back to Vandiya Devan and said, "Ayya! Do you wish to leave this fort alive?"

"Yes. I need your help to do so."

"I can assist you on one condition."

"What condition?"

"You must bring back the olai that Kundavai gives you in reply."

"That's a very dangerous condition."

"I thought you were a brave warrior who doesn't mind the danger."

"I will undertake a dangerous mission, but only if the reward is worth it..."

"Reward? You will get a reward that you wouldn't have imagined in this life. You will get the prize that Periya Pazhuvetarayar has wanted for years!" She then shot him an alluring glance.

Poor Vandiya Devan! His thoughts swirled while his brain issued one more warning, 'Don't lose your head.'

Thankfully for Vandiya Devan, a bat shouted from a tree nearby in the garden. It shouted not once, but twice and thrice!

Nandini, distracted by this, turned towards him and said, "The real mandiravadi has come. I don't need him anymore. Nonetheless, I will have to talk to him and send him off. He might be able to help you escape from the fort. Why don't you just wait near that dark palace? I will send for you."



Chapter 36 - Do You Remember?

Nandini came out of the lata mandapam and clapped her hand thrice. At the farthest corner of the garden, the real mandiravadi stepped out, from behind a tree.

Nandini went back to the lata mandapam and sat on her couch with a peaceful expression. Mandiravadi entered the mandapam and in the light of the lamps when we see his face, it looks familiar! Yes, we have seen him in Thirupurampayam! Near the Pallipadai! He was one who had ordered his men to kill Azhwarkadiyan on sight. It was Ravidasan!

When he entered the lata mandapam his face was clouded with anger and his eyes were bloodshot. He sat down on the seat opposite to the couch. Staring steadily at Nandini, he said, “Om, Hreem, Shreem Kreem, Bagavathy! Shakti! Chandikeshwari ...

“Enough! The maid has gone off somewhere. Tell me quickly whatever you want to say and leave. He has already come into the fort.”

“You traitor!” spat Ravidasan.

“Who?” asked Nandini patiently.

“I am talking about the ungrateful Nandini who is sitting before me,” said Ravidasan and pointed his finger at her. Nandini kept silent.

“Woman! You have forgotten many things, which you should have borne in mind. And I think I need to remind you of it...”

“Why do you want to talk about old stories?” asked Nandini.

“I will first remind you of the old stories and then tell you why you need to remember them well.” Nandini realized that it was futile to stop him, let out a deep sigh and kept quiet.

“Rani, listen to me! Three years ago, along the banks of Vaigai, a body was being cremated. There were no priests around to conduct the last rites. The body was placed on a heap of dry twigs and leaves that was collected from the forest. After lighting the pyre, a few people dragged you from behind a tree. Your hands and legs were bound by rope. Those men wanted to throw you in the funeral pyre alive, but one of them wanted the pyre to blaze well before you were thrown into it. So, they left you aside and went near the fire and took a terrible oath. You heard their oath. Your mouth was gagged, but you were able to see and hear whatever was happening. After they had sworn their oath of vengeance, they came near you. You tried to tell them something. Noticing it, one of them said, ‘She wants to say something.’ But another said, ‘Must be the same story. Let’s throw her in the pyre.’ ‘No. Wait. Let’s hear what she wants to say. Ungag her,’ said the leader of the gang they agreed. And when they removed the gag, do you remember what you told them?”

Nandini did not reply to him. Nor did she look at him. She was looking down at the flowers, but her beautiful eyes were filled with tears, and her face reflected the disgust and the fear that she had felt when Ravidsan had recounted the memories of her dark past.

“Woman! Why are you silent? Have you taken an oath not to speak? If you don’t want to remember that as well, then it is time that I remind you. You swore to those men that you too would take a

similar oath of vengeance and help them in their cause. You swore that you had more reasons to take such an oath. And you promised that you would use your beauty and brains to help them fulfil their promise. Nobody believed you. But I did, and I saved your life. Do you remember all this?”

Nandini turned towards him and said, “You are asking me whether I remember all this. Don’t you know that all these memories have been etched in my heart with fire? And do you know I have been burning in this fire ever since?”

Ignoring her, Ravidasan continued, “Later when we were walking along the Kaveri River, we suddenly heard Chola soldiers approaching. Our group scattered and hid in the forest. But you alone stood there, ignoring my orders. Pazhuvetarayar who was the commander of that troop saw you and took you along with him, mesmerized by your beauty. You got married to him. My men were angry with me and told me that I should have thrown you in the fire. But I didn’t leave you. One day, I caught up with you and would have killed you, but you once again begged for your life. You claimed that you got married to Pazhuvetarayar only to help us fulfil our oath. You promised to use your beauty, power, and influence to help us. Is this true or not?”

“Why are you asking the same question repeatedly? Why don’t you tell me what you want now?”

“No. You do not remember any of this. You have forgotten everything. You are a queen now who is living amidst the comforts and riches of your husband. You’ve got everything that you’d ever wished for. Why would you remember an old oath?”

“Huh! Who wants these riches? Do you think I am living here only to enjoy these useless riches?”

“Or maybe you have forgotten everything in your fascination for a handsome youth? Your new-found love is more important than an old oath for sure.”

Nandini sprang forward in her couch as if she was stung by a scorpion and cried, “That’s a lie!”

“If that is a lie, then why didn’t you send your maid to the usual place when you knew very well that I was coming to meet you today?”

“I did send her there, but somebody else climbed that ladder and came inside. That foolish woman thought that it was you and brought him here. Is that my fault?”

“I don’t care whose fault it is. This mistake almost cost my life. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s soldiers are searching for this youth. And they came near your palace searching for him. I had to jump into a nearby lotus pond to escape from them. I almost drowned there, trying to be still and I am soaked to the skin.”

“Good! You have been amply rewarded for suspecting me.”

“Woman! Speak the truth. Didn’t you lose your head over that youth?”

“What are you saying? Would I be fascinated by some man’s beauty? In this shameless Chola Kingdom, people rave about their king’s beauty. They don’t realize that a man’s true beauty lies in the number of battle scars that he bears on his body.”

“Well said! If you have not fallen in love with this youth, then why did you meet him?”

“I told you earlier, my maid Vasuki mistook him for you.”

“Why did you give him your signet ring when you have never given it to me?”

“I wanted to talk to him, that’s why I asked him to come here. Now I am going take that signet ring back from him.”

“Why did you ask him to come here? And what were you talking with him so long?”

“I was talking to him about something very important. I am sure he would be of great help to our cause.”

“You wretch! You have at last shown your true colours. How can you tell a stranger about us?”

“Why are you shouting? I didn’t say anything about us. Instead, I was trying to get information from him.”

“What information?”

“He is taking messages from Kanchipuram to Pazhaiarai. The message is for the tigress that lives in Pazhaiarai. He showed me that message. I was asking him to bring Kundavai’s reply to me, and you interrupted us.”

“Messages from Kanchi to Pazhaiarai? What is the use of all this?”

“Don’t you see? We have taken an oath to destroy the Chola clan. But you men will always look at the tigers of the Chola clan. You do not care about the tigress. The tigress takes care of the family and

provides an heir to the throne. And who do you think is ruling the kingdom? The old paralyzed Emperor or the princes of this kingdom?”

“No. It is your husband who is ruling the kingdom. Everybody knows this.”

“Wrong again! The world thinks so and so does the old Pazhuvur Lord, as he deludes himself. It is the tigress in Pazhaiarai who rules this kingdom. She is the one who is pulling all the strings. I will destroy her for sure. That’s why I want to use this youth.” Ravidasan looked impressed.

“Is that so? But how can I believe you?”

“I will hand him over to you. You blindfold him and take him through the underground tunnel, out of this fort. Escort him to Pazhaiarai and bring him back here with the message that Kundavai gives for Karikalan. If he tries to escape, you have my leave to kill him.”

“No! No! I don’t care where he goes. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s soldiers are already searching for him inside the fort and very soon they are going to look for him outside. If I go with him, I will be caught too.”

“You haven’t told me yet as to why you came to meet me.”

“I have got some men ready to go to Kanchipuram and Elangai. The men who are going to Elangai, have a very tough mission in hand...”

“What should I do about that? You want some more gold, do you? Your demand for gold increases every day...”

“The gold is not for our personal use but to fulfil our oath. Why else would we leave you here? Men who are going to Elangai can’t use Chola coins. They will need Elangai coins...”

“You took such a long time to say this? Here, I have kept it ready for you.” Saying thus, Nandini took a bag of coins from beneath her couch and gave it to him. “Take this and leave. He might come here any minute.”

Ravidasan took the bag and started to leave, when Nandini said, “Wait! Take that youth outside the fort and then leave. After that let him go on his way. I don’t want to reveal the underground route to him.”

They both came out of the lata mandapam and went near the dark palace where she had asked Vandiya Devan to wait. She clapped her hand twice, but nobody came. They both searched around the dark palace, but there was nobody. Vandiya Devan had vanished!



Chapter 37 - Clash of Lions

The people of Thanjavur held the Pazhuvur brothers in special regard. It was thanks to them that their old city had become the capital of the kingdom and had gained importance.

It was but natural for people to throng to the streets when there was a procession but whenever Periya Pazhuvetarayar left the town or was returning home, people would gather in the streets to watch the spectacle because it was customary for his brother Chinna Pazhuvetarayar to go up to the fort entrance to welcome him.

And when they met, both the brothers would embrace each other lovingly and then their procession would proceed towards the royal palace. The Thanjavur crowd loved to watch this spectacle. Many compared the brothers and their love for each other to that of Rama and Bharatha^[127], or of Bhima^[128] and Arjuna.

But that day when Periya Pazhuvetarayar came back to the fort, his brother did not come to greet him, nor did people throng the street to watch the procession. Sensing something wrong, Periya Pazhuvetarayar went to his brother's palace. He intuitively felt that his younger brother was involved in some important work, which was why he couldn't come to the entrance to welcome him.

'What could it be? Did the Emperor's health deteriorate?'

Worrying thus, Periya Pazhuvetarayar hurried his entourage towards his brother's palace. His brother was waiting outside the palace to

welcome him. Pazhuvetarayar got down from his elephant and embraced his brother.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar took his elder brother inside the palace to their usual room where they held their discussions. There, Periya Pazhuvetarayar asked him, “Thambi, Kalanthaka^[129], what is the matter? Did something happen here? Is the Emperor well?”

“The Emperor is fine. There is neither improvement nor deterioration in his health.”

“Then why are you looking so dull? Why didn’t you come to the fort entrance to welcome me, like you always do? Even the city seems unnaturally quiet.”

“Anna! A very small incident occurred here. Nothing important. I will tell you about it later. First, you must tell me about your journey.”

“My mission has been very successful. All the invitees came to Kadambur palace. And they have all agreed to help us proclaim Madhuranthakan as the next king. They are ready to join forces with us against the sons of Sundara Chola if they oppose our plan. Even influential noblemen like Kolli Mazhavanam and Vanaga Munairaiyam have agreed to help us. Sambuverayar has pledged his fort, his armed forces and his support at our disposal. We already have a big army with us, so we don’t have to worry. We just have to deal with Pallavan Parthibendran, Thirukovalur Malayaman, and Kodumbalur Vellar. Kodumbalur Vellar is in Elangai and without his support the other two can’t do anything. Now we just have to tell the Emperor about this and make him agree to our plan.”

“All that is fine. What about the people? What if they object?”

“Ah! What if they object? Do you think we can run the affairs of the Kingdom at the whims and fancies of the people? If they object, we should make sure that they do not rise against us. We have a big army at our disposal. We can use it to control the people. But I don’t think it will come to that. If we just say that it is the Emperor’s wish, they will keep quiet. Thank God! Arulmozhivarman is in Elangai. If he were here, people would want him to be crowned, out of their love for him. People don’t have much of a regard for Aditya Karikalan anyway. Turning their love towards your son-in-law is easy. They also know that he is a Shiva devotee and more handsome, than the sons of Sundara Chola. I wouldn’t be surprised if people start shouting, ‘Madhuranthaka Chola Chakravarthi’ very soon. Whatever happens, you don’t have to worry about anything, when I am there...”

“But what about the Velkarars? What if they protest?”

“The Velkarar Army has pledged their life to protect Sundara Chola and not his sons. But even if they are going to be a problem, we have our own army to counter them. We can destroy them within an hour and shut them in the dungeons.”

“Anna! We will meet stiff objection from Pazhaiarai. That old woman and that headstrong princess will surely be against us.”

“Thambi! How can you ask me to be afraid of two women? What if they are against us? We can put them down easily. You don’t worry about it - I can handle them well.”

“The king wants to meet his sons; he intends to send a message asking them to come to Thanjavur.”

“Aditya Karikalan will not come. But Arulmozhiarman might start from Elangai. Then we will have to stop him on the way itself. Until we crown Madhuranthakan as the crown prince, we should not allow Arulmozhiarman to come back home. You better leave all these worries to me. I will take care of it. You were telling me about the small incident that occurred when I was away. What happened?”

“A young soldier came from Kanchipuram. He had brought an olai for Chakravarthi and was taking one more for Kundavai.”

“What did you do? Did you imprison him?”

“No, Anna! He told me that he met you in Kadambur and that you had asked him to hand over the message directly to the Emperor.”

“What? That’s a lie! I did meet a youth in Kadambur palace. He was an uninvited guest - a friend of Kandanmaran. But he didn’t tell me anything about taking a message to the Emperor. I knew that boy was up to some mischief. Did he manage to fool you?”

“Yes, Anna! He did fool me, that too because he mentioned your name.”

“How could you do that? Did you give that olai to the Chakravarthi, without even reading it?”

“No, I read the olai. There was nothing new in it. It was the same old message, asking the Emperor to come to Kanchipuram. But after handing over the olai, I heard him warning the emperor about some danger.”

“You didn’t suspect him even after that?”

“I suspected him but didn’t imprison him.”

“Then what did you do?”

“He wanted to see the city, I sent him along with two of our soldiers. But he somehow tricked both the soldiers and escaped. I was busy sending a search party gave us the slip and escaped. That’s why I couldn’t come to the fort entrance.”

“How could you be so foolish? How could you allow him to escape like that? This is such a shame! How can a brother of mine act so stupidly? I didn’t know what I was thinking when I put you in charge of the fort. How could you allow anybody inside the fort just because he told you some blatant lies? Aren’t you ashamed of yourself?”

“He didn’t just say your name - he showed me your signet ring, saying that you had given it to him.”

“Do you think I would hand over my signet ring to just anybody from the streets?”

“But it is true that he had your signet ring. He managed to enter the fort because he showed it to the guards at the fort entrance. But if you did not give it to him, he could have got it only from one person.”

“Whom are you talking about?”

“Can't you guess? I am speaking about your young wife...”

“I warn you now, Kalanthaka. Be careful about what you speak, or I will cut off your tongue.”

“I don’t care if you cut off my tongue, but you will hear me out. You have brought home a deadly cobra, just because it looks beautiful.

One day or the other, it is going to strike at us. Please listen to me. Throw her out of your life, before she destroys us.”

“Kalanthaka Kanda, I have also been meaning to tell you this for a very long time. If you wish to criticize my work, feel free to do so. But don’t you dare say another word against the woman I have married, or I swear I will kill you, with these same hands that raised you. Be careful!”

The clash of the brothers was so fierce that it was heard outside the room. The soldiers waiting outside wondered what could have happened.



Chapter 38 - Nandini - The Seductress

It was past midnight when Pazhuvetarayar finally headed back to his palace. As he rode back fast, he was full of remorse for having shouted at his brother. He knew deep down that his brother was devoted to him.

Maybe that's why he took the liberty of saying such things. But he has such a suspicious nature, why should he blame Nandini of all the people? Such is human nature. He wanted to conceal his own mistakes, by making Nandini as his target. That wicked youth escaped thanks to his foolhardiness, and he goes around blaming his own sister-in-law!

Anyway, since he has apologized, it is no use thinking about all that. But could it be true? What if it is true? Am I becoming a womanizer after all these years? I really don't know many things about her past. Am I being fair to my brother? After all, he was the one who has stood by me all these years and fought along with me in so many wars. Why should I be so partial to her anyway? Sometimes many of her actions make me suspicious too...

"No! No! I am not being fair to her. She is so very much in love with me. She gives me so much respect. She takes so much interest in the affairs of the kingdom and helps me with it. More than anything else, she has dared to get married to a 60-year-old man when she could have got all the kings and princes in this world begging her to grant them a look. Ah! If only Sundara Chola had seen her first. He would have married her for sure! How could I suspect her of

anything? I guess sometimes people are right when they say that when an old man gets married to a young woman, he will suspect her for no reasons. No! No! I don't want to end up thus...

"But I need to get certain things clear from her. Why does she ask for my signet ring so often? Why does she go and sit in that lata mandapam alone for hours together? And it is also rumoured that a strange mandiravadi comes to visit her. Why does she meet him? For what purpose does she need his help? On top of all this, she has kept me away from her bed, even after three years of marriage. She vaguely talks about some fast, ritual or something... but has not told me what it is exactly. I should put my foot down and ask her about it today."

When he reached his palace, the womenfolk and other servants were waiting to receive him in the courtyard with a ceremonial aarathi. But the one person, whom he wanted to see more than anything else, was not among them. When he checked with them about her, he learned that she was still in the lata mandapam.

What is she doing there at this hour? Is she ignoring me?

With anger rising fast in his heart, he strode ahead towards the lata mandapam. In the garden path, he saw Nandini and her maid, coming towards the palace. Seeing him, the girl bowed low and left them alone.

But Nandini did not look at him at all; she didn't even look at him when he went near her. His plan to storm at her in anger and demand some answers was foiled because he had to pacify her now.

“Nandini! My beloved! Why are you angry with me?” saying thus he placed his hand on her shoulder. But Nandini pushed his hand away in anger.

“Ah! Your beautiful hands touched mine and pushed it away! I am indeed lucky. And you have accomplished something that no warrior in this land can boast of. But why are you angry with me? I am dying to hear your voice,” begged the old soldier.

“It has been four days since you left me?” sobbed Nandini. And when Pazhuvetarayar heard this, his heart grew anxious and heavy.

“You are angry with me for this? If you can’t bear to be away from me for four days, what will you do when I go to war? I will be away from you for months together.”

“Don’t be too sure of that. Do you think I can stay away from you for so long? I will follow you to the battlefield and stay there with you.”

“That would be just perfect. With you standing next to me, how will I fight on the battlefield? In all these 60 years of life, I have borne countless arrows and spears and have felt no pain, but I can’t stand it if a small thorn scratches your feet. How can I take you to the battlefield? I can’t see you standing so long in this stony garden path. Come here, my love. Sit by the lamp. Ah! Let me take a look at you. If you can’t stand being away from me for four days, just imagine my plight.” Saying thus, he made Nandini sit on her couch and sat beside her. Nandini wiped away her tears and looked at him with a beautiful smile.

“Ah! If I had all the three worlds in my possession, I would offer them all to her, in return for this smile but she doesn’t ask anything from

me,” thought Pazhuvetarayar.

All the doubts and questions that were tormenting him a short while ago vanished from his mind. With his heart fluttering a hundred wishes, he would give her whatever she wanted for. Such is the power of seduction!

“You have been gone for four days. Why didn’t you come here directly? Your brother is more important to you. Isn’t he?” asked Nandini pretending to be angry.

“No! My love! I would have come here directly, but I wanted to make sure that boy Madhuranthakan, came back here safely, through the underground passage.”

“Ayya! You know very well that I am only too happy to assist you in any small way in your work, but I was not pleased to see Madhuranthakan traveling in my palanquin, in my stead. Everybody thinks that you are taking me along with you, everywhere.”

“Do you think I am happy about that? But what can I do? To accomplish our goals, we need to take these risks. And it was you who came up with this idea. You suggested that we use the underground passage to smuggle him back into the fort.”

“Isn’t it a wife’s duty to help her husband? If you think...”

“You have helped me in more ways than you can imagine. Remember how this boy, Madhuranthakan was planning to become a sanyasi and build temples... We all tried our best to get him interested in the affairs of the kingdom, but he wouldn’t agree. And you just met him twice, and he immediately changed his mind. Now he has become so crazed with the idea of ruling this kingdom that

we are finding it difficult to control him. Nandini! I don't know what magic you did to him... By the way, you seem to know so much about magic, why do you need a mandiravadi visiting you? There are so many unwanted rumours about this..."

"My Lord! If some people are talking unwanted things, you will have to punish them severely. I had told you earlier as to why the mandiravadi is visiting me. If you have forgotten, let me remind you again. It is to destroy that deadly snake that lives in Pazhaiarai. You men like to fight only with other men. You find it degrading to consider women as potential danger. Little do you realize that one woman is more dangerous than a thousand men? You don't know about Kundavai, as I do. You may have forgiven her for insulting us, but I haven't. Do you know what she told me? She said, 'How can you get married to that old man? Do you have any sense? You are so beautiful; you could have married anybody in the world. What do you see in that old buffalo anyway?' My Lord! How can I forget these words or forgive her for that?"



Chapter 39 - Swirling World!

Pazhuvetarayar knew that many people had criticized and commented about his getting married to a young woman, at the age of sixty. He was also aware that Princess Kundavai was one of them.

But so far no one had dared to tell him what exactly Kundavai had said. When he heard it from Nandini, he began to burn with anger. His eyes turned red and his voice hoarse. "My beloved, did that heartless beast say that to you? She called me an old buffalo, did she? Wait and see what I do to her. This buffalo is going to stamp her like a worm!" spat Pazhuvetarayar, unable to speak further.

Nandini tried to calm him. She took his hand in hers and entwined her fingers in his.

"My Lord! I know you can't stand it if somebody insults me. But a towering elephant like you, need not bother about a mad cat like Kundavai. She has been using all her tricks to rule over everybody. I am the only one who knows how to counter her tricks. But if you wish, I will leave this palace and go away..." said Nandini and started to weep.

Pazhuvetarayar's anger subsided immediately, and he said, "No! Please! Meet a hundred mandiravadis if you so wish, I do not mind, but don't ever say that you will leave me. You are my life, my dream. I am already going mad because you do not allow me to touch you. If you leave me, I will go insane. When you know so many spells why don't you teach me a few?"

“My Lord! When you have your sword and spear, why do you need spells?”

“My love, when I hear your voice, I lose my mind; when I see your beauty, every nerve in my body yearns for you. You say that I don’t need any spells because I have my sword and spear, but I can use them only on the battlefield, not here. I am defenceless against the arrows of Lord Kama. Please teach me a spell to keep this passion under check or else let me have the good fortune of sharing your bed. Save my life or else this fire will consume me. It has been almost two and a half years since we wed but we haven’t started living as man and wife. You are keeping me away saying that you are observing a ritual or some such thing... but you haven’t told me exactly what. Else give me a cup of poison and kill me...”

Nandini shut her ears with her hands and said, “My Lord! Please don’t say such harsh words. Otherwise, I will do just as you say - drink a cup of poison and die. After that, you can live peacefully.”

“No! No! Don’t do anything like that. If you die, do you think I can live peacefully? I am already half-crazed, and if you die, I will become fully insane.”

“My Lord! Why should you become mad? Our souls have merged on the day we married each other. Whenever you are troubled, my heart flutters, whenever your heart beats, I can hear the echo in mine. When our souls have become one, why bother about the body that is made of dust...”

“Stop! Stop! How dare you utter such lies? Your body is made of dust! I have never heard a more blatant lie than that! I have known many women in my life. Lord Brahma has made their bodies with

dust, clay and sometimes he has used even limestone but surely your body is not crafted of such things. He collected all the sweet-smelling flowers that were blooming in the heaven and ground it together to make a paste. To this, he added nectar and honey and a ray of moonlight. Then he added heavenly music. Your body was made thus, my love...”

“My Lord! You talk as if you were with Lord Brahma when he made me. I don’t know why you are wasting your brilliant imagination on me. You have many wives who are of royal birth... and you have known them longer than you have known me. It has been just two and a half years since we got married....” Before Nandini could complete her sentence, Pazhuvetarayar interrupted her and gave vent to his feelings.

“Nandini, you talk about my other wives. I married them to beget heirs for my clan. Some of them were barren, while some others gave birth, only to girls. And I consoled myself with the thought that it was God’s will. For a long time, I concentrated only on my work and the welfare of this kingdom. And then the war with the Pandyas began. Even when there were many young commanders I couldn’t stay behind. We wrecked Madurai and were on our way to Kongu Nadu ^[130]. On the way, while our army was moving through the forest, I saw you there...standing alone. I thought that you were perhaps a forest goddess who would vanish if I came close. But you didn’t. I thought you were probably an apsara who had come down to the earth, due to some curse or you might have been a gandharva^[131] woman. Thinking thus I neared you and asked, ‘Who are you?’

“Surprisingly you answered me. You said, ‘I am an orphan. Please give me protection.’ I got you a palanquin and took you with me.”

“I had a feeling that I had seen you somewhere, but I couldn’t remember where. Then suddenly I realized that I had seen you not in this birth, but in my other previous ones and the memories of those past lives flooded my mind. In your previous birth, you were Ahalya^[132], and I was Indra. I came to you daring Rishi Goutama’s^[133] anger. Before that, I was King Shantanu^[134], and you were Ganga. I met you while hunting near the forest. Later in Kaveripattnam, I was born, as Kovalan^[135] and you were my Kannagi. I had forgotten you, being enamored by Madhavi ^[136]. Later realizing your real worth, I came back to you repenting my sins. We went to Madurai ^[137], where I was arrested and executed. And you burned down the whole town with the divine power of your sati and took your revenge on the Pandya royal family...

While Pazhuvetarayar went on about his past lives, Nandini turned her head and faced the other side. If he had seen the expression on her face, it was doubtful whether he would have continued. When he stopped for a while, to catch his breath, she turned and said, “My Lord! I don’t think these examples that you gave just now are apt for us. They all seem a bit inauspicious to me. If you wish, call yourself Manmadhan and me your Rathi ^[138].”

Pazhuvetarayar’s face flushed with joy when he heard this. Any man, however, ugly he is, would love to hear his lover call him handsome, wouldn’t he?

“My love, it is quite apt to call you Rathi. But how can I call myself Manmadhan? You say that because of your affection for me.”

“My Lord! You are my Manmadhan [\[139\]](#). The most beautiful quality in a man is his bravery. And it is a well-known fact that you are the bravest soldier in the whole Kingdom. Moreover, a real man must have compassion in his heart. And I stand here as an example for this compassion. Without even considering my birth or my caste, you married me, risking ridicule from people and showered me with affection. My Lord be assured I will not make you wait for long. The end of my ritual is nearing...”

“My love, tell me what ritual it is; I could help you finish it fast.”

“The headstrong, Emperor Sundara Chola should not see his sons ascend the throne, and that vain Kundavai’s pride should be broken.”

“Nandini, both these things will be accomplished soon. The crown is not for Aditya Karikalan or Arulmozhivarman. We have decided that Madhuranthakan is going to be the next heir. And the most important noblemen in the kingdom have agreed to this proposal.”

“Has everybody agreed to this?” asked Nandini stressing on ‘everybody.’

“Except a few nobles, everybody has agreed. Parthibendran, Kodumballur Vellar, and Malayaman will never agree to our idea anyway, but we can take care of them.”

“We must be very careful until our goals are fulfilled.”

“Yes, we have to be careful. The only thing that worries me is other people’s stupid actions. Something like this happened today. A

young soldier came from Kanchi made a fool out of Kalandhakan and met the Emperor alone and gave him a message from Karikalan.”

“Aha! You always declared how intelligent your brother is, but I always told you that he is not fit to be the commander of this fort. You never listened to me.”

“Yes. He acted quite foolishly today - all because the boy showed him my signet ring.”

“What! How did he get our signet ring?”

“That’s what I asked my brother too. And you know what fantastic story he came up with? He said that you might have given the ring to the youth.” said Pazhuvetarayar and started laughing.

Nandini joined him in the merry laughter and then said, “I was wrong about my brother-in-law. He is very clever indeed.”

“And what did you do when you heard your brother accuse me thus?” she asked abruptly. Now she was not laughing. Her face had reddened, and she turned her angry eyes on her husband.

“My love, I did not just sit there when I heard him say this. I admonished him so badly that he apologized profusely. Even you would have pitied him had you seen him.”

“People who get fooled will always come up with some story or the other. Has he taken any action to capture the young soldier?”

“Yes, our troops are searching for him both in and out of the fort. I am sure they will catch him. This is not going to affect our plans.

Madhuranthakan is going to ascend the throne after Sundara Chola...”

“My Lord! It is time you knew more about my ritual.”

“Yes, my love, tell me.”

“My Lord! When I was young, a very famous astrologer looked at my horoscope and said that until I was 18 years old, I would face a lot of struggles in my life.”

“And then...”

“After my eighteenth year, he said that my fortune would change and that I will attain power and wealth.”

“He was right! Tell me who this astrologer was - I will shower him with gold.”

“My Lord...”

“Yes, my love.”

“That astrologer told one other thing.”

“What was that?”

“He said that my husband would be an Emperor who will rule over hundred kings. Will you make his prediction come true?”

When Pazhuvetarayar heard this, his head swirled.



Chapter 40 - The Dark Palace

It is now time to find out what happened to Vandiya Devan, who had vanished. The young warrior had hidden near the dark palace when the mandiravadi had come. He first tried to overhear the conversation between Nandini and the mandiravadi, but he couldn't hear a word and nor was he keen on it. He knew that he was losing himself slowly to her beauty and felt that it would be better if he just left the place, without meeting her again.

He instinctively felt that she was more dangerous than the Pazhuvur brothers, and their soldiers put together. In their presence, his senses were alert, and he could use his sword, as well as his brain, which was sharper than his sword. But in front of this seductress, he felt that his sword might slip from his hand; his mind refused to think; he found himself wanting to agree with whatever she said. And if that were not enough, she had got a mandiravadi to help her out. God knows what magic tricks he has taught her...

'My God! How much she hates Princess Kundavai? She looks like a serpent ready to strike whenever she talks about her. And one can never believe women. She might even change her mind and hand me over to the Pazhuvur soldiers, just because I am taking a message to Kundavai. It would be better to leave this palace without meeting her again but how do I get out? I will have to go through the garden path and climb over the wall, but Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's soldiers are waiting for me outside. There should be some other way. Think! Think! What about this palace? Why is it

so dark? What is inside the palace? Let me go inside just once and see for myself. Who knows it might come useful. But how to get inside?’ thus ran Vandiya Devan’s thoughts.

His hands felt the big lock at the entrance. As he was feeling the entrance, his hands touched a small lever on the side of the door. Immediately, a small opening appeared within the door. It was big enough for a man to get inside.

‘This is what is called luck, I guess,’ thought Vandiya Devan as he entered the palace.

His first thought after he entered the palace was that even Nandini should not know that he was inside the palace. So, he immediately shut the door and bolted it. Now it was darker than ever. When he had opened the door from outside, in the dim moonlight he had seen that there were huge pillars inside the palace. Now it looked as if everything had been swallowed in that inky darkness.

Vandiya Devan slowly stepped towards the direction of the pillars. Taking one step at a time with his hands outstretched in front of him, he felt the first column that he encountered. He slowly walked forward and encountered one more.

Suddenly he had a very horrifying thought. He thought that he had indeed gone blind. But he also knew that it was not possible. As he walked forward, he felt as if the ground was going downwards into a pit or a dungeon.

Then suddenly he lost his nerve found himself hesitating to take the next step. He wanted to get out of the darkness. It would be better to

spin some more stories and convince Nandini, than going around aimlessly in this dark castle. Thinking thus, he turned back trying to retrace his steps, but he couldn't find the pillars that were there earlier.

What if I don't locate the door of the castle? What if I am trapped here forever?

Then suddenly he heard a flapping sound somewhere.

Could there be bats in here? No. It seems like footsteps. Somebody has closed a door and is coming towards me. Who could he be? Or could it be a... thought Vandiya Devan, as many horrifying images and old ghost stories came to his mind.

Suddenly somebody bumped into him. Vandiya Devan closed his fist and threw a punch, which only resulted in his hand hurting as if it had been severed. If it had not hurt so much, he would have burst out laughing because he realized that he had not only bumped on a pillar but had also tried to punch it.

Ironically this made him more confident and dispelled the mad panic that had seized him earlier.

He could still hear the echoes of footsteps. At times, it was loud and sometimes faint. Vandiya Devan stopped still and listened intently and at the same time he looked at the direction from which the sound appeared to be coming.

Ah! Light at last. Somebody is bringing either a lamp or a torch. What if Nandini was coming in search of him? What if it is someone else?

Let me hide for some time and then see what happens? Maybe it is a soldier who has come searching for me.

He looked around the palace and found that it was vast with countless pillars everywhere. And the floor was inclined downwards towards a winding path where the steps led downwards. And someone was coming up this way. He had a very horrifying thought...

What if this is the famous underground prison of Thanjavur? If it is, then I am heading towards certain death.

Vandiya Devan hid behind a pillar to see who was coming through the steps. Three people came up the steps. One was an ordinary soldier who bore firelight in his hand. The second one had a spear in his hand, and the third didn't have anything. And when Vandiya Devan saw their faces, his fear vanished, and surprise took over because one of them was none other than his beloved friend Kandanmaran. And when he looked at the other man who came along with his friend, he shook his head and stared hard - he looked exactly like Nandini, but when he scrutinized him carefully, he found that it was none other than Prince Madhuranthakan, whom he had seen in Kadambur. The other soldier was probably a guard of this palace.

Vandiya Devan started thinking furiously.

Why are they coming up through this dark palace and where are they going?

But the answer was evident. The Pazhuvur queen had come into the fort yesterday, and Periya Pazhuvetarayar had also come in today, but no one should know that Prince Madhuranthakan had left the fort. So, they are bringing him through this passage. That is the secret of this dark palace. It must be an underground chamber that leads one out of the fort!

Kandanmaran must have joined Periya Pazhuvetarayar after I left and was sent to escort Madhuranthakan into the fort. That's why he said that he 'might' come to Thanjavur. What will Kandanmaran do, if I appear before him now?"

Even as he thought about this idea, he rejected it. It is not appropriate to confront Kandanmaran now.

While he was thinking thus, they had climbed the stairs and had gone in a different direction. He thought of following them, but it would not be of much use because they would be going to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's palace. It would be no use going back to Nandini's lata mandapam either. Periya Pazhuvetarayar might have come there. Therefore, it would be better to go down the same route Kandanmaran and Madhuranthakan had come by. Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan went down the steps of the dark palace.



Chapter 41 - The Underground

Chamber

Vandiya Devan climbed down the steps slowly. After a while, he reached level ground, but there were a few feet steps... As the path meandered endlessly, he wondered how long he would have to roam in the dark.

Suddenly he saw a very dim light somewhere. At first, he thought that moonlight was beaming in through a window, or that a lamp was hidden in a corner.

‘No! It can’t be! Am I imagining things? Have I gone mad? How can this be? Is this even possible?’

He had reached a large chamber with a low ceiling. And the light that he saw was not moonlight nor was it coming from a lamp. It was coming from the heaps of gold coins that were stacked in the chamber! In one corner, he saw piles of gold crowns and diadems, in another; there were pots full of pearls, gold ornaments, coins of gold...

This was the treasure chamber of Thanjavur and the Chola kings. No wonder it was housed in this dark palace, Periya Pazhuvetarayar being the treasurer of the Chola Kingdom.

How lucky I am, to have come upon this treasure chamber? How surprising that I stumbled upon this, without any effort on my part? How can I make use of this good fortune? I don’t feel like leaving this

place. Countless wars have won this treasure for the Chola Kingdom. Even Kubera's^[140] wealth would certainly not match this... Vandiya Devan thought as he went around the chamber amazed, looking at the heaps of treasure.

Some pots were full of gold coins. Some had diamonds, emeralds, pearls... There were also countless jewels, necklaces, and diadems... he did not know how long he was there. He lost track of time... He took a handful of coins and gleefully scattered them on the ground. In another corner, he saw something gleaming and picked it up before he realized what it was. It was a human skull! He dropped it in fear and recoiled in horror.

But the skull had given him an important message! It told him, "Leave this place now! Begone from here. I was like you once, alive and well. But when I came here and found all this wealth, I wanted to stay. And look what happened to me. Begone before you lose your mind and life!"

Vandiya Devan wanted to get out of the palace immediately but didn't know how. Wherever he turned, there was only darkness. The steps that had led him down to the chamber seemed to have vanished. It couldn't possibly be. They must be there somewhere. As he was looking for the steps, he came across yet another pot of gold coins around which a spider had meticulously cast a web.

He remembered what the elders of his family had always told him - a man should never become a slave to three desires in his life - women, land, and gold! Just like the spider traps an unsuspecting insect in its web, this web of desires consumes our heart and traps

us in hell. Vandiya Devan pondered over it and knew that he had been tempted by the three desires, all in one day!

The temptress Nandini had tried to charm him with her hypnotic beauty, and when that didn't work, she promised him to give him the land of his ancestors and in the end, he had found his way to this treasure house! He had successfully escaped from the first two, but how could he escape from here? It seemed impossible.

Why did I get into this at all? What will I do with a kingdom or wealth? Why do I need women? The best way to live is to be carefree and independent, with nary a thought of where I would be the next day. Why should I get unnecessarily involved in all this political intrigue and unwanted desires? I would willingly give anything to get away from this place. If I leave this place, I will never set foot into Thanjavur again, he promised himself.

Aha! What was that sound? Seemed like somebody was opening a door and closing it...! 'This appears to be one endless night of wonders!' he said to himself.

He could hear footsteps echoing in the palace. He stood still holding his breath while his eyes darted around sharply to watch out for any signs of light. Just as he had expected, he saw the light from a torch and a very unusual sight as well! He looked around to see where he was standing and found that he was in a pit, from where steps led towards another path to a higher level. He could see light coming from both the sides; it seemed as if two people were coming towards the path from opposite directions. He immediately sprang towards the nearest pillar and hid behind it.

From the left, there appeared two tall figures. Vandiya Devan knew who they were already. It was his best friend Kandanmaran and the guard who had escorted Prince Madhuranthakan earlier.

From the right came two figures. One was the tall figure of Periya Pazhuvetarayar, and the other was the dainty figure of his young wife, Nandini Devi!

Vandiya Devan's heart was beating fast. He wondered what might happen when these two parties met.

Would something untoward occur here or would they just greet each other normally and go their way?

Both the parties met, but from the expression on their faces, it appeared as if they hadn't expected to meet each other, but nothing untoward happened. Periya Pazhuvetarayar asked Kandanmaran something, and he gave a reply. But Vandiya Devan couldn't hear a word of the exchange. Then, Pazhuvetarayar pointed towards the steps that he and Nandini had climbed up from. Kandanmaran bowed and proceeded forward, but he failed to notice that Periya Pazhuvetarayar signaled something to the guard. The guard bowed low once again and followed Kandanmaran holding the fire torch aloft. After they had gone out of sight, Pazhuvetarayar and Nandini took the steps that Kandanmaran had climbed down from.

Vandiya Devan felt as if he had been a witness to a drama enacted on a stage. He thought he was lucky to have got stuck in the treasure chamber below. If he had been wandering around in the

path above, he could have been spotted by either of the parties, and God knows what might have happened then.

What do I do now? Kandanmaran is going back the way he came after escorting Madhuranthakan to the palace. If I follow Kandanmaran, he will lead me out of this palace and may be out of the fort too.

Treading carefully, he followed the guard and Kandanmaran but not getting too close. As they kept walking Vandiya Devan realized how difficult it was to get out of the palace without a proper guide. Left to himself, he would have been trapped there forever!

Hail Kandanmaran!

He doesn't realize what a big favour he is doing for me. Maybe one day I will repay him for this help.

Vandiya Devan didn't realize that he would get a chance to repay Kandanmaran almost immediately.

They had reached the end of the underground path. Vandiya Devan knew that there must be a hidden door somewhere in that wall. He was not mistaken! The guard handed the torch to Kandanmaran and pressed a particular spot on the bare wall, turned a lever and then stepped behind. And suddenly a door opened out from the wall!

It was a tiny doorway, just big enough for one man to go through. The guard pointed to the door and asked Kandanmaran to go through. Kandanmaran said something to the guard and put one foot outside but before he could put his other foot out the guard had whipped out a dagger and had stabbed Kandanmaran in the back!

This happened so suddenly and so unexpectedly that Vandiya Devan cried out and sprung out from his hiding place and lunged on the guard. Hearing the sound, the guard turned around and saw Vandiya Devan!



Chapter 42 – Is this your friendship?

Vandiya Devan's first impulse was to save Kandanmaran's life, but he had to take care of this murderous guard first. He sprang forward and held the guard by his throat from behind making him drop the fire log. The fire log fell down burning low, while the guard struggled to release himself. Vandiya Devan held the guard tightly and then banged his head on the wall, after which he fell to the ground with a thud. Vandiya Devan immediately took the fire log and went near the unconscious guard (who looked as if he was dead). Unsure whether the guard was dead or not, Vandiya Devan tied his arms with his upper cloth quickly.

Next, he ran to his friend, Kandanmaran. His friend lay halfway across the doorway with the guard's dagger stuck in his back, and his spear lay near him. Vandiya Devan stepped out and dragged him outside. He took his spear in hand. The doorway to the underground passage closed on its own. Hoisting his friend on his shoulders, he turned around to see where they had emerged. A rushing stream was passing very near him, and the ground was wet and muddy. A few steps more, they would have fallen into the gushing Kaveri River that ran along the fort.

Someone had once told him that Vadavaru, one of the many tributaries of Kaveri River emerged close to the Thanjavur Fort. He was now very sure that he was out of the fort though not away from the soldiers of Pazhuvetarayar. He pondered on how to cross the river and tried to check the water level with Kandanmaran's spear.

The spear almost drowned, and it would be an impossible feat to wade across the river with his friend slung over his shoulders.

Gritting his teeth with rage, he realized what that murderous guard had meant to do with his friend. Stabbed in the back like a traitor, Kandanmaran would have been tossed out here in the river to drown. He controlled his anger with an effort and focused on what to do next. He had to somehow escape unscathed and save his Kandanmaran's life as well. He walked along the narrow banks and saw a large tree trunk fallen across the breadth of the river. Though the trunk of the tree looked old, it was strong enough to hold the weight of two men, and he crossed the river to the other side.

Out of breath and tired, Vandiya Devan laid his friend on the ground. He wanted to check whether Kandanmaran was alive or not. There was no point in carrying a dead body, given his precarious position. Thankfully his friend was alive, as he kept moaning from pain and his pulse was beating fast. Vandiya Devan wondered what to do next. He could take out the dagger that was stuck in the back. But that wouldn't help him in any way. He would just lose a lot of blood.

He looked around the place carefully and felt that he must be somewhere near Senthana Amuthan's garden home. He decided that the best course of action would be to leave his friend with them and pray that he survives. He bent down to lift Kandanmaran yet again on his shoulder when he realized that his friend's eyes were open.

"Kandanmara! Do you recognize me?"

"Yes. Why wouldn't I recognize you? You are Vallavareyan. The great friend, who wouldn't hesitate to kill me,"

Shocked beyond words, Vallavareyan said, “What do you mean? Did I try to stab you from behind...?”

“No. You didn’t stab me. Your knife scratched an itch on my back. You... traitor. I hastened through this underground passage because I wanted to save you. I wanted to catch you before you fell prey to Pazhuvetarayar’s men. I told Pazhuvetarayar that you would make a worthy commander for the fort’s watch. I came here to help you out of trouble, and this is how you repay me. Is this your definition of friendship? Is this how you treat a friend who came to save you? You didn’t think twice before betraying me. I wanted to warn you about the significant political change that was going to happen here... With friends like you around, who needs enemies? Is there is no end of people’s selfishness and treachery? Whom do I trust?” said Kandanmaran, before his voice went faint again.

“Whom do I trust indeed? Why don’t you trust the Pazhuvetarayar’s who would be happy to murder you?” muttered Vandiya Devan but his eyes were brimming with unshed tears. He hoisted Kandanmaran on his shoulders again.

Soon he could smell the intoxicating fragrance of flowers that bloomed in the night. He realized that he was close to Senthana Amuthan’s gardens now. As he neared the gardens, he was appalled to see many uprooted plants, grass and flowers everywhere. It was apparent that soldiers had searched for him high and low in the garden. Saddened, by the turn of events that had caused the ruination of his friend’s gardens, Vandiya Devan wondered what to do next.

What if the soldiers are waiting for him inside to catch him? Looking around carefully, he stepped into the garden and found his horse tied to the tree, which the soldiers had thankfully overlooked, or could it be a bait to catch him? He didn't have much choice and time was running out for his friend.

Senthan Amuthan was sleeping outside the hut and woke up with a start when Vandiya Devan shook him.

"Thambi! I need your help. This is my friend, Kandanmaran. He is Kadambur Sambuverayar's son. Someone had stabbed him and had left him to die. I brought him here."

"Scoundrels! What kind of man stabs someone in the back? You don't worry. I will take care of him. Many soldiers have come here all through the evening, searching for you, and they have ruined my garden. It doesn't matter as long as you escape. Thankfully, they left your horse behind. Just get on your horse and leave right away."

"That's my intention too. But how do we save my friend's life?"

"Don't worry about it. My mother knows how to heal wounds," as he quickly entered the hut and explained the situation to his mother through sign language.

Vandiya Devan and Senthan Amuthan carried Kandanmaran inside the hut and laid him on the bed. Senthan Amuthan's mother brought medicinal herbs and looked at the dagger that was stuck on his back. Senthan Amuthan held Kandanmaran tightly, while Vandiya Devan pulled it out.

Senthan Amuthan's mother tried to stem the gushing blood with old rags and then applied the hot medicinal herbs on the wound.

Kandanmaran screamed out aloud before Vandiya Devan could shut his mouth. At a distance, they heard the sounds of galloping horses coming towards the garden.

“Leave now,” shouted Senthana Amuthan.

Vandiya Devan took Kandanmaran’s spear in hand and hesitated at the doorway.

“Thambi! Do you believe in me?”

“I believe in God, and I trust you. Why do you ask?”

“I need your help. I need to go to Pazhairai immediately. I am carrying an urgent message for Princess Kundavai, but I don’t know the way. Can you come along and show me?”

Senthana Amuthan agreed immediately and took leave of his mother. They left together, and Vandiya Devan rode the horse at a slow trot. After covering some distance, they galloped away.

Soon after they left, a group of soldiers came to the hut. Amuthan’s mother opened the door after a long time.

“We heard someone screaming here. Who was it?” asked one soldier.

Amuthan’s mother blabbered something in her muted voice.

“Let’s not waste time talking to her. Let’s go inside.”

Amuthan’s mother tried to close the door, but the soldiers forced their way inside even as she screamed out aloud.

“Our man is here,” shouted one soldier.

“We got him,” shouted another.

“Catch him before he escapes again,” said another.

Amuthan’s mother’s screams increased in volume.

“There is so much blood here,” shouted another.

They brought the lamp near the prone figure of Kandanmaran to ascertain whether it was Vandiya Devan.

“This is not the spy.”

“Ba... ba... ba...” cried Amuthan’s mother.

“Is this the man who came here last night?” asked one soldier to Amuthan’s mother.

“Bey... ba... ba...”

“Where is your son, woman?”

“Bey... ba... ba...”

“Shut up woman. Do any of you recognize him? Have you seen him before?”

“This is not the spy.”

“No. It is him.”

“No. I have seen the spy. And this isn’t him.”

“Let us take him.”

Four soldiers started carrying Kandanmaran when they heard the galloping sound of Vandiya Devan’s horse. They dropped the injured man on the ground saying, “Let’s go now. This one isn’t going anywhere. We need to catch the spy.”

All the soldiers came out of the hut to mount their horses while Amuthan's mother's loud screams followed them out.



Chapter 43 – Pazhaiarai

Now that our hero is on his way towards Pazhaiarai, braving hordes of soldiers who are out to catch him, let us go ahead and pay a visit to this city.

Here is a glimpse at this old city from the banks of Arasalaru. How beautiful it is! One would certainly fall short of words to describe the quiet beauty of this city. Bountiful with flowing gentle rivers, swaying greens, scented flowers, graceful palaces, and holy temples, Pazhaiarai was a haven of beauty, elegance, and sublime peace.

The old city of Pazhaiarai had many small villages within its borders making this erstwhile capital, an important landmark in Chola history. With four Shiva temples guarding it from four directions, the city also housed the families of Chola soldiers. Amidst them, stood a whole host of palaces for kings, queens, princes and princesses built right from the time of Vijayalaya Chola.

The grandeur and the charm of the city today is so exhilarating that it makes one wonder, how it must have looked years ago when Sundara Chola was residing here. Reduced to a sleepy town today, Pazhaiarai was once the epitome of culture and religion.

Ever since Sundara Chola shifted his capital to Thanjavur, Pazhaiarai's importance had reduced. There were no new visitors, emissaries from other countries, delegates from neighboring kingdoms, traveling mendicants, prominent officials, poets, artists,

artisans stopped coming here to pay their respects. Instead, they made their way to the new capital – Thanjavur.

With majority of the soldiers fighting in Elangai under Prince Arulmozhiavarmar's command and the rest manning the borders with Prince Aditya Karikalan, the city was populated mostly by their families; wives, children, and aged parents. One section of the city lay virtually isolated, as the families of Velkara Padai, the elite bodyguards of the King, shifted to Thanjavur along with the king's retinue.

Despite its resemblance to a ghost city, Pazhairai wore a festive look today. Though foreign ministers, key delegates stopped coming here, the city was still visited by occasional wandering mendicants, temple officials, temple artisans, and devotees from surrounding areas.

Men, women, children are seen roaming around wearing festive silks and flowers. Many were thronging in crowds here and there watching troupes of performers. Most performers were dressed to resemble Krishna, Yashoda, Kamsa, Devaki and Vasudeva... Performing various acts of Krishna Leela, the artists were celebrating the divine birth of Lord Krishna. It was Krishna Jayanthi today.

The throng of crowds at the entrance of Nandipura Vinnakara Perumal Kovil seemed gigantic. Yet at the same time, we hear...

'Kanden, Kanden, Kanden

Kannuku Eniyan Kanden...'

I have seen... I have seen...

I have seen a sight that is sweet to my eyes

Who is this singing? Seems like a very familiar voice...Ah yes, it's our old friend, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi. Standing in the courtyard of the temple, he is singing devoutly. While many are listening to his song in rapture, some are mocking of him. And we do fear, whether the Nambi is going to break their heads.

But just then, someone arrives. A host of chariots and palanquins bearing their royal mistresses arrives at the entrance of the temple. They were the royal women of Pazhaiarai, Queen Sembiyanmadevi belonging to Mazhavereyar clan, wife of King Gandaradithan. An ardent devotee of Lord Shiva, there was a divine radiance about her that inspired respect and devotion.

Next came Queen Kalyani Devi, wife of King Aringzhar Cholan, brother of King Gandaradithan and mother of King Sundara Cholan. Though she belonged to the warring enemy clan of Vaithumbarayar, Aringzhar married her, after being enamored by her beauty. Even today, she looked radiant and lovely, and one wonders how she might have looked when she was young. Along with her, was the second wife of Sundara Chola, a Chera Princess named Parathankan Devi.

Following them were the rest of the princesses whom we met at Arisalaru Karai; Princess Kundavai, Princess Vanathi and her companions and friends.

Though Chola kings were renowned for their devotion towards Lord Shiva and Goddess Durga, since the days of King Vijayalaya Chola, they also extended their patronage to Lord Vishnu's temples. As they entered the temple, Azhwarkadiyan stood in one corner respectfully.

“Thirumalai, I haven’t seen you in many days. Did you go on a holy pilgrimage?”

“Yes, Amma. I visited Kanchi, Thirupathi, Veerananarayanapuram and many other places of interest. I have seen and heard many astounding things in all these places.”

“Do come to my palace tomorrow and tell me all about your journey then.”

“Amma, I am leaving tonight, again.”

“Then come this evening to my palace.”

“As you wish Amma.”

On their way out of the temple, Princess Kundavai made a comment about Azhwarkadiyan, which elicited peals of laughter from her friends. When he looked at them, Kundavai signaled him with his eyes and he understood her intent and nodded his assent.

Queen Sembiyanmadevi’s palace was a vast and spacious structure, and it stood resplendent among the host of other palaces in the city. In the Sabha room, she sat on a golden throne studded with gemstones, attired in a simple white sari and with sacred ashes smeared on her hands and forehead and rudhraksha beads on her hands. Though her appearance was a perfect foil to the opulence of her surroundings she had a queen-like poise and an awe-inspiring radiance that commanded respect from one and all. As one of the most senior royal women alive in the family, she was highly respected and almost venerated by all.

Yet, the past few years were not kind to this dowager queen. The reason was her son's recent marriage alliance with the Pazhuvur clan. Madhuranthakan's marriage with Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's daughter happened against her wishes. And many knew that her son was a changed man after he allied himself with the Pazhuvur clan.

Her sabha room had always welcomed artists, poets, mendicants, temple priests, sculptors, and singers. Today, there was a delegation of sculptors and priests from Thirumadukundram, Thenkurankadurai, and Thirumazhapadi to request funds for temple renovation.

Sembiyanmadevi agrees to help with the renovation of the first two temples and then she asked, "Mazhapadiya? Which Mazhapadi?"

"Amma, this is the same Mazhapadi, where Sundaramurthy Nayanar sang his devaram after Lord Shiva called him."

"Please tell us this story."

"One day, Sundaramurthy Nayanar was traveling through Chola Nadu temples and on the way, he had to cross a river. Even while he was crossing, there was a voice that streamed through his heart, 'Sundaram, have you forgotten me?' Startled, he enquired whether there was any Shiva temple nearby. And when he learned about Mazhapadi village and its small Shiva temple he immediately hastened there and sang this beautiful song for his beloved lord."

Ponnarmeniyane

Politholaiaraikasaithu –

O with the effulgence of gold,

the one who wears the tiger's skin

“Amma, even to this day this temple is very modest in size. We need your help to repair and build it anew.”

“Very well, I shall arrange for it,” replied the dowager queen.

Watching all this intently, Azhwarkadiyan along with another man came forward to the Sabha room.



Chapter 44 – This is her doing!

A young sculptor belonging to the lineage of great sculptors of Mammalapuram came forward with a petition for Sembiyanmadevi. Describing his dream to build a new temple, the sculptor displayed small-scale model of the same that excited the dowager queen to no end.

She looked at the man standing next to Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and said, “Patterey! Look at this beautiful structure. I wish I could rebuild all the main Shiva temples in the Chola Kingdom thus.”

“Amma! Who can possibly say ‘no’ to such a noble design of yours? My suggestion is that we build all the temples that are sung in the divine devaram in the same manner to signify its importance,” said Isana Shiva Pattar.

“Yes. And also, someone needs to undertake the noble work of compiling the divine verses of Apparperumal, Gyanasambandar, and Sambandhamurthy in one-fold. I want to rebuild the sacred temples that were sanctified by their beautiful verses. But I doubt if this dream of mine will ever come true. If my lord and husband had not died, we might have fulfilled it...”

“Amma! I see no reason why your dream should not come true. The Emperor and his sons hold you in very high esteem, and they would leave no stone unturned to fulfil even the smallest of your wishes.”

“Nonetheless, I am not so sure of anything nowadays. Many rumours have reached my ears too where they say that my passion for

building temples is emptying the royal treasury. It seems that many are asking, 'Why does Lord Shiva need so many temples?' I am not bothered about other people, but the Crown Prince in Kanchi..."

Even as Sembiyanmadevi was speaking, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi interrupted angrily and said, "Amma! I too am also asking the same question, 'Why so many temples for Lord Shiva alone?'"

Startled by his tone, Sembiyanmadevi looked at him while others in the Sabha room were surprised at his outburst.

"My blood is boiling, when I see this injustice being done to my Lord. I have known you as just and fair queen, yet you are meting out such injustice..." he said fiercely.

Isana Shiva Pattar said, "Maharani! My brother is forever saying something witless. Please forgive him and ignore his words."

In those days, Saivaites and Vaishnavaites were not two different sects as it is today. A single family would have members who were ardent devotees of Shiva and Vishnu, and one single priest would take care of temples of both Gods. Isana Shiva Pattar was Azhwarkadiyan's cousin once removed, which was why he sought to explain his brother's outburst, lest the queen got offended.

Sembiyanmadevi smiled and said, "Thirumalai, tell me what injustice has happened?"

"There are so many temples being built for someone who roams around like a madman with a Kapalam in his hands. But there are not enough temples for the lord who protects the divine order of our

lives. Is this justice? Please rebuild, at least one Vishnu temple, Amma.”

“Amma! It is Shiva who needs more temples and mandapams so that he can mesmerize the entire world with his divine cosmic dance. Vishnu is forever sleeping, so he needs a small temple preferably dark, lest we disturb his sleep,” said Isana Shiva Pattar rather cheekily.

“Anna! The lord who sleeps forever is the supreme lord of the three worlds. It was he, who sent the great Asura King Mahabali to the Paathaalam.”

“Is that so? Then why couldn’t your Vishnu find the divine feet of our Shiva when he burrowed through the ground.”

“If your Shiva is so huge, then he doesn’t need a temple. He might destroy the temple with his magnificent height...”

Sembiyanmadevi laughed and said, “Please stop bickering. Thirumalai, whoever stated that we should not build a temple for Vishnu? Which temple do you want me to rebuild? Tell me the details, without getting angry.”

“My Queen, I recently went to Veerananarayanapuram, a place that is named after one of the titles that your peerless father-in-law King Paranthakan bore. My Lord Vishnu is guarding the huge dam that Prince Rajadhithan had built. It pained me to see the stones crumbling from this temple. If the temple falls, the dam too might be destroyed. I request you to rebuild this temple.”

“Alright! Tell me more about the temple Thirumalai. Let all the others leave now...” said Sembiyanmadevi and Isana Shiva Pattar withdrew from the hall.

Sembiyanmadevi lowered her voice and asked, “Thirumalai! Where did you journey this time? What did you see? Whom did you meet? You have something of import to tell me, that’s why you interrupted the assembly, didn’t you?”

“Yes, Mother! I have important news to impart, but I would have waited patiently until you heard all your petitioners. However, when you started to say something about Prince Aditya Karikalan, I had to interrupt. We do not know who among the crowd today is a spy, and we have to be careful about what we say in public, especially when the kingdom is under threat.”

Hearing this, Sembiyanmadevi said bitterly, “It pains me beyond anything that my own family members would suspect me of intrigue and betrayal. Prince Aditya Karikalan who once had so much respect and devotion for me that it surpassed his regard for his own mother has now started suspecting me as well, is it? I wish I had stepped into the funeral pyre along with my lord. If only my husband had permitted me to come along with him on his last journey to heaven. But no, I was not allowed that comfort but was instead tasked to carry out his last wishes. Is there a more unfortunate creature, in this world, than me?”

“Amma! King Gandaradithar was as wise as King Janaka. He knew that this Chola Kingdom that has risen to the heights of power in these hundred years could fall prey to fratricidal battles. That’s why

he didn't allow you to follow him. He knew that because it is only 'you' who can prevent this and save the kingdom."

"I doubt it. Even my own son doesn't listen to me. What hope can I have of others then? Anyway, tell me. Who is the spy here? Does Aditya Karikalan think so less of me?"

"I heard with both mine ears, Amma. I wouldn't have believed it otherwise..."

"What did you hear, Thirumalai?"

"I heard them talking, sitting in one of the stone temples of Mammallapuram..."

"Who did you hear talking?"

"Thirukovallur Malayaman, Pallava Parthibendran, and Prince Aditya Karikalan were talking. I was hiding inside the stone temple behind a statue. Malayaman and Pallava Parthibendran were arguing vociferously. They said that Pazhuvur brothers and your son Prince Madhuranthakan are keeping Sundara Chola, as a prisoner in Thanjavur. And Malayaman said that even 'you' were involved in this plot, which the others acknowledged. Pallava Parthibendran wanted the Prince to take an army to Thanjavur and free the Emperor from the clutches of Pazhuvetarayar brothers. Though they agreed to this suggestion, the Prince wanted to try once more before they took any drastic action. He decided to send a messenger to the King, inviting him to Kanchi. I found out whom he was sending. He was no ordinary emissary but a soldier of extraordinary talents - intelligent and brave. He not only carried the messages that his Prince sent him but also successfully spied for his master. I tried to speak to him,

but there was no information forthcoming. Instead, he started questioning me in return. I suggested Kundanthai Jodhidhar talk to him, but he too had to concede defeat. The last I heard about him was that he successfully gave his message to the Emperor...”

“What happened after that? What did the Emperor say?”

“The Emperor apparently declared that he would write his reply the next day. But by then, the Pazhuvur brothers got suspicious, and he somehow escaped from the heavily guarded fort...”

“Then, he must be a brilliant and valiant spy. There is no doubt about it. What did you do, after you left Kanchipuram?”

“I wanted to come here but, on the way, I visited Veerananarayana Perumal Temple and found a crucial secret.”

“One more secret! What is it?”

“Yes, Amma! I learned that Kadambur Sambuverayar’s palace was hosting an important guest that night. Periya Pazhuvetarayar was coming there, and along with him came his young wife in a palanquin.”

“Thirumalai! This is ‘her’ work. She is solely responsible for the troubles that this kingdom is facing now. Did you meet her?”

“I couldn’t meet her Amma! Upon your orders, I brought her up as my own sister. I taught the divine verses of Prabandam and looked after her for so many years. Yet after her marriage to Periya Pazhuvetarayar, she has refused to meet me.”

“Don’t grieve Thirumalai! It is the nature of this world. What happened in Kadambur that night?”

“Thinking that it was Nandini, who was in the palanquin, I wanted to send her a message with a warning. Courting huge danger, I climbed the high walls of Kadambur, to look for her and that’s when I found that secret...”

“Thirumalai! This is a bad habit you possess. You will talk and talk about the secret but will not reveal it. What did you find there? Tell me.”

“Forgive me, my Queen! I do not wish to cause you any pain, that’s why I am hesitating. The veiled palanquin that came after Periya Pazhuvetarayar did not bear Nandini along. We were wrong to assume that Periya Pazhuvetarayar took his wife along with him everywhere.”

“Then whom does he take along with him in a veiled palanquin? Is there no limit to this man’s lecherous behaviour?”

“Amma! There was no ‘woman’ inside the palanquin.”

“No woman! Which man would hide inside the palanquin and travel then?”

“Forgive me Amma! It was your son, Prince Madhuranthakan who was traveling with Periya Pazhuvetarayar in the veiled palanquin.”

Sembiyanmadevi seemed stunned beyond words. When she recovered her speech, she muttered to herself, “God! Such a huge punishment for my sins, is this fair?”

Thirumalai then recounted the midnight conference that happened in Kadambur. Distressed beyond words, the old queen wailed, “My son! I tried to bring you up as an ardent devotee of Lord Shiva but see the result. You have grown up to shame the courageous name of Chola Kings. Woe to me that I begot a son, who would hide behind the veils as a woman.”

After a few moments, she composed herself and said, “Thirumalai! Don’t leave the city today. Meet me again after a few days. In the meanwhile, let me tell Kundavai about this new development and decide what needs to be done to avert the dangers that my foolish son has brought upon us.”

“Amma! Do you think it would be wise, to discuss this matter with the Princess?”

“Why? Do you think that even she suspects me?”

“Isn’t it natural? After all Princess Kundavai is Prince Aditya Karikalar’s own sister.”

“So what...? Thirumalai! If you tell me that the sun rises in the west and sets in the east, I might believe you. I might even agree with you when you argue that Lord Vishnu is mightier than my own Lord Shiva but do not ask me to believe falsehoods about Kundavai. I brought her up since she was a little girl. She is the daughter that I could never have. And she too loves me, just as much.”

“Amma! Let me ask you one thing. Did Kundavai Devi tell you about her visit to Kundanthai Jodhidhar?”

“No. Why do you ask?”

“Did she tell you that she met a young warrior belonging to the Vanar clan at the Jodhidhar’s house? Did she tell you that she met the same warrior near Arisalattrukarai?”

“No. What is the meaning of all these questions?”

“I think that the princess is holding something back from you. The young warrior that I mentioned was the same messenger that Prince Aditya Karikalan sent to the King.

“Thirumalai! I don’t care for such intrigues. But I do know one thing. If Kundavai has not told me something, then there must be a good reason for that. I would rather give up my life than suspect her of anything.”

“Maharani! Please don’t talk like that. The Princess has called me to talk about something. I will inform her that you wish to speak to her.” He said and withdrew.



Chapter 45 – The Crime of the Spy

Two thousand years ago, the great King Karikala Cholan built the banks of Kaveri River on both the sides. The banks protected the land for many years from river floods however when Pandyas and Pallavas rose to power, the Cholas star declined. When the kingdom was torn apart by war, there was no one to safeguard the land, from flooding river waters. This resulted in floods that changed the geography of the river. Small streams and large lakes were formed where there were none earlier. There was one such lake that flowed near the palaces of Chola kings in Pazhaiarai.

Later Chola kings deepened this lake and maintained it to delight their womenfolk with boat rides. It also acted as a natural barrier for the palace. Ordinary people couldn't venture near this lake easily, and only those who were associated with the palace and its noble residents could take a boat through the lake. Many palaces were built along with this lake, and since Pazhaiarai was once the capital of the Cholas, many beautiful gardens were laid in along the banks of the lake. Most palaces had private areas, where the palace women could swim, bathe and play in the garden, away from the prying eyes of the public.

Royal custom decreed that when a new king ascended the throne, he would build a new palace here, while the wives of the old king retained their old one. In the same manner, Princess Kundavai's palace was situated right next to Queen Sembiyanmadevi. It was the

palace where her father had lived when he ruled from Pazhaiarai, and after he had moved to Thanjavur, Kundavai became its mistress.

Beautiful and elegant in architecture, her palace had the most breathtaking garden grounds in Pazhaiarai. And it was no wonder that she and her friends spent many evenings enjoying the bountiful nature and verdant greenery that mother Kaveri bestowed on them. Sometimes, they would roam around the grounds hand in hand or in groups. Off late, though, Kundavai and Vanathi were often seen walking in pairs. That day was no different. Seeking the privacy of their friendship they walked away from others and came upon a tree with a swing.

They both seemed to think intently about something when they heard a song that one of their handmaidens was singing. It was Krishna Janmashtami that day, and predictably she was singing about Krishna's many mischievous deeds.

Kundavai who listened intently to the later part of the song commented, "Hmm. Krishna and his mischievous deeds indeed. If he is going to keep stealing butter from the gopis, when is he going to do other important work?"

Vanathi who was deep in thought did not respond to Kundavai. "Vanathi! What happened? Have you been mesmerized by Krishna too?"

"Akka! What did you ask?"

"Where was your attention? What were you thinking?"

"I wasn't thinking anything."

“Liar! Your mind was nowhere here. And I know exactly where it was. Shall I tell you?”

“If you know, then tell me.”

“Of course, I know. Your mind is wandering somewhere in Elangai where my brother is there. Poor innocent boy that he is, he has no idea about us women and our intrigues. I am sure you are thinking about ways to get his attention yet again? Aren’t you?” she asked jokingly.

“Akka! Your assumption is half correct. Yes. I do think about him all the time, but I am not plotting to gain his attention or favour. I do wonder how he is faring in the battles, whether he is hurt, hungry or tired. And I also feel sad, when I think that I am living in such a comfortable palace, safe and well fed while he is courting danger there. If only I had wings, I would fly away to Elangai and be at his side...”

“‘Fly away to Elangai to be at his side...’ Nice joke. How can you help him there?”

“Didn’t Shubadra^[141] drive Arjuna’s chariot? Didn’t Krishna take Sathyabhama^[142] along with him when he conquered Narakasura^[143]? Just like these noble women, I will also drive his chariot for him and take all the arrows intended for him upon myself.”

“Do you really think that he is going to sit quietly and allow you to die for him?”

“If that is going to bring him pain, then I would wait for him at the camp. I would dress his wounds, make his bed, cook tasty meals and play music to soothe his mind.”

“These thoughts of yours are fanciful Vanathi, but they will not come to pass. Chola warriors will never take women to their battlefields.”

“But why, Akka?”

“Our men do not fear wounds, but they do fear women.”

“But why? What will women do to them?”

“If women like you go to the battlefield, then our enemies will drop their weapons and surrender. How will our men show their valour in war? It will be known that Cholas won their wars through their women.”

“Is this even possible? Are soldiers so fickle minded to throw their weapons down, just because they see a beautiful woman?”

“Of course, they are. Vanathi! Do you remember that young soldier we met at Kundanthai Jodhidhar’s house? Do you remember how stunned he looked when he saw us?”

“Yes. I remember. But what you are saying is not true. He didn’t look shocked because he saw ‘us.’ He was stunned because he saw ‘you.’ He didn’t even look at me or any of the others.”

“Vanathi! You are making fun of me?”

“No. If I ask you something, will you tell me the truth?”

“Ask.”

“Why did you suddenly think about that young warrior today?”

“Vanathi! What sort question is this? And what is wrong, if I think about him?”

“Who said it was wrong? I too wondered, what happened to him later?”

“Why would you wonder about him?”

“Why shouldn’t I? When we meet someone, it is but natural to think about them later and wonder what happened to them.”

“It is not right for young women to have fanciful thoughts about all and sundry. We must keep our hearts within control. Vanathi! Can you hear the beating of the drum? Someone is making an announcement.”

The rhythmic beatings of the drums were heard, and an announcer’s thunderous voice boomed out an announcement.

“A spy from an enemy kingdom entered Thanjavur Fort showing a fake signet ring and has escaped after wounding two people with grave injuries. This spy is young, broad-chested and handsome. Beware of this dangerous spy. His name is Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan. Those who give him asylum will be punished with death. Those who help capture him will be rewarded with thousand gold coins. By the orders of Thanjavur Fort Commander, Kalanthaka Kandar, beware of this dangerous spy.”

Both the princesses listened intently to this announcement and for some reason, Kundavai shivered when the drums started beating again.

Just then, a handmaiden came forward and said, “Devi, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi has come to see you. He says he has some important news.”

“I am coming,” said Kundavai and got up from the swing.



Chapter 46 – Murmurs and Rumours

After meeting Queen Sembiyanmadevi, Azhwarkadiyan headed towards Princess Kundavai's palace. On the way, the sights that met him at Pazhairai's streets filled his heart with enthusiasm. He happily noted how people celebrated Krishna's birthday with such excitement. He felt no doubt about the fact that Vaishnavan was here to stay. For over hundred years, under the patronage of Chola kings, many Shiva temples were rebuilt, many grants have been given to them, countless jewels, land, and wealth have been showered on Lord Shiva, yet it did not diminish the people's enthusiasm to celebrate a festival for Maha Vishnu's avatar, Krishna. There is no doubt that Krishna's many miraculous deeds and endearing stories have captured the people's imagination. So many troupes of street dancers and drama groups have come here to celebrate this festival. He noted how people were clapping energetically at the performance of one of the dance troupes.

The actors who were playing Vasudeva, Devaki, Krishna, Balarama and Kamsa were showing their acting prowess to the public. With the public cheering them loudly, the actors sang and performed many amusing japes that attracted claps and frequent shouts. Azhwarkadiyan stopped to see their performance. The scene was where Krishna was challenging Kamsa to a duel. A small boy played the role of Krishna, and he listed out the many crimes that Kamsa had committed and challenged him to a duel. In his reply, Kamsa who was played by a broad-chested warrior wearing a mask, thundered, "Krishna! Your magic prowess will not work with me. I am

going to kill you now. I will kill your brother Balaraman and your father, Vasudevan. I am also going to kill that Veera Vaishnavan, who is standing there!”

Everybody now looked at Azhwarkadiyan and started laughing. The Vaishnavan looked around with anger and his hands itched to bring his staff down on the actor who was playing Kamsa. But it was pointless, as he had hidden his face with a large wooden mask. He silently slid away and left. But something was niggling at his mind. That Kamsa’s voice seemed a bit familiar to him, and he felt as if the actor was shouting his dialogues a tad too loudly to camouflage his voice.

Just then, he noticed a change in the mood of the people. He found the reason soon enough when he came upon the announcer whose thundering voice warned the people about the spy. The announcement literally spoiled the mood of the people and their enthusiasm for festivities diminished. Many were seen leaving the roads and talking in groups. Some were looking around suspiciously and hurried their way home. Many openly cursed the Pazhuvur brothers and expressed their sympathy to the spy whom they were hunting.

Azhwarkadiyan found that it was but natural for people of this city to hate the Pazhuvur brothers, as they were responsible for taking away their king to Thanjavur. And since that day, the importance of the city had diminished, day by day. Many spoke about how wonderful it was when Krishna Jayanthi was celebrated with the Emperor residing there. All drama troupes would perform in the main streets of the city and then would assemble at the Emperor’s palace.

And he would watch and encourage all the artists and give away expensive gifts to all the performers. What crowds, and what excitement! One could almost believe that the entire Chola Kingdom had gathered there to watch them perform.

All this was lost when the Emperor was taken to the Thanjavur Fort. They also had another outstanding grievance against the Pazhuvur brothers. Thousands of soldiers from Pazhaiarai went along with Prince Arulmozhivarman to Elangai to bring glory to the Chola Kingdom. Their families were aghast when they learned that Pazhuvur brothers objected to sending food, arms, clothing and supplies to Elangai. Their refusal to send supplies, citing various reasons did not sit well with the families of the soldiers in Pazhaiarai and with the result they became more unpopular with the masses.

Therefore, when the announcer made his announcement about the spy that the Pazhuvetarayars were hunting, many found it unpleasant. It also became a reason to discuss them and their growing influence in the kingdom.

What spy? Where is this spy? Who is powerful enough to send a spy here? These Pazhuvur brothers are ruthless people. If they do not like someone, they just need an excuse to hunt him down and kill him. Or else, they will just throw people in their underground dungeon. They have no sense of justice in them.

Azhwarkadiyan heard many such mutterings and hurried his pace towards the Princess's palace and was ushered in. Princess Kundavai was always interested in learning about his travel and stories about people and places. Sometimes, he would sing

Andaalsurams^[144] or regale her with stories of a temple that he had visited. Today, however, he found the Princess distracted, and it seemed as though, her heart was elsewhere.

“Thirumalai! What are you doing here? Is there any news?”

“Nothing of import Devi! I thought you would be interested in hearing about my travels. That’s why I came. If you are busy, I shall take your leave.”

“No! No! Stay. I forgot that I had asked you to come.”

“Devi, I just came away from Queen Sembiyanmadevi presence. She wants to discuss something important with you.”

“Alright. I will visit her. Tell me about your travels.”

“I travelled all the way from Kumari to Venkatam, Devi!”

“What do people discuss in all these places?”

“People speak of the valour of Chola Kings. They also say that the Chola Kingdom is going to expand until Ganga River soon...”

“And then...”

“Many spoke of the valorous deeds of the Pazhuvur brothers. They said that it was their bravery and valour that made the Chola Kingdom emerge victorious after so many battles.”

“Enough... Anything else?”

“They talk very proudly about both your brothers. And more importantly, their love for young Prince Arulmozhiarman knows no bounds.”

“That’s nothing surprising...what else do they talk about?”

“Many are also wondering why King’s beautiful daughter Princess Kundavai is still unmarried. Some even asked me...”

“And what did you answer?”

“I said that a worthy husband for our Princess is yet to be born in this world.”

“Nice reply. If this is true, then by the time, such a husband is born for me I would be a wrinkled old woman. Seriously, isn’t there any other talk among the people?”

“Of course, there is. Many are wondering why Prince Madhuranthakan got married so suddenly, after saying ‘no’ for so many years.”

“What about your dear sister? You used to say that she was going to become the Lord’s bride, just like Aandal. How is she?”

“She is wielding power in her palace, as the Pazhuvur queen...”

“Only in her palace? If the rumours are to be believed, many say that she is ruling the entire Chola Kingdom.”

“I have heard those rumours too. But Devi, let’s not talk about that woman, on this auspicious day. I have some beautiful songs that were written by Vishnu Chittar. Just listen to them...”

Saying thus, Azhwarkadiyan sang a song. At the end of the song, he said, “I found our Pazhaiarai so beautifully decorated today and the people’s enthusiasm for Krishna’s birth fills my heart with great joy.”

“True. But I also heard an announcement on the streets. What was it about Thirumalai?”

Thirumalai had been waiting eagerly for the very same question from Kundavai.

“Some spy escaped from Thanjavur, it seems. And those who catch him will get a reward of thousand gold coins. But what would I know, Devi about all this?”

“You really don’t know anything about this? Do you have any idea who this spy is?”

“I do have my doubts. But I am afraid of talking aloud about all this. It’s dangerous. Today, when I was walking on the streets, many were looking at me suspiciously. What if somebody caught and handed me over to the Pazhuvetarayars?”

“I don’t think there is anyone clever enough to do that. Or do you fear that I might betray your confidence to the Pazhuvetarayars?”

“Krishna! Krishna! Devi! What are you saying? I met a young warrior in Veera Narayanapuram, a few days ago. He stated that he was going to Thanjavur but did not reveal any information as to why or what his business was...”

Kundavai interjected restlessly and asked, “How did he look?”

“He seemed like a scion of an old clan. Broad-chested, handsome, impetuous and charming.”

“What did he ask you?”

“He asked me about the Emperor’s health and wondered who would ascend the throne if something happened to him and then he asked about Prince Arulmozhiarman. Later, I believe he has asked the same set of questions to Kundanthai Jodhidhar as well.”

“Aha! Did he go to Kundanthai Jodhidhar’s house then?”

“Yes. I remember now. I believe he stormed into the house when you were visiting the Jodhidhar. Thankfully, he didn’t know who you were.”

“I was right...”

“Devi, you were right about what?”

“I thought that young warrior might get into trouble soon.”

“You thought right, Devi. I do believe that he is the one that Pazhuvetarayars are hunting as the spy. They are also giving a reward for those who would provide any information about him.”

“Thirumalai! I need your help.”

“Command me, Devi!”

“If you ever meet this warrior...”

“Should I hand him over to the Pazhuvetarayars and get the reward?”

“No! No! Bring him to me. I have a task for him.”

Azhwarkadiyan, stood still for a moment feigning surprise and then said, “There is no need for that Devi. I do believe that he will come in search of you.”



Chapter 47 – Isana Shiva Pattar

Azhwarkadiyan went to his brother, Isana Shiva Pattar's house after his audience with Princess Kundavai. Located near the Vada Mettrali Temple, the Pattar's house was about half a kilometre distance away from the royal palace.

The city was quiet, and the streets were empty, as all the drama and entertainment troupes seemed to be done for the day. As he walked by the houses of Padaiveedu, he noticed many women were standing outside their homes and talking in groups, angrily. These were no ordinary women. Each one of them had sent their father, husband, and sons armed with a sword and a spear to Elangai to fight along with Prince Arulmozhivarman. Every house in this street had sacrificed a son or a husband to the glory of the kingdom. He looked around and wondered about the dissatisfaction that these women felt now and worried where it would all lead to if they started protesting too loudly.



Vada Mettrali Temple

It was dark when he reached the temple. Situated atop a small cliff, the temple cliff was once occupied by Jain monks who meditated in the caves. When Appar Swami came here for the first time, he couldn't see the temple, because the artificial catacombs that the Jains had built were all around. He entreated the Pallava chieftain who was in command to intercede. The chieftain ordered the demolition of the catacombs and within them, a small Shiva temple was seen, and Appar sang in delight.

Chola kings of later years rebuilt the temple, and the cliff walls formed a natural boundary around the temple, and there was only one entrance. Azhwarkadiyan had come to the temple because it was easy to reach Isana Shiva Pattar's house through it. When he entered the temple, he noticed a few drama troupe entertainers dressed as Krishna, Kamsa, Vasudeva, etc. Wondering what they were doing here, Azhwarkadiyan waited outside. Isana Shiva Pattar came out hurriedly when he noticed his brother's arrival. He clutched Thirumalai's hand and dragged him out of the temple precincts.

"Anna! What is this?" asked Azhwarkadiyan.

"I will tell you Thirumalai. But first, understand one thing. You will never step into this temple or any other Shiva temple ever again. You have a wicked tongue that derides my Lord. If you want to be my brother, then we can continue that relationship outside the temple. I will not stand by and watch a scoundrel like you step inside my Lord's temple. Do you understand? I have been patient for many years but your actions in Maharani's Sabha today were unpardonable. If you wish to eat, you can go to my home and fill that big belly of yours. But do not ever step into a Shiva temple or else I might just become Chandeshwara Nayanar^[145] to put you in place."

Saying thus, Isana Shiva Pattar pushed Thirumalai out of the temple and barred the door. Thirumalai tried pleading, "Anna! Anna..." But the Pattar did not relent.

"Oho! So that is your plan is it?" murmured Azhwarkadiyan and waited outside for a while. When the temple doors did not open, he circumambulated the temple three times and deliberately chose the left-hand direction (as the right-hand direction would count as a holy

circumambulation of Lord Shiva). The artificial caves that the Jain monks had once built were all barred now.

Afterward, he went to Isana Shiva Pattar's house. Unlike his brother, his sister-in-law was favourably disposed towards his visits and humorous jokes. Following his brother's orders, he filled his belly with prasadam food from Shiva Temple and lay down outside the house, on the veranda.

Half drowsy with sleep, he remembered a scene that he had seen near Kudamurattu River, a day earlier. He had hidden behind some bamboo trees when he saw a few horse soldiers galloping fiercely from the opposite end. At the head of the group, was a warhorse that was drenched in sweat and a youth was sitting on its back, looking scared yet determined. Behind him, there were five or more soldiers who were intent on catching him. One of the soldiers who held a spear in hand would have struck the youth with it but for his companion who held his hand. The horse that carried the youth ran wildly through the bamboo trees and his hair got entangled in one of the branches. While the youth was struggling to control the horse, the soldiers surrounded them and held the horse.

They started questioning him immediately, while the youth stuttered some reply. Azhwarkadiyan heard one question repeatedly, "Where is he? Where did he go?" and the youth replied, "He drowned in the river. He fell into the river." After a while, the soldiers took the horse and the youth along with them and headed towards the fort.

Hidden behind the trees, he did not understand what was happening then, but now he did. Alternatively, his mind dwelled on the actor

who had played Kamsa in the street drama troupe. “That voice... whose voice was it? Where did I hear it?”

Sometime past midnight, Isana Shiva Pattar, came home after completing his duties at the temple. When he noticed Azhwarkadiyan sleeping in the veranda, he tried to wake him up, “Thirumalai! Thirumalai!” But Thirumalai pretended to be in deep sleep instead.

Banging the door with anger, Isana Shiva Pattar went inside and argued with his wife about his brother’s presence. Next morning, however, he had calmed himself down to ask, “When are you leaving again for your temple visits?”

“I will leave after your anger has subsided, Anna!”

“Don’t ever call me ‘Anna.’ You are not my brother. You are a scoundrel, a creature with a vicious tongue!”

His sister-in-law interceded on his behalf and said, “Why do you curse him so? He has been like this, right from the beginning. The problem lies with you. You are becoming mad with your Shiva devotion.”

“You know nothing. Do you know what this scoundrel told at Maharani’s Sabha yesterday? He asked, ‘Why does Shiva need so many temples it seems?’ I felt so ashamed. And I heard that poor queen did not sleep the whole night.”

“He will not talk like that anymore. I will advise him. If you explain to him patiently, he will understand.” She said.

“Patiently indeed! I want him to go to Rameshwaram. Let him worship the lingam that Rama himself worshiped to wash his sins.

That will be his penance. Until he does that, I will not look at his face.”

Thirumalai was itching to retort back angrily, but he had to be patient.

His sister-in-law intervened again and said, “Alright then. Let us all go to Rameshwaram along with Thirumalai. Let him wash his sins there and we can pray to the Lord to grant us a child. God knows what sins we have committed that has rendered us childless. What do you say Thirumalai?”

Furious with his wife and brother, Isana Shiva Pattar stared at them with anger and went inside. After a few hours, Isana Shiva Pattar came out and spoke to his brother with practiced patience.

“Thambi! Our forefathers have cautioned us against excessive anger and wrath. I think that I am guilty of that. I hope you have not taken my words to heart.”

“Not at all Anna!”

“Then stay right here. Let me finish the afternoon rituals and pooja at the temple. I need to speak to you about something important. Will you be here?”

“I will be here Anna! I have resolved not to leave your presence henceforth!”

After his brother had left, Azhwarkadiyan left abruptly without even taking leave from his sister-in-law and went to the temple. Circumambulating the temple, yet again, he looked at the numerous artificial caves that dotted the cliff and was careful to hide when he heard a sound. His efforts bore fruit when he saw someone emerge

out of one of the caves. It was his brother. Looking around carefully, he stepped out of the cave along with another man.

“Aha! Now who would this be?” wondered Azhwarkadiyan to himself.

The man who went with his brother was well built, almost like the actor who played Kamsa at the street drama troupe the previous day. Azhwarkadiyan couldn't see his face, but he intuitively understood why his brother behaved violently yesterday.

“So, this is why you didn't want me here?”

Both men went cautiously along their way while Azhwarkadiyan followed them silently. They headed towards that lake that meandered towards the royal palaces, and a boat was waiting for them there. It looked like a royal boat that the palace women used for a pleasure ride. They both climbed into it, and the boatman started plying his oars. That was when the man who had accompanied his brother turned around. Azhwarkadiyan could now see his face clearly, and he was not surprised.

It was the same man that he had met in Veerananarayanapuram. It was beyond doubt that he was the one who had donned the role of Kamsa in the street drama troupe.

“Now where is he going in this royal boat?” he wondered silently and resolved to confirm his suspicions.

Walking along the banks of the lake, Azhwarkadiyan came to an empty palace that belonged to the Prime Minister of Chola Kingdom, Anirudha Bhramarayar. He knew that Anirudhar was on a royal visit to Madurai, and his family was living in Thanjavur. The palace

guards stood aside respectfully when they saw him. He ordered them to open the palace for him and lock it again once he entered.

Inside the palace, he headed towards the garden. There was a passage through the thick grove of trees that led him towards Princess Kundavai's royal residence. He positioned himself behind a tree and waited. His efforts were not in vain.

The scene that unfolded before him should be described by the eloquent verses of a poet like Kalidasan.

The royal boat arrived, bearing Isana Shiva Pattar and Vandiya Devan. They stepped out of the boat and climbed the stairs towards the garden, where Princess Kundavai was sitting in one of the stone benches. She stood up and came towards them, and that was when Vandiya Devan looked at her.

A beautiful creeper tree with slender vines stood between them. A bright, lovely butterfly flew in and sat on the vine, distracting Kundavai's attention. But Vandiya Devan seemed transfixed by the beautiful visage of Kundavai's face. He did not look at the butterfly nor did he note his surroundings.

Waves rippled in the lake, a gentle breeze blew through the garden and the birds chirped in a sing-song voice and time came to a standstill for these two, while eons passed.



Chapter 47 – Whirlpools and Beautiful Eyes

Man, one of Brahma's finest creations lived next to a hill. It gave him shelter from rains and the sultry sun. The bountiful forest provided him enough food to survive, and the rest of the forest creatures trembled at his sight. He roamed around the woodland with nary a care, free as a bird. Yet, at the depth of his heart, he yearned. He couldn't understand what he wanted, but he longed for something that tugged at his heartstrings, giving him sleepless nights. He felt that he was searching for something that he has not seen so far. He wondered incessantly about it in the morning, while he dreamed about it during the night. His heart yearned to see the thing that was attracting him so much. 'Where will I find that thing that is giving me sleepless nights?'

Brahma had also created a woman. She lived on the other side of the hill. And just like the man, she took shelter in the caves of the hill and partook the fruits that the forest offered her. Outwardly, she was happy and carefree. But inside she was burning with an unknown passion, a strange quest for the one who would complete her.

Separated by the hillock that sheltered them, man and woman did not meet until, one fateful day. It was summer, and a forest fire raged around, devouring the green trees. Man and woman, intent on survival, climbed the hillock to escape the raging fire. Atop the hill, they found each other. When their eyes met, they forgot why they

had come there. Sleep, fatigue, hunger and thirst did not exist anymore in their universe. They intuitively understood that they were alive for so many years, just so that they could meet thus, one day. They also realized why they had felt so incomplete. They were meant to be together for all their lives.

Watching this scene, Brahma, the God of creation withdrew to his world, satisfied with a work that had begun so well.

Vandiya Devan and Kundavai Devi resembled the man and woman that we described here. Both intuitively felt that they were born, raised and had lived so long in this world, just so that they could meet one day. Unlike Brahma's man and woman, the trappings of the world bound Vandiya Devan and Kundavai. They could not explore their mutual attraction in the same manner, as the ancient man and woman did. They were intensely aware of their respective status in the world and had to rein in their attraction and act accordingly. They looked at each other for a while and then realizing that staring was unmannerly, they fixed their eyes at other things like flowers, butterfly, and the lake, in a futile attempt to disguise their feelings.

Thankfully, Isana Shiva Pattar was at hand to remind them. Coughing discreetly, he brought both the princess and the handsome soldier back to their senses.

"Is it true, that you wanted to meet me in private?" asked Kundavai in a formal manner.

Her tone and manner brought Vandiya Devan out of a secret dream, and he asked her, "I can answer your question, only if I know who

you are? I am afraid that Isana Shiva Pattar, might have brought me to the wrong place.”

“I too have similar suspicions. Whom did you want to meet?” she asked.

“I wanted to meet the Chakravarthy Sundara Chola’s peerless daughter and Prince Aditya Karikalar’s sister and the pride of Chola Kingdom, Elayapirati Kundavai Devi.”

A beautiful smile played on her lips when she said, “You have come to the right place. I am Princess Kundavai.”

“That means, you are not the woman, whom I met at Kundanthai Jodhidhar’s house and later at Arisalaru, are you?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“Sadly, I am the same woman who behaved with so little decorum. I am sure you never dreamed of meeting the same manner less woman, so soon,” asked Kundavai cheekily.

“I didn’t dream of meeting you again, Devi, because you were always in my thoughts. Only those who bid farewell can meet again.”

“I didn’t know that men from Thondai Nadu could talk so cleverly.”

“Well, you must allow other kingdoms their share of praises and witty nothings. You cannot claim all of them for your Chola Kingdom.”

“You are right. I am guilty of that crime. But it seems like you do not like the Chola Kingdom.”

“No Devi. You are wrong. I do like your Chola Kingdom, but for two dangers here.”

“Yes. The sword and the spear of Chola soldiers are two great dangers indeed. And those who come here need to be prepared for that especially if they are coming here to spy.”

“Princess, those were not the dangers that I was referring to. I too bear a sword and a spear. And I can wield them better than anyone if the occasion calls for it...”

“I saw your skill with the spear, the other day at Arisalaru. Within the blink of an eye, you threw your spear with such precision on the dead crocodile. The poor beast lost all the straw and cotton that was stuffed inside.”

“Princess! I had no reason to believe that women of Chola Kingdom were brave enough to lose sleep over dead crocodiles. I thought that it was alive and about to eat your friends. It was a mistake.”

“Truly, it was the crocodile’s mistake. It didn’t wait until the brave Vandiya Devan, came along with his spear to slay him. That apart, what were the dangers that you were referring to?”

“I was referring to the whirlpools that are formed on the Kaveri River. They are very dangerous.”

“How did you get into the whirlpool? If my instinct is correct, you look like a person who hates to step into water,”

“Circumstances are responsible for this Devi. I was forced to jump into the river. It was all because of a young man, who was coming along with me. He couldn’t tell a small lie, and that almost resulted in my death.”

“Can you explain in detail? I do not understand your meaning,”

“Let me explain. I went to Thanjavur bearing messages from your brother, Prince Aditya Karikalar. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar branded me as a spy and sent his soldiers to capture me. My mission was incomplete, so I had to escape from his soldiers. I sought the help of the people, in whose home I was staying in Thanjavur - a youth who had befriended me. He came with me as a guide to show me the route to Pazhaiarai...”

“In whose home did you stay in Thanjavur?”

“A youth who delivers flowers to a temple in Thanjavur. His poor mother is deaf and mute.”

“Oh! What is her name?”

“I do not know her name, but her son’s name is Senthana Amuthan.”

“What happened next?”

“I took Senthana Amuthan along with me on the horse, as I was not sure of the route to Pazhaiarai. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s soldiers were hot in pursuit behind me. When we reached Kudamurattu River, I dismounted from the horse. I told him to go ahead for a while, pretending to be me, and when the soldiers come closer, I asked him to tell them that I had drowned in the river. I thought that it would give me time enough to escape. But the youth seemed to be a scion of Harish Chandra Maharaja’s^[146] noble lineage, because he asked, ‘How can I say that you have drowned, when you have not?’ So, I had to drown, to spare him the sin of lying. My God! The rivers of your Chola Kingdom are so dangerous, the whirlpools and the swift current can mean sure death to anyone. It was lucky that I grabbed the root of a tree near the bank and was able to survive.

Devi! Do you know what my last thought was, even when I was being sucked into the whirlpool?”

“How would I know? Maybe you were thinking about Gajendra Motcham^[147]...”

“No. No. In the whirlpool, I noticed that many tiny fishes were trying to swim out of it. Those fishes reminded of the beautiful eyes of Chola women. I thought that there is yet hope for someone who was caught in the river’s whirlpool, but none exists for those who are trapped in the vortex of a beautiful woman’s eyes.”

“So, you are like every other man in the world, who blames the woman for all his mistakes...”

“Well Devi, what can you expect? I too am a man...”

Sounds of faint music and drums, and the tinkling of anklets were heard from the palace then and a beautiful voice of a woman, singing one of the poems from Silapathikaram was heard. The beautiful song held the Princess and Vandiya Devan spellbound, and they did not talk until it ended.

“Looks like that a Kuravai Koothu is happening in the palace. I saw one such performance in Kadambur palace, but it was entirely different.”

“Yes. My friends and handmaidens are watching a performance. Soon they will start searching for me. What is your business with me?”

“Here it is Devi! Your brother’s olai that I brought braving whirlpools and beautiful eyes,” he said and handed it over to her.



Chapter 49 – An Astonishing Tale

Princess Kundavai took the olai that Vandiya Devan gave and read her brother's message. Her creased forehead cleared, and her face bloomed when she read the content of the message.

She looked up at Vandiya Devan and asked, "Now that you have given this message to me, what do you intend to do next?"

"My mission is complete Devi! I plan to return to Kanchi."

"Your work is not complete. It has just begun."

"I don't understand the meaning of this, Devi!"

"My brother has sent a message saying that you are trustworthy enough to entrust any mission. Are you not going to abide by his words?"

"Devi! Your brother did indeed send me to help you. But I entreat you, please do not entrust me with anything important."

"I do not understand your plea. You agreed to work for me when you left my brother at Kanchi. And now you do not want to work for me. Is this how men of Vanar clan behave? Don't they honour their words?"

"No Devi. Honour is the only thing that is left for our clan today, and I always keep my promises."

"Then why do you hesitate? Is it because I am a mere woman? Or perhaps, you do not like me?" she asked and smiled.

Devi! What a question to ask? It would have been more appropriate if the sea were asked if it liked the beautiful moon. If he did not like the moon, then why would it try to reach for it through the waves? Does the sky love the earth? Is that why it watches the beautiful Bhoomi Devi with countless stars all through the night? Does the cloud love the lightning? Is that why it tries to envelop it in a moment of passion and longing? Does the bee love the flower? Is that why it buzzes around hoping to drink the honey that the flower offers so sweetly? Why do you ask this question, Devi? How can I not like you? Why does my heart beat so furiously when you glance at me? Why do I become transfixed when I see that beautiful smile of yours?

While these thoughts raced through his mind, he stood speechless, unable to reply to Kundavai's question.

"Ayya! You have not answered my question. Do you perhaps find it repugnant to your manly honour to answer the summons of a mere woman? Didn't Prince Karikalar tell you what he has written in this message?"

"Devi! I knew what was written in this message. But I fear my journey did not begin at an auspicious hour because I made enemies all along the way and got branded as a spy. Soldiers are searching for me everywhere. When my situation is so perilous, how can I promise to fulfil my mission? That's why I am hesitating."

"Who are these enemies? Tell me about them," she asked worriedly.

"Pazhuvur brothers are trying to capture me saying that I am a spy. My dear friend, Kandanmaran, thinks that I tried to stab him in the back. A Veera Vaishnavan named Azhwarkadiyan is shadowing me persistently. Pazhuvur Ellaya Rani, Nandini Devi has sent a

Madiravadi to follow me. I am not sure who I will encounter when and what would become of me after that.”

Vandiya Devan remembered the night he had escaped from the Kudamurattu River. He had decided to travel during the night and rest during the day, so as to avoid the soldiers who were searching for him high and low. Making his way towards Pazhaiarai through the thick forest route, he had once rested inside a deserted mandapam. It was a full moon night, and he was exhausted. Suddenly he heard the hooting sound of an owl and a man walked in. He quickly got up and disappeared behind one of the pillars, but the man came straight towards him and held his throat with a vice grip. Vandiya Devan kicked his feet at the post, trying to escape. “Where is that ring that Ellaya Rani gave you? Give it to me,” the man growled. It was the Mandiravadi who had come to meet Nandini.

Vandiya Devan kicked at the pillar desperately, and it finally gave way. The roof fell in on the Mandiravadi while he backed away towards the entrance. He ran away from there without looking back and rested only after he was sure that he was not followed.

“Ayya! When did you leave Kanchi?” enquired Kundavai.

“A week and a day, Devi,” he said.

“I am astonished that you managed to earn so many enemies within such a short time. How did you do it?”

“It is a long story, Devi.”

“Nonetheless, I would like to hear it. I cannot assign any mission to you unless I know your story.”

Saying thus, the Princess bid Isana Shiva Pattar to come closer and asked, "Is the boatman trustworthy?"

"He is stone deaf, Devi."

"Good. Let us go for a ride in the boat. I need to listen to his story."

Vandiya Devan couldn't believe his ears. He is to go on the boat with the most beautiful woman in the Chola Kingdom! He must be very lucky indeed. He resolved to tell his story with a lot of detail, which consequently meant, a longer boat ride with the beautiful princess.

What's the hurry anyway?

While Vandiya Devan was not in a hurry, right from the moment, he told her about the midnight meeting in Kadambur Palace, Kundavai wanted to know everything that happened. Vandiya Devan kept his promise to himself and embellished his tale with many details and tales that did lengthen but sadly all stories do need to end sometime. They came back to the garden steps after a very long boat ride in the lake.

Sounds of music wafted from the palace, and a woman was singing about Kamsa and his evil deeds. Hearing this, Vandiya Devan said, "Kamsa was a very evil man indeed, but I am grateful for his help."

"What help?" asked Kundavai curiously.

"It was all thanks to Kamsa that I was able to enter into this city," said Vandiya Devan and started recounting yet another adventure of his.

Vandiya Devan knew that the city would be on alert and guards would be posted at the gates to capture him. They also knew that he would come bearing the Pazhuvur Signet ring so he couldn't possibly

use it to gain entry. He waited in the grove of forest for a while, watching the city gates pondering on how to enter it unnoticed. That's when he noticed a large number of drama troupe members making their way inside, to entertain the city, for the Krishna Jayanthi festival.

He struck up a conversation with one such group. Among the artists, only the man who was playing 'Kamsa' wore a large mask that covered his face. He deliberately picked a fight with that actor by commenting about his lack of acting prowess. Incensed by Vandiya Devan's comments, the actor asked him to mind his own business, which ended in a fistfight. Vandiya Devan forcibly took the mask from his face and put it on and acted as Kamsa. Impressed by his enthusiastic playacting, the troupe members appreciated him. The artist who was to play Kamsa abandoned the troupe in anger, while Vandiya Devan agreed to come along with them to the city, to perform. After playing in all the streets, he went to Vada Mettrali Temple to meet Isana Shiva Pattar, just as Prince Aditya Karikalar had instructed him to.

Hearing this, Kundavai said, "This kingdom has the divine blessing of Lord Muruga. That is why he has sent you to me during such perilous times."

"Devi! Does this mean that you will be giving me a mission to fulfil?"

"Yes. And it will be much more dangerous than any other mission that you have undertaken."

Saying thus, she made her way to towards the Vasantha Mandapam^[148]. Vandiya Devan's heart was fluttering in anticipation.

He was ready to sail the seven seas to get her the treasures of the world or to pluck the stars from the sky.

Pattar and Vandiya Devan followed her into the Vasantha Mandapam. There was a small writing desk on the Mandapam, from which she withdrew an olaisuvadi and a plumed feather to write the following -

Ponniyin Selva! Please hasten back to the Chola Kingdom when you receive this Olai. You will learn all the details from the one who bears this message. You can trust him completely.

Writing thus, she drew a secret symbol below the message to indicate that she had written the letter with her own hands. She closed the olaisuvadi and said, “Take this message to Elangai immediately and give it to Prince Arulmozhiarman and escort him back home.”

Vandiya Devan was delighted. He had wanted to meet Prince Arulmozhiarman for many years, and now it would be fulfilled.

“Devi! You have given me a mission that I would love to fulfil. I will leave for Elangai immediately.”

Saying this, he took the olai from Kundavai’s hands and their fingers touched, setting his heart on fire. He looked deep into her eyes, hoping that she would understand the many unspoken words that his voice failed to deliver. Faint sounds of music from the Kuravai Koothu performance was carried by the breeze, and Isana Shiva Pattar coughed discreetly yet again, to bring Vandiya Devan back to the earth.



Chapter 50 – Paranthakar Adhurasalai

It was a glorious morning in Pazhaiarai next day. A beautifully decorated royal elephant was brought to Kundavai's palace. Climbing through the specially built platform steps, Kundavai and Vanathi sat in a special seat on the elephant's back. A mahout walked next to the elephant, leading them through the streets. Hearing the clanging bells of the elephant, many came out to see the princesses riding through their streets. Happy to watch their beloved Elayapirati, many women followed behind their elephant.

The elephant led the princesses towards the Padaiveedu^[149] streets where the families of the soldiers lived. Small boys who were practicing with their swords and sticks left their play and joined the crowd. On the walls of the houses, many pictures of Lord Muruga and his legends were drawn, while some also had pictures of famous Chola Kings. When the elephant entered the street, all residents came out of their houses to greet the princesses. Soon there was a sizeable crowd behind the elephant that shouted, 'Long live Elayapirati!' 'Long Live Princess Kundavai!'

Princess Kundavai had established a medical clinic for the residents of the Padai Veedu, from her own royal income. Named after her great grandfather, Parantha I. Adhura Salai provided free care to the families of the soldiers. Princess Kundavai often came to the clinic, as an excuse to speak to the people.

The royal elephant stopped near Paranthaka Adhura Salai, and both the princesses descended from their mount. When the mahout led

the elephant away, the crowd came closer to talk to their beloved princess.

“Is the Adhura Salai^[150] beneficial for you people? Do the physicians give free medicines and treatment?”

All of them nodded their heads while some said, “Yes, Princess. They are helping us.”

One of the women said, “I was suffering from a cough for about a month. The physician gave me medicine, and I became alright within a week.”

“My mother eyes were growing weak and dim. The physician gave her medicine, and now she is able to see very well.”

“Vanathi! See how intelligent our forefathers were. They somehow divined that ‘this medication would cure this disease’. I wonder how they did that?”

“They probably had divine sight, Akka.”

“They do have medicines for many diseases. However, they have not found a cure for someone who suffers from excessive emotion. What to do?”

“Akka! I do not suffer from excessive emotion. As it is, all my friends are mocking me for fainting now and then.”

“Well, that’s the punishment you will have to endure for worrying my young brother. Whenever he sends a message from Elangai, he starts by asking how your health is.”

Just then, the crowd parted, and the Chief Physician came forward to welcome the Princesses inside.

“Vaidiyarey^[151]! You wanted someone to go to Kodi Karai to bring some rare medicinal herbs. I sent you a young warrior yesterday to journey there. Did he come and meet you?”

“Yes, Princess. Isana Shiva Pattar brought a brilliant young man to me yesterday. I am sending one of my sons along with him. My son knows the details of the medicinal herbs that I want. The soldier that you sent is going to Elangai I believe...”

“Is he going to bring medicinal herbs from Elangai?” asked Vanathi in wonder.

“Yes, Princess. When Hanuman brought the Sanjeevani^[152] Mountain to Elangai to save Lakshmana’s life, many medicinal herbs fell near Kodi Karai. And a part of the mountain fell down in Elangai, which is why many rare herbs are found across the sea. If I can get these rare herbs, I can make a medicine that could cure the Emperor.”

“May your words come true! Vaidiyarey! Where are the young men who will travel to Kodi Karai?”

“They are waiting inside to take your leave.

Waiting impatiently inside, Vandiya Devan was dressed for his journey and wore a large turban on his head. But Vanathi recognized him and whispered in Kundavai’s ears, “Akka! Isn’t he the same soldier we saw in Kundanthai Jodhithar’s house?”

“I think so too. After meeting the astrologer, he has come to the physician. Looks like he too suffers from the same emotional disease that you have.”

“Ayya! Are you ready to make the journey to Kodi Karai to bring back the medicinal herbs for my father?”

“Yes, Devi. I am going to Elangai to bring some rare herbs. I might even meet the Prince there. Do you have any message for him?”

“Do give him this message, if you see him. Princess Vanathi from Kodumbalur is not well. Her fainting spells are increasing every day. If you wish to see her well and alive, ask him to hasten back home.”

“I will give this message, Devi.” he said and looked at Vanathi.

Vanathi’s face bore a shy smile when she replied to Kundavai’s playful message. She said, “Ayya! I beseech you! Please do not give that message. If you meet the Prince, do tell him that I am keeping good health thanks to the care that Princess Kundavai showers on me.”

“I will give this message as well, Princess,” he said and looked at Kundavai.

“What is this? You can’t give two contradictory messages to the Prince. He will get confused.”

“Princess, I will give both the messages. I am sure the Prince will know the truth of it.”

“But please do not interchange the message for God’s sake,” pleaded Vanathi.

Kundavai turned towards the physician and asked, “Vaidiyarey! Did the royal scribe send the olai that these young men must bear?”

“Yes, Princess. We got the olai that stated that they are on royal business and a general plea to all the royal officials, to help them on

their journey. I have also written an olai for the guardian of the lighthouse at Kodi Karai.”

“Good. Let us not tarry any longer. They can leave immediately now.”

“Yes. It is time to leave,” said Vandiya Devan.

But Vandiya Devan was not in a tearing hurry to part from the woman of his dreams. He had many doubts to ask her about his journey while Kundavai too had many things to caution him about. They came out of the clinic, where two warhorses were waiting for them. The princesses climbed onto their royal elephants, and since Kundavai had already hinted that those leaving for a long journey must start on their journey first, Vandiya Devan turned the horse’s head towards the road albeit with great hesitation. Even then he couldn’t help but turn towards her and look upon her beautiful face once again, but realizing that it is unmannerly, he turned the horse’s head swiftly and galloped away within a flash. The Vaidiyar’s son, who was to accompany him, struggled to control his horse and followed him.

Kundavai watched them ride away with thoughtful eyes.

Why am I so concerned about this young warrior? A woman’s heart is a very strange indeed. This heart that had rejected the hand of many kings and princes is fluttering today at the sight of this soldier!

“Akka, what are you thinking?” asked Vanathi.

“Nothing Vanathi! I was wondering about the forwardness of that young soldier. I do regret sending a message with him to my brother now.”

“Yes, Akka! You are right. He is a rogue, and I think he is a thief too.”

“A rogue and a thief! Why do you say that?” she asked sharply.

“Ordinary thieves would want to steal useless things such as gold, silver, and precious gems but this soldier wants to steal the heart of the beloved princess that the Chola Kingdom worships. Will you allow that?”

“Vanathi! Do you think I am a flighty young girl like you? No. I will never allow that.”

As their elephant walked through the street, Kundavai noticed a group of women following them. She immediately ordered the mahout to stop the elephant and asked them, “Do you have something to tell me?”

“Devi! We are concerned about our husbands and sons who have gone to Elangai to fight. We heard that the officials in Thanjavur have stopped sending them food from here. How will they fight the war, without any food or supplies? What will happen to them?”

“Do not worry about that. Food is being sent to them from Mammallapuram by ships. Did you think that Prince Arulmozhivarman would let the brave soldiers of Chola army starve?”

Happy to hear this news, the women cheered. Kundavai would have loved to speak to them more, but her heart was aflame with some unknown emotion that she wished to examine in private.



Chapter 51 – Mammallapuram

Readers! We invite you to journey with us to Mammallapuram^[153] harbor. It has been more than 300 years since Mahendra Pallava^[154] and Narasimha Pallava^[155] built stone temples near the harbor. Mammallapuram wore a weary look as the sun shone down on the harbour. Many stone palaces are in a state of disrepair and what once was a busy port bringing in trade and goods from different parts of the world, looked deserted today. The harbour near Mammallapuram was quite shallow, although during the Pallava times, ships could come close to the beach. Now, the merchant ships were stationed at a safe distance and goods were unloaded with the help of small boats.

After the decline of Pallava Kingdom, the Cholas too built many temples near the harbor from a stone quarry that was found nearby. Within the city, King Parameshwaran Pallavan, who patronized both Saivaites and Vaishnavaites, built a huge temple for Maha Vishnu. A holy temple that was sung by Thirumangai Azhwar, here Maha Vishnu is found in sleeping form where he slumbers eternally on the ground. His divine verses describing the temple and the harbour reveal the greatness of Pallava period.

One hundred years after Thirumangai Azhwar^[156] sang about this temple, the Pallava glory weakened, and the sun rose on the Chola Kingdom.

But nothing could erase the beautiful sculptural work of Mammallapuram or the significance of beautiful Kanchi temples. They remain as an important heritage of Tamil culture and history even today.

A two-horse chariot was thundering through the streets of Mammallapuram. This beautiful chariot, with gilded gold work, was bearing three important personages belonging to the royal family.

Seated in the spacious chariot was Chakravarthy Sundara Chola's eldest son and heir - Crown Prince of Chola Kingdom, Prince Aditya Karikalan. He was a seasoned warrior who proved his mettle in battle at a very young age. He routed the Pandya King at a decisive battle and won fame for beheading him. After annexing the Pandya kingdom, Sundara Chola made him the crown prince and the heir apparent.

Karikalan fought in few other battles after becoming the Crown Prince and wanted to undertake an expedition to conquer Thondai Mandalam and Erattai Mandalam from the suzerainty of King Kannara Devan. He made Kanchi as his army base to plan further expeditions towards the north. But the Pazhuvur brothers protested against his expansion plans. They proposed that he wait until the war in Elangai comes to a satisfactory conclusion before starting another. On the other hand, the war in Elangai too stalled after they refused to send in food supplies food to the Chola army fighting there. With the result, Aditya Karikalan was furious with the Pazhuvur brothers.

In the chariot, along with the Prince were two other distinguished warriors. One of them was Thirukovallur Malayaman. A fierce warrior

and an astute thinker, he was Karikalan's maternal grandfather. An important lord who ruled over a kingdom called 'Miladu,' he was also known as 'Miladudaiya' (titular name). Feared as a great warrior and respected as 'Bhishma' the grandsire of Kauravas, Malayaman was the guiding force in Karikalan's life, though the Prince rarely listened to anyone.

The third person in the chariot was Parthibendra Pallavan, a scion of the Pallava dynasty. Older than Aditya Karikalan, he had pledged his sword and friendship to the Crown Prince and was one of his close friends and companions. He had fought many wars with Aditya Karikalan and had stood by him through thick and thin.

They were all discussing the news and rumours that they had heard from Thanjavur.

"How long should I suffer the upstart behaviour of these Pazhuvur brothers? How dare they call my messenger, 'a spy'? A thousand gold coins it seems for the man who catches him! How much longer should I wait now? I am ashamed to call myself, a warrior. My sword demands blood, thatha^[157], and you are advising patience."

"Prince, I told you then, not to send Vandiya Devan for such an important mission. I knew that he would fail spectacularly. He is a good soldier and a warrior, but you needed someone who could use his brains for this sort of work."

Aditya Karikalan's favour and friendship towards Vandiya Devan irked Parthibendra Pallavan to no end. He lost no opportunity to find fault with anything and everything that our hero did.

“So, you have started on Vandiya Devan yet again. God! If Vandiya Devan does not use his brains, then show me someone who does! I don’t think there is another clever warrior who is well suited for this mission. I told him that he needed to give my message to the Emperor in person, by any means. And that’s what he did. Obviously, the Pazhuvur brothers are angry with him. I don’t think he is to blame in any way.”

“He wouldn’t have stopped with the work in hand. He would have definitely poked his nose into other unwanted businesses for sure.”

“You be quiet for some time, Parthibendra. Thatha! Why are you silent? What is your opinion? Shall I gather our army and march towards Thanjavur and release the Chakravarthy? How long should I leave my father at the mercy of these Pazhuvetarayars?” asked the Crown Prince angrily.

Malayaman was a man who had seen over 53 battles in his life, and he was also familiar with the moods of his grandson. He said, “Let us first get down from the chariot and go to our usual place. I am an old man. I cannot talk when the chariot is rumbling away.”



Chapter 52 – Old Man’s Marriage

On the beach, numerous stones dot the landscape as the waves weaved in and out of the beach. Ancient sculptors of the Pallava Kingdom had worked on many of these rocks and had converted them into small mandapams.

The men alighted from the chariot and headed towards one of these little mandapams. Malayamaan and Karikalan sat on two stone benches near the mandapam, while Parthibendran stood next to them. The waves sometimes came near the mandapam and wet their feet. At a distance, a ship was seen waiting, while some soldiers were loading something in a small boat to carry to the ship.

“It is preposterous that we have to give away the food and other supplies that we have hoarded to prepare for our northern expedition,” commented Parthibendran bitterly.

“What else to do? Chola army is in Elangai now, gaining victories. They have captured Anuradhapuram^[158] and have routed the enemy’s armies. How can we allow our soldiers to go hungry?” asked Aditya Karikalan.

“We can’t allow them to go hungry, but we shouldn’t be sending it from here either. Food and other supplies can be quickly sent from the Nagapattinam or from the Pandya Kingdom through Sethukarai^[159]. I don’t see why we should give away our supplies from this barren land. This is going to delay our expedition towards the north.”

“Yes. You are right. I am furious about this too. I cannot fathom what these Pazhuvetarayars want? And how long do I keep quiet, while they rule the kingdom? Thatha! Why are you silent? Please say something.”

“Child! The sea waves are continuously making sounds here and on top of it, your friend Parthibendran shouts himself hoarse. What do I say in between? I am an old man now...”

“Parthibendra! Be quiet for some time. Let thatha give me his opinion now.”

“Alright, I am shutting my mouth. Poor thatha! He had to come all the way from the mountain fort here. I will shut my mouth but what about the sea. It doesn’t seem to realize that a ‘mountain among men’ is here and is still shouting about.”

“Thambi! There was once a time when the name ‘Thirukovallur Malayaman’ inspired fear and respect among my peers. Kings from Erattai Mandalam, Vallathu Vana Kovarayar, Ganga kings, and Kongu Kings used to tremble when they heard my name. Even Samudra Raja^[160] would have shut his mouth in my presence. The day I became old and weak, all these people have started their games. My dynasty can be traced for over thousand years, and these Pazhuvetarayars who came from the south are trying to destroy us. But don’t you worry. That will never happen. Karikala! You wanted to know about Pazhuvetarayar’s motive right? Let me tell you. Listen! They want to weaken you and your brother at two different locations. They want your brother to lose the war in Elangai. They want you to become furious with your brother’s failure. They hope to gain from your differences. This is their motive...”

“That will never happen, thatha! No one can separate my brother from me. Sometimes, I have an itch to just get on a ship to Elangai to help my brother. God knows, how he is suffering there, while I am sitting here idle in my palace. I am feeling very restless thatha! What do you say? Shall I go on the ship that is carrying supplies?”

“My Prince! That is an excellent idea. You have voiced what I have been thinking for many days. Let us leave tomorrow. Don’t ask thatha about this. He would only advise you to stay put and be patient. Let us leave with half of our forces and finish the war once and for all! And then we can go to Thanjavur and finish these Pazhuvetarayars...”

“Karikala! What did I say? Unless he shuts his mouth, I am not going to speak.”

“Alright! I am shutting my mouth,”

“Karikala! You are a true warrior. I can confidently say that there are very few warriors today, who can match you in vigour, force, and skill. I remember the Sevur war very vividly. You were but a mere boy of sixteen, and yet you entered the battlefield fearless with your great sword swinging this side and that, slaying your enemies like you were swatting flies. Your friend here is also a peerless warrior. But like all warriors, you both think with your sword and not with your brains. Impatient and rash, you want to jump from one adventure to another, without any care for consequences, and as a result, you go ahead and do just the thing that you ought not to be doing.”

“Thatha! You are forever giving the same advice...”

“Yes, I did. But it is of no avail, is it? Would it better if I return to my own kingdom?”

“No! No! Thatha! Tell me what I should do now?”

“You should get your brother here. I don’t want you brothers to be away from each other.”

“Thatha! What sort of idea is this? If Arulmozhi comes here, what will happen to the war in Elangai?”

“The war in Elangai has come to a standstill. We have captured Anuradhapuram and for the next four months, they cannot fight there due to monsoons. It would be impossible. Our forces will need to hold the fort in Anuradhapuram and the other forts that they have captured until the monsoon ends. This can be entrusted to the generals, who have gone along with the prince. Arulmozhi is needed here to stand by your side. Karikala! There is no point in hiding the fact that the Chola dynasty is facing a huge threat. It is important that you and your brother be together in one place. You never know when the enemy will strike.”

“Thatha! Why are you trying to scare me like this? Until I have my sword in hand, I will not fear anything or anyone.”

“My boy, I know how brave you are. But sometimes, you need to repeat what Thiruvalluvar^[161] has written so wisely,”

Quoting one of Thiruvalluvar’s famous Poems, Malayamaan said, “A warrior must not fear his enemies in the battlefield. In my dynasty, no one was born a coward. If there were one, I would have slain him, with my own bare hands. But you would be wise to fear the conspiracies, betrayals, schemes and intrigues that happen behind

your back. You should also prepare yourself for any such eventuality. You are the heir to the throne, and you cannot afford to be careless. If you are not prepared to tackle these dangers, then the kingdom will suffer a huge loss.”

“Thatha! What is this conspiracy that you are talking about? Please explain.”

“A few days ago, in Kadambur Palace, almost all the principal lords, chieftains of the Chola Kingdom came together to meet. Periya Pazhuvetarayar came for this meeting. Thennavan Mazhavezhar, Kunrathur Kezhavar, Vangamudu Munairayar, Anja Singam Mutharaiyar, Erattai Kudai Rajalizhar... were some of the guests who had arrived. There might have been more...”

“So what? They must have seen some koothu, had a bellyful of food and must have drunk some wine and slept off. Thatha! Please don’t ask me to be scared of these bearded old men, who snore,” he said scornfully.

“What can I say? Given the fact that your opinion about bearded old men is so low. I too am a bearded old man and probably older than any of them.”

“Don’t get angry thatha! I will never compare you with the likes of them.”

“You are talking about bearded old men, but you forget that their leader Periya Pazhuvetarayar got married at the ripe young age of sixty! Don’t you know that there is no one as dangerous as a man, who gets married to a young woman?”

When Malayaman, spoke about Periya Pazhuvetarayar's marriage, a curious change came over the Prince's face. His eyes reddened, and his lips quivered while he ground his teeth in anger. Malayaman did not notice these changes in the Prince's face, but Parthibendran did and changed the subject.

"Why are we talking about Pazhuvetarayar's marriage now, Ayya? Tell us what happened in Kadambur?"

"That is what I wanted to say, but the subject changed. Karikala and Parthibendra! Listen to me. All these lords met at the midnight to discuss something important. And there were a few young men in their midst too. One of them was Kandanmaran, Sambuveryan's son and the other was..." hesitated Malayaman.

"Who thatha? Who was the other young man?" coaxed Karikalan.

"Your grandfather's elder brother Gandarathidhar's son and your uncle, Madhuranthakan."

When they heard this, Karikalan and Parthibendran laughed out aloud.

"Why are you laughing? Are you mocking me again?" asked Malayaman.

"No! Thatha! You described Madhuranthakan as a 'young man', that's why we are laughing. Of all the bearded old men, Madhuranthakan is the oldest perhaps, wedded to his Lord Shiva."

"Haven't you heard that even an old man can become young sometimes? Until a few years ago, he wanted to renounce the world and dedicate his life to Lord Shiva, but now he is getting married, and that too multiple times..."

“Let him marry. What of it?”

“Thambi! Madhuranthakan’s marriages are political marriages that are brokered by the Pazhuvetarayars to gather support to his claim.”

“Thatha! What are you trying to say? Tell me plainly. What do the Pazhuvetarayars intend to do with Madhuranthakan? What is their plan?”

“This is their plan. They want to nullify your claim to the throne and crown Madhuranthakan in your stead. They want your father’s permission for this betrayal, which is why they have kept him under high security in Thanjavur,” said Malayaman.



Chapter 53 – Malayamaan's Wrath

When Karikalan heard Malayamaan's words, he did not faint away in shock, but he was shaken. Even Parthibendran fell silent with shock. Silence reigned over the small mandapam for a while.

Karikalan looked at his grandfather and said, "Thatha! I heard these rumours, but I thought they were baseless. Are you sure about this? Do you have proof? Does he have a claim at all? Is it possible?"

"It is possible. And Madhuranthakan has a better claim to the throne than your father. It was his father, King Gandharathithar, who ruled before your grandfather Aringhza Cholan. By rights, Madhuranthakan should have ascended the throne after your grandfather died."

"That's not possible. How can you say that Madhuranthakan has a claim? That cowardly a creature of comfort that should have been born as a woman, has a right to the throne? He can't even lift a sword, let alone wield it. How can you say that he has a better claim?" shouted Parthibendran.

Karikalan sternly bid him to shut his mouth. "Thatha! This kingdom is not of any consequence to me. I would happily give away my claim to a worthy man. I know that I can win ten such kingdoms, with the might of my sword. But why did they anoint me the crown prince in the first place? How can these lords change their mind after acknowledging me as the heir apparent?"

“If you are planning to give away your birth right, then here is what I will do. I will kill you with this sword of mine, I will kill my daughter who is your mother and then I will fall on the same sword and kill myself. I will never allow anybody else to ascend the throne when it rightfully belongs to you,” said Malayamaan furiously.

Parthibendran cheered in delight saying, “Well said, thatha!” and embraced the old man.

Karikalan was silent for a while, and then he looked at his grandfather and said, “Thatha! If this is their plan, then why don’t we take an army and uproot all these conspirators and release my father from the Thanjavur Fort. We can imprison Madhuranthakan and all the other conspirators in the underground prison of Thanjai. What do you say? There is none in this world to defeat me and my friend here.”

“It is true that no one can stand your might on the battlefield, but you cannot fight conspirators like this. If you march an army towards Thanjavur, you know what the Pazhuvetarayars will say? They will say that you have come to seize the throne from your own father. They might even say that your father died of shame because his own son took up arms against him and there might be people who would believe this story too. In such a situation, what will you do, child? Tell me. You will be branded as the son who fought a war with his own father.”

Aditya Karikalan couldn’t hear anymore. He shut his ears and said, “Shiva! Shiva!”

“That is why I have been telling you for so long. A great danger is waiting for the Chola dynasty.”

“What is the way out thatha?”

“First send someone trustworthy to Elangai and bring your brother back here. Arulmozhi isn’t likely to come away leaving his army behind. You need to send someone persuasive, who can explain the situation here and help change his mind.”

Parthibendran enthusiastically came forward and said, “Ayya! If you have no objection, I would like to go to Elangai. I will bring the Prince back here.”

“That is up to Karikalan. But note one thing, whoever goes there must not interfere in any unwanted business like Vandiya Devan did.”

“Aha! What did I say?” cheered Parthibendran.

“Thatha! Did you hear something about Vandiya Devan?”

“Yes. At one point, I was afraid that he had joined our enemies. But my suspicion was unfounded.”

“Did you hear that Parthibendran?” asked Karikalan.

“Let him complete what he was saying. Ayya! Why did you suspect Vandiya Devan in the first place?”

“I learned that Vandiya Devan too was present in Kadambur Palace when the meeting took place. But I later found out that he was not a part of the conspiracy.”

“Thatha! How did you get to know about this meeting in Kadambur?”

“I knew that Sambuverayar was inviting all the important lords and chieftains, yet I never got an invitation. I got suspicious. I laid a trap

and imprisoned Kunrathur Kezhavar^[162] when he was on his way back home. I interrogated him in my fort and got to know about the conspiracy. I also learned that Vandiya Devan and Sambuveryan's son, Kandanmaran are friends..."

"That's true. They both were together at the border. Since then they have been fast friends."

"I was not able to find out clearly whether Vandiya Devan was part of this conspiracy meeting. However, later I learned that he had escaped from Thanjavur Fort after stabbing his friend in the back. That proved that he was not associated with the conspirators."

"Thatha! I will never believe this tale. Vandiya Devan is capable of many things, but he would never stab anyone in the back."

"What if he had learned that his best friend was involved in a conspiracy against his Prince? Do you think he would have remained 'quiet' even then? What if Kandanmaran had wanted to engage him in this plot against you?"

"If that were the case, he would have stood up against his friend and fought face to face. He would never stoop to back stabbing."

"Be that as it may but Pazhuvetarayars are blaming Vandiya Devan for stabbing Kandanmaran and are hunting for him all over the kingdom. I am sure that some misunderstanding or the other must have forced these two friends to take up arms against each other, and that's how I was able to deduce that he was not involved in the conspiracy after all."

"Thatha! If Vandiya Devan joined our enemies, we would have been destroyed by now. So, there is your proof!" said Karikalan angrily.

“I agree with the Prince in this matter. Vandiya Devan would never betray us. I have only one problem with that man. He becomes mesmerized whenever he sees a beautiful woman. That is his only weakness,” said Parthibendran.

Aditya Karikalan smiled at this and said, “That’s why I sent him to Elayapirati after delivering my message to Chakravarthy. He just needs to meet the Princess once, and she would have a devoted slave in hand.”

Malayaman looked surprised when Karikalan told this and asked, “Oh! You sent him to Pazhaiarai? I didn’t know about this. Did you get any message from him after he left Thanjavur or did your sister send any message?”

“I am expecting news, at any moment.”

“Once Arulmozhi comes here, we will need to ask your sister to come here too. After that, we need not worry. We can leave all the problems in her capable hands and act as she commands.”

“Thatha! It looks like you are worse than Vandiya Devan in the matter of women.”

“Karikala! I have been following your sister’s orders ever since she was a child of two years. It is very much to your credit that she is so intelligent. You will not find another woman in our kingdom to match your sister in wit. Even our prime minister, Anirudha Bhramarayar, who is acknowledged to possess a brilliant mind, finds it beneficial to take advice from your sister,” spoke Malayamaan proudly.

But Parthibendran who was jealous of Vandiya Devan said, “All that is fine. But what if Vandiya Devan had seen some other woman

before he met Princess Kundavai. What if he had met that Pazhuvur Queen?” he deliberately murmured the last words so that only the Prince could hear them and predictably his friend’s countenance changed. The Prince looked furious enough to kill him.

Malayamaan did not hear his words and nor did he note his grandson’s reaction. He got up from his seat and said, “Parthibendra! You are leaving tomorrow to Elangai right? I will take my leave now. You young men will have a lot to discuss. I will make my way by foot to the palace. Do come back soon.”

After he had left, Parthibendran looked at the Prince and said, “My lord, I have known for a while that you are guarding a secret pain within your heart. And I also know that it is related to Pazhuvur queen? I have noticed your anger and the fury that you have kept within your heart, waiting to burst forth whenever we talk about Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s wife? How long are you going to hide this pain? You call me ‘your dear friend’ will you not share this secret sorrow with me, my Prince? Won’t you allow me to find a solution that would ease your pain? How long do I watch you struggle with your grief?”

Aditya Karikalan let out a long sigh and said, “My friend, this pain of mine has no balm, and there is no end to it. I will have to live with it until I breathe. However, it might ease my pain to share it with you. But not now, later tonight I will tell you about it. Let us go back to the palace with grandfather now.”



Chapter 54 – The Venom of a Woman

One of the old palaces of Pallava Kings was readied for the Crown Prince and his retinue. That night, Malayamaan left the palace to hear the story of Aravaan – the son of Arjuna at the Mahendra Mandapam. After a sumptuous dinner, Karikalan and Parthibendran sat on the terrace of the palace watching the beach and the harbour. They could hear the temple bells clanging along with the continuous roar of the sea waves.

“Look at thatha! He has gone to listen to the story of Aravaan despite the long journey that we undertook. I do not think that we will have even one tenth of his strength when we reach his age.”

“My Lord! Even you have started talking about old men and their past deeds. Tell me something, is there anything in the world that we cannot achieve. We can take ‘you’ as an example. I have not heard of another warrior or prince, who won battle scars at such a young age.”

“Parthibendra! You are a pure soul. You are incapable of duplicity, which is why you are my friend. But please do not praise me so much. Nothing can destroy a man, more than false vanity.”

“My Prince! If I am praising you, it is because you deserve it. If I need to pander for favors, then I could very well go to Thanjavur and tell Madhuranthakan that he is the bravest warrior I have ever seen. Now that is not only false but also a lie. If you ever see me shower praises undeservedly at someone, you are welcome to behead me

with that sword of yours. But the fact of the matter is that you do deserve the praise for being the youngest warrior in Chola dynasty, it would not be amiss if I were to compare you to your grandfather Prince Rajadhithan.”

“Parthibendra! Do not put me on the same pedestal as Rajadhithan. He was a warrior who was able to rout the massive army of Rashtrakutas with a tiny army. We can only aspire for a small part of his bravery. There are great warriors in all dynasties. What about the Pallavas? Can we ever see great kings like Mahendra Pallava and Narasimha Pallava ever again? Narasimha Pallava destroyed the Chalukya army completely and etched his name in history forever. Can we compare these people with anybody, at present? Look around you. These statues, temples, and beautiful stone monuments are the ones that stand the test of the time. What a great King Narasimha Pallava was? He built something spectacular and became a part of history. Are you not proud about these feats that your forefathers have achieved?”

“My Lord! A few moments ago, you told me that I praise you too much. But you forgot that I also point the mistakes that you make. I think you have become more obsessed with these statues, paintings, and architecture. My forefathers too were obsessed with it and look what happened to them? What did Mamallar do after he came back from Vathapi? He sat here making statues, while the Chalukyas mustered a large army and swept in to take revenge. They destroyed Kanchi and Uraiur. If Nedumara Pandiyan had not stopped them, the Chalukya victory would have been complete, and the Pallavas would have been completely destroyed,”

“You are wrong Parthibendra! I have not heard of a dynasty in the history that has continued forever. All kingly dynasties come to an end by some means. Lord Rama’s Ikshavaku dynasty too saw its end, one day and the same is true of kingdoms all over the world. Where the kings are strong, their dynasties flourish for a few centuries and then they disappear. Karikala Vallavan and Killivallavan were great Chola kings, whose great deeds are known today thanks to some poets who sang about their great deeds. However even we cannot discern if these poets wrote these songs after a bellyful of wine and ripe imagination. But Mahendra Pallava and Narasimha Pallava left their history and the record of their great deeds through art. That will ensure that they are never forgotten. Will we ever do what these great kings did? I doubt that. All that you and I have done is waged wars, killed people and destroyed things. Our names will be forgotten one day.”

Parthibendran looked at his friend in shocked silence. “My lord, what can I say? Your opinion about kings and wars is quite strange indeed, and I cannot argue with it. But I do know one thing. You are talking thus only because your heart is heavy with some unknown pain. Won’t you share this with me? Won’t you open your heart and show me?”

“Parthibendra! Who do you think resides within the depth of my heart?”

“That’s what I would like to find out.”

“You will not find what you expect. Not my parents, my dear sister, and brother or friends like you and Vandiya Devan. You will only find a venomous woman, a sinful creature, who shreds my heart to

pieces every single day. I have never opened my heart thus, to anybody in the world. You will be the first person to hear this story,” said Karikalan and sighed.

“My lord, I had somehow guessed that your pain is related to Pazhuvur queen. But how did this happen to you? How can you allow yourself to be attracted to a woman, who is somebody else’s wife? I have always found you treating all women with honor and respect. Today Pazhuvetarayar has become our enemy, but there was a time when he was our ally and the most respected Lord. How can you even think about his ‘wife’ like this?”

“I know I shouldn’t. Do you think I don’t know that? But I am helpless. And there is nothing that I can do, in this situation. And she did not gain a place in my heart after she became his wife. I knew her even before that. I tried to resist, forget and replace her in my heart but her venomous attraction prevails. I am talking as if, she is to blame for all my pain but in truth, I do not know. Maybe I should lay all the blame on God for separating us so cruelly.”

“My lord! How did you meet Nandini? Where and how?”

“It is a long story. Do you wish to hear it?”

“Yes. I do want to hear it. I cannot go to Elangai without hearing this secret grief that you carry in your heart. I want to bring peace to your bruised heart, my prince.”

“That is impossible Parthiba! Nothing can mend my heart. I will find no peace in this life or next. I will, however, tell you my story.”



Chapter 55 – Nandini's Lover

“I was twelve years old when I met Nandini for the first time. We were in Pazhaiarai then, and I was playing with my sister and brother near the lake. We heard our Periyapirati Sembiyanmadevi calling us. We went to the Kodi Veedu and told her about how we went boating on the lake. She was not alone. There were three other people along with her, and one of them was a girl who was about my age. Other two people were her parents. When we entered, they stopped talking and looked at us. I still remember her beautiful eyes, widened in surprise when she looked at us.”

Saying thus, Karikalan looked up the sky. A few clouds dotted the midnight blue stars, but his thoughts were somewhere in the past. Did he perchance see the face of the twelve-year-old Nandini out there? We do not know...

“Lord! What happened next?” asked Parthibendran.

“Kundavai told our grandmother about our game, and when she finished, Patti said, ‘Child! This is Nandini. She has come to Pazhaiarai just now. You can play with her in our garden. Would you like that? She will be a good companion to you.’ But for some reason, my sister did not like what she heard.

After we left the Kodi Veedu and went back to the palace, my sister said, “Anna! Did you see that girl? Did you notice how ugly she looked? Patti wants me to play with her, but I can’t help but laugh at her.’ I learned something very important that day, Parthiba! A

woman, no matter how beautiful she is, will always feel jealous of another woman's beauty.

“You know, among the women in my family, my sister is known for her beauty and grace. But she too felt jealous when she saw another beautiful girl. I argued with her and tried to irritate her, by praising Nandini's beauty. We fought for many months, and poor Arulmozhi was too young to understand why we argued incessantly.

Around that time, I left Pazhaiarai with my father to fight against the Pandyas. We fought and defeated the Elangai army that had come to their aid. Veera Pandyan went missing again. My father wanted to teach the Elangai king a lesson for interfering in our battles and for supporting the Pandyas. He wanted to send Kodumbalur Elaya Vellar to Elangai, and I helped him to rally troops, supplies and ships in Sethu Karai and left for Pazhaiarai after our army departed to Elangai.

“It was almost two years since I left Pazhaiarai. And I had forgotten all about the priest's daughter who had come from Madurai. When I met her again, I couldn't recognize her as the same girl. My sister too had grown up to be a beautiful young woman and surprise of surprises, they were both friends now. But now, Nandini would not talk to me freely or come in my presence without feeling shy. This irked me to no end. I tried to talk to her and met her frequently. I didn't know what was happening to me, but I found myself happy when she was with me. But many people did not like the fact that we were friends.

Ever since I came back, Kundavai started hating the girl again. And one day, our Patti, Sembiyanmadevi called me aside and said,

“Nandini is the daughter of a priest, while you are the son of the Emperor and the heir apparent. Now that you both have become mature, it is not right for you to meet her thus.”

Until then, I had the utmost respect for my Patti. But her words wounded and angered me to no end. I disregarded her warning and continued to meet Nandini, whenever possible. But it didn't last for long. Soon, Nandini's parents took her along with them to Pandya Nadu. I was devastated. I took all my frustration and anger out on my sister. Thankfully, I was called to battle the Rashtrakutas who had captured Thirumunaipadi and Thondaimandalam. That's where I met you.

“With the help of noble Malayamaan, we routed the enemy forces! We drove them away from our lands and captured Kanchi again. That's when we got bad news from Elangai. Our troops were overwhelmed, and Kodumbalur Elaya Vellar died in the battle. Our loss encouraged that coward, Veera Pandyan to come out of hiding and to rally troops to capture Madurai. Do you remember how furious I was when I heard that? We immediately went to Pazhaiarai to meet the King. My father's health was declining, and yet he was ready to go to war against the Pandyan. I stopped him and vowed to grace his presence again, only after I had beheaded Veera Pandyan. My father allowed me to join Budivikrama Kesari in battle, under his command and we left immediately dreaming of war and glory. Do you remember we met Periya Pazhuvetarayar on the way? He was disappointed that Budivikrama Kesari was made the commander.

“What a battle that was! It rouses my blood even now when I think about it! And it would not be an idle boast when we say that we were

peerless warriors. We defeated the Pandyan army and captured Madurai again. We wanted to kill every single Pandya soldier left alive. Veera Pandyan tried to escape again. His army of bodyguards, Abathuuthavigal were guarding him like a wall. They were the fiercest warriors that I have ever seen. They had sworn a holy oath to defend their king under any circumstances, and they fulfilled it. Not one of them escaped our swords and the dead bodies multiplied. But Veera Pandyan had escaped once again.”

“All our soldiers formed groups and started searching for the cowardly Pandyan along the banks of the Vaigai River. I didn’t sit still. I noticed hoof prints of a single horse along the banks of the river and soon I saw a trail of blood. Near the banks of the river, there was a small island, and a Vishnu temple stood amidst a garden grove. Next to that there were a few huts belonging to the priests. I don’t know whether you remember, but I told you and our soldiers not to enter or disturb the people in that island for any reason. Everybody thought that I didn’t want the soldiers to harm them. But that was not the only reason. I was protecting the woman who had stolen my heart.

“I had seen Nandini in the garden there one day. She looked different now. She had dressed her hair like Aandal and had decorated herself with beautiful flowers. When I asked her, “Why are you dressed like this?’ she said that she wanted to surrender herself to Lord Vishnu just like Aandal and dedicate her life to devotion and piety. I was aghast by her answer. But I didn’t have time to argue with her about this foolishness. I resolved to change her mind once the war was over. I asked her if she needed any help. She said, ‘My parents are here, and they are old. I have a brother, but right now he

has gone on a pilgrimage to Thirupathi. We are helpless people here, so please keep your soldiers away, lest they make any mischief.' I promised to give strict orders to my soldiers. After that, I met her few more times. My love for her had become a passion, and soon it grew ten-fold. Yet I sought to be patient. I wanted to fulfill my vow and take the head of Veera Pandyan to Pazhaiarai after which, I had hoped to ask my father's permission to marry Nandini."

"That was when I saw the prints of the hoof of the horse and the blood trail which took me inside the Garden Grove. There near the lotus pond, a horse was there. I unsheathed my sword and went near Nandini's hut and what did I see from the window? Parthiba! Veera Pandyan was lying in an old cot, and Nandini was giving him water to drink. Her beautiful face was lined with worry while her lovely eyes were filled with tears. My fury and wrath knew no bounds! I kicked the door open and went inside. Nandini immediately came towards and fell at my feet and said, 'Ayya! In the name of the love that you bore towards me once, I beseech you! Please do not hurt him.'"

"I asked her, 'Why do you wish to save this man? What is your relationship with him?'"

"She said, 'He is my lover and my God. He has agreed to marry an unfortunate creature like me.'"

"Whatever pity that I had felt when I looked at this cowardly king fled from my heart. That scoundrel! That wretch! How dare he try to steal the woman of my dreams?"

“I kicked Nandini aside and with a single stroke beheaded that snake. I can never forgive myself for that savage act. But at that moment, I was mad with fury. I turned back and looked at her once when I left the hut, and there she was staring at me with her unblinking eyes. I swear I have never such a look in anybody’s eyes. Her eyes reflected all the six passions that a man experiences – kama, krodha, lobha, moha, madha, marchariyam^[163]. Even today, I think back and wonder about it, but can’t unravel the meaning.

“By then, you had come in search of me along with some soldiers. When they saw Veera Pandyan’s head in my hands, they raised a victory roar that reverberated all around. But my heart was as heavy as the Vindya mountains...”



Chapter 56 – In the Anthapuram

Hundreds of years ago, King Mahendra Pallava, had built small mandapams all over his kingdom and tasked his royal bards to regale his citizens with stories from Mahabharatam. Due to the influence of Buddhism and Jainism in these parts, many people had embraced peace and passivity in their life. Anticipating an imminent Chalukya attack, the King wanted to remind people of the glories of war and victory and to that end, he had erected many small Mandapams all through his kingdom to make storytellers recite Mahabharatam and other war stories. Since then, these small Mandapams were called 'Bharatha Mandapam' and surprisingly even during the Chola age, Mahendra Pallava's edict of reading the great epic of Mahabharatam continued unbroken. Every evening, people thronged to these 'Bharatha Mandapams' to listen to the glorious war story. Some bards even sang beautiful songs composed in honour of the great heroes of the epic.

One of the stories that were oft-repeated was that of Aravaan – the son of Arjuna and Chitrangi, the Princess of Manipur. When Arjuna was on a pilgrimage, he married Chitrangi and has a son by her, called Aravaan. A brave warrior, Aravaan sets out to battle along with the Pandavas at the Kurukshetra. On the eve of the fight, it was customary to sacrifice a brave young warrior to propitiate the Gods, so that they grant them victory. Aravaan offered himself as a sacrifice and willingly loses his neck for the victory of Pandavas. The story of brave Aravaan has since captured the imagination of many and temples were raised for this glorious warrior all over the Chola

Kingdom. Next to Draupadi, who was venerated as a goddess, Aravaan was a most glorified hero among the Cholas.

That night Malayaman had gone all the way to the grand temple at the shore to listen to this story. Watching it from the balcony of their palace, Karikalan and Parthibendran noted that the performance had ended, and they could hear people shouting, “Long live Sundara Chola!” “Long Live Aditya Karikalar.”

“Looks like the story is finished. Malayamaan will be here soon,” said Karikalan.

“Aravaan story might have finished, but yours is not,” replied Parthibendran.

“Look at Malayamaan’s resolve and iron will! Even at this age, he has the patience to go in the middle of the night to listen to a story.”

“Is it so surprising, my lord? There are many doddering old men in this world, who can’t sleep in the night.”

“Don’t underestimate him, my friend. Do not place the noble Miladudaiyar along with all the doddering old men in the world. His experience in the battlefield is unparalleled, even today. I doubt if we would be alive to see his age and even if we did, we can’t match him in vigour and strength.”

“My Lord! There is a reason why old men like your grandfather are healthy.”

“And what would that be?”

“They do not fall prey to the mesmerizing attractions of young women. They do not lose their heart to a priest’s daughter and nurse

regrets all their life. If they liked some woman, they would go ahead and make them their own, without any regrets...”

“Parthiba! I do not believe that Nandini was a priest’s daughter. There is some mystery about her birth.”

“Does it matter whose daughter she is? She can be a priest’s daughter or the king’s daughter, for all I care. Look at what that old man, Pazhuvetarayar did? He saw her somewhere and the next thing we know that he had dragged her all the way back to his Anthapuram and added her to his long list of wives.”

“Yes, I am surprised by it.”

“Surprised by what? How this old man became bewitched by her?”

“No. I am surprised by Nandini’s action. At one time, she pledged by all things holy that she loved me. Then she tried to save Veera Pandyan’s life saying that she loved him. How did she agree to marry this Pazhuvetarayar? I still can’t believe it.”

“I am not surprised, my lord. But I am taken aback by your actions. That coward, Veera Pandyan who still called himself ‘veera^[164]’ after running away from the battle; how could you not punish the woman who tried to protect and hide him? You should have either killed her right there, or you should have imprisoned her. You didn’t do either. You just left her there...I remember now. You brought out Veera Pandyan’s head from the hut, and we were all cheering madly. When I heard someone crying from inside the hut, I asked you who it was and you said, ‘some woman from the temple priest’s family. They are scared and frightened. Let no one go inside the hut.’ I didn’t think much of it, and we were more interested in celebrating our victory.

You came along with us, but I remember now that you looked distraught and pained. You did not participate in the victory celebrations. I even wondered whether you had got hurt in the battle.”

“I was hurt not in the body, but my heart was bleeding Parthiba. I couldn’t forget the scene where Nandini came to me with folded hands, beseeching me to spare Veera Pandyan’s life. I berated myself for not listening to her. Why didn’t I grant her that wish? Why did I have to push her away and slice that snake’s head? If only I could give life to that scoundrel through some magic or by sacrificing my own life, I would have done that... but I couldn’t. Parthiba! We talk about our valour and boast around saying that there is nothing in this world that we cannot achieve. Some say that kings are God’s embodiments on earth but are we truly Gods? Can we restore the life of those who have died? No. We are only capable of taking lives!”

“I think it’s a good thing that you do not have this power. Just imagine what would have happened if you had restored Veera Pandyan’s life. He would have escaped, yet again and the war would have dragged on, all because of one woman’s false tears.”

“Pallava! You are an unfortunate creature who has never known what it is to ‘love.’”

“True. I have never fallen prey to any woman’s charms. But the same cannot be said about our dear friend Vandiya Devan who finds just about any woman, charming. That’s probably why you like him more than me. Isn’t that true, my Prince?”

“Aha! Finally, you have brought the topic around to Vandiya Devan, and I was just wondering why you have forgotten about him so long.”

“I know that you hate to hear the truth about him. Tell me what happened next? Did you meet Nandini again? How did she end up becoming Pazhuvetarayar’s wife?”

“That night, after the victory celebrations our camp was silent and sleeping but I couldn’t rest. I wanted to meet her and ask her forgiveness. I was also angry with her and wanted to berate her for falling in love with my enemy. I silently left the camp and rode towards the small island temple. But alas, all the huts in the island had been destroyed in a fire. I found an old couple sitting beside Nandini’s hut crying and beating their chests. They were Nandini’s old parents who had brought her to Pazhaiarai, all those years ago. They recognized me and came towards me.

In the beginning, I couldn’t understand what they were trying to say. I tried to console them and learn what happened there. They had gone to a neighboring village to visit their eldest daughter, who was pregnant. They had wanted Nandini to come with them, but she had refused. When they came back, they heard that some men were trying to burn a woman alive in the nearby woods. They rushed back home to the island and found the hut burning and empty and Nandini was missing. They cried asking me to tell them about their missing daughter. For many years, I had doubted the fact whether they were really her parents, and at that moment, I knew for sure that they were not. No parent would leave his or her daughter alone in a war-torn region to go away somewhere. My heart was burning, and I felt tormented by grief and guilt. I shouted at them saying that she was

dead and cursed them to hell. By the break of dawn, I was back at the camp, and no one ever knew that I had left.”

“Yes, my lord, no one knew, and you didn’t find me fit enough to reveal your innermost thoughts. Is this your friendship, my prince? I had often prided myself to be your close confidante, but I never knew that you were hiding your secret grief thus within the narrow confines of your heart. If this had happened to me, I wouldn’t have remained silent, my Prince.”

“But it didn’t happen to you Parthiba! And who knows how you might have acted if this had happened to you.”

“My lord, what happened next? Did you meet Nandini again before she married that old man?”

“If I had met her earlier, she wouldn’t have married Pazhuvetarayar. We were away when Pazhuvetarayar got married. Do you remember how distasteful we found the news of his marriage, to a young woman old enough to be his granddaughter? At that time, I had no inkling as to whom he had married. After a few days, there were talks about announcing me as the next heir apparent and crowning me as the Yuvaraj^[165]. My grandmother, Sembiyanmadevi, and my father wanted to declare my right to the throne without any delay. She was afraid that someone might instigate Madhuranthakan to stake a claim to the throne. I became the heir apparent, and they gave me the title of ‘Parakesari’ and along with it the right to engrave my royal titles in stone. My father said to me, ‘from this day on, this kingdom is yours.’ All the ruling lords, chieftains, commanders and

the people, accepted this. I had forgotten my sorrow about Nandini in all this but not for long. Something happened there that has remained etched in my heart, ever since.”

“After the ceremony, the Emperor took me to the anthapuram. I sought the blessings of all royal mothers and noble women there. Behind me, my brother and the Pazhuvur brothers had come. I spotted my sister and her companions there smiling at me gracefully. But among all their faces, I could only see one woman’s face. She was there, well and fine while I had drowned myself in sorrow thinking that she had perished in the fire. How did she come there, I wondered? She looked so resplendent dressed in silks and jewels that it made me ask myself whether I was dreaming her presence. But she was real and bewitching and looked every inch a queen. In those few moments, I dreamt of a happy life with her. I really believed that the day when this kingdom became mine might be the day when all my heart’s wishes would come true. While I was building castles in the air, my mother Vanama Devi came forward to bless me. That’s when my father shouted aloud and fell down in a dead faint. It was chaotic for a while, as they carried him to the inner chambers and tried to revive him. He woke up soon and was advised to rest.

I took my sister aside and asked her, ‘How did Nandini come here?’ And that’s when I heard the news that Nandini was Pazhuvetarayar’s wife, and I felt as if some had stabbed me in the heart. My friend! I have been wounded many times in many battles, but none of those injuries can compare to the pain that I felt when I learned the truth.” Saying thus, he kept his hand on his heart.



Chapter 57: Maya Mohini

Right from the time, when Aditya Karikalan had started his story, Parthibendran had been listening to him albeit without much sympathy. But when his friend held his heart, he could actually experience his pain, and his eyes grew moist.

“My Prince! I never knew that one can undergo so much sorrow and suffering from a mere woman. I never realized the agony that your heart must have felt on your coronation ceremony. I remember feeling surprised to see you downcast and upset. We tried to make merry and cheer you by talking about the future of this kingdom under your reign.”

“Yes. You tried to cheer me by talking about the great heights that this kingdom would soar up to under my reign. You dreamed of expanding the kingdom all the way to the Himalayas and across the sea beyond Elangai and other places but you had no clue about the state of my heart. Later, one day, Nandini sent me an invitation to visit at her palace. I was in a dilemma whether to accept her invitation or not but I finally decided to meet her. I wanted to ask her many questions. I wanted to know the secret of her birth. I felt that there was some connection between my father fainting on that day and her presence in the anthapuram. If you recall, since that day, my father’s health declined steadily. I knew instinctively that there was some mystery connected with her birth, and I wanted to learn more about it. But within the heart of my hearts, I knew that they were all mere excuses just to see her again. I was going to meet her only

because of her seductive allure. Pazhuvetarayar was not there, and there was no one to stop me at his palace. Everybody thought that I had gone there to get the blessings of the old womenfolk in his palace.

I met her in the beautiful lata mandapam behind her palace. Parthiba! You must have heard of whirlpools and large currents that exist in the sea. They are immensely powerful, and many are potent enough to suck even a big ship down its vortex. That's how I felt in her presence. I felt myself losing everything that I held precious - my life, my heart, and my soul. I poured out words that shame me to this day. My heart tried to stop me, 'What is this you are saying?' but I couldn't stop myself from saying those words that I regret to this day.

She expressed her happiness about me becoming the heir apparent.

'I am not happy about it,' I said.

She asked, 'Why?'

'What sort of question is that? How will I be happy? You have betrayed me in the worst way possible,' I said. She acted as if she didn't understand my words while I poured my heart out. I berated her for betraying me, for loving Veera Pandyan, for trying to save his life, for marrying Pazhuvetarayar ...

'Prince! You first killed the love that I had for you. Later you killed the man who had pledged to marry me. I doubt if your heart would be at peace until you have got rid of me. You are free to kill me now. There is no one to stop you.' Saying thus, she took out a small dagger from her waist and held it in her hand for me.

'Why would I kill you? You are one who is killing me with your words.'

In the end, I told her something that shames me to this day. 'It is not too late. You just have to leave this old man and come to me. I will take you away. I am ready to sacrifice this kingdom, for your sake. We can take a ship to a faraway land and forge a new life.'

She laughed hard at my words. 'What are we to do in that far away land? Will we survive by selling wood and vegetables?'

'You are right. You won't like that. 'You' who was brought up in a priest's house is now the Pazhuvur queen. Why would you like it?'

'Prince! I am not happy being the queen of a mere lord. I intend to become the Empress. If you want me, you can kill both the Pazhuvur brothers and send your father to the prison and then take me as your queen.' I was horrified by her words. 'Ayyo! You are saying such terrible things.'

'Terrible! You don't know the meaning of that word, Prince! Wasn't it terrible to cut the throat of a wounded man who was lying on the bed?'

My anger knew no bounds when she spoke of the Pandyan. I don't remember clearly what all I said, but I cursed her terribly and left the place. But before I left, she said, 'My Prince! Come back to me whenever you change your mind about making me your queen.'"

After listening to Nandini's terrible words, Parthibendran was incensed with anger, "My Prince! She truly is a demoness to say such words. It's a good thing that you didn't meet her after that."

"It is true that I didn't see her, but she is forever in my thoughts. Pallava! She is around me at all times, tormenting, laughing, crying and pleading. Sometimes she is seductive, wanting to embrace and

kiss me, while on other occasions, she has a dagger in her hand wanting to stab me. Sometimes she is in front of me with her hair dishevelled, crying and beating her chest and other times, she is laughing aloud like a mad woman. Oh! God! That woman never leaves me alone. This evening, grandfather gave many reasons as to why I should not go to Thanjavur but the real reason why I am not going there is Nandini.

“My Prince! You are not going there just because of a mere woman? What do you fear from her? Do you think she will poison you through trickery?”

“No Parthiba! No! You still have not understood me. I am not afraid of her trying to kill me but I fear her seductive allure. I am afraid I might lose my mind in her presence and do all those things that she commands me, ‘Put your father in the prison,’ ‘Banish your sister,’ ‘Kill the Pazhuvur brothers and make me your queen.’ My friend! The only solution to this is that either I should die, or she should die, or we both should die. I will never find peace in this world otherwise.”

“My Lord! Why are you saying thus? Why should you die? Give me leave to go to Thanjavur. I will go to Elangai later. Let me go to Thanjavur and kill this woman for you. I don’t care if I am struck with Sthreehithidosham^[166]”

“If you do anything of that sort, I will consider you as my prime enemy. If Nandini has to die, I will do the deed myself with mine own hands. I will kill her and then kill myself too. I can’t bear it if someone tries to harm her.”

“My friend! You forget all this. Forget about Nandini. Go to Elangai tomorrow. Convince my brother to come back here. Let him be here with grandfather. Let them make plans to counter the plot of the chieftains and lords. We will leave for Elangai and conquer it and go beyond the sea to capture many other kingdoms beyond it. We will expand the kingdom’s border and spread the fame of Cholas all the way up to the Kingdom of Arabia. Do you know in that kingdom, kings can drag any woman they like and put her in the anthapuram?”

Before Parthibendran could reply to this, Thirukovallur Malayaman came there.

“I haven’t heard a more glorious tale than that of Aravaan. You won’t find it even in those kingdoms that you were mentioning a little while ago. But why are you two still awake? Parthibendra! Have you forgotten that you are leaving for Elangai tomorrow?”

“All this while, we were discussing my journey to Elangai, Thatha.” He said.



Ponni's Beloved Volume 2 – The Storm

An Excerpt from The Storm

Chapter 1 – Poonguzhali

The waves washed gently against the shore and receded, marking a peaceful dusky evening in Kodi Karai^[167]. The sky was dotted with birds flying back home across the pristine white sands of the soft beach. In the woods near the beach, the air seemed still, and the sun was fast sinking behind a veil of clouds.

A small boat, its oars being plied by a young woman, made its way towards the shore. She reminds us of Senthan Amuthan's description of his uncle's daughter Poonguzhali.

Yes, she is indeed Poonguzhali. Perhaps to justify her beautiful name, she had decorated her hair with a flower and her lovely curly tresses fell in cascades upon her shoulders. An attractive necklace of shells adorned her neck but indeed, it seemed pleasing to the eye only because she wore it.

What could be more alluring than a beautiful maiden plying a boat? Surely, it would be her melodious voice. Sitting languidly on the boat, she sang a haunting song about the sea and it seemed as if the wind stood still to listen to her honeyed voice. Even the sinking sun stood still for a while before ushering in the night.

While the waves of the sea are placid and gentle,
why does the sea within me surge and rise?
When the mother earth sleeps in peace,
why should my heart rise in anguish?

Even the birds of the forest search for their nests!

Hunters and archers seek their homes too!

When the heaven and earth are enveloped in peace
why is a storm stirring within the heart of that doe-eyed girl?

The sea will stand still and the breeze will crawl in,
But why does the wind swirl so strong in that girl's heart?

Listening to her, one wonders what sorrow this young maiden might be hiding in the deepest recess of her heart that seemed to give such a poignant tinge of sadness to her voice.

The song ended as she neared the shore. Reaching the beach, she nimbly got out of the boat and pulled it behind her, deftly securing it and let it rest near the many other boats tied there. She looked around the beach and spotted the light from the lighthouse that acted as a beacon warning ships lest they come too near the shore. Beyond the woods, a temple stood hidden among the trees.

Two hundred years ago, Sundaramurthy Nayanar^[168] had come to Kodi Karai Kuzhagar temple^[169] and had sung his famous Devaram^[170] about how Lord Shiva stood alone amidst the sea and the beach.

My Lord! Why are you here all alone on this lonely beach? This place isn't worthy of you! You are needed in a place where throngs

of devotees would place their offerings at your divine feet and not on a lonely stretch of beach.

Yet even after two hundred years, Kodi Karai still remains a secluded stretch of beach, sand and woods at the time of our story. The thick forest that surrounded the temple was populated with wild animals and hooting owls, making it more dangerous than it was two hundred years ago. There was, however, one difference. Two hundred years ago, there was no lighthouse here it had been built during the reign of Emperor Paranthakan I and since then it had become a home for a few families who took care of the lighthouse and the temple.

Poonguzhali looked around her and thought of going towards the lighthouse and then she saw the temple Gopuram^[171] of Kuzhagar temple and decided to go there instead. As she made the decision, the temple bells started ringing melodiously.

Why am I going home so early? Let me visit the temple. I can ask the Battar^[172] to sing divine devaram songs and then take the prasadam^[173] home.

Deciding thus, she walked quickly towards the temple. On the way, she saw a herd of deer running towards the forest. Among them was a lovely young deer, graceful and childlike. Poonguzhali's enthusiasm knew no bounds when she saw the herd. She ran along with them as if she was going to catch them but no matter how fast you run, you cannot really compete with the agility of the deer. The herd overtook her and ran gracefully ahead.

At one place, all the deer collectively leapt as if they were escaping from a dangerous deep pool but one of the smaller ones fell in the

middle. Sinking in the quicksand, it tried to claw its way up but moaned piteously when the attempt failed. The mother deer and the rest of the herd had stopped running and were watching the small deer worriedly but they couldn't help the young one.

Poonguzhali immediately set about to help the small doe. She noted carefully where the quicksand ended and approached the place where the deer was stuck. The herd and the mother deer looked at her suspiciously not knowing her intentions. Softly, she cooed at them with a strange sound and that seemed to reassure them. She bent over the quicksand pool and grabbed the little deer's legs and pulled it to safety. The little deer stood trembling from fear for some time and then turned around and ran to its mother for succour and comfort. Soon the entire herd started running at breakneck speed.

"Such ungrateful creatures!" she exclaimed and then comforted herself saying, "Though they are certainly better than humans who are worse than ungrateful."

She started walking towards Kuzhagar temple into the forest. The thick grove of the forest was so dense that strangers who are unfamiliar with the terrain could easily get lost and roam around clueless for long. Nestled amidst the trees stood the old temple looking a bit desolate and deserted. She entered the temple and went straight to the inner sanctum. The temple priest looked at her in surprise and smiled. Visitors hereabouts were rare and attractive young boat girls were more than welcome.

After she finished her prayers, the priest gave her a coconut and the prasadam to eat and said, "Will you wait for a while? I will come along with you."

“I will wait for you ayya^[174]! I am in no hurry.”

Saying thus, she came out and nimbly climbed on one of the trees to hoist herself on the temple walls. Along the walls, there was a statue of Nandi^[175], the bull. Sitting with her back on the considerable bulk of Nandi, she leisurely ate the coconut and the temple prasadam.

As darkness enveloped the temple as dusk set in, she heard horses galloping. She looked intently at the direction of the sound and her heart stirred with a long-gone memory that threatened to choke her with an indescribable sorrow.

Who is coming here? What do I care who it is? There are too many strangers coming around here these days, citing royal duties. Yesterday too, two people had come wanting to go to Elangai. They looked so disgusting but Anna took them on his boat after they gave him a bag full of gold coins. May thunder fall upon their gold! Who wants it here? What purpose can gold serve when you are living amidst a forest? But Anna and Anni's world revolves around money. They just want more and more!

As the sound of galloping horses came closer, she noted that there were two riders. It looked as though if they had travelled a long distance. The man on the first horse was quite young, handsome, broad-chested and looked like a soldier. However, when compared with another face that she had enthroned in her heart, she found him downright ugly. On second thoughts, his face looked like an owl!

As readers might have guessed, the first man on the horse is our hero, Vandiya Devan. Behind him came the physician's son who had accompanied him from Pazhaiaarai. They both were saddle sore and

weary, yet Vandiya Devan's face lit up when he saw Poonguzhali lounging atop the temple wall, carelessly eating the coconut. When he saw that she too was looking eagerly at his face, his enthusiasm knew no bounds. He stopped the horse and looked at her with a smile. If he had known that she had been comparing his face to that of an owl, he might not be so enthusiastic to talk to her. Thankfully, God found it worthwhile to make humans hide their innermost thoughts from others.

When Poonguzhali realized that the man on the horse was staring at her, she immediately jumped down on the soft sand of the temple and started running along the temple wall.

When Vandiya Devan saw her running, he too got down from his horse and started after her. Now, who can divine why she felt like running away from a man who was staring at her or what prompted Vandiya Devan to take off after her. We can only conclude that each one of them was following their natural instincts in the order of the world.



[\[1\]](#) Cholas were the longest ruling dynasties in South India. Earliest Chola Kings of recorded history were from 3rd Century inscriptions of Maurya Emperor Ashoka. The Chola dynasty produced many great kings who were known for their good governance, military command and piety. They were also avid builders and patrons of art, which enabled them to leave a lasting legacy, through the temples that they built all over South India.

[\[2\]](#) Built in the 10th century by Prince Rajadithya Chola during 907 – 955 AD, this is a 16-kilometer dam located in the Cuddalore district of today's Tamil Nadu. Today, it is one of the water reservoirs that is used to supply water to Chennai.

[3] Present day name for Veeranayarana Lake built during the 10th century by the Chola Prince Rajadhithya.

[4] In Tamil Calendar the month of Aadi is from mid-July to mid-August.

[5] Built in the 10th century by Prince Rajadithya Chola during 907 – 955 AD, this is a 16-kilometer dam located in the Cuddalore district of today's Tamil Nadu. Today, it is one of the water reservoirs that is used to supply water to Chennai.

[6] Also pronounced as 'Bana'. Banas were a dynasty in South India who claimed descent from the legendary asura Mahabali.

[7] The titular name assumed by the Prince of Vanars (Bana).

[8] Son of King Paranthaka I, he died in the Thakollam (present day Arakonam) war that was fought against the Rashtrakutas.

[9] Present day Arakonam near Vellor District of Tamil Nadu.

[10] A respectful term in Tamil used to address men.

[11] An area in present day Tiruchi (Tamil Nadu) Uraiyur was the capital of ancient Cholas.

[12] Kanchi or Kanchipuram is 72 Km from present day Chennai (Tamil Nadu capital). Historically Kanchi was the capital of Pallava Kings and a center of education, art and architecture.

[13] A tributary of River Kaveri.

[14] A city in South India, Thanjavur was the historical capital of Chola Kings. Home to many iconic temples, the city is the most important center of South Indian art, architecture and heritage.

[15] Paranthaka II was the son of Aringzha Chola and the grandson of Paranthaka I. Though he was named after his grandfather, he was so handsome that his subjects lovingly called him 'Sundara' which means 'beautiful' in Tamil. In Ponni's beloved, Sundara Chola is the Emperor of Chola Kingdom and the father of Prince Aditya Karikalan (Crown Prince), Princess Kundavai and Prince Arulmozhivarman.

[16] 'Pirati' is a respectful way to address a noble lady in the South. 'Elaya' means 'young' in Tamil. Since Princess Kundavai was a young woman, everybody addressed her thus.

[17] Kadambur is a Panchayat town in Kovilpatti taluk of the Thoothukudi district in the present Indian state of Tamil Nadu.

[18] Vaishnavan was someone who exclusively worshipped Lord Vishnu and held him in regard high above any other God. Staunch Vaishnavaites wear the mark of Vishnu in 12 places on their body and refrain from worshipping Lord Shiva in any form.

[19] Sacred ash from burning dried wood. Worshippers of Shiva apply this sacred ash on their foreheads as three horizontal lines.

[20] Saivars worshipped Lord Shiva and were staunch devotees who strictly followed the traditions of their saints. They wore the mark of Shiva on their body and refrained from worshipping Lord Vishnu or any of his avatars.

[21] Someone who followed the edicts of Adi Shankaracharya and has renounced all worldly desires.

[22] Vishnu is the preserver and sustainer of life according to Hindu Mythology and one of the main male deities of Hindus.

[23] Brahma is the God of Creation according to Hindu Mythology.

[24] Shiva is the destroyer of evil who is depicted as an omniscient Yogi who lives on Mount Kailash.

[25] Described in the great epic Ramayana as the King of Sri Lanka who abducted Sita, the Wife of Prince Rama. Prince Rama later defeated the King at an epic battle in Sri Lanka with the help of the monkey army of King Sugreeva of Kishkinta.

[26] Brahman as described in Hindu Upanishads is the ultimate, unchanging reality and is composed of pure being and consciousness.

[27] Gopis were the cow herding girls who were Lord Krishna's companions while he was growing up in Vrindavan.

[28] Literally 'Thambi' means 'younger brother' in Tamil. It is also used to address men who are younger than one's self.

[29] Celestial abode of God Vishnu where he lived with his consort Goddess Lakshmi (Goddess of wealth). Hindu Puranas say that Vaikundam is located near the Capricorn constellation.

[30] A folk-dance performance. An informal dance structure where the performers recreated stories from Ramayana, Mahabharata and Tamil epic classics.

[31] Located in present day Kattumannarkoil in Cuddalore district of Tamil Nadu, this is a Vishnu Temple and was built in early 9th century much before the time our story starts. A pilgrim spot for staunch Hindus, there are many stone inscriptions about ancient Cholas in this temple.

[32] Andal is a female saint who is much revered and respected in the Vaishnava tradition. Popular tradition says that she was found by a Saint name Periyalvar in the temple garden of Srivilliputhur (near present day Virudhunagar district in Tamil Nadu). Periyalavar brought up the child as his own and named her 'Kodhai'. From a very young Kodhai was dedicated to the worship of Lord Vishnu and dreamed of marrying him. She composed many fervent works where she begs the Lord to

come to her and claim her as his bride. She wrote Thirupavai and Nachiar Thirumozhi that are still recited by the devotees of Vaishnava tradition.

[33] Inner sanctum of a temple.

[34] Poems from Saint Aandal's Thirupavai where she pleads with Lord Vishnu to claim her as his bride.

[35] The capital of the Bana Kingdom as described in the Sangam Literature. The ancient kingdom of Banas called 'Perumbanappadi' lies in present day Andhra Pradesh in India.

[36] Literal meaning 'uncle'. It is also used as a term to address elders who are close to one's family.

[37] Women's living quarters within the palace.

[38] Cheras were the ancient dynasty that ruled over parts of Tamil Nadu and Kerala. When they were in power, they were in constant conflict with the Cholas and Pandyas.

[39] The Hindu God of War also known as Karthikeya, Skanda and Subramanya. He was the Commander-in-Chief of the Devas in their war against the Asuras. He is also known as the Son of Shiva. Lord Muruga is a very popular deity worshipped in South India where he has six important temples.

[40] A couple who performed a war dance in the Kadambur Palace.

[41] A Hindu temple priest who performs temple rituals.

[42] Principal form of Mother Goddess in Hinduism. There are many incarnations of Goddess Durga and she is known to the embodiment of pure energy in Hindu lore.

[43] One of the clans in the Chola Kingdom. King Aringzha Chola (King Sundara Cholas' father) married Princess Kalyani from this clan after being enamoured by her beauty.

[44] An ancient Tamil name for Sri Lanka, which is still being used.

[45] King of Ayodhya and the father of Prince Ram in Ramayana.

[46] Believed to be the seventh incarnation of Lord Vishnu, Rama was the first son of King Dasaratha who was exiled by his father for 14 years.

[47] A title used to address highly respected older noblewomen in royal families.

[48] A South Indian dynasty that ruled over South India with Kanchipuram as their capital. Noted as patrons of art and architecture that can still be seen in Mahabalipuram and Kanchipuram.

[49] A Rashtrakuta kingdom near the River Krishna.

[50] Rules of ancient warfare.

[51] A mythical kingdom ruled by women warriors where men were subservient to women.

[52] One of the noblemen/chieftains in Chola Empire.

[53] A tributary of the River Kaveri.

[54] Presently known as Palar River it rises in Nandi Hills in Karnataka and flows through Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu.

[55] Refers to present day Coorg in Karnataka.

[56] Beautiful supernatural female beings who were youthful, elegant and lovely. According to Hindu mythology, Apsaras lived in the court of Lord Indra (God of the Devas).

[57] A Classical string musical instrument.

[58] A clan that ruled over the present day Pudukottai area during the rule of Cholas.

[59] Literally means 'older sister' in Tamil language and is used to address women who are slightly older than one's self.

[60] Avvayar is one of the most famous Tamil poets who lived during the golden Sangam period. According to popular myths Avvayar became an old woman even when she was a young girl after she took the blessings of Lord Muruga to avoid getting married.

[61] Literally translated this means 'astrologer who lives in Kudanthai'. A secondary character in this novel, Kalki never reveals his name hence he is called Kudanthai Jodhidar all through the book.

[62]

[63] A form of address for Goddess Durga. Most Astrologers worship Durga as their patron Goddess.

[64] An erstwhile capital of medieval Cholas situated near Thanjavur. This was the final resting place of King Raja Chola.

[65] The holy mark of Conch and Discus that signifies the power of Lord Vishnu according to the ancient art of Palmistry and a mark of kingship.

[66] Hindu God denoting Planet Jupiter. Also known as 'Guru' Brihaspati is the God of wisdom.

[67] Hindu Goddess of learning and arts. One of the most significant Goddesses in Hindu mythology, Saraswathi is invoked daily in the prayers by students to bless them with knowledge.

[68] Arjuna or Arjun was one of the Pandava brothers in Mahabharata who was a great archer and warrior.

[69] Also known as Kamadeva, Manmadan is the God of Love.

[70] Vermillion used by Hindu women. Hindu families in South India offer vermillion to women (unmarried and married) who visit their homes as a token of respect.

[71] Food that is offered to the Hindu Gods during the prayer. Hindus worship Gods with flowers and fruits. Flowers are used to decorate the God/Goddess while fruits are offered as an offering to appease his/her appetite. Prasadam that is offered can be fruits, sweets, rice etc.

[72] Lord Krishna's female companions who were milkmaids in Vrindavan.

[73] An Asura (Demon) who prayed to Lord Shiva and received a unique power to burn up anybody and turn them into ashes if he placed his hand on their head. Gleeful that he got such a great boon from Lord Shiva, he sought to test it out on him. Aghast that his devotee could turn the boon on its giver, Shiva fled from the Asura who pursued him through the three worlds. In the end, Shiva sought out Vishnu for help. Vishnu transformed into Mohini (a beautiful alluring woman) to distract the asura. The asura fell in love with Mohini and entreated her to marry him. Mohini however told him that she would marry him only if he agreed to dance with her and match her step for step. Mohini began the dance and the Asura maddened with lust danced along with her imitating her steps. During the dance, Mohini placed her hand above her head and performed a step and the Asura unmindful of the consequences, did the same and burned up.

[74] Story of destruction of three powerful asuras (demons) by Lord Shiva.

[75] Tamil poet saints of South India whose devotion for Lord Vishnu was absolute. They are venerated by the Vaishnavaites and many of their poems on Lord Vishnu are sung every day in Vishnu temples.

[76] Group of 63 Tamil poet saints of South India who worshipped Lord Shiva. Literally translated 'Nayanmars' means 'Hounds of Shiva'. Nayanmars and Azhvars were in the forefront of the Bhakti movement that took place in South India from 7th Century AD to 15 Century AD.

[77] A suburb near Tiruchirappalli (Present day Tiruchy) in Tamil Nadu.

[78] A celestial nymph of the Devas Ramba was a beautiful apsara who was also the Queen of Apsaras.

[79] Urvashi was a celestial nymph of the Devas. She was considered to be the most beautiful apsara in Indra's celestial court.

[80] Also known as Shachi, Indrani is the wife of Indra (King of the Devas).

[81] Presently known as Tirumala, this is the town where the sacred seven hills of Lord Balaji are present. At the top of the hills in Tirumala, is Tirupathi the temple town of Lord Balaji, the most popular and holy temple in India.

[82] According to Hindu texts there are four orders of women who have different types of characteristics and body types.

[83] The Aani month falls in Tamil Calendar from 15 June to 15 July.

[84] Puratasi month falls in Tamil Calendar from September 17 – October 16.

[85] Also known as 'Big Dipper' today, Saptarishi literally means 'seven rishis (ascetic sages)'. According to Hindu mythology seven rishis were the mind born sons of Lord Brahma who later became stars.

[86] An ancient game played with a wooden board and sea shells.

[87] A decorative plate on which camphor is lit to perform the end ritual of the pooja. It is also performed to welcome an esteemed guest and to bid farewell to soldiers who left home for war.

[88] Performing prayers in Hindu religion.

[89] Literally means 'sacrifice', a Yagna is a ritual pooja where priests offer libations into the sacred fire as an offering for the Gods.

[90] A sign or gesture made with the hands and fingers usually used in the Classical forms of dance such as Bharatnatyam.

[91] In Hindu mythology, the first of the ten reincarnations of Vishnu was the form of a giant fish where he saves the Vedas and the seven divine rishis from the great deluge.

[92] Literally means 'God' in Tamil. It is also used to refer to one's master.

[93] A memorial temple built for war heroes in ancient Tamil Nadu.

[94] A small town near the present day Thanjavur in Tamil Nadu.

[95] A great Chola King who ruled during the Sangam period (190 AD). He was one of the greatest Chola kings who brought the entire Sri Lanka under the Chola reign.

[96] One of the early Chola Kings.

[97] Language of people of Ellangai (Sri Lanka).

[98] The oldest of the Pandava brothers, King Yudhistra is also known as Dharma, the righteous in the epic Mahabharata.

[99] Emperor Sundara Chola's father.

[100] Emperor Sundara Chola's mother who was known for her beauty.

[101] Presently a town in Thanjavur District in Tamil Nadu. Thiruvaiyaru is a temple town that is renowned for its association to many poet saints.

[102] Literally means 'King'.

[103] A seed that is used as Hindu prayer beads. Worn by Shiva devotees, the word Rudraksha literally means Shiva's teardrops.

[104] Northern most part of present Tamil Nadu was called Thondai Mandalam.

[105] An elite army of bodyguards whose sole aim was to protect the King.

[106] A traditional South Indian sweet made from jaggery.

[107] Hindu Goddess of Love and wife of Kamadeva (called as Manmathan in Tamil).

[108] An ancient Indian practice of wedding where a Princess could choose her own groom from an assembly of Princes and Kings. In some Swayamvaras the bride's father would prescribe a test of arms and those who win in the test won the bride. In Ramayana, Rama had to break a bow to win Sita as his bride. In Mahabharat, Arjuna needed to pass an archery test to win Draupadi as his wife.

[109] The holy mountain of Kailash, which is supposedly the abode of Lord Shiva and Parvati.

[110] Literally means 'older brother'. It is also used to call those who are slightly older than us.

[111] Palm leaves used to write messages.

[112] Various regions in ancient South India.

[113] Means danger in Tamil (Vandiya Devan warned of Abaayam to the King but cleverly changed it to Abayam when Pazhuvetarayar questions about it).

[114] The legendary white elephant that King of Devas (King of Gods) Indra possessed.

[115] One of the nine planets in Hindu tradition, Rahu is the severed head of an asura. According to Hindu mythology it is Rahu that swallows the Sun causing an eclipse.

[116] A seventh century Tamil poet saint who wrote countless poems praising different forms of Shiva.

[117] An ancient town during the Sangam period that disappeared during a Tsunami around 300 BC.

[118] Literally means 'I am at your service' in Tamil.

[119] A hall of pictures drawn and painted on the walls.

[120] Second wife of King Gandaradithar and mother of Madhuranthakan.

[121] Literally means 'young queen' in Tamil.

[122] A small open cottage built in a garden adorned with flowers and creepers.

[123] Literally means sorcerer.

[124] Lord Krishna's cherished companion and milkmaid in Vrindavan.

[125] The Princess of Vidharbha who eloped with Krishna and became his first wife.

[126] Second most important wife of Lord Krishna, she was the daughter of Satrajit.

[127] Second son of King Dasaratha and Rama's brother. Bharatha's mother Queen Kaikeyi secured two boons from Dasarath and exiled Rama and tried to crown Bharatha as the King. However, Bharatha who was devoted to Rama refused his mother's plans and tried to bring Rama back from exile.

[128] Bhima was the second son of King Pandu and the strongest Pandava brother.

[129] Chinna Pazhuvetrayar's given name.

[130] Western part of South India that includes many regions of present day Karnataka (namely Coorg District).

[131] Heavenly beings in Hindu mythology, renowned for their skills in music, dance and other arts.

[132] Wife of Rishi Gautama. According to Hindu scriptures, beautiful Ahalya was seduced by God Indra, who disguised himself as her husband. When Rishi Goutama learned about this, he cursed Ahalya to become a stone.

[133] One of the great rishis in Hindu mythology. His wife Ahalya was tricked by God Indra into performing adultery and was cursed to become a stone while Indra was cursed with thousand one thousand female genitalia on his body for tempting the rishi's wife.

[134] Shantanu was a Kuru King of Hastinapura (features in Mahabharata). He married Ganga (River Goddess) and begot Bhishma. Bhishma later took an oath of celibacy and got him married to Satyawathi a fisherwoman.

[135] A central character in an ancient Tamil epic called Silpadikaram. Kovalan was a young son of a merchant who married Kannagi in Kaveripatinam. They lived happily for some time and then he fell in love with a courtesan named Madhavi and left his wife. After some time he repented his actions and returned to his wife.

They decided to move to Madurai to start a new life. Kannagi gave her gold anklets to her husband so that he could sell them to start a business but instead he got arrested by the King's guard because the anklet resembled that of the Queen's. Kovalan is punished and executed. Kannagi demands justice from the King and proved that her husband was innocent and then burned the city of Madurai in her righteous anger.

[136] The beautiful courtesan who enchanted Kovalan away from his devoted wife Kannagi.

[137] Capital city of Pandya Kings of South India.

[138] Wife of Manmadhan (Hindu God of Love)

[139] Hindu God of Love who is always invisible.

[140] Hindu God of Wealth in Hindu Mythology.

[141] Krishna's sister who married the Pandava brother Arjuna

[142] One of Krishna's principal wives.

[143] An Asura who is killed by Krishna and his wife Sathyabhama

[144] The Thiruppavai is a set of Tamil devotional religious hymns attributed to the female poet-saint Andal (also known as Nachiyar, Kodhai or Goda Devi).
Courtesy - Wikipedia

[145] One of the 63 Nayanars of Lord Shiva.

[146] A legendary Hindu King from the lineage of King Rama of Ayodhya who was known for his steadfastness in saying the truth.

[147] A puranic tale where Gajendra – The king of Elephants is attacked by a crocodile and Lord Vishnu arrives on his Garuda at the nick of the moment to save his devotee.

[148] A private chamber built in the Garden for the Princess's use.

[149] Street where Chola soldiers lived

[150] Medical Clinic

[151] Physician

[152] A mountain in the Himalayas filled with rare medicinal herbs. In Ramayana, when Lakshmana fell prey to Indrajit's poison darts, Hanuman was asked bring the medicinal herbs. Instead of herbs he brought the mountain where the herbs grew. One part of the mountain fell down in Elangai while he was returning to Himalayas. Even today, many rare medicinal herbs grow in the places where parts of the Sanjeevani Mountain fell.

[153] Situated 60 KM south of Chennai, Mammallapuram is an ancient historical town and a busy seaport of Pallavas. Many temples, sculptures, art and architecture dot the landscape of Mammallapuram which was named after King Narasimha Pallavar. Today Mammallapuram is a heritage site under the care of UNESCO.

[154] Mahendravarman was a Pallava King who ruled in the early 7th Century over the Northern parts of South India. He was the father of Narasimha Pallavar who successfully defeated King Pulikesi II and ransacked the Chalukya capital Vatapi (Badami).

[155] Narasimhavarman ruled over the Pallava Kingdom around 630 AD. The city of Mammallapuram is named after him. A great king who completed the art and architecture work commenced by his father Mahendravarman, Narasimhavarman also defeated Pulikesi II, the Chalukya King.

[156] One of the twelve poet saints of Vaishnavas.

[157] Literally means grandfather in Tamil.

[158] An ancient city in Sri Lanka.

[159] The spot where Shri Rama built the bridge to cross the sea to Sri Lanka in Ramayana to take his monkey army. This bridge still exists to this day!

[160] Lord of the Sea.

[161] A celebrated Tamil poet who lived sometime between 1st Century BC and 3rd Century BC whose contribution to literature is immense. His body of work Thirukural (work of ethics) is a classic Sangam literature consisting of 1330 couplets about virtue, morality and ethics.

[162] One of the lords who attended Sambuverayar's feast in Kadambur.

[163] Six passions that man experiences – Lust, wrath, greed, temptation, pride and envy

[164] Veera – means brave in Tamil.

[165] Crown Prince

[166] The grave sin of killing a woman.

[167] Known as Point Calimere, Kodi Karai is a low headland on the Coromandel coast in Nagapattinam district.

[168] The Nayanmars were a group of 63 devout poets. Of them, Sundaramurthy was an 8th century poet who composed many poems about Lord Shiva during the Bhakti movement of South India. He is the most popular of the Nayanmars and his compositions are sung even to this day.

[169] Known as Kodi Kuzhagar Temple or Amrithakadeswarar Temple, it is believed to be built by the Cholas. There are many inscriptions on the temple that date back to the 9th Century.

[170] The first seven volumes of Tirumurai which is a twelve-volume collection of Shaiva poetry. All seven volumes are comprised of divine hymns sung by popular Nayanmars – Sambandar, Tirunavukarasar (Appar) and Sundarar.

[171] Ornate tower of the temple, usually set atop gateways.

[172] Temple priest.

[173] Food offered to the gods in the temple is distributed among the devotees. In other words, it is a gracious gift from the gods.

[174] A respectful term in Tamil used to address men.

[175] The divine bull and the guardian deity of the gate to Kailasa, the abode of Lord Shiva.